

# Naibi

NYE-bee

Original write-ups of traditional and popular card games

78 games for 1 to 8 players, playable with the decks you already own.

Naibi is the first European word for playing cards, recorded in Florence in 1377. It comes from the Arabic nā'ib, “deputy” — the rank of court card in the Mamluk pack that every European deck descends from. Spain still calls them naipes.

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## SOLITAIRE (1 PLAYER)

# Accordion

|                      |                                                                          |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | The Idle Year, Tower of Babel, Methuselah, Leapfrog, Accordion Solitaire |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                                                 |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                                               |
| <b>Time</b>          | 5-15 minutes                                                             |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                   |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                                                     |

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## Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck. Every card becomes a pile of one, and those piles sit in a single line running left to right. There are no foundations, no reserve, and no stock once the line is down. The row is the entire game.

How the row gets built is the one setup decision, and the two traditional answers produce very different games. Dealing as you go is the older habit: turn one card, put it at the right-hand end of the line, take any moves you fancy, then turn the next. You never know what is still to come. Dealing the whole pack out first spreads all 52 face up before a single move is made, which converts the deal into a puzzle you can study. The open form is enormously easier, and most computer versions use it, so it is worth being clear which one you have agreed to play.

A line of 52 will not fit across a normal table. Lay it in bands, one under the next, and read it as a single line that wraps at the edge: the last pile of one band and the first pile of the next are neighbours. Only the exposed card of each pile is ever consulted, so keep the piles squared up rather than spread.



One line of 52 piles



The line once all 52 are down: one card per pile, face up, wrapping into bands of thirteen. Dealing as you go builds the same line a pile at a time.

## Play

Only the exposed card of a pile counts. Every move has to answer two questions, and both answers must come out right. Distance first: a pile travels leftward and lands either on its immediate neighbour or on the pile two beyond that, a hop of one place or of three, and no other distance exists in the game. Agreement second: the card showing on the mover and the card showing on the pile it lands on must be of one suit, or else of one rank. Fail either test and there is no move. Colour is irrelevant and so is rank order: a 4 does not go on a 5 for being next to it in sequence, it goes on another 4 for being a 4, or on any other club for being a club. Nothing ever moves rightwards, and the left-hand end of the line is a dead end by construction: the first pile has nothing to its left and can never move at all, while the second and third have a neighbour to slide onto but no pile three places back, so a leap is not available to them.

Piles move whole. You never peel a card off the top or split a packet in two; the entire pile lifts and lands squarely on the target, and whatever was showing on the mover is now showing on the merged pile. That is where the game gets its bite, because a move both shortens the line and changes what the surviving pile offers.

Players call the short move a slide and the long one a leap. A slide closes the line by one place and disturbs very little. A leap jumps two piles and drops the mover three back, which rearranges its whole neighbourhood at once and is usually the move that unlocks a run.

Gaps are what catch beginners out. The row is never allowed to keep a hole in it. A pile that departs from the middle leaves a space behind, and that space disappears at once as the remainder of the row closes up behind it, so what you are looking at is one pile shorter than it was a moment ago. The cost of that tidiness is your bearings: downstream of the move, a pile that had one neighbour on its left now has another, and the pile it counts back to three places away is not the pile it was. Distances are always counted on the line as it stands, never on the line as it was dealt, and forgetting that is the commonest way to talk yourself into an illegal move.

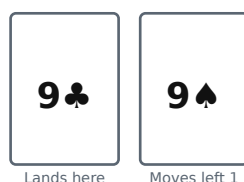
Nothing is compulsory in the form most people play. A legal move may be declined, and declining is frequently correct, since a cheap slide can wreck a leap that would have collapsed four piles in one stroke. The nineteenth-century rules were far stricter: they oblige you to move whenever a move exists, and to take the nearer pile whenever both distances are legal, which strips out essentially every decision.

Dealing as you go, you may alternate freely between turning the next card

and working the line, and you may take as many moves as you like between deals or none at all. When the pack is spent there is no redeal and nothing to fall back on.

The deal ends when the pack is exhausted and no exposed card anywhere in the line matches the pile one place or three places to its left. Running dry of moves earlier does not end anything while cards remain to be turned: keep dealing, because the next card can revive a line that looked finished. Count the piles left standing.

Slide, same rank



Leap, same suit



No match



A pile moves left one place or left three places, and only when the exposed cards agree in suit or in rank. The mover is always the card on the right.

## Goal & scoring

You win by gathering the whole pack into a single pile of 52. Anything short of that is a loss, and losses are overwhelmingly the normal result.

Accordion has a reputation as one of the least winnable patiences ever printed and it has earned it. Played blind, one card at a time, with a program simply taking whatever move is available, wins arrive on the order of a handful per ten thousand deals. Spread all 52 face up and plan instead, and the picture changes completely: careful open play has been reported to bring games home as often as one in three. Almost the whole of that gap is information rather than cleverness, which is why the old name The Idle

Year, a joke about how long you would wait for a win, describes the blind game and not the open one.

There is no formal scoring, but the obvious measure is the number of piles standing when you get stuck, with one being a win and fewer always better. Six or seven is a decent blind deal and a dozen is an ordinary bad one. Setting yourself a target, say anything at five or under, gives a session some shape without pretending the game is winnable on demand.

## Variants

**Open Accordion** — Spread the whole pack face up in the line before touching anything, then work out the collapse with full information. The moves and the win condition are identical; only what you can see changes. That single difference separates a game that is very nearly hopeless from one worth thinking hard about, and it is what most software deals by default, so many players have never met the blind version at all.

**Strict rules** — The oldest printed form, from the 1880s, leaves you no discretion at all. Whenever a legal move exists you are obliged to make it, and whenever a pile could go either one place left or three places left you must take the nearer. The outcome is then fixed entirely by the shuffle. It survives mainly as a baseline: comparing it against free play is how you measure what the right to decline a move is actually worth.

**Royal Marriage** — A short eliminator built on the same habit of reading a row for matches, but played by throwing cards away rather than stacking them. Cards are laid out in a line and, whenever two cards of the same rank or the same suit sit with exactly one or two cards between them, the trapped cards are discarded. The king and queen of hearts start at opposite ends and the aim is to strip the row until they meet. It finishes in a couple of minutes and is a far gentler introduction to the idea.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, Bicycle Cards, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, BVS Solitaire, Solitaire Association.



# Canfield

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Demon, Demon Patience                      |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-25 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                       |

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## Setup

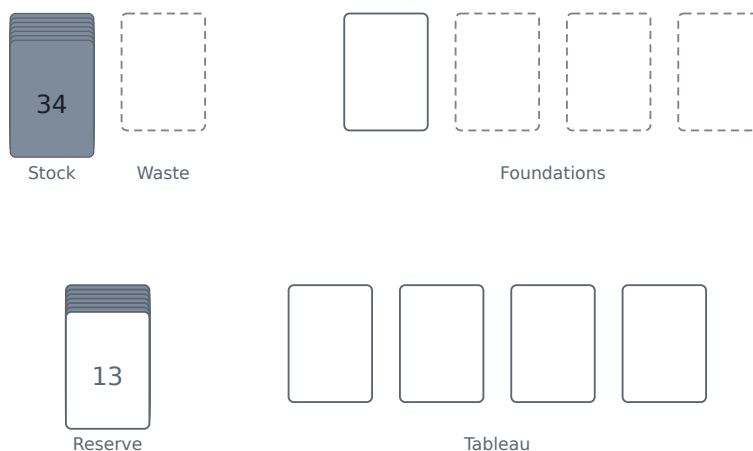
Before anything else, the name. In North America this game is Canfield and Klondike is Klondike; in older British books Canfield is the name given to Klondike, and this game is Demon Patience. Two respectable traditions, two incompatible answers, and the confusion goes back to a pair of 1908 rule books that each attached the wrong label. Go by the layout below rather than by whatever is printed at the top of the page you are reading.

Count out thirteen cards face down in a column and turn the last of them face up. That column is the reserve, and it is the demon: everything difficult about the game lives in those thirteen cards, which you cannot see and cannot get at except one at a time from the top.

Turn the next card and set it above and to the right. Whatever rank it happens to be is the base rank, and it decides the shape of the whole game — all four foundations must begin on that rank, so if it is a nine you are looking for the other three nines before anything else can start.

Lay four cards face up in a row beneath the space kept for the foundations. That is the tableau, and four columns is all you get. The remaining thirty-four cards are the stock.

There is nothing else to arrange and nobody to wait for.



The one card already on a foundation sets the rank the other three must start from. Only the bottom card of the thirteen-

card reserve is face up.

## Play

Foundations go upwards in suit from the base rank and turn the corner at the top: after the king comes the ace, then the two, and each pile finishes on the rank just below the one it started from. Tableau columns go downwards in alternating colours and turn the corner at the bottom, so a king may be laid on an ace.

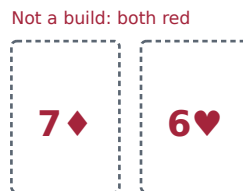
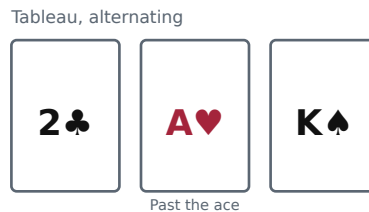
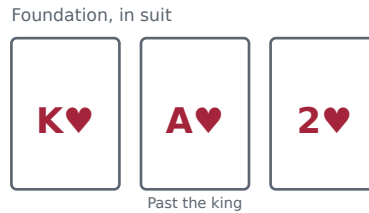
What may be moved where:

- The face-up card at the foot of the reserve is available at all times, to a foundation or to a tableau column.
- The top card of the waste is available in the same way.
- From a tableau column you may take the top card by itself, or lift the entire column and set it down as a unit. What you may never do is split a column and move part of it. This is the rule that separates Canfield from Klondike, and forgetting it makes the game look far more generous than it is.
- A card already banked on a foundation may be brought back down to the tableau. It is worth doing when it unblocks something, and worth thinking about first, since it cannot be done twice in a row to any effect.

Empty a tableau column and the reserve refills it — not any card you like, the next card off the reserve. Emptying columns is therefore the only way to dig through the demon, and it is the engine of the whole game rather than a side effect of it. Once the reserve is finally exhausted, a gap may be filled with anything, and at that point the position usually opens up all at once.

When nothing else will move, deal three cards face up from the stock to the waste and try again with whatever is now on top. Take the waste through as many times as you like: the stock is turned over and dealt again without limit, so the game only ends when a full pass produces no move at all.

One piece of technique is worth knowing before the first deal, because it is less a trick than the way the game is meant to be played. There are two hidden places on the table and only one of them stays hidden. Whatever is not in the thirty-four cards the stock will show you, and not already face up, is in the reserve — so a single pass through the stock before you move anything tells you which thirteen cards the demon is holding, and roughly how far down each one sits, missing base cards included. What using the waste costs is position: every card taken off it shifts the rest back by one on the following pass, which is occasionally a tool and more often the reason a card you were counting on fails to come round.



Both builds turn the corner. Foundations climb in suit straight past the king into the ace; tableau columns descend in alternating colours straight past the ace into the king.

## Goal & scoring

All fifty-two cards onto the foundations. Nothing else counts as a win, and most deals do not produce one.

How often is worth stating carefully, because the honest answer has three numbers in it and they are all correct. A solver that can see every card and never errs gets home on roughly 71 percent of deals. Very strong human play, with the reserve genuinely hidden and each waste-pile decision reshuffling everything behind it, is credited with something nearer 35. Across a large sample of ordinary online play — better than a hundred thousand deals — it is about 9 percent. The gap between the first number and the last is not a measure of how hard the game is; it is a measure of how much of it is played blind.

So count cards banked rather than games won. Around forty of the fifty-two is what good play averages, and getting all four foundations open at all is a decent afternoon's result on a bad deal.

The historical scoring is the gambling version the game is named after, and you can play it against yourself with a notepad. A pack costs fifty, each card you get onto a foundation pays five, and so ten cards is break-even and

anything above that is profit. Richard Canfield ran it at his Saratoga Springs casino from about 1900, one croupier per player, and the players lost steadily — as anyone who has tried to bank ten cards from a cold deal would expect. It did not last. He sold the place in 1907, and historians of the game now suspect that what he actually dealt was Klondike, which would make this the one card game named after a casino that never carried it.

## Variants

**Storehouse** — Also called Reserve or Thirteen Up, and much the kindest member of the family. Take the four twos out before dealing and set them up as the foundations, so the base rank is fixed and all four piles are open from the first move — which removes the thing that strangles most Canfield deals. Foundations build up in suit as usual, but the tableau builds down in suit too rather than by alternating colours. The stock turns one card at a time and may be run through only twice. Its ceiling is lower than Canfield's at around 44 percent winnable, and yet ordinary players win close to that, which tells you most of what you need to know about where Canfield's difficulty actually comes from.

**Rainbow** — Canfield with the colour rule dropped: tableau columns build down by rank alone and suit is ignored entirely. To pay for that the stock is turned one card at a time and redeals are limited, commonly to none at all or to two. It is the version to reach for when a game keeps dying on a tableau full of same-coloured cards, and the single-card turn makes the waste pile far easier to plan around.

**Selective Canfield** — Deal the reserve, then turn five cards instead of four. Choose whichever of the five you want as the base card and lay the other four out as the tableau. Everything afterwards is ordinary Canfield. One choice, made before a single card has moved, and it is a real one: a base rank near the middle leaves you tableau space above and below it, while a base of two or a base of king means half the pack has nowhere useful to go.

**Superior Canfield** — Two rules relaxed at once. The whole reserve is spread face up so you can see all thirteen cards from the start, and an empty tableau column may be filled with any available card rather than only from the reserve. Together they turn the game from a blind one into a puzzle, which is either the point or a betrayal of it depending on why you sat down. It is the closest thing in the family to playing Canfield with the solver's information.

**Double Canfield** — Two packs shuffled together, eight foundations, and usually a reserve of twenty-six with five tableau columns. Counter-intuitively it is easier rather than harder: with two of every card, a rank you need is rarely stuck in only one place, and the extra tableau column gives the alternating-colour build somewhere to go. A reasonable answer for anyone who likes the

shape of Canfield and has grown tired of losing to it.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Solitaired, Solitaire-Play.

# Clock

|                      |                                                                           |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Clock Patience, Clock Solitaire, The Clock, Sundial, Four of a Kind, Hunt |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                                                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                                                |
| <b>Time</b>          | 5-10 minutes                                                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                    |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                                                      |

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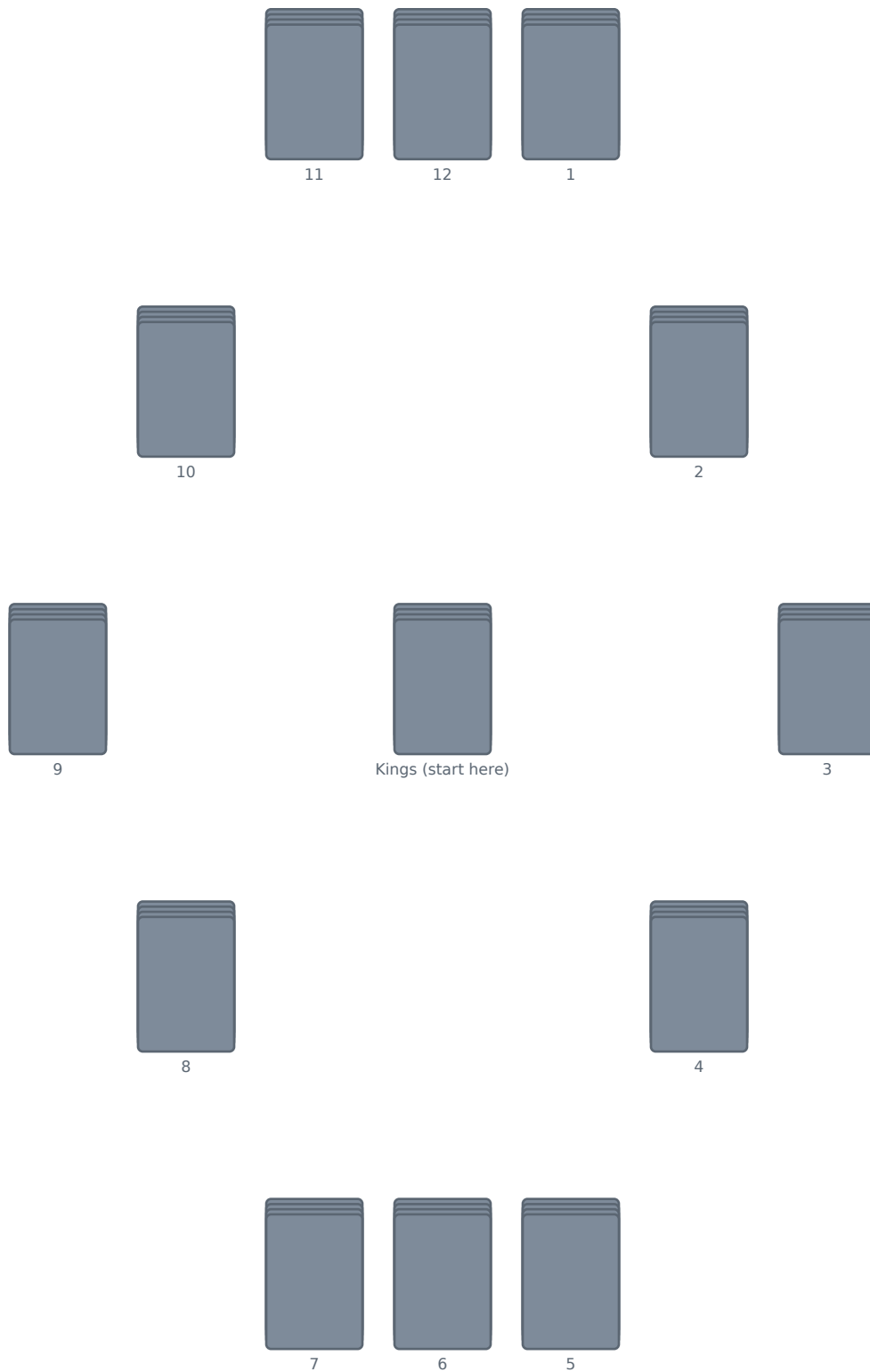
## Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck and deal it into thirteen face-down piles of four without looking at anything. Dealing one card at a time and going round the layout four times is the tidy way to do it and keeps the piles honest.

Twelve of the piles form a ring in the positions of the numerals on a clock face, one at twelve o'clock, one at one o'clock, and so on round to eleven. The thirteenth pile sits in the middle of the ring. That centre pile belongs to the kings, and it is also where play starts.

Ranks map onto the hours the obvious way. An ace is one o'clock, each numeral card is its own number, the jack is eleven and the queen is twelve. Kings have no hour on a dial, so they go to the centre. Suit and colour never matter for anything.

As the game runs, every position grows a face-up group underneath its face-down packet, so leave each pile enough room for a spread below it. Nothing else is needed: no stock, no waste, no foundations.



Thirteen face-down piles of four: twelve on the hours and one in the middle for the kings. The first card turned comes off the centre.

## Play

Turn the top card of the centre pile face up. After that the game runs itself.



Read whatever card is now in your hand as an address. An eight is addressed to eight o'clock, a jack to eleven o'clock, a king to the middle. Carry it there and tuck it face up beneath the face-down packet waiting at that position. The position pays you back on the spot: help yourself to its topmost face-down card, and that card becomes the one in your hand, to be read and delivered by exactly the same procedure. Each card names the pile you visit next, and the pile you visit hands you the next card, so the whole deal is one unbroken chain.

There is nothing to choose at any point. You never pick a destination, never pick which pile to open, and never decide when to turn. The chain is fixed by the shuffle from the first card onward, and two people dealt the same pack in the same order get the same result. This is why Clock is handed to children and used as a fortune-telling toy rather than played as a contest.

The chain can only ever die at the centre. Every other pile hands you a replacement the moment you add a card to it, because it starts with four face-down cards and receives exactly four over the course of a deal. The centre is the exception: it gave up its first card for free at the very start, so it is running one turn ahead of its supply all game. Placing the fourth king therefore leaves nothing to turn and the deal stops on the spot, however many cards are still face down elsewhere. For the same reason a pile can never strand you by handing you a card of its own hour at the wrong moment, which is a worry beginners often have and never need to.

Watch the face-down packets thin out as you go, because that is the only feedback the game gives. If the ring is emptying evenly by the time the third king shows, the deal is alive. If two or three positions have never been visited at all, it is already lost and the remaining turns are just confirmation.

## **Goal & scoring**

You win by turning every card in the layout, which happens exactly when the fourth king is the last card you turn up. At that moment all thirteen positions hold their four matching cards face up, the ring reads round in order from one to twelve, and the kings are in the middle where they belong.

You lose the moment the fourth king appears with any face-down card still on the table. There is no rescue and no redeal built into the game; you gather the cards, shuffle and start over.

The odds are fixed and well known. Since there are no decisions to make, the result is settled entirely by the shuffle, and the chance of a win works out at one deal in thirteen, a shade under eight per cent. Nothing you do changes that. If you want something to compare between deals, count the

cards left face down when the fourth king turns up and treat fewer as better: a deal that stalls with three cards down was an unlucky shuffle, while one that stalls with thirty was never going anywhere.

## Variants

**Watch** — The usual relief valve, met under this name and under none at all. The first time the fourth king comes up, you may set it aside and turn any face-down card still left in the layout instead, resuming the chain from there. One rescue per deal only. A game that was failing badly still fails, but the near misses, the deals that stall with a couple of cards to go, mostly come home. It adds no decision worth the name, since which card you pick makes no difference to whether the chain survives.

**Play it out** — Rather than stopping when the fourth king kills the chain, restart it and carry on until every card in the layout is face up. The first death is always in the centre but later ones can strand you anywhere, so fix the restart point by the dial rather than by where you stopped: go to one o'clock and turn its top face-down card, and if that position is already clear keep stepping clockwise until you reach one that is not. Restart as often as necessary, and score the deal by the number of restarts you needed, lowest best. The procedure is otherwise unchanged. It suits younger players, who tend to find the abrupt ending of the standard game unsatisfying, and it at least gives every deal a number rather than a flat loss.

**Grandfather's Clock** — A different game that borrows the dial, and the one to look for if the clock face is the appeal but pure luck is not. Twelve foundations are laid out as a clock face, each starting on a different card, and each is built upwards in suit, turning the corner from king to ace as needed, until its top card is the one matching its hour: an ace at one o'clock, a 10 at ten, the queen at twelve. The forty cards left over form eight tableau columns of five, built down regardless of suit and moved one card at a time. That is twelve plus forty, so the pack comes out exactly. It involves genuine choices and the large majority of deals can be won. Big Ben is the two-pack relative built on the same idea.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, BVS Solitaire, Wolfram MathWorld, Cats at Cards, MobilityWare, Anytime Card Games, CardGames.io.

# Forty Thieves

|                      |                                                                    |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Napoleon at St Helena, Big Forty, Roosevelt at San Juan, Le Cadran |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                                           |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 2 standard decks (104 cards)                                       |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                                                      |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                               |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                                               |

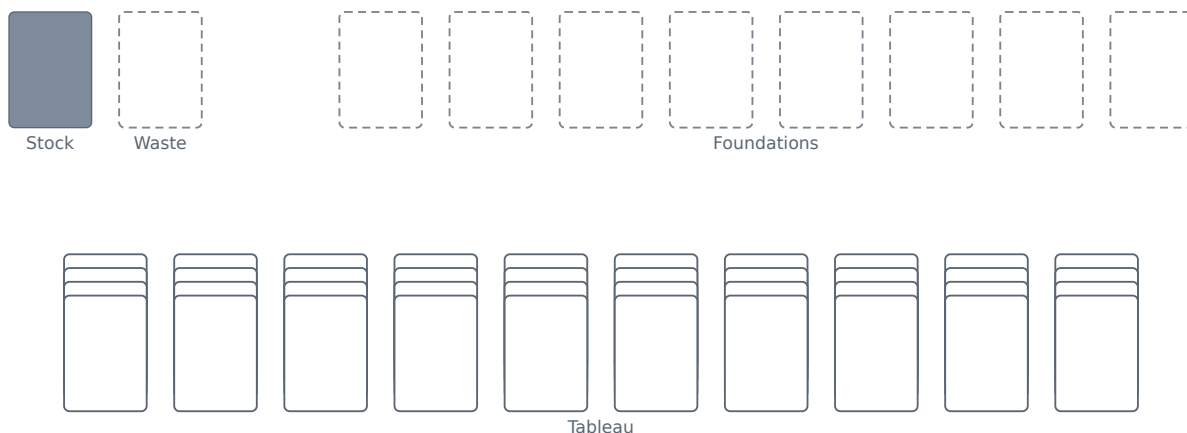
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## Setup

Shuffle two full 52-card decks together into a single 104-card pack. Deal 40 cards face up into ten columns of four, going across the row so each column takes one card per pass, and overlap them so every rank stays readable. Nothing is concealed: all forty are in plain sight before you touch anything.

The rest of the pack goes face down as the stock, with a space beside it for the waste. Above the tableau, leave room for eight foundations — each suit is built twice, once from each deck.

Clear a broad table first. Two decks in ten columns need considerably more space than any one-deck game, and by mid-play a single column can run past a dozen cards.



All forty tableau cards start face up. Eight foundations, since every suit is built twice; the 64-card stock is turned once and never returns.

## Play

The eight foundations climb in suit from the ace — two spade piles, two heart piles, two of each of the others, every one running ace to king. A card sent to a foundation is finished with. It cannot be brought back down, which turns each promotion into a decision rather than a reflex.

The ten columns build downward in suit and in suit only. The 9 of spades goes on the 10 of spades and nowhere else at all. Ranks do not wrap round:

an ace at the end of a column is the bottom of its run and takes nothing, and a king moves only to an empty column or onto its own foundation. Anyone arriving from Klondike will lay a red card on a black one out of pure habit; there is no colour rule here to reward that.

Then the restriction the game is famous for. Exactly one card moves at a time, always. Your candidates are the exposed card at the end of a column and the card on top of the waste, and either may go to a foundation, onto another column, or into an empty column. Suppose a column ends in the 10, 9, 8 and 7 of spades in perfect order: you still have to relocate them one by one, which means finding homes for three of them before the run can travel anywhere. Nothing anywhere in the rules picks up a group.

An empty column, by contrast, takes any card whatever. Empty columns are the only manoeuvring room the game hands you, and most of Forty Thieves strategy follows from that single fact. A spare column is how you dig out a buried ace, how you reverse a column into a usable order, and how you unload the waste. Filling one thoughtlessly is the move that most often loses the deal.

Turning the stock is your own affair: one card at a time onto the waste, whenever you choose, with nothing obliging you to wring the tableau dry first. Only the waste's top card is live, and cards come off it singly. There is one pass and no redeal: 64 cards, 64 turns, and once the last is face up the stock is gone for good. Whatever you strand under an unplayable waste card stays stranded until that card finds a home.

Nothing is compulsory, and holding a card back is often correct. The 5 of diamonds sitting at the end of a column is somewhere to park the 4 of diamonds; on the foundation it is somewhere you no longer have. Because promoted cards never come back, the standard advice about clearing cards upward as fast as possible is actively bad here.

The deal is over when all eight foundations are complete, or when the stock is spent and nothing legal remains. You will usually recognise a loss well before that formal ending: once both copies of a card you need are buried under lower cards in every column, with no empty column in prospect, the position is dead even though moves are still available.

## **Goal & scoring**

You win by completing all eight foundations — every suit built twice, ace through king, all 104 cards off the table. There is nothing in between; the deal is won or it is not.

Traditional play keeps no score, and computer versions that add one usually

borrow the Klondike arrangement of points per card promoted plus a time bonus. The figure people actually quote about this game is its win rate, and it is punishing. Large runs of random deals played without much care come in around four games in a hundred. Players who plan several moves ahead and treat empty columns as the scarce resource they are report something closer to one deal in ten. Both numbers are honest; they are measuring different players.

No exhaustive solver study has settled Forty Thieves the way one settled FreeCell, so the true ceiling — how many deals fall to perfect play with full information — is unknown. What is clear is that the spread between careless and careful results is unusually wide for a solitaire game, which is the signature of a game where skill genuinely bites. Losing is the normal outcome, and the sensible way to keep score is across a session rather than a deal.

## Variants

**Josephine** — The Forty Thieves layout and rules with the one-card restriction dropped: a descending same-suit run at the end of a column may be lifted and moved as a block. The run has to be in order and in suit to travel, and an empty column will accept a whole run as readily as a single card. That one change removes most of the drudgery of shuffling cards through empty columns and lifts the win rate enormously, which is why it is the version many people prefer to play.

**Streets** — Everything as in Forty Thieves — ten columns of four, eight foundations, one pass through a 64-card stock, one card moved at a time — except that the tableau builds down in alternating colours instead of in suit. Doubling the number of cards that will accept any given card makes a real difference, and it is the natural first step down in difficulty for anyone finding the parent game airless.

**Maria** — Nine columns of four rather than ten, so 36 cards are dealt and 68 go to the stock, and the tableau builds down in alternating colours. The narrower tableau costs you a column of working space while the colour rule gives back flexibility, leaving a game that sits between Forty Thieves and Streets.

**Limited** — Twelve columns of three, again 36 cards on the table, with the same same-suit building and the same one-card-at-a-time rule as Forty Thieves. Shallow columns mean far less is buried at the outset and two extra columns mean more places to put things, so the opening is much freer even though nothing about the movement rules has been relaxed.

**Rank and File** — Ten columns of four again, but only the last card of each column is dealt face up; the three under it lie face down and turn over as they are uncovered. Ten cards visible at the start where Forty Thieves shows forty,

which hands the game the hidden information the parent has none of. The tableau builds down in alternating colours. Most rule sets also allow a descending alternating-colour run to travel as a block, the way Josephine does, while a few hold to the strict one-card rule; agree which you are playing before you deal, because it changes the game markedly. Also seen as Dress Parade.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Semicolon Solitaire Rules, BVS Solitaire, Solitaire Association, Denexa Games, SuitedGames, Solitaired.

# FreeCell

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Free Cell, FreeCell Solitaire              |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-30 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                       |

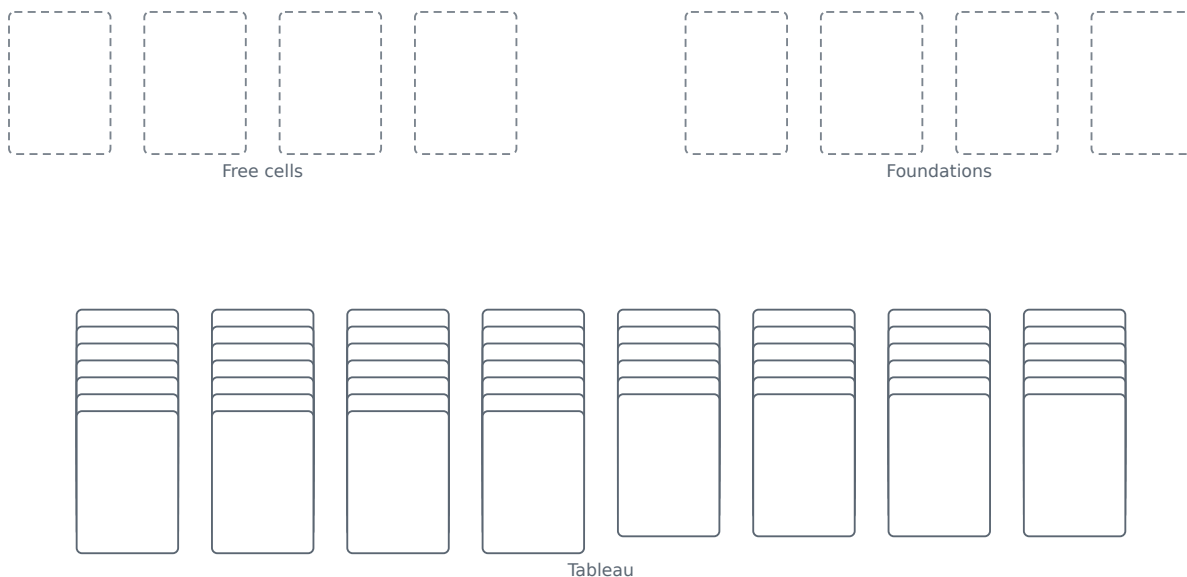
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## Setup

Take one 52-card deck without jokers, shuffle it, and deal the whole pack face up into eight tableau columns: seven cards each to the first four columns and six each to the last four. Spread each column so that every card in it stays readable, with the last card of the column fully exposed.

Above or beside the tableau, set out four free cells on one side and four foundation spaces on the other. All eight start empty.

That is the entire layout. There is no stock, no waste and no redeal, and nothing is dealt face down. From the first move to the last you are working with complete information, which is what separates FreeCell from Klondike and Spider. No new card can turn up, so a deal is a puzzle that is already either solvable or not before you touch it.



The whole pack is dealt face up: no stock, no waste and nothing hidden.

## Play

The foundations are built up in suit from the ace to the king, one foundation per suit. The tableau columns are built down in alternating colours, so a black jack accepts a red 10 and that red 10 accepts a black 9.

Strictly speaking exactly one card moves at a time, and it has to be either the exposed card at the end of a column or a card sitting in a free cell. You can send it to:

- a foundation, if it is the next rank up in that suit;
- a tableau column whose end card is one rank higher and the opposite colour;
- an empty free cell, which holds exactly one card and imposes no other condition;
- an empty column, which accepts any single card at all. Unlike Klondike, empty columns are not reserved for kings, and this is the most powerful resource in the game.

A card parked in a free cell is fully available and can be played out again to a column or a foundation whenever it fits. The only cost of using a cell is that it is no longer free for manoeuvring.

Almost every version lets you drag a whole run at once, which is the supermove, also called a power move. It is not a separate rule. It is shorthand for a run of ordinary single-card moves that the software performs for you: the upper cards of the run get shuffled into free cells and empty columns, the bottom card is moved, and the run is rebuilt on top of it. The number of cards you can shift this way is therefore capped by the workspace you have:

maximum cards =  $(1 + \text{empty free cells}) \times 2^{\text{empty columns}}$

Read it as two separate effects: every free cell adds one to what you can carry, and every empty column doubles whatever that comes to. Four cells with nothing else spare will therefore shift five cards, and freeing a single column on top of them takes the same four cells to ten. The exception is the destination itself. A column you are moving into cannot double as workspace, so it drops out of the exponent — dropping a run into your only empty column with all four cells free gets you five cards rather than ten.

That doubling formula is what most implementations use, and it is what a careful player can actually achieve by hand. A minority of programs are stingier and multiply instead of doubling, capping the move at  $(1 + \text{empty free cells}) \times (1 + \text{empty columns})$ , which with four cells and two empty columns allows 15 cards rather than 20. If your version refuses a move you think should be legal, this is usually why. Nothing is lost either way: the supermove is only a convenience, and you can always perform the same transfer one card at a time.

The run you are moving must already be a proper descending, alternating-



colour sequence. A stack that merely sits together is not movable as a block, and if you do not have the storage for the whole run you have to break it up by hand.

Taking a card back off a foundation into the tableau is allowed in most implementations and is occasionally the move that saves a deal, but some versions lock a foundation once a card is played there, so check before you count on it.

No move is ever compulsory. You are never obliged to send an ace or any other card to a foundation, and holding a low card back in the tableau to catch the next card down is a standard technique. Many programs autoplay cards to the foundations for you once they can no longer be needed; that is a convenience setting, not a rule, and it can usually be switched off.

The deal ends when all four foundations reach their kings, or when you are stuck: all four free cells occupied, no empty column, and nothing among the four cell cards and the eight column ends that fits onto a foundation or onto another column. Because nothing is hidden, being stuck is always the end of that deal; there is no redeal and no reshuffle.

## **Goal & scoring**

You win by moving all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit in order from ace up to king. FreeCell keeps no points in its traditional form. A deal is won or lost, and players who want a finer measure compare move counts or elapsed time on the same numbered deal rather than tallying a score.

The interesting number in FreeCell is how often a deal can be won at all. Because every card is visible and four cells is a generous allowance, nearly every deal has a solution: solvers put it at roughly 99.999 percent of random deals. Microsoft's original set of 32,000 numbered deals contains exactly one that has been proven impossible, deal 11,982, and establishing that took a volunteer effort running through the mid-1990s. When the same generator was extended to a million deals, only eight unwinnable ones turned up in total: 11,982, 146,692, 186,216, 455,889, 495,505, 512,118, 517,776 and 781,948.

Losing a FreeCell deal is therefore almost always your mistake rather than the shuffle's, which is both the appeal and the cruelty of the game. Solvable does not mean easy, though. Deals 617 and 1,941 from the original set are the notorious ones, and 1,941 is the answer solvers usually give when asked which of the 32,000 is hardest without being impossible. Working through the numbered deals in order is a long-running informal challenge.

## Variants

**Baker's Game** — The game FreeCell was derived from. Identical layout and identical four free cells, but the tableau builds down in suit instead of alternating colours. Removing colour-based landing spots roughly halves the places any card can go, and winnability drops from near-certainty to somewhere around three quarters of deals, so a lost game here is much less likely to be your fault.

**Eight Off** — Eight free cells rather than four. Deal 48 cards into eight columns of six, then place the remaining four cards one each into four of the eight cells, leaving four cells open. The tableau builds down in suit, and only a king may be moved into an empty column. The extra cells are compensation for both of those tighter restrictions.

**Seahaven Towers** — Fifty cards go into ten columns of five, and the last two cards are placed into two of the four free cells, leaving two open. The tableau builds down in suit and only kings may fill an empty column. With ten short columns, two occupied cells and no colour alternation, it plays much more tightly than FreeCell and rewards planning several moves ahead.

**ForeCell** — Deal four cards face up into the four free cells first, then 48 cards into eight columns of six. You start with every cell full, so your first job is emptying them. The tableau builds down in alternating colours as in FreeCell, but only a king may be moved into an empty column, which removes the escape hatch that makes standard FreeCell so forgiving.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, Solitaire Central, BVS Solitaire, PlayFreeCellOnline, Freecell Solver documentation (Shlomi Fish).

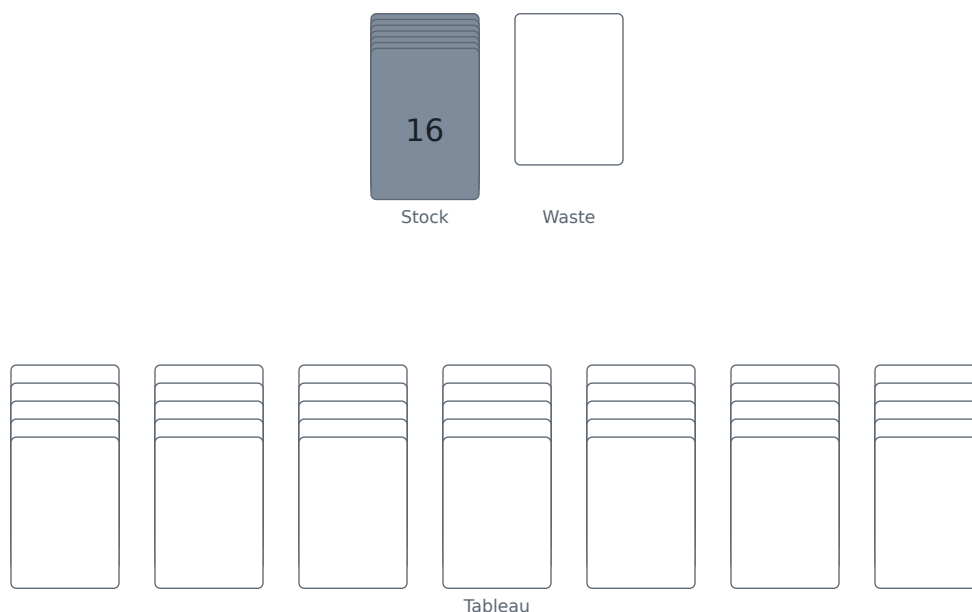
# Golf

|                      |                                               |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Golf Solitaire, Golf Patience, One Foundation |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                      |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                    |
| <b>Time</b>          | 5-15 minutes                                  |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                          |

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## Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck. Deal 35 cards face up into seven columns of five. Overlap the cards in each column so every rank stays readable, with the last card dealt to a column sitting at the exposed end. All 35 are visible from the start, so nothing is hidden. The 17 cards left over become the stock, kept face down in a single pile. Turn the top stock card face up beside it to start the waste pile, which is the one pile you will build on for the rest of the deal, leaving 16 cards in the stock. Many descriptions call that build pile the foundation, which is where the alternative name One Foundation comes from, and several of them treat turning the first card as the player's opening move rather than part of the deal. Nothing hangs on that except whether you call the stock 17 or 16 at the moment play begins. Leave room for the waste to grow, since in a good deal nearly the whole pack ends up there. There are no foundations by suit and no reserve; the seven columns, the stock, and the waste are the entire layout.



All 35 tableau cards are face up; the first stock card is turned to start the waste.

## Play

Only the exposed card at the open end of each column is in play. The rest are locked until the cards covering them are gone.

On your turn you may move any one exposed column card onto the waste pile, provided its rank is exactly one higher or one lower than the current top card of the waste. Suits and colours are ignored entirely. If the waste shows a 9, you may play any 8 or any 10. Moving a card exposes the one behind it in that column, which may then be playable in turn, so a single well-placed card can start a long chain.

Ranks do not wrap in the standard game. Aces are low and kings are high: only a 2 plays onto an ace, and only a queen plays onto a king. Playing an ace on a king, or a king on an ace, is illegal. This is the single rule that ends most deals, and the most commonly relaxed one. A harsher version appears in some rule sets: there a king is a complete dead end and nothing whatever may be packed on it, not even a queen, so a king on the waste forces you to draw. Settle which of the two you are using before you deal, because the difference is large.

You may keep making legal moves for as long as you like; you are never forced to draw. Cards never move between columns, never move back off the waste, and never go onto the stock. Once a column is emptied the gap stays empty for the rest of the deal, and nothing may be placed there.

When you are stuck, or simply choose to, turn the next card of the stock face up onto the waste. That card becomes the new build card regardless of what it covers, so a draw can reset the sequence to any rank. Drawing is the only way to change the top of the waste other than playing a column card.

The deal ends when the stock is empty and no exposed column card can legally be played onto the waste. There is no redeal and no shuffling of the waste back into the stock. If you have cleared all 35 column cards you have holed out; otherwise the deal is over with cards still on the table.

A separate multiplayer game is also called Golf. That one is usually played as Six-Card Golf, where each player manages a private face-down grid, swapping and discarding to reach the lowest total over nine deals. The two games share only the golf scoring metaphor and are otherwise unrelated; the rules here are for the single-player patience.

Plays on a 9



Ace on a king



King on an ace



Play onto the waste one rank up or one rank down, suits ignored. Ranks do not wrap in the standard game, so a king takes only a queen and an ace takes only a 2.

## Goal & scoring

The object of a single deal is to clear all 35 cards out of the seven columns and onto the waste. Cards left in the stock do not matter.

Score as in golf: count one stroke for every card still stranded in the columns when the deal ends. Clearing the tableau scores zero for the hole, and a common house rule lets you go under par by subtracting one for each card still face down in the stock when you hole out.

A full round is nine deals, one per hole, with the strokes added up, and two rounds of nine make an eighteen-hole match. No authority sets a par for this, so the targets players quote are convention rather than rule; the figure in general circulation is 45 strokes for nine holes, with a total in the mid-thirties counting as a good round. Under strict no-wraparound rules most deals cannot be cleared at all, so a nine-hole total of zero is not a realistic goal.

## Variants

**Putt Putt (wraparound)** — Ranks wrap, so a king may be played on an ace and an ace on a king, making the sequence a continuous loop. This removes

the dead ends that spoil most strict deals and lifts the win rate dramatically, which is why nearly every computer version offers it as an easy mode.

**Relaxed stock** — Allow one redeal: gather the waste after the stock runs out, turn it over without shuffling, and use it as a fresh stock. Some house rules instead let you undo the last move or deal a shorter tableau of six columns of five, leaving 22 cards in the stock. All of these trade difficulty for a better chance of holing out.

**Black Hole** — David Parlett's rework. Deal 17 fans of three cards around the ace of spades, which sits alone in the centre as the only foundation. Build up or down on it with wraparound, taking the exposed card of any fan, and there is no stock at all. Everything is visible from the start, so it plays as a puzzle rather than a gamble, and the great majority of deals are solvable.

**All in a Row** — Also by Parlett. The whole deck is dealt into 13 overlapping fans of four cards in a single row, with no stock and no starting foundation card. The first card you take becomes the base of the waste and you build up or down with wraparound from there, aiming to absorb all 52 cards.

**Double Golf** — Two shuffled decks, 104 cards, dealt into a wider tableau. No layout is standard across sources, so fix one before you deal: eight columns of eight uses 64 cards and leaves 40 in the stock, which keeps the ratio of tableau to stock close to the single-deck game. Everything else, including scoring one stroke per card stranded in the columns, is unchanged. Duplicated ranks give more branching options, but the larger layout means a single dead run can still leave a heavy score.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Solitaire Laboratory, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, Parlett Games, Bicycle Cards.

# Klondike

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Solitaire, Patience, Klondike Solitaire    |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 5-20 minutes                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                       |

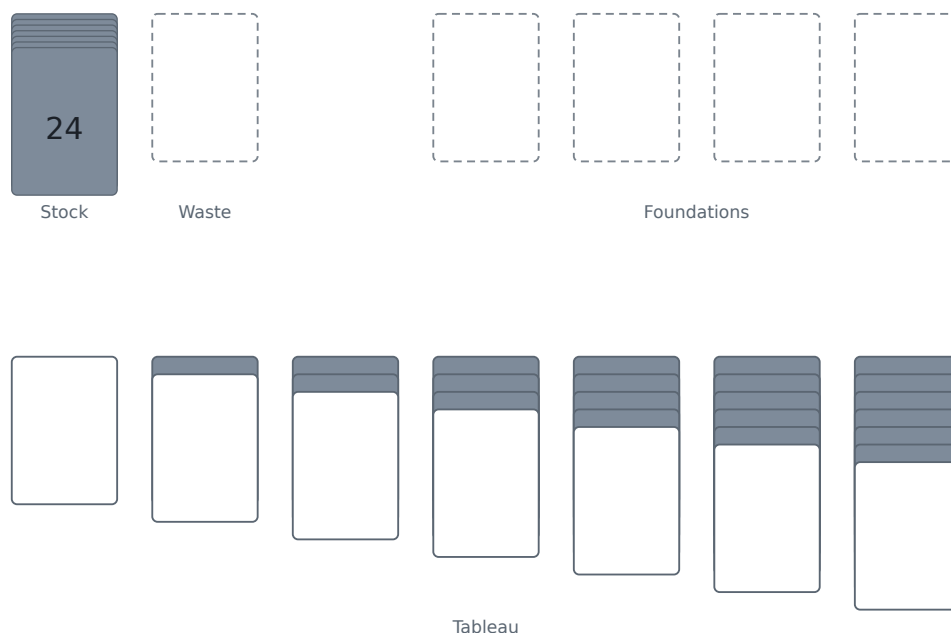
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## Setup

Use a single 52-card deck with the jokers removed. Shuffle, then build seven tableau piles from left to right: one card in the first pile, two in the second, on up to seven in the seventh, for 28 cards in total. The tidy way to deal it is one card to each pile in a left-to-right sweep, skipping any pile that already holds its full count. Turn the exposed card of every pile face up and leave everything under it face down.

Above the tableau, reserve four spaces for the foundations. They start empty. The 24 cards you did not deal go face down in a single packet as the stock, with an empty space beside it for the waste. There is no dealer to choose and no opponent, so play begins the moment the layout is built.

One caution before you follow rules printed elsewhere: older British sources sometimes call this game Canfield, while North American sources use Canfield for an entirely different game, the one also known as Demon. Match the layout described above rather than the title on the page.



Only the last card of each tableau pile starts face up.

## Play

There are two places to build. The four foundations go up in suit starting from the ace: an ace may go up the moment it is exposed, then the 2 of that suit, and so on through the king. The seven tableau piles go down in alternating colours, so a red 9 accepts a black 8, and that black 8 accepts a red 7.

Playable cards are the exposed card at the outer end of each tableau pile and the top card of the waste. You may move one of those to a foundation, or to a tableau pile whose exposed card is one rank higher and the opposite colour. You may also lift a run of face-up tableau cards that already descends one rank at a time in alternating colours and move it as a unit onto a card that continues that sequence. Most rule sets let you take just the lower portion of a run; stricter ones make you move the whole face-up group or nothing.

Any time a move leaves a face-down card at the end of a tableau pile, turn it up immediately.

Empty columns carry the one real restriction: only a king, or a run headed by a king, may be moved into a column you have cleared. Nothing else may go there, so emptying a column with no king in sight usually wastes the space.

Nothing is compulsory. You may leave an exposed ace sitting in the tableau, decline to fill an empty column, or go to the stock while tableau moves are still available; the only forced action is turning up a newly exposed face-down card.

When the tableau has nothing you want, work the stock. Turn cards face up onto the waste and play from there. Only the top card of the waste is ever playable, and it leaves one card at a time. How many cards you turn per go is the setting that defines the two common versions.

Draw one: turn a single card at a time. Every card in the stock reaches the top of the waste on every pass, so nothing stays out of reach and the game is far more forgiving.

Draw three: turn three at once, overlapped so you can read all three but only the outermost is playable. The two behind it become available only after the card in front of them is played. Because the stock is consumed in blocks of three, roughly two thirds of it is unreachable at any given moment, and every card you take shifts which cards surface on the next pass. If fewer than three cards are left when you reach the end of the stock, turn up however many remain and treat the outermost of them as the playable one. This is the older and harder default.



When the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to form a new stock. That is a redeal, and its limit is the other point players argue about. Casual play generally allows unlimited redeals in both draw modes. Scored versions restrict it in two different ways. Standard scoring keeps redeals unlimited but bills you for each one past the first pass. Vegas scoring caps the passes outright: one pass and no redeal at draw one, three passes and two redeals at draw three. Timed and competitive settings commonly borrow the three-pass cap for draw three. None of this is standardised, so settle the limit before you deal.

Taking the top card back off a foundation into the tableau is permitted in most rule sets and is sometimes the only way to free a card you need, though scored versions charge you for it and a few rule sets forbid it outright.

The deal ends when all four foundations are complete, or when you are stuck: the stock empty with no redeal left, nothing playable off the waste, and no legal move anywhere in the tableau. There is no partial win and no reshuffle. If you lose, gather the cards, shuffle properly, and deal again.

## **Goal & scoring**

You win by getting all 52 cards onto the foundations, each suit built ace through king. Most people simply play win or lose and keep no score.

Standard scoring, the system most software uses, awards 5 points for moving a card from the waste to the tableau, 10 for moving a card to a foundation, and 5 for turning up a face-down tableau card. Pulling a card back from a foundation costs 15. Recycling the stock costs points once you are past the first pass: 20 per recycle at draw three and 100 per recycle at draw one, where a fresh pass is worth far more. The running total is not allowed to fall below zero. Timed play adds a clock to that: you shed 2 points for every 10 seconds at the table and collect a finishing bonus that shrinks the longer you took, so a fast win scores far above a slow one.

Vegas scoring treats the deal as a wager. You buy the deck for 52 units, one per card, and collect 5 units for every card you land on a foundation, so eleven cards puts you 3 ahead and break-even is closer than it looks. Passes through the stock are capped rather than penalised: one at draw one, three at draw three. Many players carry a running bankroll from deal to deal instead of settling each deal on its own.

Klondike is not always winnable, which matters more than beginners expect. Solver studies of draw-three Klondike with every face-down card revealed in advance, and unlimited redeals allowed, put the ceiling near 82 percent of deals, so something close to one deal in five cannot be won by

anyone regardless of skill. Draw one is more forgiving and its ceiling is higher, but there is no equally well-established published figure for it, so treat any specific draw-one percentage you see with suspicion. Playing blind, as you actually do, real results are much lower: large samples of players come in near a third of games at draw one and around one game in ten at draw three, and those aggregate numbers vary noticeably from site to site.

| Scores                                    | Value | Notes                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Standard: waste to tableau                | 5     | —                                                                          |
| Standard: card to a foundation            | 10    | —                                                                          |
| Standard: turning up a tableau card       | 5     | —                                                                          |
| Standard: foundation back to tableau      | -15   | —                                                                          |
| Standard: recycling the stock, draw three | -20   | Each recycle once you are past the first pass.                             |
| Standard: recycling the stock, draw one   | -100  | Each recycle once you are past the first pass.                             |
| Standard: lowest possible total           | 0     | The running total is not allowed to fall below zero.                       |
| Timed play: time cost                     | -2    | Every 10 seconds, plus a finishing bonus that shrinks the longer you take. |
| Vegas: buying the deck                    | -52   | One unit per card, paid before the deal.                                   |
| Vegas: each card on a foundation          | +5    | Eleven cards puts you 3 units ahead.                                       |

## Variants

**Vegas Klondike** — Klondike played as a bet. You pay 52 units for the deck, one per card, and earn 5 units for each card you get onto a foundation, so eleven cards is break-even plus a little. Passes through the stock are strictly limited: one pass and no redeal at draw one, three passes at draw three. Losing money on a deal is the normal outcome, and many players keep a cumulative bankroll across a session instead of settling each deal separately.

**Thoughtful Klondike** — Identical to ordinary Klondike except that the identity of every face-down card is known from the start. It is mostly a research construct: because the only difference is information, any deal solvable in Thoughtful Klondike is solvable in Klondike too, so solving it gives an upper bound on how often the real game can be won. This is where the roughly 82 percent figure for draw three with unlimited redeals comes from; the same technique is what any credible winnability claim for Klondike rests on.

**Double Klondike** — Two decks, 104 cards, nine tableau piles dealt one through nine, and eight foundations, two per suit. Building rules are unchanged: foundations up in suit from the ace, tableau down in alternating colours, kings only into empty columns. The extra piles make it noticeably easier to win than single-deck Klondike. The name is also used for a two-player

race in which each player has their own tableau but both feed a shared set of foundations.

**Whitehead** — The same 28-card, seven-pile layout as Klondike, but everything is dealt face up so there is nothing hidden. The tableau builds down in matching colour rather than alternating colour, red on red and black on black. Only runs that are entirely of one suit may be moved as a block, and an empty column will take any card or run, not just a king.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Laboratory, GameRules.com, Solitaired, Solitaire.com, BVS Solitaire, Solitaire winnability study (Blake and Gent).

# Pyramid

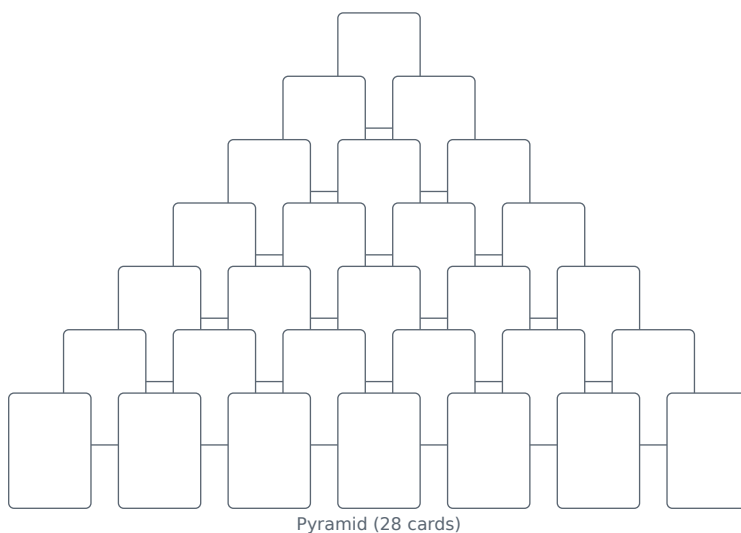
|                      |                                                             |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Pyramid Solitaire, Solitaire Thirteen, Pile of Twenty-Eight |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                                    |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                                  |
| <b>Time</b>          | 5-15 minutes                                                |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                                        |

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## Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck and build the pyramid face up in seven rows. Lay one card at the top, then two below it, then three, and so on down to a bottom row of seven, for 28 cards in all. Offset each row so that every card rests on and partly covers the two cards above it, and so that each card in turn is partly covered by the two below it. Only the seven cards of the bottom row start out completely uncovered.

The remaining 24 cards form the stock, squared up face down to one side. Leave space next to it for a waste pile and space somewhere clear for discards. Ranks count as numbers throughout: ace is 1, jack is 11, queen is 12, king is 13, and every other card is its face value. Suit and colour never matter.



Every card is covered by the two below it, so only the seven cards of the bottom row start free.

## Play

A card is available only when nothing overlaps it. In the pyramid that means both cards below it have already been removed. The bottom row is available from the start; each removal frees the cards above once their other supporter also goes.

Remove available cards in pairs that add to exactly 13. The pairings are ace with queen, 2 with jack, 3 with 10, 4 with 9, 5 with 8, and 6 with 7. Kings are worth 13 on their own, so any available king is removed by itself at any time. That holds wherever the king is: an uncovered king in the pyramid and a king sitting on top of the waste can each be discarded singly. Removed cards are set aside for good and never come back into play.

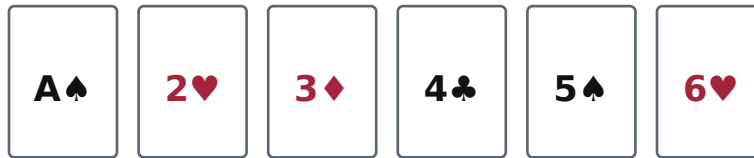
Both cards of a pair must be available at the moment you take them, but they need not be in the same place. You may pair two uncovered pyramid cards, or one pyramid card with the top card of the waste. Two pyramid cards that sit side by side in the same row can be paired normally, since neither covers the other. What you cannot do is use a card that is still covered, however visible its rank is.

When you want a new card, turn the top card of the stock face up onto the waste. Only the top of the waste is live; the cards under it are buried until it is played. Play the turned card immediately if you can, or leave it and turn another. The card you just turned may be paired with the previous top of the waste, so two consecutive stock cards summing to 13 clear each other.

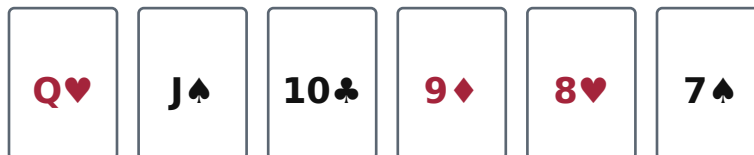
Draw at your own pace, and take any legal removal at any time. Nothing is ever compulsory: you may decline a pair that is sitting right in front of you, and deliberately leaving one card of a matched pair in place to save a rank for later is a standard tactic, as is holding a convenient card on top of the waste while you work through the pyramid. Equally, there is no obligation to draw while useful pairings remain on the table.

The strict traditional rule gives you a single pass through the stock and no redeal, and that is what this entry assumes. Sources genuinely differ here and most computer versions default to three passes instead, so agree a number before you deal. The deal ends when the stock is exhausted and no further pair can be removed. Since a card buried in the waste is gone for the rest of the deal under those rules, the order in which you spend stock cards matters more than anything else you do.

One card



Pairs with



Goes alone



Worth 13

Available cards are removed in pairs totalling 13, counting ace 1, jack 11 and queen 12. Each card pairs with the one directly below it. A king is 13 by itself.

## Goal & scoring

You win by dismantling the whole pyramid: all 28 cards removed. Cards left in the stock or waste are ignored, so clearing the last pyramid card wins immediately even with a stack of unused cards beside you.

The traditional game keeps no score beyond won or lost. Under the strict single-pass rules a clear is genuinely uncommon, and a great many deals are unwinnable no matter how well you play, so judging yourself on wins per session is fairer than judging a single deal.

If you want a score, the usual convention is a penalty of one point per card left in the pyramid, tallied over several deals with the lowest total best. Computer versions often add time bonuses and streak bonuses on top, which is a house scoring layer rather than part of the game.

## Variants

**Three passes** — After the stock runs out, turn the waste over without shuffling to make a new stock and go again. Two redeals, for three passes in total, is the most common relaxed setting and the one most computer versions default to. It rescues cards buried early in the first pass and raises the win rate

substantially.

**Draw three** — Turn stock cards three at a time instead of one, with only the top of each triple available, and allow unlimited redeals to compensate. Sold as King Tut or Tut's Tomb in various solitaire collections. Buried cards become reachable eventually, but you have far less control over which card is showing at any given moment.

**Giza** — An open variant by Michael Keller. The pyramid is dealt as usual, but the 24 leftover cards go face up into eight piles of three instead of a face-down stock, with the top card of each pile available. Nothing is hidden and there is no drawing, so the deal is a pure planning puzzle that you either solve or do not.

**Apophis** — Deal the standard 28-card pyramid, then run the stock into three separate waste piles instead of one, choosing which pile each turned card goes on. The top card of all three piles is available at once, which gives you three live cards to work with and much better control over what you keep in reach.

**Clear everything** — A harder scoring condition rather than a different layout: you must remove all 52 cards, stock and waste included, not just the pyramid. Very few deals can be beaten this way, so it is best treated as an occasional challenge rather than the default.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Solitaire Central Rulebook, Wikibooks Solitaire card games, BVS Solitaire, Bicycle Cards, PlayingCardDecks.

# Spider

|                      |                                                                                                             |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Spider Solitaire, Spider Patience                                                                           |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                                                                                    |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 2 standard decks (104 cards); the easier settings replace the pack with repeated copies of one or two suits |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                                                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                                                                                        |

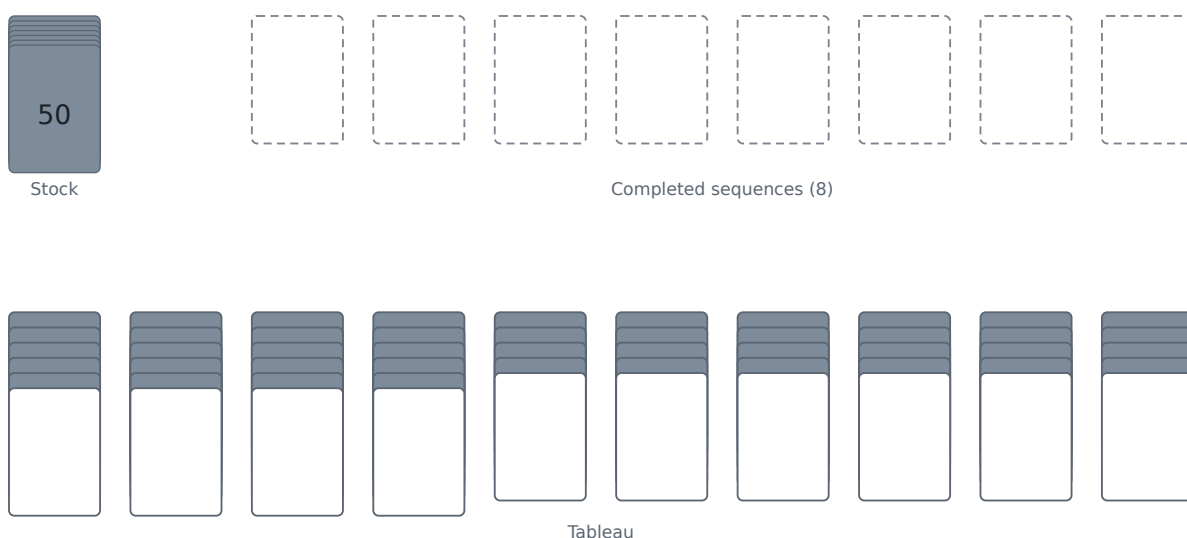
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## Setup

Spider is played with 104 cards, the equivalent of two standard decks. Which suits those cards come from is the difficulty setting. The four-suit game uses two full decks, two of each suit. The two-suit game uses four copies each of two suits, usually spades and hearts. The one-suit game uses eight copies of a single suit. With real cards you are effectively playing four-suit unless you go to the trouble of assembling a stripped pack, which is why the easier settings are mainly a computer thing.

Shuffle all 104 cards together and deal 54 of them into ten tableau columns: six cards each to the first four columns and five cards each to the remaining six. Deal them face down, then turn the exposed card of each column face up. The 50 cards left over become the stock, set aside face down. It will feed the tableau in five deals of ten.

There are no foundation piles to build on. Just leave a clear area beside the tableau for completed sequences, which come off the table intact. You will need room for eight of them.



Only the exposed card of each column starts face up; the stock feeds five deals of ten.



## Play

Everything happens in the tableau. Build columns downward by rank, and by rank alone: any 9 may be placed on any 10 whatever the suits. Aces are low and kings are high, so nothing can ever be placed on an ace, and a king can never be placed on another card.

Suit matters for moving, not for placing. You may always move the single exposed card at the end of a column. You may move several cards as a block only if they sit at the end of a column in unbroken descending rank order, one rank at a time with no gaps, and are all of the same suit. The 8, 7 and 6 of clubs travel together; a stack of club 8, heart 7, club 6 is a perfectly legal arrangement on the table but has to be taken apart one card at a time. Where the block lands is governed by rank only, exactly as for a single card: that run of clubs will go onto any 9 at all, or into an empty column. So the suit rule constrains what you can pick up, never what you can put it on. That single restriction is what makes the multi-suit games hard, and it is the rule newcomers most often get wrong.

When a move uncovers a face-down card at the end of a column, turn it face up at once.

An empty column will accept any card, or any block you are allowed to move. Nothing is reserved for kings. Putting a king there is usually the strongest use of the space, though, since a column headed by a low card can only ever take a few more cards on top.

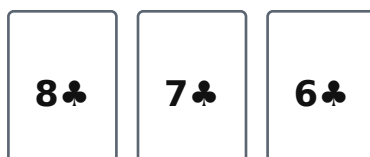
When you have no move worth making, deal from the stock: one card face up onto the end of every one of the ten columns, all at once. Dealing is never forced and never has to wait for the tableau to dry up, so you may take a deal whenever you judge the position is as good as it is going to get. You may do this five times, which exactly exhausts the 50-card stock. There is one hard condition attached. Every column must contain at least one card before you deal. If any column is empty you cannot deal, and you have to fill it first, even with a single junk card. Players regularly lose games by clearing a column and then discovering they have locked themselves out of the stock, so plan the deal before you empty anything. Note also that a deal drops a card onto every column whether it helps or not, so it will usually bury runs you were part way through assembling.

Whenever a full descending same-suit sequence from king down to ace sits at the end of a column, it is removed from the table and set aside. That sequence is finished and can never be touched again. Removing it exposes whatever was underneath, which is very often the real reason you built it. Most software lifts a completed sequence off automatically the moment it

forms; where removal is offered as a choice there is never a reason to decline, since nothing can be built on an ace anyway.

You win the moment the eighth sequence comes off. You lose when the stock is exhausted and no legal move remains, though in practice a game is over well before that, as soon as the cards you still need are buried under a card of lower rank in every column that could reach them. Shuffling, undoing a deal, or restarting is not part of the rules; the deal you were given is the deal you play.

Moves as a block



Not a block: mixed suits



Not a block: rank gap



The block lands on any 9



Suit ignored

Suit decides what you may pick up, never where it lands. A block must be one suit in unbroken descending order; anything else has to move one card at a time.

## Goal & scoring

You win by assembling and removing all eight complete king-to-ace sequences, each one entirely in a single suit, which clears every card off

the table. Anything short of eight is a loss; there is no partial credit in casual play.

Where software keeps score, the usual arrangement hands you 500 at the outset and then erodes it as you work: every action costs a single point, and that includes taking a deal from the stock as well as reversing yourself with undo. Running the other way is a credit of 100 for each suit sequence sent off the table. Add all eight credits to an untouched opening balance and the ceiling comes to 1,300, a figure nobody meets, because the hundreds of moves a genuine game demands have eaten into the balance long before the last sequence forms.

Not every deal can be won, and the suit setting changes the odds enormously. One-suit Spider is winnable nearly every time with careful play, with competent players reporting rates around 90 percent and higher. Two-suit is a real puzzle, with skilled play landing somewhere in the 30 to 40 percent range. Four-suit is the serious version: strong players usually win well under 20 percent of deals, and casual averages sit in the single digits. Unlike FreeCell, Spider has no authoritative exhaustive solvability study, so these numbers come from large samples of actual play rather than from solvers, and you should treat them as ballpark figures.

## Variants

**Spiderette** — One deck, Klondike-shaped. Deal 28 cards into seven columns of one through seven, exposed card face up, and keep the other 24 as stock. Building, group movement and sequence removal follow Spider exactly, but you only need four king-to-ace suit sequences. The stock is dealt seven at a time, one card onto each column, and the last deal is short: three cards, going to the leftmost columns.

**Will o' the Wisp** — A faster one-deck Spider. Deal seven columns of three cards each, 21 in total, with only the exposed card of each column face up. The remaining 31 cards feed the tableau one card per column: four full deals of seven, then a final short deal of three that goes to the three leftmost columns. Everything else matches Spider, and four suit sequences win it. The shallow columns mean far less is hidden at the start, which makes it markedly kinder than Spiderette.

**Black Widow** — Spider with the group-move restriction dropped. Same two decks, same 54-card deal into ten columns and same five deals of ten from the stock, but any run in descending rank order may be picked up and moved as a block whatever its suits. Removal still demands a full king-to-ace sequence in one suit, so the goal is unchanged. Lifting the restriction that makes four-suit Spider punishing leaves a game far easier than four-suit but still harder than one-suit Spider, since you must eventually sort the suits out to score. Some

sources instead use the name Black Widow for plain one-suit Spider, so check which is meant before you sit down.

**Simple Simon** — One deck, no stock, nothing hidden. All 52 cards go face up into ten columns of eight, eight, eight, seven, six, five, four, three, two and one. Build down by rank ignoring suit, move blocks only when they are same-suit descending runs, and put any card into an empty column. Remove the four king-to-ace suit sequences to win. With no stock and full information it is a pure puzzle rather than a game of chance.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Semicolon Solitaire Rules, Solitaired, BVS Solitaire, SuitedGames, TrySolitaire, Solitaire Bliss.

# TriPeaks

|                      |                                                  |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Tri Peaks, Three Peaks, Triple Peaks, Tri Towers |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                                         |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                       |
| <b>Time</b>          | 5-15 minutes                                     |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                           |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)                             |

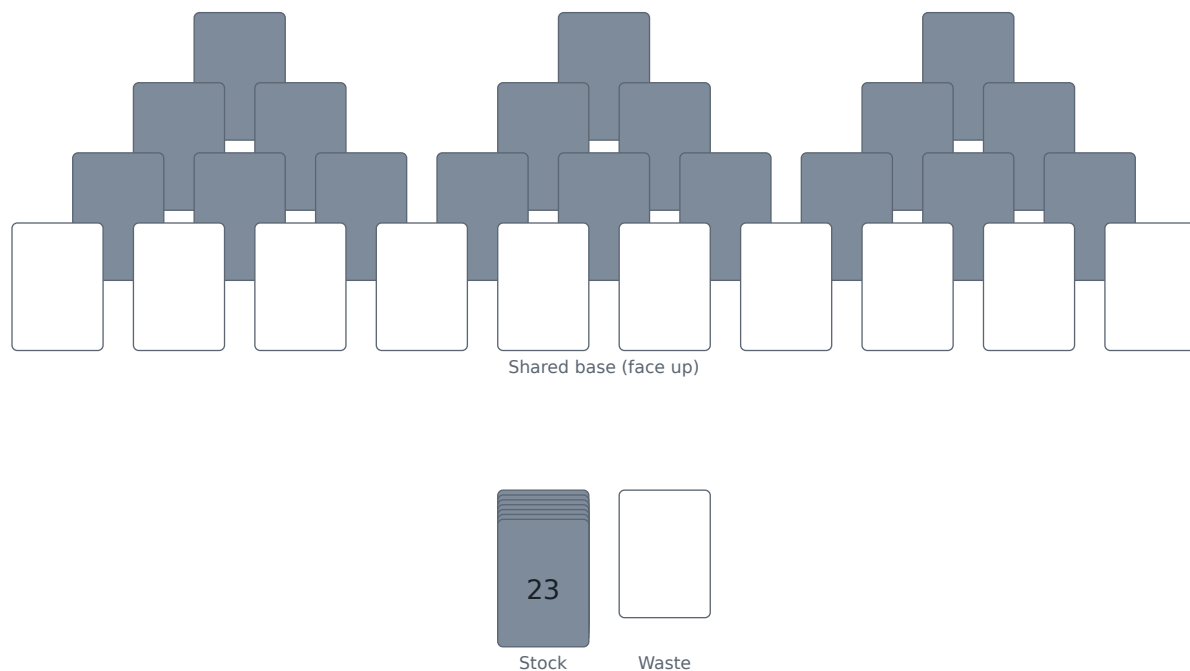
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## Setup

Shuffle a full 52-card deck. The tableau takes 28 of it, arranged as three peaks that share a single base, and everything except the bottom row goes down face down — eighteen hidden cards in all.

Three separated cards along the top, one to a peak. A row of six beneath them, two tucked under each summit so that each summit rests on both. A row of nine below that, three to a peak. Then the bottom row of ten, face up, running the full width of the layout. That last row is where the peaks interlock: its fourth and seventh cards each help support two neighbouring peaks at once, which is why clearing one peak so often opens another.

That leaves 24 cards. One of them goes face up beside the peaks to open the waste pile and the other 23 stay face down as the stock. Ranks matter and suits never do, so there is no need to keep the layout tidy by colour.



Three peaks stand on one ten-card base. A card turns face up once both cards below it are gone, so the board opens upward and the summits fall last.

## Play

A card is playable only when nothing overlaps it. The ten cards of the base are free from the start; every other card is pinned by the two cards below it and turns face up the instant the second of those leaves.

The move is one rule. Take any free card whose rank is one step from the card showing on the waste and lay it on the waste, where it becomes the new target. Suit is irrelevant; rank is the whole question. With a 9 showing, any free 8 and any free 10 are yours, and whichever you take is what the next card must match.

Ranks run in a circle for this purpose. The ace sits between the king and the 2, so a king may be played onto an ace and an ace onto a king. That hinge is what turns a chain of four cards into a chain of a dozen, and it is the rule worth agreeing before you deal: the original game allows it and nearly every computer version follows, while stricter rule sets stop the sequence dead at the king and lose a noticeable share of otherwise winnable deals by doing so.

When nothing on the table matches, turn the top stock card face up onto the waste. It becomes the new target whether it suits you or not. There are 23 of those turns and no more. The waste is never turned over, never reshuffled, and a card buried in it is finished for the deal.

Drawing is never forced and never has to wait until you are stuck, so you can spend a draw to escape a position you dislike. The whole game lives in the moments when two or more free cards would both be legal: take the wrong one and the other is stranded, costing you a draw you will want back. Looking one card ahead is rarely enough. The players who clear peaks are the ones working out which card has to go now to release the card sitting on top of it.

The deal ends when the last of the 28 peak cards reaches the waste, which is a win, or when the stock is empty and no free card matches, which is a loss. Cards still in the stock at the finish are simply ignored.

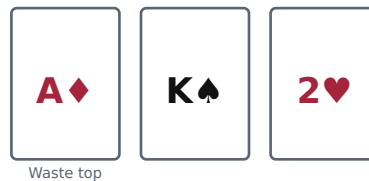
Ordinary match



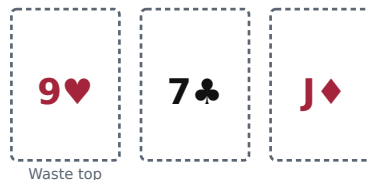
The wrap, going up



The wrap, coming back down



Two ranks away: illegal



Any free card one rank from the waste top may be played. Suit is ignored, and the ranks wrap so the ace bridges the king and the 2.

## Goal & scoring

You win by clearing all 28 cards of the three peaks onto the waste.

Whatever is left in the stock does not count, so the last peak card ends the deal on the spot.

The original scoring is built around one idea: consecutive removals. A run of cards taken without touching the stock is called a streak, and each card in a streak is worth more than the one before it, so the value of a chain climbs steeply the longer you keep it alive. Drawing from the stock breaks the run and the count restarts. Clearing a peak pays a bonus on top, and the peak that finishes the deal pays double what the earlier two pay. The system was tuned so that a player who builds chains, rather than grabbing whichever

card is legal first, comes out ahead across a session — which is why the wrap at the ace is worth so much more than it looks.

Commercial versions layer their own arrangements over this, commonly a clock, a deduction for each draw, or a penalty for cards left standing if you concede. None of that belongs to the original game.

Most deals can be cleared. Solvability with the wrap allowed is usually quoted above 90 percent, and one exact-solver run over about a thousand deals put it near 97, while ordinary players report winning around half their games. That gap is not luck. It is the price of spending draws in the wrong order.

| Scores                         | Value                     | Notes                                                                   |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| First card of a streak         | 1                         | —                                                                       |
| Second card of the same streak | 2                         | —                                                                       |
| Each card after that           | 3, then 4, then 5, upward | —                                                                       |
| Drawing from the stock         | 0                         | Breaks the streak; the next card removed scores 1 again.                |
| A seven-card streak, all told  | 28                        | One plus two on up to seven, against 7 for the same cards taken singly. |
| Clearing the first peak        | 15                        | —                                                                       |
| Clearing the second peak       | 15                        | —                                                                       |
| Clearing the third peak        | 30                        | —                                                                       |

## Variants

**Strict ranking, no wrap** — The ace is treated as the bottom of the order rather than a hinge, so it plays only beside a 2 and the king plays only beside a queen. Nothing else changes, and the two rule sets look identical until the first king turns up. Closing the wrap cuts off the long chains the scoring is built around and converts a fair number of clearable deals into dead ends, which is why almost every published version leaves it open.

**Double TriPeaks** — Two decks and two full peak layouts side by side, 56 tableau cards in all, with the 48 cards left over feeding one shared waste and one shared stock: turn one up to start the waste and 47 remain to draw, so you get 47 draws rather than 23. The matching rule, the wrap and the face-down pattern are untouched, and all six peaks must come down to win. Roughly twice the board with roughly twice the draws, so it plays longer than the single game without being much harder per card. Sold under names including Six Peaks and Two Deck TriPeaks.

**Golf** — The older and plainer relative. Thirty-five cards go face up into seven columns of five with nothing hidden at all, and the same one-rank-either-way rule sends an exposed card to the waste. Traditional Golf does not wrap at the ace, which is the main reason it is the harder game despite showing you



everything on the table from the start.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Semicolon Solitaire Rules, BVS Solitaire, Solitaire Association, TrySolitaire, Solitaire Bliss, Solitaire Network.

# Yukon

|                      |                                 |
|----------------------|---------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Yukon Solitaire, Yukon Patience |
| <b>Players</b>       | 1 player                        |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)      |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-30 minutes                   |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                            |
| <b>Category</b>      | Solitaire (1 player)            |

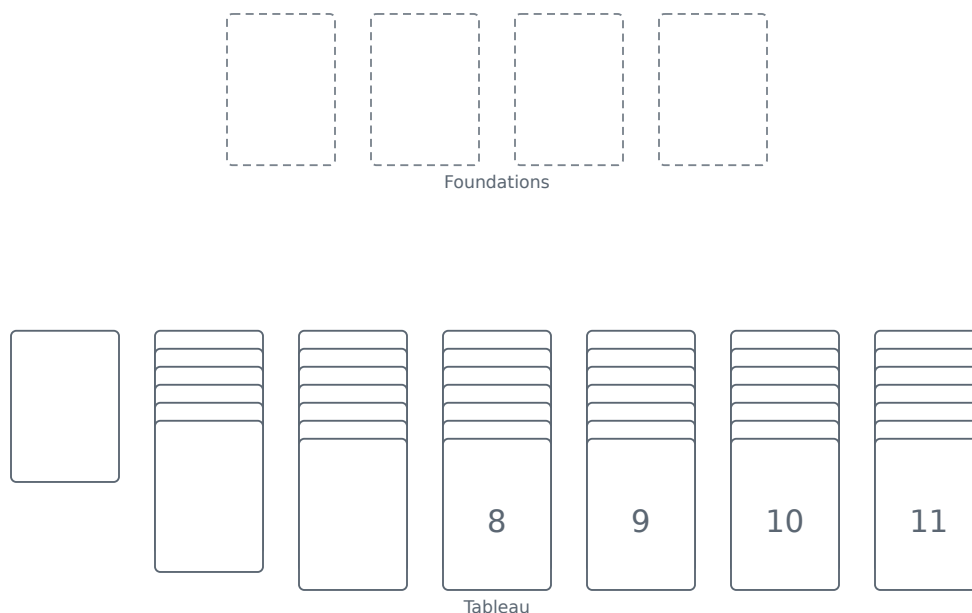
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## Setup

Yukon takes one 52-card deck and rather more table than you expect, because every card ends up in the tableau and the columns grow long.

Begin with a Klondike deal. Lay out seven columns, one card into the first, two into the second, on up to seven into the seventh, all face down, then turn up the last card of each column. That accounts for 28 cards. Now take the 24 still in your hand and deal them face up, four to each of the six columns other than the first, so column one is left exactly as it was: a single card, face up.

Leave four spaces above the tableau for the foundations. They start empty. There is no stock and no waste, since the whole deck is already on the table. Overlap each column enough that every face-up rank stays readable.



The whole pack is dealt. Column one is a lone face-up card; columns two to seven hide one to six face-down cards apiece beneath five face-up ones.

## Play

Two kinds of building go on, and only one of them is where the game is decided.

The four foundations rise in suit from the ace: any ace showing at the end of a column may be laid up at once, the 2 of its suit next, and so on to the king. Foundation moves take a single card, and that card has to be the exposed one at the end of a column. The seven columns build downward in alternating colours: a black 7 belongs on a red 8, and a red 6 on that black 7. Ranks do not wrap round in the tableau: a queen goes on a king, but an ace is the bottom of a run and accepts nothing at all.

Now the rule everything turns on. You are not confined to the exposed card of a column. Put a finger on any face-up card anywhere in the tableau, lift it together with every card lying on top of it, and set the whole load down as one unit. The passengers can be in any state at all — out of order, colours repeating, a king riding on a 2 — and none of it matters. The only test is applied to the card you picked up: it has to land on a card one rank higher and of the opposite colour.

Uncovering a face-down card turns it up at once. That is the one thing in Yukon that happens by itself.

An emptied column is reserved for kings. Move in a king by itself, or a load whose bottom card is a king, and nothing else. Emptying a column is hard work in a game with no stock to refill it, so doing it without a king waiting is usually wasted effort.

Most rule sets let you take a card back off a foundation, and with no reserve of any kind to fall back on, that is the kinder default. Only the topmost card of a foundation may come back, it travels alone, and it has to land on a card one rank higher of the opposite colour — or in an empty column, and then only if it is a king. A few rule sets forbid the move outright, so settle which you are playing before you deal.

Nothing is compulsory. Exposed aces may sit where they are, empty columns may stay empty, and a legal move can always be declined in favour of a better one later.

With no stock, there is no rescue. The deal ends when the fourth foundation reaches its king, or when you survey the table and find that no card, alone or loaded, has anywhere legal to go. That second ending arrives more abruptly than beginners expect. Twenty-one of the fifty-two cards start face down, all of them stacked beneath columns you have to dig through, and the freedom to shuffle great heaps of cards around does not help at all once the card you need is at the bottom of one.

End of a column



Lands on it as one unit



Only this must fit

Same colour at the join: illegal



Red onto red

The move that defines Yukon: any face-up card travels with everything piled on it. Only the card you grab has to fit — one rank lower, opposite colour.

## Goal & scoring

The deal is won when all 52 cards have climbed the foundations, ace through king in each of the four suits. Anything short of that is a loss. With no stock and no redeal there is no partial credit and no second run at the same deal.

Traditional play keeps no score at all. Software usually bolts on the Klondike standard system — a credit for each card promoted to a foundation, a credit for each face-down card turned up, a charge for pulling a card back down — or simply runs a clock.

How often Yukon can be won is genuinely unsettled, and the figures in circulation measure two different things while being quoted as though they measured one. The largest published tally, drawn from over half a million recorded games, lands close to 14 in 100 — roughly one deal in seven — which mostly reflects that people abandon awkward deals rather than grind them out. Claims that a patient player takes the large majority of deals are equally common and are not absurd, since only 21 cards are hidden and the rest can be rearranged almost at will. Nobody has run the kind of exhaustive solver study that settled FreeCell, so treat any single headline

percentage sceptically and judge yourself across a run of deals instead of one.

## Variants

**Russian Solitaire** — Identical deal and identical freedom to move any face-up card with its whole load, but the tableau builds down in suit rather than in alternating colours. Losing the colour rule removes roughly half of every card's possible destinations, and the result is one of the harder one-deck games. It is the best-known member of the family and worth trying only once ordinary Yukon feels routine.

**Alaska** — The Yukon layout and the Yukon group move, with the tableau built in suit but in either direction: on the 9 of hearts you may place either the 8 or the 10 of hearts. The choice is made afresh at every card and a column is never locked into the direction it started in, so an exposed card will take either of its suit-neighbours, whichever one you still have loose. Being able to run a column upwards as well as downwards buys back some of what the same-suit restriction takes away, which puts Alaska between Yukon and Russian Solitaire in difficulty.

**Moosehide** — The Yukon deal, the Yukon foundations and the Yukon group move, with one change to the tableau: a card builds on any card one rank higher except one of its own suit. The 8 of clubs will go on either red 9 or on the 9 of spades, but never on the 9 of clubs. Three of the four cards of a rank stay open to you where the colour rule leaves only two, so this is the loosest build in the family and a shade kinder than Yukon itself, with Russian Solitaire at the far end. Watch the name: a few rule sets attach it instead to a Yukon deal in which only a proper descending alternating-colour run may be lifted as a group, Klondike style, which is a much harsher game. Check which one your source means before you start.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, BVS Solitaire, Solitaire City, Solitaired, Solitaire Bliss, Solitaire Network, Pure Solitaire.

## TRICK-TAKING

# Belote

|                      |                                                                             |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Belote Classique, Belotte                                                   |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4 players                                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 32 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                      |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                |

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## Setup

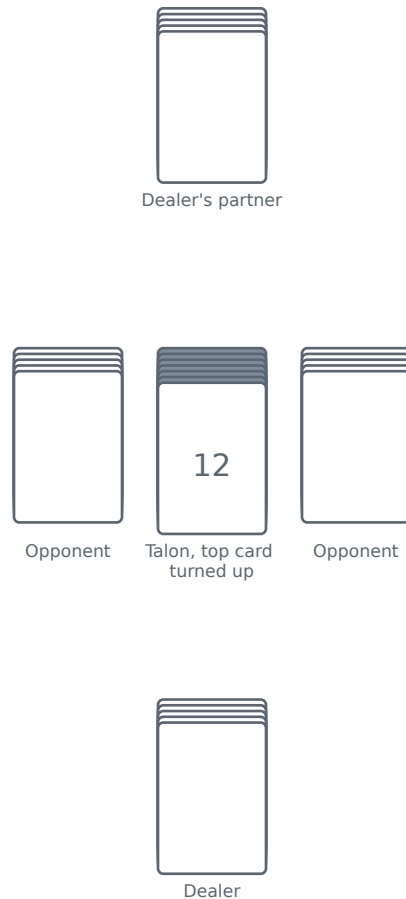
Four players in two fixed partnerships, partners facing each other. Build the pack by pulling every card below the seven out of a standard deck, which leaves thirty-two.

Cut for the first deal. After that the deal moves to the right, and so does play — belote is one of the French games that runs anticlockwise, and getting the direction wrong is the commonest mistake at a mixed table. Traditionally the pack is shuffled only once at the start of a session and merely cut between hands, so the order the tricks left it in carries forward. Plenty of tables shuffle anyway; agree which you are doing.

Deal five cards to each player in two packets, three then two or two then three, and turn the next card face up in the middle. That card is the *retourne*, and it is the trump on offer. The other eleven sit face down beside it, untouched for the moment.

Before anything else, learn the two rankings, because trump and plain suits use different ones and neither is the order you already know. A plain suit runs ace, ten, king, queen, jack, nine, eight, seven from the top. In trump the jack vaults to first and the nine to second, giving jack, nine, ace, ten, king, queen, eight, seven.

Card values split the same way. Outside trump an ace is 11, a ten is 10, a king 4, a queen 3, a jack 2, and the nine, eight and seven count nothing. In trump the jack is worth 20 and the nine 14, while the ace, ten, king and queen keep their ordinary values and the eight and seven are still blanks. The pack therefore holds 152 points, and the final trick is worth 10 more, so every deal puts 162 on the table before any declaration is counted.



Partners sit opposite and play passes to the right. Twenty cards go out first, five to each player; the twelve left over wait in the middle with the top one face up as the trump on offer.

## Play

**Bidding.** Starting with the player on the dealer's right and going round to the right, each player in turn either takes the retourne's suit as trump or passes. Whoever takes it becomes the taker, picks the card up into hand, and commits their partnership to the contract. If all four pass, a second round starts from the same seat, and now a player may name any of the other three suits as trump — never the suit that was turned. Taking in the second round still means taking the card: the taker adds the face-up card to their hand, where it is now just an ordinary card of a plain suit. Four more passes and the hand is dead; the cards are gathered and the next player to the dealer's right deals afresh.

Once trump is settled the rest of the pack goes out. The taker, already holding the turned card, gets two more; each of the other three gets three. Everyone finishes with eight and nothing is left over.

**Declarations.** Combinations held in the hand pay, but only one side collects them. Runs of three, four, and five or more cards in a single suit score, and so does four of a kind in any rank except the eights and sevens.

The catch is that runs are read in the ordinary order — ace, king, queen, jack, ten, nine, eight, seven — which has nothing to do with the order the cards take tricks in. The three biggest trumps sitting in your hand look magnificent and are not a run at all.

Collecting them is a contest, and it is settled over the first trick. Each player who holds something announces it as they play their card to that trick, naming the kind and, if a rival claims the same kind, the top card of it — never the suit. Once the trick is complete the best declaration at the table is known: the side that owns it scores every declaration on its side, and the other side scores none of its own, however many it was holding. Four of a kind outranks any run; between runs the longer wins, and between runs of equal length the higher top card. Should the two best still be dead level, the one in trump prevails, and if neither is in trump nobody scores. The side that has won the contest lays the cards face up as it plays to the second trick, so the other side can see the combination was real; a declaration never shown is never paid.

Belote-rebelote stands outside all of that. Hold the king and queen of trumps and you say belote as you play the first of the pair and rebelote as you play the second, which is worth 20 to your side. It cannot be outranked, it never competes with anything, and it counts whether the rest of the hand goes well or badly. Forget to say it at the right moment and it is gone.

The tricks. The player on the dealer's right leads to the first trick. What you are allowed to put on a trick is far more constrained than in most trick games:

- Follow the suit led whenever you hold it.
- When trump is led, following is not enough: play a trump higher than any already in the trick if you have one. If every trump you hold is lower you must still follow with one of them. (Most French tables demand this even when your own partner is winning the trick; a few release you. Agree before the first deal.)
- Void in a plain suit an opponent is winning, you must trump it.
- Void in a plain suit that an opponent has already trumped, you must beat that trump if you hold a higher one. If your trumps are all lower you must still play one, throwing it away for nothing.
- Void in a plain suit while your own partner is winning the trick, you are released from all of it: play any card you like, trump or not.
- Void in the suit led with no trump left at all, you are equally free, and simply discard.



Having to throw a losing trump under an opponent's higher one is the rule that catches newcomers, and the partner exemption is the one that saves them: when your partner already holds the trick, French players say the partner is master, and you are released from having to trump at all.

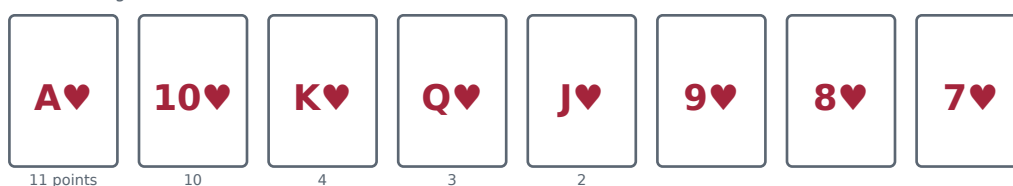
The highest trump takes the trick, or the highest card of the suit led when no trump is played, and the winner leads to the next. Eight tricks empty the hands.

Trump, high to low



Trump ranking with spades as trump. The jack and the nine jump the ace, and they take the two largest card values with them.

Plain suit, high to low



Every other suit. The ten still outranks the king, but the jack falls back to fifth and is worth only 2, and the nine is worth nothing.

Quarte, 50



Not a run



Belote-rebelote, 20



Declarations are read in the ordinary order, never in the trick-taking order. The top three trumps are not a run, however good they are to hold.

## Goal & scoring

At the end of the hand each side counts the card values in the tricks it took, whoever took the last trick adds 10 for it, and each side adds the declarations it is entitled to.

Everything then hinges on one comparison: did the takers finish with at least as many points as their opponents? If so, nothing needs adjusting anywhere and each side banks the total it just counted — and note the direction of that, because it makes a dead heat at 81 apiece a success for the takers rather than a failure. Only when the takers come out strictly behind has the deal collapsed into what French players call *dedans*. Nothing the takers gathered stays with them. The full 162 crosses the table, and so does every declaration point earned during the deal, theirs as well as the defenders' own, all of it written into the defenders' column. *Belote-rebelote* is the exception that survives: those 20 belong to the player who called them and are not affected by how badly the rest of the deal went.

Taking all eight tricks is *capot* and pays 90 above the trick score, so a side that sweeps the hand books 252 before anything it declared.

The match runs to 1000 points and the first side to reach it wins. Should both sides cross in the same deal, the game is drawn.

| Scores                                    | Value | Notes                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------|-------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Jack of trumps                            | 20    | —                                                      |
| Nine of trumps                            | 14    | —                                                      |
| Ace, any suit                             | 11    | —                                                      |
| Ten, any suit                             | 10    | —                                                      |
| King, any suit                            | 4     | —                                                      |
| Queen, any suit                           | 3     | —                                                      |
| Jack, not trump                           | 2     | —                                                      |
| Nine not trump, and all eights and sevens | 0     | —                                                      |
| Last trick                                | 10    | 162 on the table every deal                            |
| Capot, all eight tricks                   | +90   | —                                                      |
| Belote-rebelote (K and Q of trumps)       | 20    | never contested, and kept even when the contract fails |
| Run of three ( <i>tierce</i> )            | 20    | —                                                      |
| Run of four ( <i>quarte</i> )             | 50    | —                                                      |
| Run of five or more ( <i>quinte</i> )     | 100   | —                                                      |
| Four jacks                                | 200   | —                                                      |
| Four nines                                | 150   | —                                                      |
| Four aces, tens, kings or queens          | 100   | —                                                      |
| Four eights or sevens                     | 0     | not a declaration                                      |

## Variants

**Coinche (Belote Contrée)** — The tournament form, and in France at least as popular as the parent game. The *retourne* disappears: all eight cards are dealt at once and the players hold an auction, bidding a number of points from 80 upward together with the suit they intend to play in. Any opponent may *coincher*, doubling the stakes, and the bidding side may *surcoincher* to double them again. The contract must be made exactly as bid or the whole value goes to the defenders, which turns the game from a matter of card play into a matter of accurate valuation. Scores are normally rounded to the nearest ten.

**Belote sans annonces** — Belote with declarations switched off entirely, apart from *belote-rebelote*, which everybody keeps. Runs and four of a kind are worth nothing and are not announced at the first trick. It strips out the fiddliest part of the rules and the whole business of comparing declarations, so it is what most tables teach a beginner on before adding the announcements back in a few hands later.

**All trumps and no trumps** — Two extra contracts widely used in Coinche and standard across the Balkans. In *tout* *atout* every suit ranks and scores as trump, so all four jacks are worth 20 and all four nines 14, and the deal holds 248 in the cards plus 10 for the last trick, or 258. In *sans* *atout* no suit is trump, every suit ranks the plain way, and the values are doubled to compensate for how little the pack is otherwise worth — ace 22, ten 20, king 8, queen 6, jack 4, and 20 for the last trick, giving 260. Because neither total is 162, both are scaled back against it before a contract in them can be compared with a suit contract. French *coinche* tables often prefer a third arrangement for no trumps, counting the ace as 19 and everything else normally, which lands on 162 exactly and needs no scaling at all.

**Short-handed belote** — Belote for two or three players drops the partnership and keeps everything else: both rankings, the card values, the declarations and *belote-rebelote*, the obligations to follow, beat and trump, and the taker alone against whoever is left. What has no settled form is the deal, which differs from region to region and from app to app — some three-player versions share out all thirty-two cards and do without a talon, others keep the *retourne* and a face-down remainder, and the two-player versions usually draw from a stock after each trick until it is exhausted and then play out the closing tricks under the full obligations. Fix the deal and the target score before you start rather than halfway through. Useful for learning the ranking without three other people waiting.

**Litige** — A different way of handling the 81-all deal, which the main rules simply award to the takers. Under *litige* only the defenders write their 81 down; the takers' half is neither scored nor discarded but waits, unowned, and attaches itself to the next deal somebody actually brings home, going to that

side on top of whatever they score there. Tie again and a second 81 joins the first, so the pot swells until a contract finally succeeds. It turns the one deal that can otherwise feel like nothing happened into something worth winning the next one for.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Britannica, Denexa Games, Fédération Française de Belote, iBelote, Nordic Card Games.

# Briscola

|                      |                                                                                  |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Briscola, Briškula                                                               |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                                                        |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 40 cards (A, K, Q, J, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                                    |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                           |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                     |

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## Setup

Briscola runs on forty cards. An Italian pack of coins, cups, swords and batons is ready to go as it comes; with an ordinary pack, discard the jokers and every eight, nine and ten, and you are left with exactly the same game in familiar pips. The Italian court of king, horse and jack maps onto king, queen and jack, which is the northern convention and the one most books print; many players in the south swap the last two over, making the jack the three-point card and the queen the two-point one. Settle which before you deal, because it is worth a point either way.

Deal and play both run counter-clockwise, so cards go out to the dealer's right and the deal itself moves right after every hand. Settle the first dealer any way you like; nothing in the game turns on it. Four players is the classic form, partners facing each other across the table; two is the form everyone learns on.

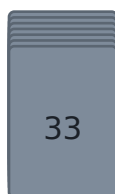
Give three cards to each player, one at a time, starting with the player on the dealer's right. What comes off the pack next is a single card, played face up on the table; the undealt remainder then goes down on top of it at an angle, squared enough to serve as a stock but leaving an edge of that one card on show all deal long. Its suit is the briscola, trump for the whole hand, and since everything else has been stacked over it, it is also the card that will be drawn last of all.

What has to be learned before the first trick is that the ranking follows the money rather than the pips. Only aces, threes and the three court cards carry any value at all, the pack holds 120 points between them, and 84 of those points sit in the four aces and the four threes alone. Those eight cards decide most hands, which is why they also sit at the top of the order.

Each side keeps its won tricks in a face-down pile and leaves them alone until the deal is over. Nobody counts aloud during play.



Opponent



Stock



Trump card  
(briscola)



Your hand

The two-handed deal. The trump card sits face up with the rest of the pack laid across it, so the suit stays in plain sight all game and that one card is the last draw of the deal.

| Players | Each player gets | Removed     |
|---------|------------------|-------------|
| 2       | 3 cards          | —           |
| 3       | 3 cards          | any one 2   |
| 4       | 3 cards          | —           |
| 5       | 8 cards          | —           |
| 6       | 3 cards          | all four 2s |

## Play

The player on the dealer's right leads to the first trick, and thereafter whoever won the last trick leads to the next.

Then comes the rule that makes Briscola what it is: there is no obligation to follow suit, ever. Whatever is led, you may answer with any card in your hand. Nobody is ever squeezed into throwing away a good card, so every trick is a free choice between spending a counter and hoarding it.

A trick is won by the highest trump played to it. With no trump in it, the trick falls to whoever played highest in whatever suit was led, and cards of the two or three suits that are neither trump nor the led suit cannot win it no matter how high they rank — a discarded ace off-suit takes nothing and

gives away eleven points to whoever does win. The winner turns the trick face down onto their pile.

Drawing keeps hands at three. A completed trick is followed by a round of replenishment, one card to everybody: it opens with whoever took the trick and travels counter-clockwise from there. Every player count that uses a stock divides the remainder evenly, so no round of drawing runs dry partway through and nobody is left a card short. It is that final round which strips the pile down to the exposed trump, so the trump card falls to whoever sits last in the drawing order — with two players, the one who has just lost the trick. From then on nothing is replaced, so every deal ends with three drawless tricks in which the whole remaining pack is, in principle, knowable. Counting what has already gone is where the game stops being luck.

The hand ends when everybody has run out of cards.

Partnerships. Most tables let partners help each other along in one of two ways, and the first trick is played in silence under either. One way is an agreed set of facial signals — *segni* — flashed when the opponents are not looking, each standing for one high trump: lips stretched over the teeth for the ace, the mouth pulled to one side for the three, a glance upward for the king, the tip of the tongue for the horse, a shrugged shoulder for the jack. The other, reported around Rome, is a limited vocabulary of questions and orders belonging to whoever leads the trick: you may ask a partner whether they hold low trumps, whether they hold high ones, whether they hold an ace or three outside trumps, or whether they can take the trick without trumping, and you may instruct them to do any of those things. What you may not ask about is the ace or the three of trumps themselves. Some groups allow neither, so decide before the first deal which kind of table you are at.

At five players the arithmetic stops working and the game turns into a different one, in which the whole pack is dealt out, there is no stock, and the trump suit is settled by auction.

High to low



Rank order inside every suit, high to low. This is the same in trumps and in plain suits — the trump suit does not reorder itself, it simply beats everything.

## Goal & scoring

The object is to capture point cards in tricks. When the last trick is over, each side gathers everything it won and adds up the values, and the totals must come to 120 between them — if they do not, a card has gone astray and the count has to be done again. That figure holds at three and six players as well, because the twos pulled out to make the pack divide are worth nothing.

Sixty-one takes the deal. There is no bonus for taking more, and the winner of a deal wins it exactly as much with 61 as with 120. A dead-level 60 apiece is a draw and neither side gets anything for it.

One deal is a short game, so tables usually play a match: best of three deals, or best of five, with a drawn deal counted to nobody and replayed. Some groups instead keep a running tally of deals won and stop at an agreed figure. At three players, where there are no partnerships, the highest of the three totals takes the deal — 61 is not needed and often not reached, since the same 120 is split three ways. One published scheme scores the three-handed game differently again, awarding a game point to each player who passes 40, two if only one player manages it, and three for taking all 120.

Because at two, four and six players 61 is the only threshold, the endgame is not about squeezing out extra points but about knowing when you are already safe. Once your pile is past 60 you can afford to throw the rest away, and a good player who is behind will hold aces back rather than spend them on tricks that do not close the gap.

| Scores                      | Value | Notes                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Each ace                    | 11    | —                                                                     |
| Each three                  | 10    | —                                                                     |
| Each king                   | 4     | —                                                                     |
| Each queen (horse)          | 3     | southern Italian tables swap the queen and jack values                |
| Each jack                   | 2     | —                                                                     |
| Seven, six, five, four, two | 0     | twenty worthless cards, called scartini; the three is not one of them |
| Whole pack                  | 120   | 61 wins the deal, 60 apiece is a draw                                 |

## Variants

**Briscola Chiamata** — The five-handed game, also met as *Briscola Bastarda*, *Briscola Assassina* or *Briscolone*. All forty cards are dealt out, eight each, with no stock and no turned trump. The auction is for the right to call a partner, and



it runs downwards: bidders name a rank only and never a suit, each bid must be lower than the last, and the auction goes to whoever will settle for the weakest partner. The winner then names the trump suit, and whoever holds the called card in that suit is their partner — silently, so for the first few tricks nobody is sure who they are helping. Bidding as far down as the two turns the auction into a points auction instead, each bid promising more than the last. The caller's side must take 61 card points, or whatever higher figure was bid; the other three win by holding them to 60. A caller who names a card in their own hand plays alone against four, and wins or loses double for it.

**Briscola Scoperta** — Open Briscola. Every hand is dealt face up and the stock is turned so that the next card to be drawn is visible too. All the hidden information disappears and the game becomes a pure calculation exercise, which makes it excellent for teaching a beginner what the discards are actually costing them.

**Briscolone** — A two-handed version with five-card hands instead of three and no trump suit at all, so a trick always goes to the higher card of the suit led. Losing the trump removes the game's escape hatch: an ace led is safe, and there is no way to steal a fat trick with a low card of a favoured suit. One deal does not settle it — play runs on to a cumulative 121 or 151 card points — and it is commonly played with an obligation the parent game never imposes, that you must follow suit when you can. A three-card version of the same idea goes further and makes you head the trick as well, for the three tricks after the stock has gone. Confusingly the name is also used in places for the five-handed calling game.

**Brisca (Spain)** — Brisca is the same game in Spain and runs the same way, including the freedom to throw whatever you like: heading the trick is no more obligatory there than it is in Italy. Two rules of its own are worth knowing. The exposed trump card can be bought — a player who has won at least one trick and holds the seven of trumps may swap it for the turned card if that card is higher than a seven, or the two if it is a seven or lower, at any time before the last draw. And a player holding the ace of trumps may play it and declare *arrastro*, which obliges everyone still to play to that trick to put down the best card they hold, trump suit first. Argentina's *brisca porteña* drops the free play altogether and requires following, trumping and overtrumping throughout, which makes it a noticeably different game from the one described above.

**No signals at all** — Some groups play the partnership game with no communication of any kind: no signs, no questions, no comment on the trick in progress, and the only information crossing the table is which cards get played and when. Chile's *brisca* is played this way as a matter of course. Groups used to signalling find the partnership game much harder without them, since a lead has to carry the whole message on its own.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Board Game Arena, Denexa Games, Gambiter, Official Game Rules.

# Contract Bridge

|                      |                                                                                                   |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Bridge, Rubber Bridge, Duplicate Bridge                                                           |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4 players                                                                                         |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards); most tables keep a second pack with different backs to speed the deal |
| <b>Time</b>          | 60+ minutes                                                                                       |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                                           |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                                      |

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## Setup

Bridge seats exactly four, locked into two partnerships for the session, each player facing their partner. Seats are named for the compass points, so one side is North and South and the other East and West, and those names are used for everything from filling in the score to discussing the hand afterwards.

Settle seats and the first deal by spreading a shuffled pack face down and having everyone draw a card. The two highest play against the two lowest; the highest card of all picks a seat and deals first. The deal then moves one place clockwise after every hand.

Use the full 52-card pack with jokers removed. Cards rank ace high down to the two, and the four suits are equal until the auction settles which of them, if any, is trumps. The player on the dealer's left shuffles and the player on the dealer's right cuts. Deal the entire pack one card at a time clockwise, beginning with the player on the dealer's left and ending with the dealer, thirteen to each player. Two packs are worked in tandem. While one hand is being played out, the spare pack is put in order by the player sitting opposite the dealer, who then parks it beside the seat that deals next; the following deal is therefore prepared before anyone needs it, and nobody has to stop and work out whose turn it is.

You need a score sheet. Rubber bridge uses one ruled with a vertical line separating the two sides and a horizontal line across it; trick points are written below that line and everything else above it, which is why bridge players talk about scoring above and below the line.

Vulnerability is a state a partnership is in, and it raises the stakes in both directions at once: bonuses grow and so do penalties. At rubber bridge you become vulnerable by winning a game and stay vulnerable for the rest of the rubber. At duplicate it is simply printed on the board and owes nothing to what happened on the deal before.

One thing this entry leaves out on purpose: bidding systems and

conventions. Acol, Standard American, Stayman, Blackwood, transfers and the hundreds of gadgets built on top of them are agreements a partnership makes about what its bids mean. They are not rules, and no two partnerships need use the same ones. What follows is the machinery of the game, which is identical whatever system you have agreed.

## Play

### THE AUCTION

The dealer calls first and calling passes clockwise. On your turn you make exactly one of four calls.

- Bid. Name a number from one to seven and a denomination: one of the four suits, or notrump. The number counts tricks above the first six, so a bid of four hearts undertakes to win ten of the thirteen tricks with hearts as trumps, and seven of anything undertakes to win the lot. Each bid must outrank the one before it, either by naming a higher number or by naming a higher-ranking denomination at the same number.
- Pass. No bid this turn. Passing does not put you out of the auction; you may bid later if someone else keeps it alive.
- Double. Available only when the last bid was made by an opponent and nothing but passes has followed it. It is a claim that the contract will fail. It changes nothing about the play and nothing about how many tricks are needed; it only inflates the score, multiplying what declarer earns for succeeding and what the defenders collect for beating it.
- Redouble. Available only to the side whose bid has just been doubled, again with nothing but passes since. It inflates the same figures further.

Any fresh bid cancels a double or redouble, and the new contract starts out undoubled. The auction closes when a call is followed by three passes in a row, and the last bid made becomes the contract. Should all four players pass immediately, nobody has undertaken anything: at rubber bridge the deal is abandoned and passes on, while at duplicate the board is recorded as a zero for both sides.

Beware the trap in the doubled part-score. Because the trick score is what gets multiplied, doubling can push a modest contract over the hundred-point threshold and hand the opponents a game they had not bid for. Doubling is a scoring weapon, not a defensive one.

Irregularities such as bidding out of turn or making a bid that is too low do not simply get rewound. The Laws prescribe a specific rectification for each, usually restricting what the offender's partner may do afterwards, and in club play a director is called to apply it.

## DECLARER AND DUMMY

The side that made the final bid plays the contract. Declarer is whichever of the two partners first named that denomination anywhere in the auction, which is not always the player who made the last bid: if your partner opened one spade and you eventually bid four spades, your partner is declarer. Declarer's partner becomes the dummy and the other two are the defenders.

## PLAYING THE HAND

Before anything at all is revealed, the defender sitting to declarer's left has to open — which means choosing that card from the auction and nothing else. Only then does dummy lay all thirteen cards face up on the table, sorted into suits, with the trump suit placed at dummy's right. Declarer now plays both hands, naming which card to play from dummy when it is dummy's turn.

Dummy is a spectator for the rest of the hand. Dummy chooses nothing, advises nobody, and may not look at another player's cards; the one thing dummy may properly do is ask declarer whether a suit really is exhausted before a revoke becomes established.

Each trick runs clockwise from whoever leads. You must follow the suit led if you hold it; with none of that suit you may play anything, trump or discard, and you are never obliged to win a trick you could win. Whichever trump on the trick is biggest takes it, and where no trump was played, the biggest card of the opening suit does. The winner leads to the next trick, and thirteen tricks are played out.

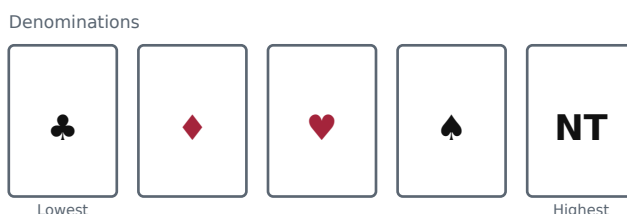
Failing to follow suit while holding the suit is a revoke. It stays correctable until the offending side leads or plays to the following trick, at which point it is established; correcting it in time costs nothing beyond the exposure, and a defender's withdrawn card becomes a penalty card that has to be played at the first legal opportunity.

An established revoke is not replayed. Play runs to the end of the deal and the books are balanced afterwards, once all thirteen tricks are in.

What the balancing costs depends on how much the offending side got out of it, and two tricks is the ceiling. That ceiling is reached in one situation only: the revoker took the trick they revoked on and their side went on to take at least one more before the deal ended. Fall short of either half of that and the bill is a single trick — either because the revoker won the revoke trick but the side took nothing afterwards, or because the revoker lost it while the side still ended up with that trick or one that came later. Three situations cost nothing whatever: an offending side that took no trick at all

from the revoke onwards, a revoke on the twelfth trick, and a deal on which both sides revoked. Where even the transfer leaves the innocent side short of what an honest hand would have given them, the director makes up the shortfall by adjusting the score outright.

Any player may claim or concede the remaining tricks at any point by putting the hand face up and stating how the rest will go. Play stops there and then. If anyone disputes it, the claim is settled by ruling rather than by playing on, and any genuinely doubtful trick is given against the claimer.



The five denominations a contract can be in, weakest to strongest. At the same number, each one outranks everything to its left, so anything lower has to be bid a level higher.

## Goal & scoring

Declarer's side must win at least as many tricks as the contract undertook. The defenders are trying to hold them to fewer. Only one side scores on a deal: make the contract and declarer's side is paid, break it and the defenders collect a penalty while declarer scores nothing whatever.

Trick points are earned only for the tricks actually contracted for. Anything beyond that is an overtrick and is paid as a bonus, which is the reason bidding a game and bidding a slam matter so much: the bonus attaches to what you promised, not to what you happened to take.

A game is a hundred trick points. At rubber bridge those points go below the line and accumulate, so a part-score of forty sits there waiting and a later part-score of sixty finishes the game off. Bonuses and penalties go above the line, where they count toward the final total but never toward game. Winning a game wipes the slate below the line clean and makes you vulnerable. The first side to win two games takes the rubber and its bonus, and the match is decided by adding each side's whole column, above and below.

Duplicate bridge cuts the thread between deals. The same cards are played at every table, so each board is scored on its own: nothing carries over, a part-score earns a small flat bonus instead of banking toward anything, and a contract worth a hundred trick points pays its game bonus there and then. Vulnerability is preset on the board.

That raw score is then converted into a comparative one, which is the real point of the format. Matchpoint pairs scoring ranks your result against every other pair who held your cards, so a twenty-point edge counts as much as a slam. IMP scoring compresses the raw difference between two tables onto a scale that flattens small gains and still rewards big ones. Either way you are judged against what everyone else did with the same thirteen cards, which is what removes luck of the deal from the contest.

Honours are a rubber-bridge relic: a bonus for holding a clutch of top trumps in one hand, claimed at the end of the deal regardless of who won anything. Duplicate does not score them at all.

| Scores                                            | Value                                   | Notes                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Each odd trick in clubs or diamonds               | 20                                      | —                                                                                          |
| Each odd trick in hearts or spades                | 30                                      | —                                                                                          |
| Odd tricks in notrump                             | 40 first, then 30 each                  | —                                                                                          |
| Doubled or redoubled trick score                  | Doubled, or quadrupled                  | The multiplied figure is what counts toward game, so two spades doubled is already a game. |
| Game bonus                                        | 300 not vulnerable, 500 vulnerable      | Duplicate. At rubber bridge a game is a step toward the rubber bonus instead.              |
| Part-score bonus                                  | 50                                      | Duplicate only; at rubber bridge part-scores carry over.                                   |
| Small slam, twelve tricks bid and made            | 500 not vulnerable, 750 vulnerable      | —                                                                                          |
| Grand slam, thirteen tricks bid and made          | 1000 not vulnerable, 1500 vulnerable    | —                                                                                          |
| Making any doubled contract (the insult)          | 50                                      | 100 if redoubled.                                                                          |
| Each overtrick, undoubled                         | 20 in a minor, 30 in a major or notrump | notrump overtricks are 30, not the 40 the first contracted trick pays                      |
| Each overtrick, doubled                           | 100 not vulnerable, 200 vulnerable      | Twice that if redoubled.                                                                   |
| Each undertrick, undoubled                        | 50 not vulnerable, 100 vulnerable       | —                                                                                          |
| Doubled undertricks, not vulnerable               | 100, 200, 200, then 300 each            | —                                                                                          |
| Doubled undertricks, vulnerable                   | 200, then 300 each                      | —                                                                                          |
| Redoubled undertricks                             | Twice the doubled penalty               | —                                                                                          |
| Rubber won two games to none                      | 700                                     | —                                                                                          |
| Rubber won two games to one                       | 500                                     | —                                                                                          |
| Unfinished rubber, side holding a game            | 300                                     | —                                                                                          |
| Unfinished rubber, side holding only a part-score | 100                                     | —                                                                                          |
| Four trump honours in one hand                    | 100                                     | Rubber and Chicago only.                                                                   |

## Variants

**Chicago (four-deal bridge)** — A fixed block of four deals rather than an open-ended rubber, which is why it suits an evening with a known finishing time. Vulnerability is set by the deal number instead of by winning games: nobody on the first, dealer's side on the second and third, everybody on the fourth. Games and part-scores are settled inside the block: a part-score carries forward and can be completed into a game by a later one, and a part-score made on the fourth deal that does not finish a game scores a flat 100 instead. Game bonuses are the duplicate figures, 300 not vulnerable and 500 vulnerable, and there is no rubber bonus because there is no rubber. The auction, the play and the trick values are unchanged.

**Minibridge** — The auction is removed entirely, which makes it the usual way to teach the play first. All four hands are dealt and each player announces their high-card points, counting four for an ace, three for a king, two for a queen and one for a jack. The side with more of them declares, and the stronger of its two hands is declarer; on a tie the player who announced first takes it. Dummy then goes down face up before anything else, which is the reverse of the real game, and only after seeing it does declarer name the denomination and say whether the target is a part-score of seven tricks or a game. The player on declarer's left leads and thirteen tricks are played out exactly as in the full game. Beginners get to practise declarer play and defence months before touching a bidding system.

**Honeymoon bridge** — A family of two-player adaptations, since bridge proper needs four. In the common form each player is dealt thirteen cards and the remaining twenty-six sit face down as a stock. Thirteen tricks are then played at notrump with the non-dealer leading and no obligation to follow suit; after each one the winner takes the top card of the stock and the loser the next, so both hands are back to thirteen when the stock is exhausted. Some players turn the top stock card face up so that each trick is visibly a contest for a known card. Only now do the two bid against each other, doubles and redoubles included, until one of them passes, and the contract is played out with no dummy, the non-declarer leading. It preserves the auction and the card play, though not the partnership judgement that makes bridge what it is.

**Auction bridge** — The direct ancestor, played until the late 1920s and still occasionally dealt. Everything about the auction and the play is familiar, but declarer scores trick points for every trick above six, whether or not the contract called for them. Overtricks therefore count toward game, so there is no reason to reach for a risky contract when a low one that takes the same tricks scores identically. Contract bridge's insistence on being paid only for what you promised is exactly what killed it.



Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, American Contract Bridge League, The Bridge World, BridgeBum, Denexa Games, Britannica.

# Doppelkopf

|                      |                                                                                     |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Doko                                                                                |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4-5 players (best with 4)                                                           |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 2 standard decks stripped to 48 cards (two of each A, K, Q, J, 10, 9 in every suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 45-90 minutes                                                                       |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                             |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                        |

---

## Setup

An ordinary deal is two against two, and for the first trick or two nobody is sure which two. That is the game: the partnerships are hidden inside the deal and have to be worked out from what people play.

Build the pack from two ordinary decks. Take A, K, Q, J, 10 and 9 of each suit out of both and put the rest away, which leaves forty-eight cards and two identical copies of every one of them. Packs sold for the game in Germany hold the same forty-eight, usually in the ordinary suits with the queen indexed D for Dame and the jack B for Bube. Where German-suited cards are used instead, those two are the Ober and the Unter.

The rules below are the tournament rules of the Deutscher Doppelkopf-Verband, which is the one published standard the game has. Informal play is another matter — the association was founded in 1982 precisely because the game was played to very different rules from one region to the next, and it changed the kitchen table hardly at all, so a table you have not sat at before will have house rules. Ask before the first deal; the commonest additions are in the variants below.

Deal twelve cards to each player in four rounds of three, starting to the dealer's left and going clockwise. Nothing is left over. The deal moves one seat left each hand. Five may sit down, in which case the dealer takes no cards and no score that hand, so a fifth player costs everyone one hand in five rather than a seat.

Card values are the ones Skat uses: an ace is 11, a ten is 10, a king 4, a queen 3, a jack 2, and the nines count nothing. Sixty points sit in each suit and 240 in the pack, and the whole game is a fight over the halfway line.

The ranking is the part to learn before dealing rather than during. In an ordinary hand every queen, every jack and the whole diamond suit are trumps — twenty-six cards of the forty-eight — headed by the ten of hearts, which is called the Dulle. The queens come next in the fixed order clubs, spades, hearts, diamonds, then the four jacks in that same order, then

diamonds from the ace down. What is left is three short side suits: clubs and spades run ace, ten, king, nine, and hearts runs ace, king, nine, because its ten has gone to the trumps.

One consequence catches everyone. Since each card is in the pack twice, two players can put the identical card on a trick, and the one played earlier is the one that wins it. That is true of the Dulle as well.

## Play

Reservations. Before a card is played the table finds out what kind of hand this is. Starting to the dealer's left, each player says gesund — healthy — meaning an ordinary hand suits them, or Vorbehalt, a reservation, meaning it does not. Four healthies and it is a normal hand. Otherwise whoever reserved says what they want, and the highest-ranking wish is played: a solo outranks a marriage, and a solo somebody is obliged to bid outranks a voluntary one, since a tournament round requires each player to take one solo during it. Where two players want the same thing the earlier speaker gets it.

A normal hand needs no declaring at all, and this is the mechanism the whole game hangs on. The two players holding the queens of clubs are the Re side and the other two are Kontra, and nobody says which they are. Working that out, and keeping your own side quiet, is most of the skill.

A marriage is what a player does when both queens of clubs turn up in one hand. Rather than take on three opponents alone, they declare Hochzeit and then take as partner whoever wins the first trick that the marriage holder does not — the clarifying trick — within the first three. Win all three yourself and the offer expires: you finish the hand as a lone diamond solo. A player dealt both queens who says nothing at all is committed to a silent marriage, which is that same diamond solo played without warning anybody.

A solo is one player against three, and it changes what is trump:

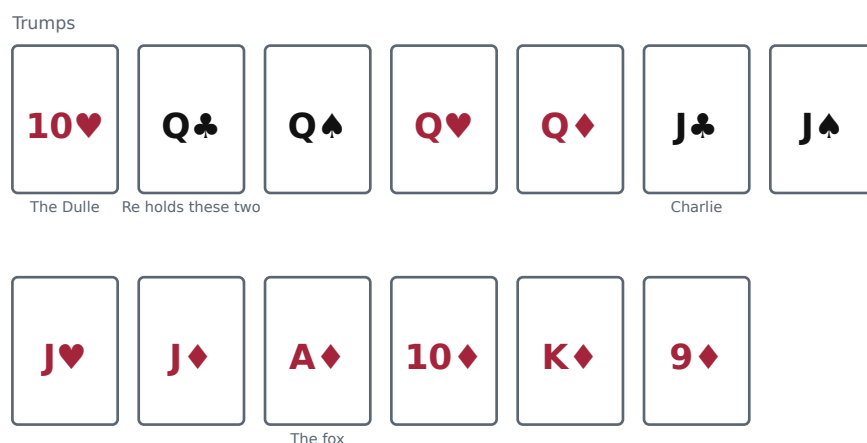
- Suit solo: the declared suit's ace, ten, king and nine take over the place the diamonds held, at the foot of the trump order below the queens and jacks. Hearts as trump is the awkward one, since its ten is already the Dulle, so a hearts solo has twenty-four trumps rather than twenty-six.
- Queen solo: the eight queens and nothing else. Every suit then runs ace, ten, king, jack, nine.
- Jack solo: the eight jacks and nothing else, with the suits running ace, ten, king, queen, nine.
- Aces solo: no trumps whatsoever, all four suits ace, ten, king, queen, jack, nine. Its German name, Fleischloser, means meatless.

The tricks. Whoever spoke first in the reservations leads to the first trick, except that a compulsory solo hands the lead to the soloist; after that the previous trick's winner leads. Follow suit if you can — and the trap is that the trumps count as one suit for that purpose, having eaten three ranks out of every other. A spade lead asks for the ace, ten, king or nine of spades and nothing else, so the queen of spades will not answer it, and leading that queen asks the table for trumps rather than for spades. Anyone who cannot follow may trump or throw away, as they like — there is no obligation to do either. A trick with any trump on it belongs to the highest of them; a trick with none belongs to whoever went highest in the suit that opened, and two identical cards are settled by which was put down first.

Announcements. These raise what the hand pays and are the only sanctioned way to tell your partner you exist. A player says Re while holding at least eleven cards to claim the queens-of-clubs side will win it, or Kontra on the same terms for the other side; because that is eleven and not twelve, the first trick is free and you can watch it before committing. Everything beyond that is a claim about how badly the opponents will do, and each step demands a card fewer in hand and rests on the step before it:

- No 90 — the opponents will finish under 90 — with at least ten cards.
- No 60, with at least nine.
- No 30, with at least eight.
- Schwarz, meaning they will not take a single trick, with at least seven.

None of these may be said before your side has said Re or Kontra, so the ladder is climbed in order or not at all. After a marriage the clock starts late: nothing may be announced until the clarifying trick is finished, since until then nobody knows who they are playing with.



The twenty-six trumps of an ordinary hand, high to low. Each of these thirteen cards is in the pack twice, and when two of them meet on a trick the one played first wins.

Clubs



Spades



Hearts



Everything else, and there is not much of it. Hearts is a rank shorter than the other two because its ten has been promoted to the top of the trumps.

## Goal & scoring

Count the card points in your side's tricks. Re has to reach 121 of the 240 and Kontra needs only 120, since a tie in cards goes to the defenders. Announcing changes those numbers. Say Kontra and your own bar rises to 121. And every negative announcement replaces your bar with the one you promised — 151 for no 90, 181 for no 60, 211 for no 30, and every trick for schwarz — so a side that said no 60 loses the hand at 180, however comfortable 180 sounds.

What gets written down is a single figure per deal, plus for the winners and minus for the losers, so the four columns always add to nothing. The figure is built by adding a point for each thing that actually happened, and almost everything counts once: the win itself, every thirty-point threshold the losers fell under, a clean sweep of the tricks, each negative announcement anybody made, and each of those the winners went on to play through anyway. Re and Kontra are the exception at two points each, and they count for whichever side ends up collecting rather than for whoever said them. The table has the full list.

Four more are available in a normal hand only, and never in a solo. One goes to Kontra simply for beating the queens of clubs. One goes for taking a trick worth 40 or more, which is itself called a doppelkopf and can only happen when all four cards are tens or aces. One goes for capturing an opponent's ace of diamonds, the fox. One goes for winning the final trick with a jack of clubs, known as Charlie Miller.

A soloist's figure is tripled and written into their own column alone, while each of the three opponents takes the untripled figure with the sign reversed. Losing a solo you talked up is the expensive way to spend an evening.

There is no target score in the rules. A session is an agreed number of deals, usually whole rounds of the table so that everybody deals equally often, and the highest running total at the end wins. A tournament round is twenty-four deals and is stopped at a hundred minutes of play, which is a fair guide to how long a dozen hands will take you.

| Scores                                   | Value              | Notes                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ace                                      | 11                 | —                                                                         |
| Ten                                      | 10                 | —                                                                         |
| King                                     | 4                  | —                                                                         |
| Queen                                    | 3                  | —                                                                         |
| Jack                                     | 2                  | —                                                                         |
| Nine                                     | 0                  | 240 in the pack, so Re needs 121 and Kontra 120                           |
| Winning the hand                         | 1                  | —                                                                         |
| Losers held under 90, under 60, under 30 | +1 each            | —                                                                         |
| Losers took no trick at all              | +1                 | —                                                                         |
| Re announced                             | +2                 | —                                                                         |
| Kontra announced                         | +2                 | —                                                                         |
| No 90, no 60, no 30 or schwarz announced | +1 each            | counted whichever side announced it                                       |
| Winners played through an announcement   | +1 each            | 120 against no 90, 90 against no 60, 60 against no 30, 30 against schwarz |
| Kontra beat the queens of clubs          | +1                 | normal hands only, never in a solo                                        |
| A trick worth 40 or more                 | +1                 | a trick of that size is itself called a doppelkopf                        |
| Caught an opponent's ace of diamonds     | +1                 | —                                                                         |
| Jack of clubs took the last trick        | +1                 | —                                                                         |
| Solo                                     | x3 for the soloist | each opponent takes the untripled figure with the sign reversed           |

## Variants

**Poverty (Armut)** — The best known of the additions the tournament rules leave out, and worth having. A player dealt three trumps or fewer may reserve and declare poverty, then push three cards face down across the table, which must include every trump they hold. Going clockwise, each of the others may take the three cards unseen and return any three in exchange; whoever accepts becomes the partner for the hand and the two of them are Re. Turned

down all round, the deal is annulled and the same dealer deals again. It is a better contract than it looks, because the pauper can now throw high cards onto tricks the partner is already winning.

**Without nines** — Throw all eight nines out and play a forty-card pack, ten cards each. Called scharfer Doppelkopf, sharp Doppelkopf, and popular enough in casual play to be worth asking about before you sit down. Every hand is stronger, the dead cards are gone, and the balance tips further toward the trumps, which go from 26 of the 48 to 24 of the 40. Everything else is unchanged.

**The second Dulle wins** — Some tables reverse the tie rule for the tens of hearts alone, so that when both fall on one trick the second beats the first. It looks like a footnote and is not: holding the Dulle is no longer a safe way to take a trick you must have, and the standard trick of leading one at a marriage in order to be adopted stops working. A common refinement plays it the ordinary way round on the last trick only.

**Piglets (Schweinchen)** — A player dealt both aces of diamonds may announce Schweinchen, and those two cards become the highest trumps in the hand, above the Dulle. Tables disagree about when the announcement has to be made and whether one or both aces are promoted, so settle it first. Where piglets are played, a holder of both nines of diamonds can sometimes answer with super piglets, which go above the piglets in turn.

**Bock rounds** — A doubling round triggered by an agreed event — a hand where both sides take exactly 120, a Re or Kontra announced and then lost, a deal that scores nothing. From the next deal onward every score is doubled for a full round of the table, one deal per player. Nothing in the tournament rules knows about them; they belong to casual play, along with poverty and the piglets, which is reason enough to ask what is running before you sit down.

## Background

Doppelkopf grew out of Schafkopf, the south German game that had a written rulebook by 1895, by the straightforward expedient of playing it with two packs — the doubling is where the name comes from. It went the other way geographically from its parent and is now played across Germany but concentrated in the north and around the Rhine and the Main.

Until the 1980s there was no such thing as the rules of Doppelkopf, only the rules wherever you happened to be. The Deutscher Doppelkopf-Verband was founded in March 1982, at the first German championship in Braunschweig, to write a single set for competition. It succeeded at that and left the kitchen-table game largely as it found it, which is why an entry like this one has to say which rules it is describing.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Deutscher Doppelkopf-Verband.



# Euchre

|                      |                                                                       |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Eucre, Euker                                                          |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-6 players (best with 4)                                             |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 24 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-40 minutes                                                         |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                  |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                          |

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## Setup

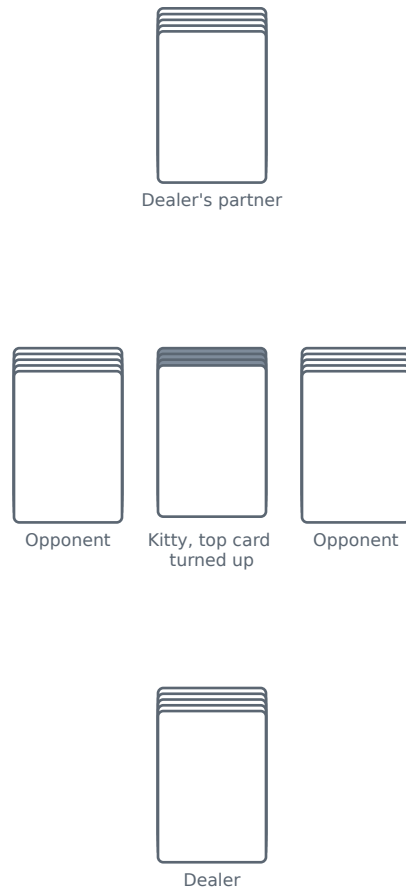
Four players in two fixed partnerships, partners seated opposite each other. Strip a standard pack down to 24 cards: ace, king, queen, jack, ten and nine in each of the four suits. Nothing lower is used.

For the first dealer, turn cards face up one at a time around the table and give the deal to whoever receives the first black jack. After that the deal passes clockwise every hand.

Deal five cards to each player clockwise in two rounds, three to a player then two, or two then three. Whichever pattern you start with, keep it for the rest of that deal. That accounts for twenty cards. Stack the remaining four face down in the middle as the kitty and turn its top card face up. That upcard is the suit on offer in the first round of bidding.

Do not sort your hand yet, because ranking is not fixed until trump is settled. In the three plain suits cards run ace, king, queen, jack, ten, nine from high to low. In trump the order is right bower (the jack of the trump suit, the best card in the deck), then left bower — the matching jack in the other suit of its colour — then ace, king, queen, ten, nine. The left bower does not merely rank as trump, it belongs to trump for the whole hand. With spades as trump the jack of clubs is a spade: you may not use it to follow a club lead, and you must play it to a spade lead if it is your only spade. The trump suit therefore holds seven cards and the same-color suit only five.

Keep score on paper, or with the traditional pair of spare low cards laid face down and turned to show the count.



Partners sit opposite. Twenty of the 24 cards are dealt five at a time; the last four stay in the middle and the upcard opens the bidding.

## Play

First round of bidding. The turned card offers its suit as trump. Starting on the dealer's left and going clockwise, everyone in turn either takes that offer or passes it along. Accepting is called ordering it up if you are one of the dealer's opponents, assisting if you are the dealer's partner, and taking it up if you are the dealer. As soon as somebody accepts, bidding stops: the dealer adds the upcard to hand and buries any one card face down under the kitty, going back to five cards. The side that chose trump are the makers, the other pair the defenders.

Second round of bidding. If all four pass, the dealer turns the upcard face down on the kitty and the auction goes round once more from the dealer's left. Now a player may pass or name any suit as trump except the suit just turned down. Naming the other suit of the same color is called next; naming either suit of the opposite color is cross, or green. Nobody exchanges cards in the second round, and the kitty is finished with. If all four pass again the hand is dead: throw the cards in and pass the deal. Under the very common stick-the-dealer rule the dealer is instead forced to name a suit rather than let the hand die.

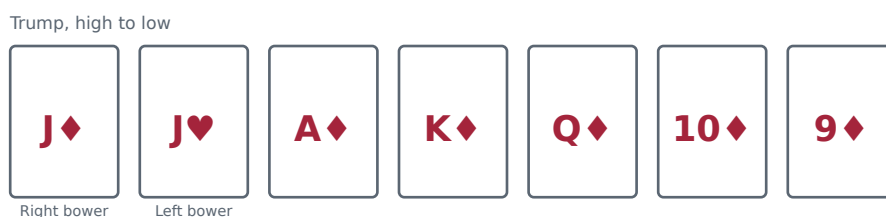
Going alone. Once trump is settled and before a card is led, any player may declare a loner — the maker, or either defender. That player's partner lays all five cards face down and takes no part in the hand, so a lone maker plays one against two and a lone defender two against one. If both sides put somebody up alone, everybody else is out of it and the deal comes down to two players and ten cards. The declaration has to come before the opening lead; you cannot decide to go alone once play has started.

Playing the tricks. The player to the dealer's left leads to the first trick — except when somebody is playing alone, in which case the lead belongs to the player on the loner's left instead. Where both sides have gone alone, the defender leads. Each player in turn clockwise must follow the suit led if holding a card of it. A player who cannot follow may play anything at all, trump included. There is no obligation to trump and no obligation to beat what has already been played. A trump on the trick beats everything that is not one, and the biggest trump takes it. Untrumped, it falls to whoever played highest in the led suit. The winner of a trick leads to the next. Five tricks are played and the hand is then scored.

The bower trap. Two situations catch new players, and both come from the left bower changing suit. With hearts as trump, a diamond lead cannot be answered by the jack of diamonds at all: that card has become a heart. And when hearts are led, a player holding that same jack and nothing else red is not void after all — the jack is their heart, and down it goes.

Reneging. Failing to follow suit when you were able to is a renege. Club and tournament practice is to stop the hand the moment the fault is spotted and move 2 points — awarded to the innocent side, or deducted from the offenders, depending on the group. Casual tables more often finish the hand out and simply deny the offending side any score for it. Both are in use, so agree which applies before you deal.

Four of the twenty-four cards never reach a hand, so besides the upcard three cards stay unknown all deal. That, along with the dealer's buried discard, is what makes tracking the seven trump cards worth the effort.



Trump ranking with diamonds as trump. The jack of the same colour joins the trump suit and outranks the ace, which is the rule newcomers most often get wrong.

Plain suit



Every other suit ranks normally. Hearts is short one jack, because that jack is now a trump.

## Goal & scoring

A side wins by being first to 10 points. Points come only from the outcome of a hand; individual tricks are worth nothing on their own, and the defenders score nothing at all whenever the makers succeed.

Score at the end of each hand as follows:

- Makers win three or four tricks: 1 point.
- Makers win all five, called a march: 2 points.
- A lone maker wins three or four tricks: 1 point.
- A lone maker wins all five: 4 points.
- Makers win fewer than three tricks: they are euchred, and the defenders take 2 points.
- A lone defender euchres the makers: 4 points to the defenders.

Note the asymmetry on a loner. Going alone and succeeding pays two extra points, while going alone and failing costs nothing extra — a euchre pays 2 unless it was a lone defender who did the euchring. Note also that ordering up hands the makers all the risk: a euchre is worth as much as a march, which is why a side sitting on 8 or 9 points is dangerous to bid against.

Only one side can score in any given hand, so the two totals never advance together and there is no way for both sides to reach the target at once: the moment a side's total hits 10 the game stops and that side has won. No tie-break is needed.

Games are usually a race to 10. Playing to 11 is common in some regions, and league play sometimes uses a fixed number of hands with the higher total winning instead of a target score, in which case an equal total is normally settled by playing one more hand.

## Variants

**Stick the dealer** — Also called screw the dealer. If the first three players pass in the second round of bidding, the dealer may not pass and must name one of the three eligible suits. It removes thrown-in hands entirely, speeds the game up, and creates the game's most reliable pressure point, since the dealer is often forced into a suit they would never have called voluntarily. Widespread enough that many tables treat it as standard rather than a variation.

**Cutthroat (three-handed) Euchre** — Three players, no partnerships, the same 24-card deck and the same five-card hands. Fifteen cards are dealt, the nine left over form the kitty, and its top card is turned up exactly as in the four-handed game. Whoever names trump plays alone against the other two, who cooperate for that hand only. The maker scores 1 point for three or four tricks and 3 points for all five, though some groups pay only 2 for the march; if the maker is euchred, each of the two defenders scores 2. First to 10 wins. The temporary alliances make it a very different bidding game from the partnership version.

**The Benny (25-card Euchre)** — A joker, sometimes replaced by the two of spades, is added to the deck as the Benny or best bower: the highest trump no matter which suit is trump. Holding it guarantees a trick. If the Benny is turned up as the upcard, the dealer names the trump suit. Common in Britain, Australia and parts of Canada, often alongside a target of 11 points rather than 10.

**Bid Euchre** — An auction version, usually with a larger deck (frequently 24 or 32 cards, or two packs combined for more players), in which players bid a specific number of tricks rather than simply accepting or naming trump. The high bidder names trump, and scoring is by tricks won rather than by the fixed 1, 2 and 4 point table. A side that fails to reach its bid loses points equal to the bid. It scales to five and six players more comfortably than standard Euchre.

**No loner after passing** — A restriction some tables put on going alone: a player who passed in the round that trump was eventually made in may not then play alone. It exists to stop somebody passing on a strong hand, waiting for an opponent to be talked into naming trump, and then going alone against them for the 4 points a lone euchre pays. Worth agreeing on, because without it the trap is available to anybody patient enough to use it.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, World Euchre Federation, Ohio Euchre, Trickster Cards.

# Five Hundred

|                      |                                                                                                           |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | 500                                                                                                       |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-5 players (best with 4)                                                                                 |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck cut down to 43 cards — A to 5 in the black suits, A to 4 in the red suits, plus one joker |
| <b>Time</b>          | 45-90 minutes                                                                                             |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                                                   |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                                              |

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## Setup

Four at the table in two partnerships, each pair facing one another. Pick a first dealer however you like; from then on everything in this game — dealing, bidding, playing — travels to the left.

The pack is not one you own, so build it. Take a standard deck and throw out every 2 and every 3, then the 4 of spades and the 4 of clubs as well. Put one joker back in. Forty-three cards are left: the black suits running from the ace down to the five, the red suits down to the four, and the joker belonging to no suit at all.

Deal ten cards to each player and three face down in the middle as the kitty. The traditional rhythm interleaves them: three each and one to the kitty, four each and one to the kitty, three each and the last to the kitty.

One score sheet, two columns, running from zero in both directions. Both directions matters — a side can lose this game by going far enough backwards, and a column that only counts up will not show it coming.

What you are setting up is Euchre grown up: ten cards in the hand rather than five, an auction in place of a turned-up card, a kitty for whoever wins that auction, and a contract to lose every trick for anyone brave enough to call it. Australia treats the game as a national institution and had nothing to do with inventing it — an American company drew it up and copyrighted it in 1904, which is a fair summary of how these things go.



Ten cards each and three face down in the middle. Whoever wins the auction takes the kitty into hand unseen by anybody else and throws any three cards away.

## Play

The auction opens to the dealer's left and goes round as many times as it needs to. Pass and you are out of it for good. Everything else is a claim on a number of tricks, six at the least, played some particular way:

- A number and a suit. Eight diamonds undertakes that you and your partner will take at least eight of the ten tricks with diamonds as trumps.
- A number and no trumps. The same undertaking with no trump suit at all.
- Misère: you will lose every trick, playing alone while your partner lays their hand face down and sits it out.
- Open misère: the same, except that after the first trick you spread your hand face up on the table and play the rest of it in plain view.

Bids outrank each other by tricks first and then by suit, and the suit order is the one thing to memorise: spades lowest, then clubs, diamonds, hearts, and no trumps highest. Six spades is the cheapest bid available and ten no trumps the dearest. The two misères are slotted into that ladder by value

rather than by trick count — a plain misère sits above every bid of seven and below every bid of eight, and may only be called once somebody has actually bid seven, while an open misère outranks ten diamonds and may be called at any point, including as the opening bid.

Everyone passing throws the hand in.

The last bidder standing takes the kitty into hand without showing it, then buries any three cards face down — the discards may include cards that came out of the kitty. Those three are out of the game. Then the contractor leads to the first trick.

Play itself holds no surprises. Follow the suit led while you hold it and throw whatever you like once you do not; the biggest trump in a trick takes it, and with no trump present the best card of the led suit does; whoever collects a trick leads to the next.

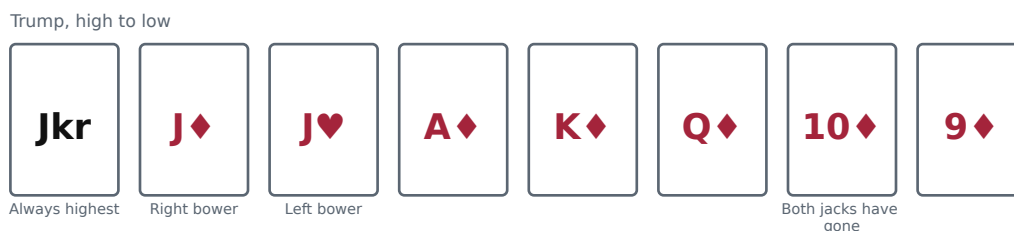
What is not orthodox is the trump suit, which runs thirteen deep rather than ten or eleven. On top of it is the joker. Under the joker, the right bower, meaning trump's own jack. Under that, the left bower — the matching jack from the suit of the same colour, which has abandoned its printed suit completely and counts as a trump for every purpose there is, following suit included. Then the ace, the king, the queen and straight on down to the ten, since both jacks are elsewhere. The suit that shares trump's colour is left nine or ten cards long with no jack at all.

The joker without a trump suit to belong to needs its own set of rules, and they are worth reading before a no-trump or misère contract rather than during one:

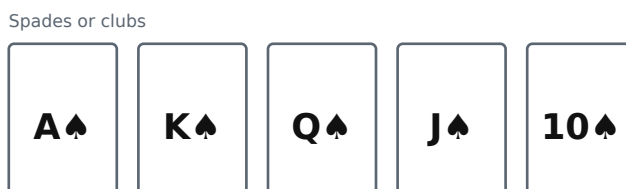
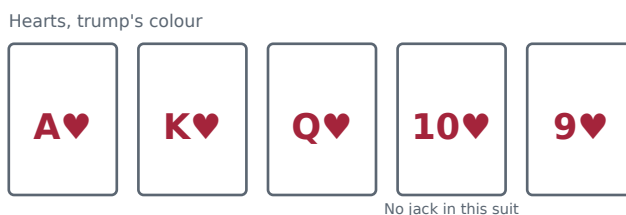
- The contractor, if holding it, may nominate a suit for it before the opening lead, and it is then simply the top card of that suit.
- Unnominated, it belongs to no suit, beats everything, and is restricted instead. Following someone else's lead you may only play it when void in the suit led. Under a misère you must play it when void; under a no-trump contract you need not, and may keep it back.
- You may lead the joker and name a suit that everyone else must follow, so long as that suit has not been led before. That privilege expires: with every suit already opened, leading the joker becomes illegal, and the last trick of the hand is the only exception.

One trap follows from all that. A misère bidder who keeps the joker and forgets to nominate a suit for it has already lost the contract, because the joker will win the trick it is played to and there is nothing to be done about it.





Trump ranking with diamonds as trump. The joker tops everything, both red jacks are trumps, and the ten therefore follows the queen. The order runs on down to the 4.



The other suits rank normally, but the one sharing trump's colour is missing its jack, because that card is now the left bower. Red suits run down to the 4 and black suits to the 5.

## Goal & scoring

Five hundred points wins, which is where the name comes from, and there is a condition on it that decides real games: you have to get there on a hand you bid and made. Points picked up defending somebody else's contract will carry you past 500 and leave you sitting there unable to finish, playing on until you win a contract of your own. There is also a back door. Reach minus 500 and you have lost the game outright, without anyone having to win it.

What a contract is worth looks like a table to memorise and is really one formula. Six spades is 40. Every extra trick you undertake adds 100, and every step up the suit order — spades to clubs to diamonds to hearts to no trumps — adds 20. So eight hearts is 40, plus 200 for the two tricks above six, plus 60 for hearts being three steps above spades: 300. The two misères are priced flat, at 250 and 500, which is what fixes them where they sit in the bidding order.

Take the tricks you bid and your side scores the contract's value. Extra tricks beyond the bid earn nothing at all, with one exception: sweep all ten

and a contract worth less than 250 pays 250 instead. Above 250 there is no bonus, because you were already being paid enough.

Fall short and the same number comes off your score instead, which is how a side ends up going out backwards. A greedy ten no trumps that fails costs 520 in a single hand and can lose the game on its own.

The defenders score 10 a trick for every trick they take, and they score it whether the contract stood up or not. This matters more than it looks: it means defending is never wasted effort, a hopeless hand is still worth fighting for scraps in, and a side can climb most of the way to 500 on other people's contracts — only to find they still have to bid something to close it out.

Misère pays nothing to the defenders either way. The contractor either loses every trick and takes 250 or 500, or wins one and drops the same amount.

| Scores                             | Value                  | Notes                                                       |
|------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Six tricks                         | 40 to 120              | spades 40, clubs 60, diamonds 80, hearts 100, no trumps 120 |
| Seven tricks                       | 140 to 220             | —                                                           |
| Eight tricks                       | 240 to 320             | —                                                           |
| Nine tricks                        | 340 to 420             | —                                                           |
| Ten tricks                         | 440 to 520             | —                                                           |
| Misère                             | 250                    | outranks any bid of seven, ranks below any bid of eight     |
| Open misère                        | 500                    | outranks ten diamonds, ranks below ten hearts               |
| Slam on a contract worth under 250 | 250 instead of the bid | —                                                           |
| Contract failed                    | minus its full value   | —                                                           |
| Each trick taken by the defenders  | 10                     | scored win or lose, but never against a misère              |
| Winning the game                   | 500                    | only on a hand you bid and made; minus 500 loses outright   |

## Variants

**Three-handed** — Cut the pack down again so that the seven is the lowest card in every suit, giving 33 cards with the joker, and deal ten each with a three-card kitty as usual. There are no fixed partnerships: whoever wins the auction plays alone and the other two combine against them for that hand only. Every player keeps their own score, and the same conditions apply — 500 or more on a contract of your own wins, minus 500 loses. It is the sharpest version of the game, because the contractor gets no help at all and the defenders have to work out between them who is covering what.

**Five-handed** — Use the whole 52-card deck plus the joker, 53 in all, and deal ten each with the usual kitty. After discarding, a contractor playing a suit or no-trump contract either announces they are going alone against the other four, or names any single card other than the joker or a bower — whoever holds it is their partner and must not say so. The partnership becomes public when the named card appears, which is often several tricks in and occasionally never. A called partner shares the contract's value or its loss equally; a contractor going alone takes all of it. Misère is always played single-handed.

**Six-handed** — Two partnerships of three, sitting alternately, playing by the four-handed rules. It wants a purpose-made 63-card pack with 11s and 12s in every suit and 13s in the red suits, ranking between the 10 and the jack — these are sold as six-handed 500 decks, and in Australia are commonly used for the four-handed game too with the extras taken out. Failing that, add the 2s, 3s and red 4s from a second deck and agree that where two identical cards fall in one trick, the first one played beats the second. Under a misère both of the contractor's partners lay their hands down.

**A joker that is only a trump** — Some tables cut the no-trump joker rules out entirely: the joker is the highest card in the pack, may be played to any trick regardless of what you hold, and may be led at any time with the leader naming the suit to be followed. Others go the other way and require the contractor to nominate a suit for it in every no-trump contract. Either simplification removes the misère trap of holding an unnominated joker, and both are worth settling before the bidding rather than discovering in the middle of a 500-point contract.

Rules checked against: [Pagat](#), [Wikipedia](#), [GameRules.com](#).

# Hearts

|                      |                                                                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Black Lady, Chase the Lady, Black Widow                                                    |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-6 players (best with 4)                                                                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; a few low cards come out for 3, 5 or 6 players |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                               |

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## Setup

Hearts is at its best with four players, each on their own. There are no partnerships and no trump suit. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Aces are high and twos are low in every suit.

Pick a first dealer however you like, drawing for the low card being the usual method, then pass the deal one seat to the left after every hand. The dealer shuffles and deals the entire pack out one card at a time, clockwise, beginning with the player on their left. Four players get 13 cards each and the hand runs 13 tricks.

Other numbers need the pack trimmed so the deal comes out even. For three players, remove the 2 of diamonds and deal 17 each. For five, remove the 2 of diamonds and the 2 of clubs and deal 10 each. For six, remove the 2 and 3 of diamonds and the 2 and 3 of clubs and deal 8 each. The cards pulled are always low clubs and diamonds, the two suits that carry no penalties, so all 26 penalty points are still in the deal whatever the player count. Other combinations of low cards are used at some tables; the only things that matter are that the deal comes out even and that no heart and not the queen of spades is withdrawn.

There is no layout, no stock and no discard pile. Everything sits in the players' hands, and there is nothing to write down until the first hand has been played out.

| Players | Each player gets | Removed        |
|---------|------------------|----------------|
| 3       | 17 cards         | 2♦             |
| 4       | 13 cards         | —              |
| 5       | 10 cards         | 2♦, 2♣         |
| 6       | 8 cards          | 2♦, 3♦, 2♣, 3♣ |

## Play

Every hand opens with a pass. Pick three cards out of your hand and lay them face down in front of the player who is to receive them. Nobody may look at the cards coming their way until they have committed their own

three, so the exchange is genuinely blind on both sides. The direction rotates deal by deal: pass to the left on the first hand, to the right on the second, straight across on the third, and on the fourth hand nobody passes at all and you play what you were dealt. Then the cycle starts again. Three and five players have nobody sitting directly opposite, so their rotation drops the across pass and runs left, right, hold; six players use the full four-hand cycle.

Once everyone has picked up what came their way, the 2 of clubs opens: whoever was dealt it has to lead it. If the 2 of clubs was removed for the player count, the lowest club still in the pack leads instead: the 3 of clubs in a five-handed game, the 4 of clubs in a six-handed game. Play then goes clockwise, one card from each player.

You must follow the suit led if you hold anything in it. Only when you are void may you play something else, and then you may play any card you like subject to the two restrictions below. Nothing is trump, so a trick goes to whoever played the highest card in whatever suit was led. A card thrown off-suit cannot win the trick no matter how high it is. The winner gathers the trick face down and leads to the next one.

Two restrictions shape the whole hand.

First trick. No penalty card may be thrown on the opening trick. That rules out every heart and the queen of spades, even if you are void in clubs and would love to be rid of them. The only escape is a hand that contains literally nothing else, which almost never happens. Some groups relax this to bar hearts only and allow the queen on the first trick, so settle it before you deal.

Leading hearts. You may not lead a heart until hearts have been broken, and they are broken the first time somebody discards a heart on a trick led in another suit. The one exception is a player whose remaining cards are all hearts; they may lead one. The queen of spades is under no such restriction. She can be played whenever spades are led and discarded whenever you are void, and in the standard game putting her down does not break hearts. A good number of tables play that she does break them, which is worth agreeing on in advance.

A hand ends when all the cards are gone. Everyone turns their tricks face up, counts the penalty cards inside them, and the results go on the score sheet before the next player deals.

## **Goal & scoring**

Hearts is a game you are trying to lose. The winner is whoever holds the

fewest penalty points when the game ends.

Each heart you collect in a trick costs 1 penalty point and the queen of spades costs 13, so exactly 26 points are distributed every deal. Nothing else scores at all. The number of tricks you win is irrelevant; only what is inside them matters.

The exception is shooting the moon. If a single player takes all 13 hearts and the queen of spades in the same hand, the result inverts: the shooter chooses between having 26 taken off their own total and having 26 added to every opponent's. Taking it off your own is the better option when the opponents are already close to the finish or when you are sitting on zero and cannot go below it. The attempt is all or nothing. Let one heart escape to another player and you simply keep the pile you have gathered, which is normally a catastrophe.

Keep a running total for each player. The game ends at the end of the hand in which anyone reaches or passes 100 points, and the player with the lowest total at that moment wins. A target of 50 makes for a quicker game. If two or more players are level on the lowest total when the game would end, nobody has won: deal again and keep playing complete hands, with the same finish condition applied each time, until exactly one player is alone on the lowest score.

| Scores                      | Value | Notes                                                                   |
|-----------------------------|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Each heart taken in a trick | 1     | —                                                                       |
| Queen of spades             | 13    | —                                                                       |
| Every other card            | 0     | The number of tricks you win does not matter, only what is inside them. |
| Penalty points in one deal  | 26    | —                                                                       |
| Shooting the moon           | 26    | Charged to every opponent, or subtract 26 from the shooter's own total. |
| Game ends at                | 100   | Lowest total wins; 50 makes a quicker game.                             |

## Variants

**Omnibus Hearts (Jack of Diamonds)** — The jack of diamonds becomes a bonus card worth minus 10, so whoever takes it in a trick has 10 points struck off their score for that hand. It reshapes the deal completely, because diamonds are suddenly worth fighting for rather than dumping, and a shot at the moon now requires the jack as well as all the hearts and the queen of spades. Some groups use the 10 of diamonds for the same purpose.

**Black Maria** — The British three-handed form. Take out the 2 of clubs so that each of three players receives 17 cards. Three spades carry penalties instead

of one: the queen is worth 13, the king 10 and the ace 7. Cards are passed three to the right only, there is no fixed opening lead, and many groups play it without any moon-shooting rule, so the hand is purely about dodging the black suit.

**Cancellation Hearts** — Built for six or more players using two full packs shuffled together. Identical cards cancel each other: if the same rank and suit appears twice in one trick, neither copy can win it, and the trick goes to the highest surviving card of the suit led. If every candidate cancels out, nobody wins the trick; it stays on the table and is swept up along with all its penalty cards by whoever takes the next one.

**Spot Hearts** — Hearts are worth their pip value rather than a flat point each. The 2 through 10 count face value, the jack, queen and king count 10 apiece, the ace counts 15, and the queen of spades is raised to 25. That makes a single deal worth 124 points instead of 26, so the game target has to be scaled up to match, commonly to 500. Low hearts become throwaways and the ace of hearts becomes the card everyone is watching.

**Shoot the Sun** — An extra tier above shooting the moon that almost nobody achieves. Taking every trick in the hand, not merely every penalty card, is worth double the usual moon: 52 points against each opponent, or 52 struck off your own total, whichever you prefer. Groups that use it treat a failed sun as an ordinary moon attempt, so a player who wins twelve tricks and all the penalties still scores the plain moon. Doubling is not universal; plenty of tables recognise the feat but pay it at the ordinary 26, so say which you are using before anyone tries it.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Dice Game Depot, Trickster Cards, Cool Old Games.

# Oh Hell

|                      |                                                                                             |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Oh Pshaw, Blackout, Nomination Whist, Contract Whist, Up and Down the River, Elevator, Bust |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-7 players (best with 5)                                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                                                                  |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-90 minutes                                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                                |

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## Setup

Three to seven players, everyone for themselves, with one standard 52-card deck. Cards rank in the ordinary way within each suit, ace high down through king, queen, jack and the numbers to the two. There are no partnerships, and the game plays best with four to six.

A game is a fixed series of deals in which the hand size changes every time. The most common shape is an arc: start at the largest hand you have agreed on, drop one card per deal down to a single card, then climb back up to where you started. With five players starting at ten, that is 10, 9, 8 and so on down to 1, then 2, 3 up to 10 again, nineteen deals in total. Other groups run the arc upward only, or downward only, or cut it off at a round number such as seven. Decide the shape and write the sequence at the top of the score sheet before the first card is dealt, because the whole game is scored against it.

The ceiling on hand size is what the deck allows: divide 52 by the number of players and round down. Many groups shave one card off that figure, so that a card is always left over to turn for trump, and most play a shorter arc than the maximum anyway simply to keep the game to a sensible length.

Choose a first dealer at random; the deal then moves clockwise every hand. Deal the agreed number of cards one at a time to each player, then turn the next card of the undealt stock face up. Its suit is trump for that deal. That card belongs to nobody and stays face up beside the remaining stock, which is not used. On a deal that consumes the entire pack there is no card left to turn, so that hand is played with no trump at all.

Rule a grid before you start: one column per player, one row per deal, with space to record each player's bid next to their running total.

| <b>Players</b> | <b>Each player gets</b> |
|----------------|-------------------------|
| 3              | 17 cards                |
| 4              | 13 cards                |
| 5              | 10 cards                |



|   |         |
|---|---------|
| 6 | 8 cards |
| 7 | 7 cards |

## Play

**Bidding.** With the cards dealt and trump turned, each player in turn starting to the dealer's left, and finishing with the dealer, announces out loud exactly how many tricks they intend to win. Bids are spoken in order, not written secretly, so later bidders are better informed than earlier ones. Zero is a legal and frequently correct bid. No bid may exceed the number of cards in the hand.

**The hook.** Bidding last is less of a privilege than it looks, because one figure is always barred to the dealer: whichever one would leave the table's bids balancing perfectly against the tricks in the hand. Somebody is therefore certain to fail every deal. Say the hand is five cards and the four earlier bids were 1, 2, 0 and 1, totalling four; every number is open to the dealer except 1. This is the rule the game is named for, and it exists to stop a table from politely arranging for everyone to succeed. Where the earlier bids have already overshot what the hand contains, nothing at all is barred to the dealer, since no bid can bring the total back down.

Write every bid on the score sheet before a card is played. Bids cannot be revised once the first lead is made.

**The play.** Whoever sits on the dealer's left opens, and may open with anything at all — trump included, since nothing here holds it back. Going clockwise, anybody holding the suit that was led has to play one. A player holding none of the led suit may play any card, trump or otherwise, and is under no obligation either to trump or to try to win. Whichever trump on the trick is biggest takes it; with no trump on it, the biggest card of the opening suit does. The winner of the trick leads to the next. On a no-trump deal nothing can beat the opening suit, so its biggest card always wins.

Keep the tricks you win in your own stack rather than a communal pile, since everyone has to be able to count their own at the end. In long hands it is worth restating bids aloud partway through.

**The one-card deal.** Each player holds a single card and has no decision to make in the play at all, so the entire hand is the bidding: you are guessing whether your card beats everyone else's. These deals swing the scoreboard hard, and they are the reason the arc bottoms out at one card rather than stopping higher.

When the last trick of a deal has been taken, compare each player's count with their bid, score the hand, gather the cards, and pass the deal one seat clockwise. Play continues until the agreed sequence of deals is exhausted.

## Goal & scoring

You win by holding the highest total when the agreed run of deals is finished. There is no target to race to and no sudden-death ending; the game is over when the arc is over.

Two methods are in general use, and you have to settle which before the first deal, because they reward completely different bidding.

The one usually described as the most widespread is the generous one: every player takes 1 point per trick won whatever happened, and anybody who hit their bid exactly adds a flat 10 on top. A bid of 2 brought home is 12; missed, it still pays a point a trick, which keeps a trailing player interested.

The other is all-or-nothing. Hit your contract on the nose and the hand pays a flat 10 with the size of the contract added, so a fulfilled 3 is worth 13 and a fulfilled 0 is worth 10; land anywhere else, above or below, and it pays nothing whatever. Overtricks earn no consolation at all — bidding three and taking four is exactly as worthless as bidding three and taking two, which is what makes deliberately dumping a trick on an opponent a real weapon. It swings harder and ends tenser, and it is where the game's other names come from: the scorer blots out every failed bid, leaving the sheet covered in blobs.

A bid of zero is the most dependable score on the sheet, since it pays 10 and requires no cards at all. It is also the hardest thing to defend once someone leads a suit you are void in and you are forced to spend a card that might win.

Ties for first place are normally just shared. Some groups settle them with a single extra one-card deal.

## Variants

**Alternative scoring schemes** — Besides the standard 10 plus bid, two schemes are widespread. The forgiving one gives 1 point per trick taken to everybody plus a 10-point bonus for an exact bid. The punishing one gives 10 plus the square of the bid when you succeed and subtracts the square of the difference when you miss, which makes large bids enormously valuable and near-misses expensive. All three are played under the same name, so ask before you sit down.

**No hook (free bidding)** — Drop the restriction on the dealer entirely, so the bids may total exactly the number of tricks and every player at the table can theoretically make their contract. The game becomes friendlier and much less cutthroat, since nobody is guaranteed to fail. Some groups compromise by

applying the hook only on the smaller hands, where it bites hardest.

**Blind one-card deals** — On the deal where each player holds one card, nobody looks at their own card. Instead each player holds it face outward against their forehead, so they can see everyone else's card but not their own, and bid on that information. It turns the most luck-heavy deal of the game into a deduction problem and is popular enough that many groups treat it as part of the standard game.

**Nomination trump (Contract Whist)** — Rather than turning a card for trump, the highest bidder names the trump suit, which is where the alternative name Nomination Whist comes from. Bidding then becomes a genuine auction, since the right to choose trump is worth competing for, and in this form the player who took the auction names the suit and leads to the first trick rather than the player at the dealer's left. Some versions of this form also require the first-hand bid to be made before players look at all of their cards.

**Deal-pattern variations** — The names attached to this game usually track its deal pattern. Up and Down the River and the British Nomination Whist run the full descending-then-ascending arc. Oh Pshaw generally means the ascending-only version, starting at one card and building up. Elevator and Blackout are used for either direction depending on the region. The rules of play are identical in all of them; only the sequence of hand sizes and hence the length of the game changes.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Trickster Cards, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, PlayingCardDecks.

# Pinochle

|                      |                                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Pinocle, Penuchle, Partnership Auction Pinochle                                                                                                  |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 4)                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 pinochle deck (48 cards: two each of A, 10, K, Q, J, 9 in every suit), which you can build from two standard decks by keeping only those ranks |
| <b>Time</b>          | 45-90 minutes                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                                                                                     |

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## Setup

This entry describes single-deck partnership auction Pinochle: four players, two fixed partnerships, one 48-card pinochle pack. Double-deck partnership Pinochle, which is at least as widely played in North America, is described under variants.

Each suit is twelve deep rather than thirteen, because it holds only six ranks and holds each of them twice: ace, ten, king, queen, jack, nine. Forty-eight cards in all. Rank within a suit is not what you expect: the ace is high, but the ten sits second, above the king. The full order is A, 10, K, Q, J, 9 from high to low. When two identical cards meet in the same trick, the one played first outranks the copy.

Partners face one another across the table. Settle the first deal however you like, high cut being usual, then pass the deal clockwise. Shuffle, cut, and deal every card out clockwise in packets of three or four until each player holds twelve. There is no stock and no widow in this version; all 48 cards are in hands from the start.

Rule a score sheet with one column per partnership. Each hand produces a bid, a meld figure and a trick figure for each side before anything is combined, so leave room to write all three rather than only a running total.

Agree two house questions before the first deal, because tables differ and both change how you bid: whether the contracting side exchanges four cards after naming trump, and whether you are playing to 1000 points or some other target.

## Play

A hand runs in three stages: the auction, the meld, then twelve tricks.

The auction. Bidding opens with the player to the dealer's left and moves clockwise. A bid is the number of points your side undertakes to score this hand, meld and captured counters combined. The usual minimum opening bid is 250, though 200 and 300 are both common house figures, and each

later bid must beat the previous one, normally in steps of 10. Passing puts you out of the auction for the rest of that hand: you cannot come back in when the bidding returns to you. The auction therefore ends as soon as three of the four players have passed, whether or not those passes were consecutive, and the one player still live holds the contract for their side. A passed-out auction is handled in one of three ways, so choose in advance: require the player to the dealer's left to open at the minimum so that there is always a contract, which is the most common fix; oblige the dealer to take it at the minimum; or throw the hand in, pass the deal and redeal.

Naming trump and the pass. Whoever wins the auction declares the trump suit. An exchange of four cards each way is common at that point: the partner picks four, slides them across the table face down, and the bidder, after studying them, sends four back. Nothing obliges the bidder to return what arrived — four cards out of the original holding is equally legal, as is any mixture of the two. Where no exchange is used the bidding runs distinctly more cautious, which is precisely why this belongs on the list of things settled before cards are dealt.

Melding. All four players lay their scoring combinations face up on the table at once. Each side adds its meld aloud, the totals are written down, and the cards are then taken back into hand before any card is played. Only what is in your hand at that moment counts; nothing you capture later in the play can be added to it. Overlap between combinations of unlike kinds is allowed, so a single physical card can earn its keep several times over. Hold the spade queen and she pays inside the spade marriage, again inside the pinochle alongside the diamond jack, and a third time inside the set of four queens, all from the one card. What is barred is spending a card twice on the same kind of combination, so a spade queen sitting between two spade kings still yields a single marriage rather than a pair of them. None of it is banked until you take a trick, though: a side that goes through the whole play without winning even one records nothing for everything it laid down.

The tricks. The high bidder leads to the first trick and play runs clockwise. Give this one a moment before you start, because it is the rule most likely to differ from what somebody at the table learned: in the auction game the lead belongs to the contractor, but the versions of partnership Pinochle played without an auction hand it to the player at the dealer's left instead. The rules for playing a card are strict, which is the feature that separates Pinochle from most trick games:

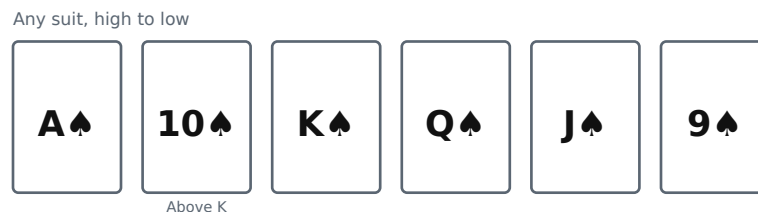
- If you can follow suit you must, and if you can also beat the highest card of that suit already played, you must do that as well.

- Void in the suit led, you are obliged to trump if you have anything to trump with, and that obligation stands even when your trump is already beaten.
- If the trick has already been trumped and you cannot follow suit, you must beat the trump on the table when you are able; holding only lower trumps, you must still play one of them.
- Only when you can neither follow suit nor trump may you play whatever you like.

That third rule is the one point of the play that varies: a minority of tables let a player who cannot overtrump discard instead. Settle it before the opening lead.

Any trump beats any plain card, so the trick belongs to the highest trump played to it. Where nobody trumped, it goes to whoever played the highest card of the led suit. Between two identical cards, the one led or played earlier wins. The winner of a trick leads to the next. When all twelve tricks are gone, the side that took the last trick claims a bonus, both sides count the counters they captured, and the hand is scored.

One consequence of the must-beat rule worth planning for: you cannot quietly duck a trick to protect a ten. If you hold the ace and the ten of a led suit and an opponent's ace is already on the table, you are compelled to play your own ace, and your ten is exposed for the rest of the hand.

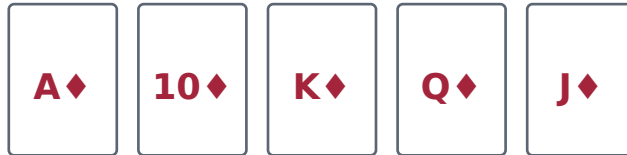


Rank within a suit is not the usual order: the ace is high but the ten sits second, above the king.

Pinochle, 40



Run in trump, 150



Diamonds trump

Royal marriage, 40



Not two marriages



A card may serve in combinations of different kinds at once, but never twice in the same kind. A run in trump already contains the royal marriage, so the 40 is not claimed again.

## Goal & scoring

The counters are the aces, tens and kings. In the point-count scheme most tables now use, each counter captured in a trick is worth 10 to the side that took it, and queens, jacks and nines are worth nothing. Twenty-four counters make 240, and the last trick is worth an extra 10, so exactly 250 points are available in tricks every hand. The older values, still in use, are ace 11, ten 10, king 4, queen 3, jack 2 with 10 for the last trick, which comes to the same 250.

Meld values in the single-deck game:

- Run in trump (A-10-K-Q-J of trump): 150. Both trump runs at once: 1500, although some tables score them simply as 150 apiece.

- Royal marriage, the king and queen of trump: 40.
- Plain marriage, king and queen of any other suit: 20 each.
- Dix, the nine of trump: 10 each, so 20 for the pair.
- Pinochle, the queen of spades with the jack of diamonds: 40. Double pinochle: 300.
- Aces around, one ace of each suit: 100. Double: 1000.
- Kings around: 80. Double: 800.
- Queens around: 60. Double: 600.
- Jacks around: 40. Double: 400.

A run already contains the royal marriage, so you do not also claim the 40 for it.

Settling a hand. Each side totals its meld together with the counters it captured. Where the contractors have matched or beaten the number they bid, both columns simply take what was earned. Falling short is another matter: the contract is set, everything the contracting pair earned that hand evaporates, and their column takes a penalty the size of the bid itself, which is quite capable of pushing a total into the negatives. Some groups soften that by letting a set side keep the meld it laid down and only deducting the bid; the harsher version given here is the more common one. The defending side scores its meld and counters as normal, subject to the same requirement that meld needs at least one trick to stand, which means a defending pair shut out of every trick records nothing at all for the hand.

The game runs to an agreed total, with 1000 and 1500 both in common use, and the first side past it wins. Should both sides cross in the same deal, the declaring side takes the game whatever the two totals actually are — they carried the contract, so they get the benefit of arriving first. The customary tie-break is that the contracting side's score is settled first, so if both sides cross the target in the same hand the contractors win, having taken the risk. Some groups play to 1500, and some let a side stop play mid-hand to claim the game.

| Scores                            | Value | Notes                                 |
|-----------------------------------|-------|---------------------------------------|
| Counter captured (ace, ten, king) | 10    | queens, jacks and nines count nothing |
| Last trick                        | 10    | 250 available in tricks each hand     |
| Run in trump (A-10-K-Q-J)         | 150   | both trump runs 1500                  |
| Royal marriage (K-Q of trump)     | 40    | not claimed again inside a run        |
| Plain marriage (K-Q, other suit)  | 20    | —                                     |
| Dix (nine of trump)               | 10    | 20 for the pair                       |



|                       |               |                                                                       |
|-----------------------|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pinochle (Q♠ with J♦) | 40            | double 300                                                            |
| Aces around           | 100           | double 1000                                                           |
| Kings around          | 80            | double 800                                                            |
| Queens around         | 60            | double 600                                                            |
| Jacks around          | 40            | double 400                                                            |
| Contract set          | minus the bid | the contractors' meld and counters are lost as well                   |
| Game                  | 1000 or 1500  | agreed beforehand; a simultaneous crossing goes to the declaring side |

## Variants

**Double-deck partnership Pinochle** — Four players in partnerships with an 80-card pack: two pinochle decks combined with all the nines removed, so four copies of A, 10, K, Q and J in each suit. Everyone gets 20 cards. Bidding opens at 50 and rises in steps of one or five. Meld values are roughly a tenth of the single-deck figures, so a trump run is 15, aces around 10, kings around 8, queens around 6, jacks around 4, a royal marriage 4, a plain marriage 2, a pinochle 4 and a double pinochle 30. Counters are the aces, tens and kings at 1 point each, 48 in total, plus 2 for the last trick, giving 50 points in tricks per hand. Game is 500. There is no card pass, and the same must-follow, must-beat, must-trump rules apply. Many North American players regard this as the standard modern form of the game.

**Two-handed Pinochle** — The classic head-to-head game, and the oldest form. Each player gets 12 cards from the 48-card pack and the remaining 24 form a face-down stock with its top card turned up to set trump. There is no auction. After each trick the winner may lay down one meld and score it immediately, then draws the top card of the stock while the loser takes the next, so both are back to 12 cards. On winning a trick you may also swap the dix, the nine of trump, for the exposed trump card. Suit-following and must-beat rules do not apply while the stock lasts; once it is exhausted, including the final face-up trump, the last 12 tricks are played under the strict follow, beat and trump rules. Counters score as in the four-handed game and the last trick is worth 10. Game is usually 1000, and if both players cross the target in the same hand the one with the higher total wins.

**Three-handed Auction Pinochle** — The best-known solo form, played with the 48-card pack. Each of the three players gets 15 cards and three go face down as a widow. Players bid, minimum usually 300, and the high bidder turns the widow face up, takes it in, names trump, and buries any three cards, which count toward the bidder's own trick score if they are counters. The bidder then plays alone against the other two, who cooperate. The bidder must reach the bid with meld plus counters or be set for the amount bid; the defenders score nothing but the satisfaction of setting the contract, and games are frequently settled per hand in chips rather than by a target total.

**Traditional counter values** — Instead of counting each ace, ten and king as 10, some tables use the historical values of ace 11, ten 10, king 4, queen 3 and jack 2, with the nine worth nothing and 10 for the last trick. The total available is identical at 250, but the distribution differs, making individual aces and tens relatively more valuable and kings less so. Worth confirming which scheme is in use before bidding, since it slightly shifts what a hand is worth.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Trickster Cards, Denexa Games.

# Piquet

|                      |                                                                             |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Rubicon Piquet                                                              |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2 players                                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 32 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 45-75 minutes                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                |

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## Setup

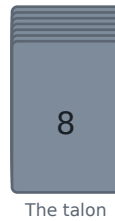
Take a pack and throw out everything from the six down, leaving thirty-two cards running seven, eight, nine, ten, jack, queen, king, ace, with the ace high. There is no trump suit in this game at any point.

Cut for the deal; whoever wins should take it, because there is a small advantage in being the non-dealer on the sixth and last hand, and dealing first is what puts you there. The deal then alternates.

Twelve cards to each player, in twos or threes as the dealer prefers, and the remaining eight go face down in the middle as the talon. Whichever rhythm the dealer picks, they must use it for their other two deals.

The names matter and will be used throughout. Whoever dealt is younger hand for that deal; their opponent is elder hand. Elder does nearly everything first — exchanges first, declares first, leads first — and that head start is the compensation for not having dealt.

One thing is worth checking before anything else happens. A hand containing no jack, queen or king at all is *carte blanche* and scores 10 outright. Say so the moment you notice. You prove it by dealing your hand rapidly face up after your opponent has discarded and before you discard yourself — and if you are elder, you have to announce how many cards you mean to exchange first, so that younger can choose their own discards without having seen your hand.



Twelve cards each and eight face down between them. Elder takes from the top of the talon, up to five; younger takes from underneath whatever elder left, usually three.

## Play

The exchange comes first and is the hardest decision in the game. Elder discards between one and five cards face down and draws the same number off the top of the talon. Younger then discards between one and whatever elder did not take — three, ordinarily — and draws to match. Anyone taking fewer than their maximum must say so before drawing. Keep your own discards beside you; you are allowed to look back at them later, and you will want to.

What the two players are doing is different. Elder, with five cards and the lead, should be building the best hand available and not thinking about defence at all; it is almost always right to take the full five. Younger, with three, has to hedge — hold something that stops elder's long suit, keep a guarded queen or king where you can — while still going for combinations. The asymmetry is the game.

A courtesy that follows from the arithmetic: elder taking fewer than five may look at the rest of the five, and younger taking fewer than allowed may

show the leftovers to both players once elder has led.

Then the declarations, which is where most of the points are. Three categories, and in each one only the better holding scores anything at all:

- Point — your longest suit, scoring one for each card in it.
- Sequence — three cards or more, all of one suit and adjacent in rank, counting the longest such run you hold.
- Set — three or four cards of one rank, and only ranks of ten or better; nines, eights and sevens do not count.

Elder announces first, taking the categories in that order, and younger answers each announcement with one word. "Good" concedes it. "Not good" claims a better one. "Equal" asks for more detail, and elder gives it — and if the two are genuinely identical, neither player scores that category at all.

Ties break like this. Points of the same length are settled on pip total, counting each court card as ten and each ace as eleven. Sequences of the same length are settled on the top card, so ace-king-queen beats king-queen-jack. Any four of a kind beats any three, and two of the same size are settled on rank.

Winning a category is worth more than the one combination that won it: whoever has the best sequence also scores every other sequence in their hand, and whoever has the best set scores their other sets too. The loser of the category scores none of theirs, however many they were holding.

You are not obliged to declare anything. Sinking a declaration — staying quiet about a holding you expect to lose, or one that would tell your opponent too much about your hand — is legitimate and sometimes correct. The price is that it is irrevocable: once elder has announced something, elder cannot go back and claim a better one after hearing "not good".

Elder then leads to the first trick, and only after that lead does younger announce and score the categories where they said "not good" or where elder stayed silent.

Twelve tricks are then played out. Nothing is trump, following the led suit is compulsory, and either player may look back through the completed tricks whenever they like. Points come in a steady trickle: one for leading to a trick, one more for taking a trick that your opponent led, and one extra for taking the last one.

Tierce, three cards



Quart, four cards



Quint, five cards



Not a sequence: two suits



A sequence is one suit and consecutive, three cards at the least. Length is what pays, and the step from four cards to five is the sharpest jump in the game.

## Goal & scoring

A match is a partie of six deals with the deal alternating, and the higher total at the end of it wins. Level after six, play two more; level after those, call it a draw.

Each player calls out their running total for the hand as they score, so both totals are public throughout — there is no hidden bookkeeping in Piquet, only hidden cards.

The margin is what is actually settled, and there is a trapdoor in it. Beat your opponent and you take the difference between the two totals plus 100. But if the loser failed to reach 100 points across the whole partie, they have not got over the rubicon, and instead of the difference you take the sum of both scores plus 100. The effect is brutal and deliberate: losing 99 to 120 costs 319, while losing 101 to 120 costs 119. Scraping past 100 is worth more to a losing player than almost anything else on the table.

The two big bonuses are what make an ordinary hand occasionally enormous.

Repique is worth 60, and goes to a player who reaches 30 in declarations alone before their opponent has scored anything whatever. For deciding whether that happened, the score is reckoned in a strict order regardless of when things were said: carte blanche, then point, then sequences, then sets, then anything made in play. So a player who racks up 30 from sequences and sets does not get a repique if the opponent held the better point, because the point is counted first.

Pique is worth 30, for reaching 30 from declarations and play together before the opponent has scored at all. Here the points count in the order they genuinely fell, which quietly puts the bonus out of younger hand's reach for good. Younger declares nothing until elder has led, and that lead is itself worth a point — so by the time younger can score at all, the opponent is never on nothing. Pique is elder's bonus and nobody else's. The 10 for the cards cannot be used to reach the thirty either.

A category that ties, with neither player scoring, does not shield anybody from either bonus.

At the end of the twelve tricks, whoever took the majority scores 10 for the cards. Six tricks each scores nobody anything. Taking all twelve is capot and pays 40 in place of the 10 — rare, and usually the end of that partie's suspense.

| Scores                          | Value      | Notes                                                         |
|---------------------------------|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Carte blanche                   | 10         | a hand with no jack, queen or king; announce it at once       |
| Point                           | 1 per card | longest suit; ties on pip total, courts 10 and aces 11        |
| Tierce, a sequence of 3         | 3          | —                                                             |
| Quart, a sequence of 4          | 4          | —                                                             |
| Quint, a sequence of 5          | 15         | —                                                             |
| Sixième, a sequence of 6        | 16         | —                                                             |
| Septième, a sequence of 7       | 17         | —                                                             |
| Huitième, a sequence of 8       | 18         | —                                                             |
| Trio, three of a rank           | 3          | tens or better only                                           |
| Quatorze, four of a rank        | 14         | tens or better only; beats any trio                           |
| Leading to a trick              | 1          | —                                                             |
| Taking a trick you did not lead | 1          | —                                                             |
| Taking the last trick           | 1 extra    | —                                                             |
| The cards                       | 10         | for taking seven tricks or more; nothing is scored at six all |
| Capot                           | 40         | all twelve tricks, in place of the 10                         |

|                    |                     |                                                              |
|--------------------|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Repique            | 60                  | 30 from declarations alone before the opponent has scored    |
| Pique              | 30                  | 30 from declarations and play before the opponent has scored |
| Winning the partie | the margin plus 100 | or both scores plus 100 if the loser fell short of 100       |

## Variants

**Piquet au cent** — The older game the modern one grew out of, and still played. Instead of a fixed six deals, a game runs until somebody reaches 100 points or more, and getting there while your opponent is still short of 50 wins a double game; a partie is then the best of five games, with a double counting as two. The rubicon disappears along with the six-deal format, which changes the whole shape of a losing position — there is no longer any reason to grind out a hundred, only to arrive first. Accounts differ on how much else travels under the name: some treat it simply as a different finish, others as the full early package described below.

**The early thirty-six card game** — How Piquet was played around 1650, and worth trying once for the shape of it. The sixes stay in, making thirty-six cards; the talon is twelve rather than eight; and elder hand may exchange up to seven. With that much of the pack passing through the players' hands the declarations grow far bigger and far more contested, and the discard — already the hardest decision in the modern game — turns into something close to a puzzle. It is normally played to a hundred points, which is why some writers file it and Piquet au cent under a single heading.

**Trick points only for tens and above** — Found in some forms of the hundred-point game. A point is scored during play only when the card led, or the card that takes the trick, is a ten or better; anything lower earns nothing. The consequence is the interesting part. In the standard game elder hand banks a point for leading to the first trick no matter what it is, and that is precisely what puts a pique out of younger hand's reach forever. Under this rule an elder who opens with a nine, an eight or a seven scores nothing at all — and younger can score a pique after all.

**Ten for the last trick** — Award 10 points for taking the final trick instead of the customary 1. A small change on the score sheet and a large one to the endgame: keeping a stopper back for trick twelve stops being worth a tidy extra point and becomes worth as much as the cards, so both players have to plan the closing tricks rather than simply cashing winners in order.

**Claiming the cards early** — Some tables let a player announce the 10 for cards the moment seven tricks are secure, and count it towards the thirty needed for a pique. It is common enough to be worth asking about, but the standard laws are read the other way — the 10 is settled at the end of the play,



by which time the opponent has almost always scored something and the question does not arise. The house rule seems to have grown out of a nineteenth-century law that mentions capot without mentioning the cards, and it makes piques a good deal easier to come by.

## **Background**

Piquet was already well established by 1650 in a form a modern player would recognise, and it is still one of the two or three best card games ever devised for exactly two people. What follows is the version the English-speaking world settled on from the late nineteenth century, codified by Cavendish in 1882 and known in the books as Rubicon Piquet — the older hundred-point game is in the variants. It asks a lot at the start — there is French vocabulary, there are three separate scoring categories before a card is played, and there are two bonuses large enough to decide a match on their own — and it repays every bit of it. Learn it over an evening rather than in ten minutes.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Parlett Games.

# Pitch

|                      |                                                        |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Setback, High-Low-Jack, Auction Pitch, Blind All Fours |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-7 players (best with 4)                              |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                             |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                          |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                 |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                           |

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## Setup

Pitch is All Fours with an auction bolted on, and the auction is what makes it. The English original turned a card up to fix trump; here somebody bids for the right to choose it, and then chooses it by leading — which is what pitching means and where the name comes from.

The game runs two ways and the rules are identical for both. Four people in two partnerships, sitting opposite their partner, is the ordinary social form and plays to 21. Everyone for themselves — cutthroat — takes three to seven and plays to 11, or to 7 for something short. Fix which before you deal, along with the target, because it is the one thing this game genuinely varies on.

Cut for first deal; it then moves clockwise, as does play. Deal six cards to each player in packets of three. The rest of the pack is set aside and is not used, so at four players nearly half the deck never appears — which is why the whole game hinges on what happens to be in play rather than on what exists.

Cards rank as you would expect, ace down to two, and there is no trump suit at all until the first card of the first trick is led.

One sheet of paper, one column per side, plus and minus. Scores go negative here often enough that people say "in the hole" rather than "minus three", and if you are keeping score with counters instead, hand each side twenty-one and take them away.

## Play

The bidding is a single round and then it is over. Starting to the dealer's left, each player either passes or names a number higher than the last bid. Two is the minimum anyone may bid and four is the top of the ordinary range; five is available only as smudge, which is a claim on all six tricks as well as all four points.

The dealer bids last and has two privileges for it. The dealer may steal the bid by matching the highest bid rather than beating it, and if everyone else

has passed, the dealer is forced to bid at least two rather than being allowed to throw the hand in. Both are worth knowing before you sit down, because they change what a marginal hand is worth in third seat.

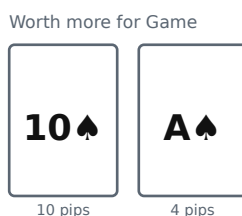
Whoever ends up highest is the pitcher. There is no announcement of a trump suit: the pitcher leads to the first trick, and whatever suit that card is, that is trump for the hand. Naming it and playing it are the same act, which means the pitcher cannot bluff about it and the rest of the table learns the suit and the pitcher's opening card at the same moment.

The rule that makes the play unlike most trick-taking games: you may always trump. Faced with a suit you hold, you must either follow it or play a trump — those are the two legal options, and choosing the trump is entirely allowed. What you may not do is discard something else while holding the suit led. That is a revoke, and it costs the offender the value of the bid.

Holding none of the suit led, you may play anything at all.

A trick belongs to whoever put the biggest trump into it; where nobody trumped at all, it belongs to the best card of whatever suit opened. Its winner leads to the next, and six tricks empty the hands.

Because you may trump at will, the hand is not a contest to take tricks. It is a contest to take four specific things, and a trick with nothing in it is worth nothing. Expect people to throw away winners and to trump their own side's high card to drag a scoring trump out of the trick.



The distinction that catches everyone out. In a trick the ace beats the ten; in the count for Game the ten is worth more than the ace and more than anything else in the pack.

## Goal & scoring

First side to the target wins — and there is a condition on that which decides more games than it sounds like it should. You can only win on a

hand you bid and made. Reaching 21 on points scavenged off somebody else's contract leaves you stuck there, unable to close it out, while they bid three, make it and win from 18. The rule keeps the last few points honest and stops a game ending by accident.

So what is being bid for. Four points are on offer in every hand, and all four live in or around the trump suit:

- High, for the top trump that was dealt at all. Not necessarily the ace — if no ace of trumps came out, the king is high, and so on down.
- Low, for the bottom trump that was dealt. Not necessarily the two, by the same argument.
- Jack, for the jack of trumps. Unlike the other three this one can simply fail to exist: if the jack of trumps was never dealt, nobody gets the point and there are only three to be had that hand.
- Game, for taking the most pips in tricks, counting tens as ten, aces four, kings three, queens two and jacks one. Eighty pips in the pack, and a tie awards nothing.

High and Low go to whoever was dealt them, so those two points are settled before a card is played and cannot be taken away. Jack and Game go to whoever ends up with the cards, which is why a hand can be won by ambushing one trick and losing the other five.

The one place the sources genuinely part company is Low. A great many tables — most partnership play among them — instead award it to whoever wins the trick the low trump falls in, which turns the two of trumps from a card you simply hold into a card you have to shepherd home. It is a real change and not a detail: agree which rule you are using before the first deal.

Now the settlement, and the mechanism the game's other name is built on. Make your bid and you score everything you took, not merely what you bid — bid two, take all four, score four. Fall short and nothing you took counts: you are set back the amount you bid, which comes straight off the total and can put you below zero. Meanwhile your opponents score whatever they picked up, whether or not they were involved in the auction. Smudge is the exception in both directions: bid it and make it for five, bid it and drop a single trick and you are five worse off, and the hand still has to be played to the end so the other side can collect.

One last piece of bookkeeping, for the hand where two sides both cross the target at once. Award the points strictly in order — the pitcher's first, then High, Low, Jack and Game — and whoever arrives first has won it.

| Scores | Value | Notes |
|--------|-------|-------|
|--------|-------|-------|

|                      |               |                                                                                  |
|----------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| High                 | 1 point       | highest trump dealt, to whoever was dealt it                                     |
| Low                  | 1 point       | lowest trump dealt                                                               |
| Jack                 | 1 point       | jack of trumps, to whoever takes the trick; nobody scores it if it was not dealt |
| Game                 | 1 point       | most pips taken in tricks; not awarded on a tie                                  |
| Smudge, bid and made | 5 points      | all four points and all six tricks; only scores if it was the bid                |
| Bid not made         | minus the bid | —                                                                                |
| Revoke               | minus the bid | —                                                                                |
| Each ten, for Game   | 10 pips       | —                                                                                |
| Each ace, for Game   | 4 pips        | —                                                                                |
| Each king, for Game  | 3 pips        | —                                                                                |
| Each queen, for Game | 2 pips        | —                                                                                |
| Each jack, for Game  | 1 pip         | 80 pips in the pack altogether                                                   |

## Variants

**Draw after the pitch** — Once trump is out, everyone discards face down whatever they do not want and the dealer tops their hand back up to six from the undealt part of the pack. Trumps may not be thrown, and in practice most players bin everything else and hope. It is the single most popular addition to the partnership game, and it changes the character completely: the ace, the two and the jack of trumps nearly always reach the table, so High, Low and Jack stop being lotteries about what was dealt and become things you have to win.

**Cutthroat Pitch** — Every player for themselves, from three to seven of them, with the bidding and play exactly as in the partnership game and a shorter target — 11 is usual, 7 for a quick session. It plays quite differently despite the identical rules, because the entire table has a shared interest in setting whoever won the auction, and an informal alliance forms and dissolves every hand. This is the version card books tend to describe, and traditionally the one played for money.

**Ten-point Pitch** — The mid-western expansion, and a much bigger game. Two distinguishable jokers join the pack, and the off-jack — the other jack of the trump colour — is promoted into the trump suit. Trumps then run ace, king, queen, jack, off-jack, high joker, low joker, ten and down. Each of the three newcomers carries its own point, taking the total to seven, and awarding three more for the trey of trumps takes it to ten. Deal is nine cards each at four players, with the remainder left as a widow.

**Pedro and Cinch** — Promote the five of trumps into a scoring card worth five points on its own, and the hand is suddenly worth nine rather than four; that

game is Pedro. Add the other five of the same colour, also worth five, and the total reaches fourteen and the game is Cinch, or Double Pedro. Both are properly separate games rather than house rules, with their own bidding conventions, but they grew directly out of tables adding one more thing to chase.

**No junk points** — Only the bidding side scores. Make the bid and take your points as usual; fail and be set back as usual, but the opposition collect nothing either way. It removes the consolation prize and with it most of the reason to fight over a hand you cannot win, so play becomes flatter and games run longer. Worth knowing because it is common enough that somebody will assume it.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards.

# Schieber Jass

|                      |                                                                                |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Schieber, Chibre                                                               |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4 players                                                                      |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 36 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 45-90 minutes                                                                  |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                   |

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## Setup

Jass is a whole family of Swiss games rather than one game, and Schieber is the branch of it most tables mean when they sit down without saying which. Four players in fixed partnerships, partners opposite each other. The name comes from *schieben*, to push: the one decision each hand turns on can be pushed across the table to your partner, who then has to make it.

The pack is thirty-six cards, an ordinary deck with everything below the six taken out. Swiss packs come in two designs and the country is split down the middle over them — Swiss-German suits of roses, bells, acorns and shields in the east and centre, French suits in the west and south — but the game is the same and any 36-card pack plays it. Swiss cards call the queen an Ober, the jack an Under and the ten a Banner, and those names turn up in the rules whichever pack is on the table.

Two rankings and two sets of card values, and none of it is negotiable:

- A plain suit runs ace, king, queen, jack, ten, nine, eight, seven, six, and the ten counts 10 while the jack counts 2, so its fifth-highest card is its second most valuable.
- In trumps the jack leaps to the top as the Puur, worth 20, and the nine follows it as the Nell, worth 14. The rest keep their order and their values underneath: ace 11, king 4, queen 3, ten 10, and nothing for the eight, seven and six.

That puts 62 points in the trump suit and 30 in each of the others. Add 5 for whoever takes the last trick and every deal is worth 157.

Deal and play run to the right, anticlockwise. Anybody may deal the first hand; after that the deal moves one seat right each time. Who gets the first hand's choice of contract is a table custom rather than a rule — cut for it, or hand it to whoever is dealt a nominated seven — and from the second hand on it is simply the seat to the dealer's right. Deal all thirty-six cards out in packets of three, starting with the player on the dealer's right, so everyone holds nine and nothing is left over.

Score on a slate if you have one, which is how it is done in Switzerland — a Z drawn on it, hundreds along the top, fifties on the diagonal, twenties along the bottom. A sheet of paper loses nothing but the atmosphere.

## Play

Choosing the game. Forehand — the player to the dealer's right — either names what is played or pushes the choice to their partner, who must then name it. Nobody bids and nothing is contested: the choice is a privilege attached to a seat, and it moves one seat right each deal. What may be named:

- Any of the four suits as trumps.
- Obenabe, no trumps and every suit ranking downward from the ace.
- Undenufe, no trumps and every suit ranking upward from the six, so the six is the best card in it and the ace the worst. Most tables now move the 11 points across with it, making the six worth 11 and the ace nothing, and some of those let four sixes stand as a Weis in place of four aces. Older Swiss practice, and the Vorarlberg and South Tyrol forms, leave the values where they are; ask.

With no trump suit there is no Puur and no Nell, so 32 points go missing. The four eights make them up, counting 8 each instead of nothing, and the deal is worth 157 again.

Whatever you chose then sets a factor, and every point your side collects that deal is multiplied by it — the Weis and the Stöck exactly as much as the card points. The table has the figures. Two of the four suits are worth double, which is what makes choosing a live decision rather than a formality. On a Swiss pack those two are shields and bells; on a French pack the usual convention hands the doubling to the two black suits, but the sources genuinely disagree about it, so settle which two before the first deal.

The tricks. Forehand leads to the first one; from then on the lead belongs to whoever took the last. The following rule is the one that marks these games out from the whist family, and it is worth reading twice: holding the suit led, you may either follow it or play a trump, as you please. There is never any obligation to follow a plain suit when a trump would suit you better.

What is forbidden instead is undertrumping. Once somebody has trumped a plain suit, nobody after them may drop a smaller trump onto it to be rid of the card. If you can follow the suit led, your choice narrows to following it or beating that trump; if you cannot follow, you may play anything at all except a trump that fails to beat it. A player holding nothing but trumps is



released from all of that and may play any of them.

Two more:

- When trumps are led you must play one if you have one, with a single exception, and it is a valuable one: if the Puur is the only trump left in your hand, you may hold on to it and play anything else instead.
- The trick belongs to the highest trump on it, and where no trump was played, to whoever went highest in the suit that opened.

Nine tricks empty the hands. Taking all nine is a match and pays 100 above the 157, before the multiplier.

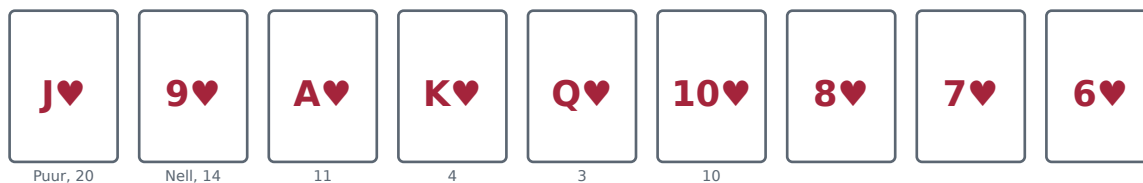
Weis. Combinations held at the start of play score, and only one side collects them. A run of three or more cards in one suit counts, and so does four of a kind in ace, king, queen or ten, with four jacks the best thing in the game at 200. The trap is that Weis are read in the ordinary suit order, ace down to six, which has nothing to do with the trick-taking order — the Puur, the Nell and the ace of trumps are the three best cards you can hold and they are not a run.

The collecting is settled over the first trick. As each player plays their card they may name the value of their best Weis; whoever is beaten says so, and where two claims are level the players compare length, then top card, then trump, then seating order, giving away as little as they can while they do it. The side owning the best single Weis scores every Weis on that side, and the other side scores none of its own however good they were.

Anybody may ask to see a scored Weis before the second trick.

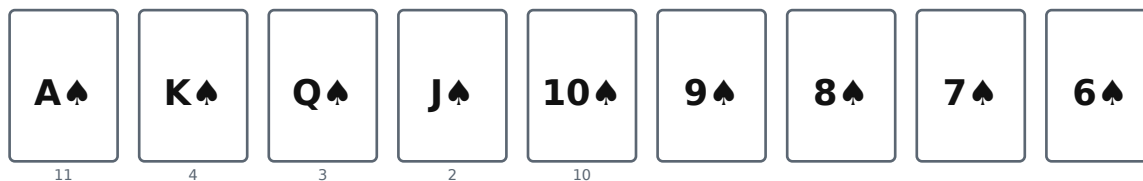
Stöck sits outside all of that. Hold the king and queen of trumps and you say stöck as you play the second of them, for 20, and it cannot be beaten or cancelled by anybody's Weis.

Trumps



Trumps, high to low, with hearts as trumps. The jack and nine jump to the front carrying the two largest values; the ten ranks below the queen and is worth more than the king and queen together.

Plain suit



Every other suit. The jack drops back to fourth and is worth 2, the nine is worth nothing, and the ten is still the second most valuable card in the suit.

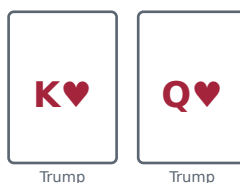
Run of four, 50



Not a run



Stöck, 20



Weis run in the ordinary suit order, never in the trick-taking order. The three best trumps in the game sit next to each other and are not a run.

## Goal & scoring

Each side counts the card points in its tricks, whoever took the last trick adds 5, and the two totals must come to 157. A side that took all nine holds all 157 and adds another 100 for the match, making 257. Apply the contract's factor to that, and add whatever Weis and Stöck went onto the slate earlier — those were multiplied by the same figure when they were written down — and the deal is finished.

Nobody has to make anything. There is no contract to fail and no penalty for choosing badly — a bad choice simply hands the opponents a large score at your multiplier, which is punishment enough.

The target is agreed before the first deal, and this is the one number the sources genuinely differ on. Where the multipliers are in use, 2500 is the usual figure and some rule sets say 3000; where every contract counts single, 1000. A game to 3000 typically runs about a dozen hands.

Crossing the line is a move rather than an event. A side that believes it has arrived must say so — the Swiss verb is *sich bedanken*, to give thanks — and the game stops there, in the middle of a hand if need be. Claim correctly and you have won, even if the opponents were about to pass you. Forget to claim and you have not won yet. Claim without the points and you lose on the spot, so count the slate before you open your mouth.

Which leaves the case where both sides could cross on the same trick, and this is what the three scoring elements are named in order for. *Stöck*, *Wiis*, *Stich* — marriage, melds, tricks — is the commonest Swiss answer: count the *Stöck* first, and if that takes a side to the target it has won; then the *Weis*; then the trick. *Stöck-Stich-Wiis* is also played, and *Vorarlberg* tends to put the trick first. Swiss cafés that keep cards behind the bar often have their order posted on the wall, which tells you how often it comes up.

| Scores                                            | Value | Notes                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jack of trumps ( <i>Puur</i> )                    | 20    | —                                                                            |
| Nine of trumps ( <i>Nell</i> )                    | 14    | —                                                                            |
| Ace, any suit                                     | 11    | in <i>Undenufe</i> , most tables give this 11 to the six and the ace nothing |
| Ten, any suit                                     | 10    | —                                                                            |
| King, any suit                                    | 4     | —                                                                            |
| Queen, any suit                                   | 3     | —                                                                            |
| Jack, not trump                                   | 2     | —                                                                            |
| Nine not trump, and all eights, sevens and sixes  | 0     | —                                                                            |
| Each eight, in <i>Obenabe</i> and <i>Undenufe</i> | 8     | replaces the missing <i>Puur</i> and <i>Nell</i> , keeping the deal at 157   |
| Last trick                                        | 5     | 157 on the table every deal                                                  |
| Match, all nine tricks                            | +100  | —                                                                            |
| <i>Stöck</i> (king and queen of trumps)           | 20    | never contested by anyone's <i>Weis</i>                                      |
| Run of three                                      | 20    | —                                                                            |
| Run of four                                       | 50    | —                                                                            |
| Run of five or more                               | 100   | —                                                                            |
| Four aces, kings, queens or tens                  | 100   | —                                                                            |
| Four nines                                        | 150   | only if agreed beforehand; many tables do not allow it                       |
| Four jacks                                        | 200   | —                                                                            |
| Roses or acorns as trumps                         | x1    | —                                                                            |

|                            |    |                                                   |
|----------------------------|----|---------------------------------------------------|
| Shields or bells as trumps | x2 | with a French pack, usually the two black suits   |
| Obenabe                    | x3 | —                                                 |
| Undenufe                   | x4 | multipliers apply to tricks, Weis and Stöck alike |

## Variants

**Everything single** — Drop the multipliers and score every contract at face value, which lowers the target to 1000 and takes the arithmetic out of the choice. Choosing then becomes purely a question of which contract your hand plays best in, rather than of gambling a weak hand at four times the stake because Undenufe was worth it. It is the easier version to learn the game on.

**Coiffeur Schieber** — The other direction entirely, and enough of a game in its own right that it is usually written up separately. The contracts become a grid: each side has eight to get through, sixteen deals in all, and a contract once played is crossed off and unavailable for the rest of the session. Each carries its own multiplier from one to eight, rising through the suits to Obenabe, Undenufe and two jokers, and the score for a hand is the card points divided by ten with the units thrown away, times that multiplier. Since you cannot keep choosing what suits your hand, the question becomes which remaining box to spend a mediocre one on — which is what the name puns at, coiffeur for quoi faire, what on earth do I do.

**Shoving back** — Some tables let a partner who has been pushed to push it straight back, which forces forehand to choose after all. It sounds like a joke and is not: the first push says nothing more than that your hand is unremarkable, and the second says the same thing louder, so the pair have swapped a decision for a small amount of genuine information.

**Large Weis** — An extended schedule, promoted by the modern Swiss rulebook Puur-Näll-As, which public Schieber tournaments now largely follow. Long runs go on scoring past five — 150 for six, 200 for seven, 250 for eight, 300 for nine — and, unlike the ordinary schedule, one card may count in a four of a kind and in a run at the same time, so four kings alongside a run through one of them score both rather than the better of the two.

**Bergpreis** — A consolation prize for reaching the halfway mark first — 1500 in a 3000-point game, 500 in a 1000-point one. The metaphor is a bicycle race: the first side up the mountain takes the climb, and the game is still decided by whoever gets down the far side. It changes nothing about the play and gives a side that is being beaten something to hold on to.

## Background

Jass reached Switzerland from the Low Countries and was first recorded there in 1796, when the word meant the highest trump — the jack — rather than the game. It has since taken over the language: the 36-card packs are

Jasskarten, and the Swiss will call almost any card game played with them a Jass. There are said to be more than seventy variants, of which Schieber is the one most people play, and the game is regular television, with weekly Jass programmes on Swiss national broadcasting.

The two pack designs mark a real cultural line. Swiss-German suits are used east of a boundary running through the Brünig pass, the Napf and the Reuss, and French suits west and south of it, so which cards are on the table says roughly where you are. The game travelled with the language rather than the border, and is played in Liechtenstein, Vorarlberg, Alsace, South Tyrol and the southern edge of Baden-Württemberg, along with pockets of the United States — Wisconsin and Ohio among them.

Belote, also in this collection, is a French relative from the same branch of the family, which is why its jack and nine of trumps are worth 20 and 14 as well.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Wikipedia (German).

# Sheepshead

|                      |                                                                             |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | American Schafkopf, Sheephead                                               |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-5 players (best with 5)                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 32 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                      |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                |

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## Setup

Five is the number Sheepshead is written for, and what follows assumes five. Three and four also have settled forms, listed in the variants.

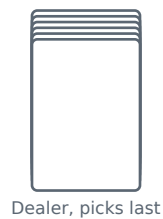
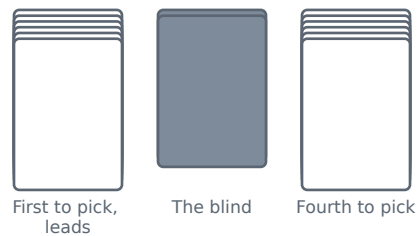
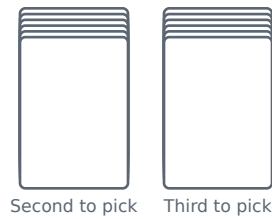
Strip a standard pack down to the aces, kings, queens, jacks, tens, nines, eights and sevens — thirty-two cards. Everything smaller goes back in the box.

The ranking is not the one you know and there is no way round learning it first. Fourteen of the thirty-two are trumps, permanently, deal after deal: every queen, every jack and the whole diamond suit. They run queen of clubs, spades, hearts, diamonds, then jack of clubs, spades, hearts, diamonds, then the diamonds from the ace down. The eighteen cards left over make three fail suits — clubs, spades and hearts, six apiece — each running ace, ten, king, nine, eight, seven, so the ten sits above the king. And a card made trump has left its printed suit behind for good: your jack of hearts is not a heart, so it will not answer a heart lead, and leading it asks the table for trumps.

Card values are the Schafkopf ones: an ace is 11, a ten is 10, a king 4, a queen 3 and a jack 2, with the nines, eights and sevens worth nothing. The pack holds 120, so the number to beat is 61.

Deal six cards to each player, three at a time and clockwise, and put two face down in the middle after the first round of three. Those two are the blind. Deal the blind somewhere in the middle of the deal rather than off the bottom at the end, where the last cards are the ones most likely to have been seen. The deal passes left.

One person picks up the blind each hand and takes on the table, usually with a partner nobody can identify yet. Keep score with a column per player, running plus and minus; the columns always add to zero, which is the check that nothing has gone wrong.



Six cards each and two face down in the middle uses up all thirty-two. The chance to pick starts at the dealer's left and goes clockwise; that same seat leads to the first trick.

| Players | Each player gets |
|---------|------------------|
| 3       | 10 cards         |
| 4       | 7 cards          |
| 5       | 6 cards          |

## Play

**Picking.** Starting at the dealer's left and going clockwise, each player either takes the blind or passes. Whoever takes it is the picker, adds those two cards to their hand, and then buries any two face down. Buried cards are out of play but not out of the reckoning: they count to the picker's side at the end, provided that side takes at least one trick. Bury points deliberately — it is the one wholly safe place to put an ace.

If everyone passes, agree in advance what happens. The usual answers are a forced pick by the dealer, a leaster, or a doubler; all three are described in the variants.

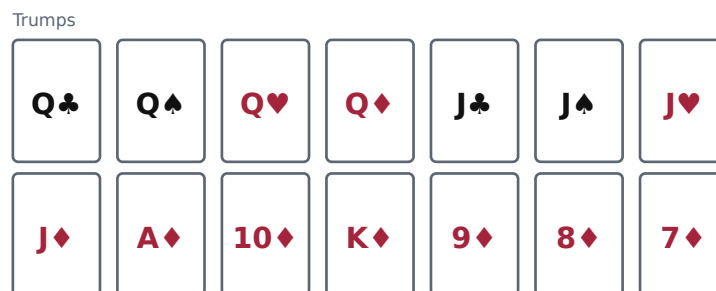
**Calling a partner.** The picker names a fail ace — clubs, spades or hearts — and its holder plays as the partner for that hand without either of them admitting it. Four rules make this work rather than being a call into thin air:

- Only a fail ace may be named. Diamonds are trumps, so the ace and ten of diamonds are never available.
- Whatever suit is named, the picker has to be holding something in it, and cannot name an ace already in hand.
- That holding is then frozen. It may not be thrown away on somebody else's trick, and it has to go down the first time its suit is led.
- The partner is tied the same way in reverse, and must put the ace down the first time that suit is led even while holding other cards of it.

Two situations need a way out, and which one you are in depends on how many of the fail aces you hold. Short of all three, but with no fail card you could keep back — every one held is itself an ace, or there are none at all — you may name a suit you cannot follow and put a card face down as an unknown: it goes on the trick when the called suit is led, has no power to win it, and still counts its points to whoever does. Holding all three fail aces leaves no ace to name at all, so a ten is named instead, and the ace of that suit is what the picker keeps back for the moment its suit is led. A picker who would rather not have a partner at all announces it before the lead and plays alone against four.

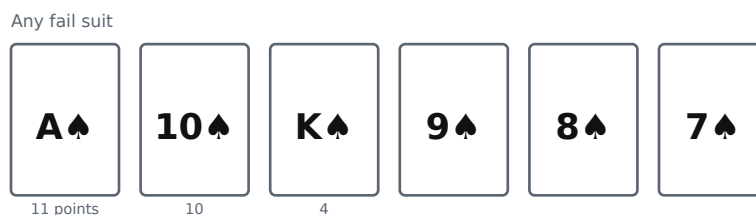
The tricks. The dealer's left neighbour leads to the first trick, and thereafter the winner of a trick leads to the next. Follow suit if you can. Trump counts as its own suit here, so a trump lead demands a trump from anybody who holds one, and the queens and jacks in your hand answer to that lead rather than to whatever is printed on them. Anyone unable to follow may trump or throw off any card they like. Whoever laid the strongest card takes the trick: the top trump if any were played, and otherwise the top card of whichever fail suit opened it. A card of another fail suit cannot win a trick however large it is. Six tricks empty the hands.

Throwing a high-value card onto a trick your own side is winning is called schmearing, and it is most of what the play is about. Until the called suit appears the partner is anonymous, so the real question on almost every trick is whether the player about to win it is a friend.



The fourteen trumps, high to low. They are the same every deal, and a card in this row belongs to no other suit.





Each of the three fail suits, high to low. Six cards, with the ten above the king and the queen and jack gone to the trumps.

## Goal & scoring

Count the card points your side took. The picker and partner need 61 of the 120 and the other three need 60, so a sixty-all split is a defensive win. Two further lines matter: holding the other side under 30 is schneider and pays double, and taking every trick pays triple. Because the winning line sits at 61 rather than 60, the schneider line is 31 for the picking side and 30 for the defenders — the picker is schneidered on 30 and safe on 31.

What gets written down is a game point per player, plus and minus, adding to zero. One figure drives all of it, and it belongs to the picker, who chose the hand: 2 for a win, 4 for a win that schneiders the defence, 6 for taking every trick, and the same three numbers negative for the matching failures. The partner takes half of whatever the picker takes, and each of the three defenders pays half of it — which is what makes the columns cancel. The table has the six rows. They are the five-handed schedule, and other table sizes score differently, so a three- or four-handed game has to settle its own before the first deal.

A picker playing alone doubles their own figure, so those six become 4, 8 and 12 and the same three negatives. Each defender still wins or loses 1, 2 or 3 as before — there are simply four of them now instead of three, which is what keeps the columns adding to zero.

Two things about the losing rows are worth settling before you deal. Most tables, and by one account almost every tournament, play double on the bump, which doubles every losing row: a plain loss then costs the picker 4 and the partner 2 and pays each defender 2. It exists to make people think before picking. And where the picking side takes no trick whatever, some tables charge the entire penalty to the picker and let the partner off — minus 9 to the picker, nothing to the partner, plus 3 to each of the other three — rather than splitting it two to one. Sources differ on which of those is standard, so it is a table rule rather than a fact about the game.

There is no target score. Play an agreed number of hands, or an agreed length of evening, and the highest running total wins. Where the game is played for money, one game point is one agreed unit.

| Scores                         | Value                      | Notes                                                         |
|--------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ace                            | 11                         | —                                                             |
| Ten                            | 10                         | —                                                             |
| King                           | 4                          | —                                                             |
| Queen                          | 3                          | —                                                             |
| Jack                           | 2                          | —                                                             |
| Nine, eight, seven             | 0                          | 120 in the pack; the picking side needs 61 and the defence 60 |
| Picking side takes 61-90       | +2 / +1 / -1               | picker / partner / each defender                              |
| Picking side takes 91-120      | +4 / +2 / -2               | defenders held under 30, which is schneider                   |
| Picking side takes every trick | +6 / +3 / -3               | —                                                             |
| Picking side takes 31-60       | -2 / -1 / +1               | —                                                             |
| Picking side takes 30 or less  | -4 / -2 / +2               | the picking side schneidered                                  |
| Picking side takes no trick    | -6 / -3 / +3               | some tables charge the picker alone: -9 / 0 / +3              |
| Picker alone                   | double the picker's figure | four defenders instead of three, each unchanged at 1, 2 or 3  |

## Variants

**Jack of diamonds** — The other common way of finding a partner. Nobody calls anything: whoever holds the jack of diamonds is the picker's partner, and since that card need not be played early the secret usually keeps longer than a called ace does. The picker who finds the jack in hand, or in the blind, normally has to play alone — though many tables let such a picker call up to the next jack they do not hold, most often the jack of hearts.

**Three-handed and four-handed** — Three-handed is a real game rather than a fallback, with its own long-running tournament: ten cards each, two in the blind, and the picker against the other two with no partner to find and a scoring schedule of its own to agree. Only three cards land on a trick, which lifts the fail aces a long way — one stands a real chance of taking a trick on its own — and makes how many trumps you hold matter nearly as much as which ones. Four-handed usually deals seven each with four in the blind, which means the picker buries four and, with that much hidden, commonly plays alone; some tables allow a partner and some do not. Six, seven and eight-handed forms exist too, generally by shrinking the hands and adding partners.

**Leasters** — One answer to a hand nobody wants. If all five pass, the blind is set aside and the hand is played with the goal reversed: no partners, no picker, and whoever finishes with the fewest card points takes a point from each of the other four. Most tables require a trick to qualify, which stops anybody winning by simply ducking everything and leaves taking all six tricks as a strange back-door win. The blind normally goes to whoever takes the last trick, and is not

looked at until the hand is over.

**Forced pick and doublers** — The other two answers to a passed-out hand. Under a forced pick the dealer, having had the last look, must take the blind whatever is in it; tables often waive double on the bump in exchange, since the pick was not voluntary. Under a doubler the cards are simply thrown in and dealt again, and the replacement hand is played for twice the stakes, which is a real reason to find a pick in a hand you would otherwise have passed.

**Cracking and blitzing** — Two ways of raising the stakes mid-hand. Anyone seated after the picker, who therefore never had the chance to take the blind, and who is not the partner, may crack — usually by rapping the table — which doubles the hand. The picking side may crack back to double it again, and some tables allow a further raise beyond that. Blitzing is the other lever: a player holding both black queens may show them to double the hand as well, normally only once somebody has cracked. Where both are in use a ceiling is worth agreeing on, because the multipliers compound.

## Background

Schafkopf is Bavaria's own game, and Sheepshead is what became of it in America, down to the name: Schafkopf means sheep's head, and somebody translated it. Nineteenth-century German rule books and early twentieth-century American ones both carry it, in forms for three, four, six and eight. Whether the German name ever meant a sheep's head is another question: one account traces it to scoring a game by drawing a stylised sheep's head in nine strokes, another argues it began as a barrel head — Schaff, a barrel — and refers to what people played on.

Wisconsin adopted it thoroughly enough that it is often described as the state's unofficial card game, and Milwaukee named it the city's official one in 1983. Tournaments run there through the year, including a national three-handed one held every March since 1970, and the game also has a following in the German-settled counties of southern Indiana. The five-handed called-ace form described above is what modern accounts treat as the main game; almost everything else about it is negotiable, and a table you have not sat at before will tell you its rules first.

Rules checked against: [Pagat](#), [Wikipedia](#), [Sheepshead.org](#).

# Skat

|                      |                                                                             |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | German Skat, Deutscher Skat                                                 |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-4 players (best with 3)                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 32 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 45-90 minutes                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                |

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## Setup

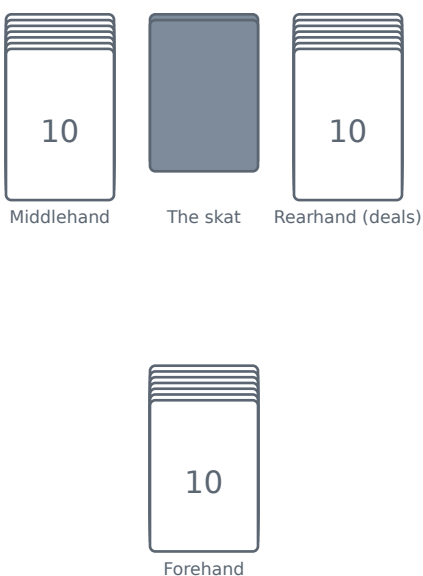
Skat is a game for three, always. Four may sit at the table, in which case whoever deals stands out of that hand and the other three play it, so a four-handed table simply gives every player one hand in four off. Take a standard pack and remove everything below the seven, leaving thirty-two cards.

Cut for first deal, then pass it to the left each hand. Deal in the traditional packets: three cards to each player, two face down in the middle, four more to each player, three more to each player. Everyone ends with ten, and the two cards in the middle are the skat that the game is named after.

Card values are what the play is for. An ace is 11, a ten is 10, a king 4, a queen 3, a jack 2, and the nine, eight and seven count nothing at all. That puts 120 points in the pack, which is why 61 is the number that matters.

Now the ranking, which has to be learned before the first hand rather than during it. The four jacks are not members of their printed suits. In a suit game they stand above everything as the top four trumps, in the fixed order clubs, spades, hearts, diamonds, and the seven cards of the chosen trump suit rank underneath them — so trump is eleven cards deep and each of the other three suits is only seven. Inside any suit the ten sits immediately below the ace and above the king. A grand game promotes nothing but the four jacks. A null game has no trump at all and hands the jack back to its own suit, where it belongs between the queen and the ten.

Rule a sheet with a column per player, running plus and minus. Individual tricks are never written down; each hand yields a single figure, and in the basic scheme only the declarer's column moves.



Ten cards each and two face down in the middle. Forehand sits to the dealer's left, speaks last in the auction and always leads to the first trick, whoever ends up declaring.

## Play

The auction. Seats are named for it: forehand on the dealer's left, middlehand next, rearhand last. At a four-player table the dealer takes no part in anything.

Bids are game values, and only numbers that a real contract can produce are legal. The ladder therefore starts at 18, the cheapest game there is — diamonds, base value 9, times a matador and the game itself — and climbs 20, 22, 23, 24, 27, 30, 33, 35, 36 and on up. A bid claims that the game you mean to play is worth at least that much. It says nothing about which game.

The contest opens between middlehand and forehand. Middlehand may want no part of it and drop out immediately; otherwise a number goes across the table, and what comes back from forehand is one word. Pass settles it there. Yes does not — it is a claim on that same figure, and the burden returns to middlehand, who now has to find a bigger number or quit. Numbers and yeses alternate until one of the pair gives up. Rearhand inherits whichever of them is left, and the same alternation runs again with rearhand doing the calling. Standing at the end of all this is one player, the declarer, who takes on the other two single-handed; those two are allies for the duration of the hand and no longer.

Forehand is the one seat that never has to bid. If middlehand and rearhand both pass at once, nobody has asked forehand for anything, and forehand may simply announce a game — worth at least the minimum 18 — or pass in turn. Should all three pass, the table either throws the cards in and redeals or plays Ramsch. Settle which before the first hand.

Choosing the game. The declarer's first decision is the skat. Take it, and you hold twelve cards for a moment and must bury any two face down; those two count toward your own card points when the hand is totted up. Refuse it, and you are playing a hand game, which is worth an extra multiplier — the skat still belongs to your side either way, whether you looked at it or not. The contract is then announced: a trump suit, or grand, or null, together with any extras.

The extras nest in a fixed way, and this is where people go wrong. Announcing schneider or schwarz in advance is open only to a hand game, and each announcement drags the one below it along: schwarz announced includes schneider announced, and in suit and grand contracts ouvert requires schwarz announced on top of that, with your ten cards spread face up before the opening lead. A grand ouvert therefore carries hand, schneider, schneider announced, schwarz, schwarz announced and ouvert all at once — six factors above the matadors and the game, so with all four jacks it is  $(4 + 1 + 6) \times 24$ , or 264, the largest ordinary game in Skat. Null ouvert carries no such condition: you simply lay the hand out and try to lose every trick with it visible.

The tricks. Forehand leads first, declarer or not. Follow suit if you can. The trap is the jacks: with hearts as trump, leading the jack of diamonds is a trump lead, not a diamond lead, and a player whose only trump is the jack of clubs is obliged to play it. A player who cannot follow may do anything — trump, or throw away. There is no duty to trump and no duty to beat. The trick belongs to the biggest trump played to it, or where nobody trumped, to whichever card of the opening suit is highest. Its winner leads to the next. Ten tricks exhaust the hands.

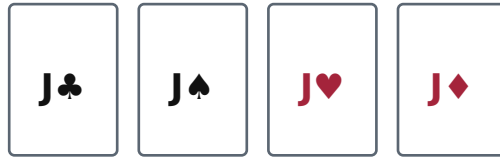
Null works the same way minus the trumps. Following suit is still compulsory, nothing from outside the opening suit can beat it, and whichever card of that suit is highest takes the trick.

Reckoning up. The declarer sweeps in every trick won plus the two skat cards and counts the values. The defenders count theirs as one pile, not two. Between them the totals must come to 120, which is a useful check that nothing has gone astray.



A suit game with spades as trump. All four jacks desert their own suits to head the trump suit in an order that never changes, so trump runs eleven cards deep.

Trump



Every suit



Grand. Only the jacks are trump, in the same order, and all four suits are seven cards long.

Every suit



Null. No trump anywhere, and the jack goes home to its own suit, between the queen and the ten. The ten is no longer promoted either.

## Goal & scoring

Two players are trying to stop one. What the declarer has to achieve depends on the contract:

- Suit or grand: 61 card points or better. Sixty is a loss.
- Schneider: 90 or better. Optional as a bonus, compulsory if it was announced.
- Schwarz: all ten tricks.
- Null: not one trick. A single trick ends it, and card points are beside the point.

Game value is a base value multiplied by a count of factors, and the count begins with the matadors — the unbroken run of top trumps at the head of the order.

Count matadors downward from the jack of clubs. If you hold it, you are with as many trumps as the run you own before the first gap: the jack of clubs on its own is with 1, the jacks of clubs and spades is with 2, and so on through the trump order. If you do not hold it, you are without as many as the run at the top you are missing. The arithmetic does not care which: with 3 and without 3 both contribute 3. Add 1 for the game itself, add a factor for every extra that applies, and multiply the total by the base value. A grand played from the hand with the two top jacks comes to  $(2 + 1 + 1) \times 24$ , or 96.

Null ignores that whole apparatus and uses four flat values instead, which is why a null is often the cheapest way to buy an auction with a hand full of low cards.

Settling. Bring the contract home and your column gains the game value. Fail and it loses twice that, and the factors that actually happened are counted before the doubling — a declarer held to 30 card points or fewer has been schneidered and pays for that factor as well. There is also a way to lose on paper alone. If the game you actually played is worth less than the number you bid, you have overbid, and the hand is lost however many points you took. The deduction is then twice the lowest legal value of your contract that reaches your bid, which can be a great deal more than the game was ever going to pay. Counting matadors before you open your mouth in the auction is not caution, it is the whole discipline of bidding.

There is no target score. Agree a number of hands — a multiple of the number of players, three or four, so that every seat deals the same number of times and, at a four-handed table, sits out the same number of times — and the highest total at the end wins.

| Scores                    | Value   | Notes                                                   |
|---------------------------|---------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Ace                       | 11      | —                                                       |
| Ten                       | 10      | —                                                       |
| King                      | 4       | —                                                       |
| Queen                     | 3       | —                                                       |
| Jack                      | 2       | —                                                       |
| Nine, eight, seven        | 0       | 120 in the pack, so 61 wins and 90 is schneider         |
| Base value, diamonds      | 9       | —                                                       |
| Base value, hearts        | 10      | —                                                       |
| Base value, spades        | 11      | —                                                       |
| Base value, clubs         | 12      | —                                                       |
| Base value, grand         | 24      | —                                                       |
| Matadors, with or without | +1 each | —                                                       |
| The game itself           | +1      | always counted                                          |
| Hand, skat left alone     | +1      | —                                                       |
| Schneider made            | +1      | —                                                       |
| Schneider announced       | +1      | hand games only, and on top of the factor for making it |
| Schwarz made              | +1      | —                                                       |
| Schwarz announced         | +1      | hand games only                                         |
| Ouvert                    | +1      | needs schwarz announced in suit and grand games         |
| Null                      | 23      | flat, no multipliers                                    |
| Null hand                 | 35      | —                                                       |



|                  |                       |   |
|------------------|-----------------------|---|
| Null ouvert      | 46                    | — |
| Null ouvert hand | 59                    | — |
| Contract lost    | minus twice the value | — |

## Variants

**Ramsch** — What many tables play instead of redealing a passed-out hand. Nobody declares; the jacks are the only trumps, as in grand; and the aim reverses, since whoever finishes with the most card points loses that many. Taking every trick is a durchmarsch and wins outright instead, usually for 120. A player who takes no trick at all is a Jungfrau and, at most tables, doubles what the loser pays. In the shove-along form, Schieberamsch, the skat is passed round the table before play and every shove doubles the damage again. It is not part of the official rules, so the details are whatever your table says they are.

**Kontra and Re** — A doubling exchange borrowed from other German games. Before the first card is led, a defender who fancies the odds may call kontra, doubling what the hand is worth; the declarer may answer re and double it again, and some tables allow a further step or two beyond that. It changes nothing about how the cards are played and everything about how loudly a marginal contract is punished. Common in casual and club play, absent from tournament rules.

**Officers' Skat** — The two-player version, and a genuinely good game rather than a compromise. Nothing is held in the hand and there is no skat: all thirty-two cards go straight onto the table, sixteen to each player as eight face-down cards each covered by a face-up one, usually laid out as two rows of four pairs. Only the exposed card of a pair may be played, and playing it turns the card beneath face up, so half of what you hold is public and the other half arrives one card at a time. The auction shrinks to the non-dealer naming the game and the trump. Trumps, card values and the target of 61 are unchanged, and the deal runs to sixteen tricks rather than ten. Known in German as Offiziersskat.

**Seeger-Fabian tournament scoring** — The scheme used by German and international skat associations, layered on top of ordinary game values. A declarer who wins adds 50 to the game value; a declarer who loses subtracts 50 on top of the doubled value. Each defender picks up 40 whenever a contract is beaten, cut to 30 at a four-player table so that totals made at tables of different sizes stay comparable. The effect is to reward taking on contracts rather than sitting back, since a passed hand earns nobody anything, and it makes scores from different tables comparable.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Britannica, Parlett Games, Skatgame.net, Deutscher Skatverband, Official Game Rules.

# Spades

|                   |                                            |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Players</b>    | 2-4 players (best with 4)                  |
| <b>Deck</b>       | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>       | 45-90 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b> | Medium                                     |
| <b>Category</b>   | Trick-taking                               |

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## Setup

Spades is a four-player partnership game. Partners sit opposite each other so that the two sides alternate around the table. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Cards rank ace high down to 2 low in every suit, and spades are permanently trump. Nothing is turned or named to decide the trump suit; it is spades in every hand of every game.

Choose the first dealer by cutting, high card taking the deal, and move the deal one seat to the left after each hand. The dealer shuffles, offers a cut to the player on their right, then deals the whole pack out one card at a time clockwise starting with the player on their left, so everyone finishes with 13 cards. Each hand is therefore 13 tricks.

Set up the score sheet before you start. You need one column per partnership for points and, next to each, a small separate running tally of bags. The bag count carries across the entire game rather than resetting each hand, and forgetting to track it is the single most common way a Spades game goes wrong.

## Play

Bidding comes first and takes exactly one round. Beginning left of the dealer and going clockwise, everyone reads their hand and says how many tricks they think it is worth — any figure from 0 to 13. Bids do not have to increase, nobody may pass, and once a number is said it stands. You may not describe your hand or ask your partner anything, but every bid is public, so the last player to bid knows a great deal more than the first. The two partners' bids are added together into a single contract for the side: bids of 4 and 3 mean that partnership must take at least 7 tricks. Some groups impose a minimum team contract of 4, so check the house rule before you deal.

A bid of 0 is nil, a declaration that you personally will win no tricks whatsoever. Your partner bids normally and their number alone becomes the side's trick contract. Nil is scored separately and can succeed or fail independently of whether that contract is made.

A blind nil is committed to sight unseen, so it has to be called out the moment the deal ends, before you fan your cards. Most tables allow it only to a side trailing by 100 points or more. Bidding then proceeds normally around the table, and once the last bid has been made, with nobody yet having led, the blind bidder slides two cards face down to their partner and takes back two that the partner sends over face down in return. That trade exists so the bidder can dump two likely winners and pick up junk, leaving the partner to carry the extra strength.

The first trick is led by whoever sits to the dealer's left, and it may not be opened with a spade. Play continues clockwise. You must follow the suit led if you can; if you are void you may play any card at all, including a spade. Spades are permanent trumps: any spade beats every plain card, and the highest spade in a trick takes it. A trick nobody spaded goes to the highest card of the led suit. A card of some third suit never wins. Whoever takes a trick opens the following one.

Nobody may open a trick with a spade until the suit is broken, which happens once some spade has fallen on a trick led in another suit, whether that was a deliberate ruff or a helpless discard. The one exception is a player holding nothing but spades, who may lead one. Nothing stops you trumping in the first time you are void; that is normally how spades get broken.

Failing to follow suit when you held the suit led is a renege. If it comes to light before the last trick of the hand has been gathered, the usual remedy is that the offending side is set for the hand: it takes the full negative score for its bid no matter how many tricks it actually won, any nil it declared is treated as broken, and the other side scores as normal. Some groups prefer a milder penalty of three tricks handed over to the opponents with the hand otherwise standing. Either way the correction only applies while the hand is live; once the deal has been scored and the cards are shuffled, the score stands.

Everyone keeps their side's tricks together where both partnerships can count them. When the thirteenth trick is finished, count the tricks each side took and score the hand, then pass the deal to the left.

## **Goal & scoring**

The first partnership to 500 points wins.

Make the contract and it pays 10 a trick — counted on what you bid, not on what you took — with anything over that worth 1 apiece. Those extras are bags, also called sandbags, and the single point each one pays now is really a loan against a penalty later. Bid 7 and take 9 and you score 72: seventy

for the contract and two for the bags.

A side that falls short is set and loses 10 points per trick bid, with no credit at all for the tricks it did win. Bid 7 and take 6 and you lose 70.

Bags accumulate for the whole game in their own tally. The moment a side reaches 10 bags, 100 points are deducted from that side's score and 10 comes off the bag count, leaving any surplus in place to start the next batch. Games are routinely decided by a sandbag penalty rather than by anything that happened in a trick, which is why deliberately underbidding a strong hand is a losing habit.

Bring a nil home and the partnership banks 100, with the partner's contract settled separately on its own merits. Win a single trick and that same 100 goes the other way as a loss. Where the nil was blind, both figures double to 200. What becomes of the tricks a broken nil bidder collected is the detail worth pinning down beforehand: at most tables they are dead weight, useless toward the partner's contract yet still totted up in the side's bag tally, while other groups treat them as ordinary tricks and credit them to the contract.

Play continues until a side is at 500 or more at the end of a hand. If both sides cross in the same hand, the higher total wins, and a genuine tie is broken by playing one more hand. Many groups also set a floor of minus 200, at which point that side loses outright.

| Scores                        | Value             | Notes                                                             |
|-------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Contract made                 | 10 per trick bid  | —                                                                 |
| Each trick over the bid (bag) | 1                 | —                                                                 |
| Contract set                  | -10 per trick bid | No credit for the tricks the side did win.                        |
| Reaching 10 bags              | -100              | 10 comes off the bag tally; any surplus stays for the next batch. |
| Nil made                      | 100               | —                                                                 |
| Nil broken                    | -100              | —                                                                 |
| Blind nil made                | 200               | —                                                                 |
| Blind nil broken              | -200              | —                                                                 |
| Game                          | 500               | —                                                                 |
| Optional loss floor           | -200              | House rule: a side reaching it loses outright.                    |

## Variants

**Cutthroat (Solo) Spades** — Partnerships are abolished and every player bids and scores for themselves, which turns the game into a running series of temporary alliances against whoever is ahead. Nil is usually reduced to 50 or 100 by agreement and the target is shortened, often to 200 or 300. Three-

handed cutthroat is common too: remove the 2 of clubs so that 51 cards deal out to 17 each.

**Suicide Spades** — A partnership variant in which exactly one member of each side must bid nil on every single hand, with the partner carrying the whole trick contract alone and usually held to a minimum of 4. Partners decide between themselves who takes the nil, normally by an agreed signal or simply by whoever bids first. Scores swing enormously and the game becomes almost entirely about protecting a partner's nil.

**Whiz and Mirror** — Two restricted-bidding forms. In Whiz, each player must bid either nil or the exact number of spades in their hand, and no other bid is legal. Mirror is the stricter cousin: you must bid your spade count, and nil is only available to a player who was dealt no spades at all. Both remove almost all bidding judgement and shift the entire game onto the play of the cards.

**Jokers and high deuces** — Both jokers join the pack as the two highest trumps, the big joker above the little joker, and two low cards are taken out so the deal still comes to 13 each. In the widespread joker-joker-deuce-deuce form the 2 of hearts and the 2 of clubs are the cards removed, and the two surviving deuces are promoted into the trump suit, the commonest order being big joker, little joker, 2 of spades, 2 of diamonds, then the ace of spades on down to the 3. A good number of tables rank the 2 of diamonds above the 2 of spades instead, so settle the order out loud before the first deal rather than mid-trick.

**Two-handed Spades** — Instead of a deal, the pack sits face down and the players alternate building their hands from it. Cut for the first draw, high card going first. On your turn you look at the top card and either keep it, in which case the next card goes face down to a dead pile unseen, or reject it face down, in which case you must take the card underneath. Continue until each player holds 13 cards; the remaining 26 are out of play. Mirroring the four-handed game, the player who drew first also bids first and leads to the opening trick, and may not lead a spade. The ban on leading spades before they are broken and the scoring are unchanged, and the game still runs to 500.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Trickster Cards, VIP Spades, Spades.co, DKM Games, MPL Games.

# Sueca

|                   |                                                                                  |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Players</b>    | 4 players                                                                        |
| <b>Deck</b>       | 1 standard deck stripped to 40 cards (A, 7, K, J, Q, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2 in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>       | 20-45 minutes                                                                    |
| <b>Difficulty</b> | Easy                                                                             |
| <b>Category</b>   | Trick-taking                                                                     |

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## Setup

Sueca is the national card game of Portugal and is played in Brazil, Angola and wherever else Portuguese is spoken. It is for four and only four, in two fixed partnerships, partners sitting opposite one another.

Take an ordinary pack, drop the jokers and pull out every eight, nine and ten. Forty cards remain. Deal and play go counter-clockwise in Portugal, so cards move to the dealer's right and the deal passes right after each hand; in Brazil the whole rotation is reversed and everything runs to the left instead.

Choose the first dealer by cutting, low card taking it. Preparing the pack is split between the dealer's two neighbours — the right hand shuffles it, the left hand cuts it — and then the whole forty goes out, ten cards apiece. The mechanics of that are described differently wherever you look — singly or in one block of ten, starting from the dealer's right or the dealer's left — and the sources do not even agree on which form is Portuguese and which Brazilian, so take your table's and do not worry about it. Dealing in blocks is quick and, since every card is dealt anyway, gives nothing away. What no version varies is where trumps come from: nobody chooses them, they fall out of the deal. One of the dealer's own ten is exposed to the table before the dealer takes it up, and the suit on its face governs the entire deal. The dealer then picks it up and holds it like any other card. Some tables would rather it stayed face up in front of the dealer until the moment it is actually played. Either way the suit is public and the card is the dealer's to play, but say which before the first deal so that nobody thinks a card is being concealed. Nothing is left over, there is no stock and no bidding, so within a few seconds of the shuffle everybody is looking at a complete hand and a known trump suit.

Two things then need to be in your head. The first is the ranking, which is not the order printed on the cards and cannot be worked out from them: it is arranged so that the two cards carrying the heaviest point values are also the two that win tricks, which means the cards you most want are the cards hardest to take. The second is that the pack is worth 120 in all and each suit carries thirty of it, so the counters are spread evenly and there is no

cheap suit to attack.

Unusually for a partnership game of this family, there is no signalling tradition here. Portuguese practice bans it outright: no table talk, no faces, nothing but the cards.

## Play

Sueca runs anticlockwise, so the dealer's right-hand neighbour opens the first trick; thereafter the previous trick's winner opens the next.

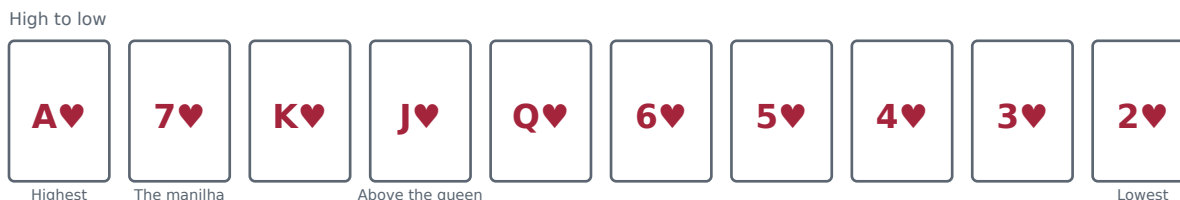
Follow suit if you can. That single restriction is the whole of the law: a player holding the suit that was led must play one, and only a player void in it is free to do anything else. There is no obligation to trump when you are void, and no obligation to beat what is already on the table. Throwing a worthless card away is always allowed once you cannot follow.

Trumps outrank the whole pack, so one card of the trump suit is enough to take a trick away from an ace. Where nobody ruffs, the best card of the suit that opened wins it. The winning side gathers it face down; some tables let one player of each partnership keep all their tricks and count at the end, others stack them in the middle of the table in front of the pair.

Ten tricks exhaust the hands and the deal is over.

Because every card is dealt and the trump card was shown, nothing is hidden except the distribution across the three hands you cannot see. Good players work it out from the discards, and this is where the ban on signals bites: the only way to tell your partner that you are out of hearts and full of trumps is to demonstrate it, which necessarily tells the opponents too. Leading a suit your partner can ruff, or leading trumps early to strip them from the opposition before the aces and sevens come out, are the two standard plans.

Revoking — failing to follow suit when you held the suit — is treated seriously, and the deal stops the moment it is spotted. What it costs is a table rule. The usual penalty is two games to the innocent side, and some tables make it the whole four-game rubber, there and then. Agree which applies before anybody deals, because under the harsher one a single careless card can end the entire session.



Rank order in every suit, high to low, in trumps and plain suits alike. Two ranks are lifted out of their printed places: the seven sits second and the jack outranks the queen.

## Goal & scoring

Card points are what the tricks are for. When the last trick is played each partnership counts the value of everything it captured, and the two figures must total 120; if they do not, the count has gone wrong somewhere and has to be redone.

The deal is then converted into games, which is the currency the match is actually played in:

- 61 to 90 card points: 1 game.
- 91 to 120 card points without taking every trick: 2 games. Including 120 itself, which is not a misprint. Twenty of the forty cards carry no value whatever, so a trick built entirely out of them can be conceded without denting the total; a side in that position holds the maximum score and has still not taken all ten tricks, and its deal is worth two games rather than four.
- All ten tricks — a bandeira, literally a flag: 4 games, which wins the match outright whatever the score stood at before.
- Exactly 60 apiece: no game to either side. Many tables then carry the deal forward instead of forgetting it, making the next one worth an extra game — so 61 to 90 on it pays two rather than one — and stacking that again if the next deal ties as well. The rule is as widely stated as it is overlooked, so say which you are doing.

Four games make a rubber and win the match. Since a strong deal pays double, a side can come from nothing to victory in two hands, and since the flag pays the whole rubber at once, a partnership holding a run of trumps has something worth going for beyond mere safety.

Sources disagree on one edge case: whether the four-game flag is earned by winning all ten tricks or by capturing all 120 card points, which are not quite the same thing, since a trick containing no counters can be lost without costing a point. Taking all ten tricks is the more widely stated requirement, and it is the cleaner rule to adopt.



Beyond 61 the incentive changes shape. A side already sure of the deal should be pushing for 91 rather than coasting, because the second game is worth exactly as much as the first and is often only one ace away.

| Scores               | Value | Notes                          |
|----------------------|-------|--------------------------------|
| Each ace             | 11    | —                              |
| Each seven (manilha) | 10    | —                              |
| Each king            | 4     | —                              |
| Each jack            | 3     | —                              |
| Each queen           | 2     | —                              |
| Six down to two      | 0     | —                              |
| Each suit            | 30    | 120 in the pack, evenly spread |

## Variants

**Brazilian rotation** — The Brazilian form reverses the table: the deal, the passing of the deal and the order of play all run clockwise rather than counter-clockwise, so the first cards and the opening lead go to the dealer's left. Nothing else changes, but a Portuguese player dropped into a Brazilian game will lead out of turn at least once.

**Sueca Italiana** — An Italian reworking that bolts an auction onto the front. Players bid, and the winner names both the trump suit and a card they do not hold; whoever has that card becomes their partner without announcing it, so the partnerships are not the seating and stay concealed until the called card appears. The shape is closer to the five-handed Italian calling games than to Sueca proper.

**Bisca** — The wider Portuguese family Sueca belongs to, and the way to play when there are not exactly four of you. Bisca games keep a stock: fewer cards are dealt, a trump is turned, and players draw back up to a full hand after every trick until the pack is exhausted. Versions exist for two, three, four and six players, and someone who knows Sueca can pick any of them up in a minute.

**Fixed match length** — Rather than racing to four games, some groups agree a number of deals in advance — often eight or twelve, so that every player deals the same number of times — and total the games at the end. It removes the sudden death of the flag and stops a match ending three minutes after it started, at the cost of the tension that makes the rubber worth playing.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Ludoteka, Gambiter, GameRules.com, GameVelvet.

# Tarneeb

|                      |                            |
|----------------------|----------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Tarnib, Tarnibe, Hakam     |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4 players                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking               |

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## Setup

An ordinary 52-card pack, shuffled and cut, ranking the way you expect from the ace down to the two. Every card goes out, singly, thirteen to a player. Nothing is left over and nothing is turned up — this game has no trump suit whatever until somebody has won the right to name one, which is the entire point of it.

Before anything else, the direction. This table turns right. Bidding goes anti-clockwise, play goes anti-clockwise, the deal moves anti-clockwise after each hand, and the player sitting on the dealer's right both speaks first and leads first. Say it out loud before the opening hand; almost everything else in this collection runs the other way, and half an hour in it is an argument rather than a correction.

Two partnerships of two, fixed for the session, with your partner opposite you. Pick the first dealer at random.

One sheet of paper, two columns, and room to go below zero in both of them — you will need it.

The name is the trump suit. Tarneeb is what Arabic speakers call the trump in this game, so a game named after its own trump is a fair description of where the interest lies. It is played across the Levant, most likely originating in Lebanon, and through much of the Middle East besides; the Arabian Peninsula generally calls it hakam. Anyone who has played whist will be at home inside a single hand, and everything that makes this different is in the auction and in what the scoring does with it afterwards.

## Play

Bidding opens with the player to the dealer's right and travels anti-clockwise. A bid is simply a number: how many of the thirteen tricks your side promises to take. Seven is the lowest anyone may say and thirteen the highest, and each bid has to beat the one before it. Pass and you are finished for this auction; you cannot come back in later even if the bidding goes round again.

With all four passing on the first circuit, the hand is dead. The same dealer gathers the cards, shuffles and deals again.

Otherwise the auction runs round as many times as it needs to until three players have dropped out. The survivor now names the tarneeb, or else chooses to do without any trump suit at all, and leads to the first trick.

What that survivor has actually bought is worth being clear about, because it is not what the number suggests. The bid buys the right to choose trump and to lead, and it sets the price of failure. It does not set the reward: a side that makes its bid scores the tricks it actually took, so bidding seven and taking ten is worth ten. The number is a bar to clear rather than a target to hit.

The play is plain trick-taking with nothing unusual in it. Follow the suit that was led if you hold it. Holding none of it, do whatever you like — put a trump on, which is the whole point of having one, or throw a card from some other suit away. Nobody is ever obliged to trump. A trick goes to the biggest trump played to it, or, where nobody trumped at all, to the best card of whichever suit opened it. Whoever takes a trick leads to the next one, and thirteen tricks empty the hands.

A little conventional technique goes a long way here, and two pieces of it have names. Tashleeh is the declarer's business of drawing trumps out of the defenders' hands early, so that the long suit you chose the contract on can actually run. Ta'leem is the partner's job: having run out of trumps, lead a low card of some suit to tell your partner that is where you want the next lead to come back to. Signalling by how you put the card down — slapping it, flicking it — is common in casual play and disapproved of nearly everywhere that takes the game seriously.

## Goal & scoring

A game runs across as many hands as it takes for one side to reach the agreed target. Thirty-one and forty-one are both standard and the sources genuinely split on which is the default, so name the figure before the first deal; fifty-one and sixty-one are played too, and simply make for a longer evening.

Each hand settles like this. The bidding side counts the tricks it took. Reach the bid and that count is the score — not the bid, the tricks. Fall short and the bid is subtracted from your total instead, and the defenders pick up one point for each trick of their own.

That asymmetry is the whole strategic engine, and it is worth sitting with for a moment. When a contract stands up, the defenders score nothing

whatever, however many tricks they scraped together. So bidding is not only a way of scoring; it is the only way to stop the other side scoring at all. A side that keeps passing on marginal hands does not stay safe, it simply stops being paid. Meanwhile there is no bonus for accuracy and no penalty for undershooting, so the sensible bid is the lowest number that wins you the auction rather than an honest estimate of your hand.

Taking all thirteen tricks is kaboot. Off a bid of less than thirteen it is worth 16 — the thirteen tricks plus three for the sweep. Bid thirteen outright and bring it home and it pays 26. Bid thirteen and drop even one trick and it costs 16, with the defenders scoring double for every trick they took, which makes it the most expensive thing anyone can attempt at this table.

Scores go negative and stay on the sheet. A side that has been set twice can find itself needing most of the game back before the target is even in view.

| Scores                                      | Value                 | Notes                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bid of 7 to 12, made                        | the tricks you took   | not the number you bid, so overshooting is free            |
| Bid of 7 to 12, missed                      | minus the bid         | —                                                          |
| Defenders, against a contract that stood up | 0                     | however many tricks they took                              |
| Defenders, against a contract that failed   | 1 per trick they took | —                                                          |
| Kaboot, all 13 on a bid under 13            | 16                    | the thirteen tricks and three more for the sweep           |
| Bid of 13, made                             | 26                    | —                                                          |
| Bid of 13, missed                           | minus 16              | and the defenders score double for each of their tricks    |
| Target to win the game                      | 31 or 41              | settle it before the first deal; 51 and 61 are also played |

## Variants

**Egyptian Tarneeb** — Popular in Egypt, and a substantially bigger game. A bid names the trump suit as well as the number, with the suits ranked clubs lowest, then diamonds, hearts, spades, and no trumps above them all — so seven clubs is the cheapest call available and thirteen no trumps the dearest, and you overcall either by taking more tricks or by taking the same number in a better suit. Two things make the auction unlike bridge's. Passing does not put you out: you may come back in later, and even raise your own bid if the other three pass, which then reopens the auction for everybody. And a double is not a bid, so it does not restart anything. Bidding ends only when a full circuit passes with nobody calling. A doubled contract doubles what the bidding side wins or loses, with a redouble taking it to four times in some circles, and the target is normally 41.

**One bid each** — Played in parts of Lebanon and much the fastest version of the auction. Every player speaks exactly once and then it is over — no raising, no second thoughts, no reading the table across three circuits. Because the dealer speaks last, the dealer alone may take the contract by matching the highest bid rather than beating it, which is a real advantage and the compensation for having dealt.

**Throwing in a hopeless hand** — A test for a hand with literally nothing in it, and a mercy where the alternative is thirteen tricks of watching. You may throw the cards in if you hold no ace, no king in a suit of two or more, no queen in a suit of three or more, and no jack in a suit of four or more — that is, no card anywhere that could take a trick against an opponent cashing that suit from the top down. Where it applies, the deal passes on and the next dealer shuffles.

**Ten in one suit** — Some tables require a player dealt ten or more cards of a single suit to declare themselves one way or another rather than quietly bidding seven with it. The choice is to pass outright, to bid kaboot and undertake all thirteen tricks with your partner's help, or to throw the hand in for a redeal by the same dealer. The rule exists because a ten-card suit makes the auction meaningless — nobody else can compete — and the game is more interesting if such a hand has to be either declared or discarded.

**Trump on the first trick** — The declarer is obliged to lead a trump to the opening trick rather than choosing freely. It takes away the option of setting up a side suit before drawing trumps, and it hands the defenders one clear piece of information immediately. Common enough in some regions to be assumed rather than announced, so it is worth asking about.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, GameRules.com.

# Twenty-Nine

|                      |                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | 29, Twenty Nine                                                                                                      |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4 players                                                                                                            |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 32 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7 in each suit); the low cards are kept aside as markers |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                                                        |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                                                               |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                                                                                         |

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## Setup

Northern India, Bangladesh and Nepal all play this, and it belongs to a South Asian family whose defining oddity is that jacks and nines outrank aces. The oddity is not local: promoting those two cards is the signature of the Dutch Jass games, and the likeliest story is that Dutch traders brought the idea to the subcontinent, where it took root and stayed.

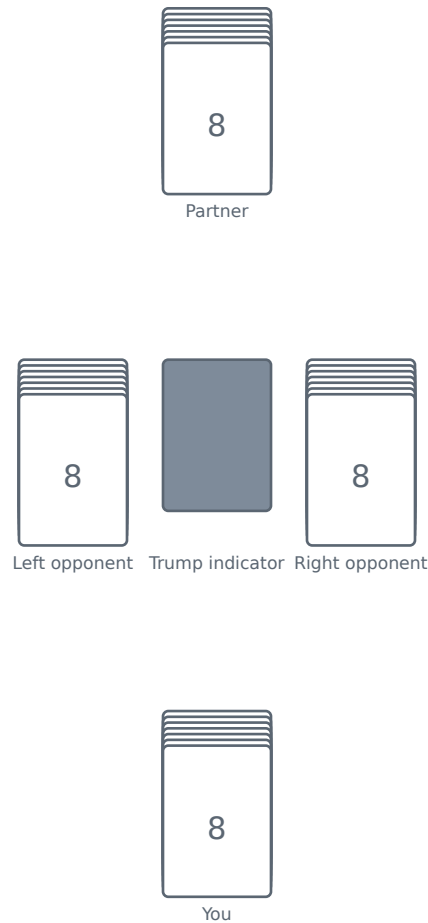
Four players in fixed partnerships, sitting opposite your partner. Play goes clockwise.

Take a pack and keep the ace, king, queen, jack, ten, nine, eight and seven of each suit — thirty-two cards. Do not put the rest away. The twos, threes, fours and fives are the trump indicators, one set of four to each player, and the two sixes are the scoreboard.

The ranking is the first thing to learn and the last thing anyone remembers, because it is not the ranking of any European game you know. In every suit, trump or not, the order runs jack, nine, ace, ten, king, queen, eight, seven. The jack is the boss and the nine is next, and the ace is a distant third.

Card points follow the same idea: a jack is worth 3, a nine 2, an ace 1 and a ten 1, and the king, queen, eight and seven are worth nothing at all. That comes to 28 points in the pack.

So where does 29 come from? Two answers, both current. Some tables award an extra point for taking the last trick, making 29 in all, and that is where the name began — but most players have dropped it and kept the name. The other explanation is arithmetic: with 28 on the table and a bid of, say, 16, the defenders need 13 to beat it, and 16 and 13 make 29. Take your pick.



Eight cards each once the deal is finished. The face-down card in the middle names the trump suit, and only the player who won the auction knows what it is.

## Play

The deal comes in two halves with the auction wedged between them, which is the structural idea the whole game hangs on: you bid on four cards and receive four more afterwards.

Each player gets four cards, dealt singly. Then bidding opens to the dealer's left and runs clockwise for as many rounds as it takes, each player either raising or passing out for good. A bid is a number of card points your side undertakes to win. Fifteen is the floor and 28 the ceiling. Three passes in a row settle it, and if the first three all pass, the dealer has to take it at 15 rather than throw the hand in.

The winner now chooses trumps in secret. Take your four indicator cards, square them into a face-down pile, and put a card of the chosen suit at the bottom of it. Nobody else sees it. The dealer then gives everyone four more cards, bringing each hand to eight.

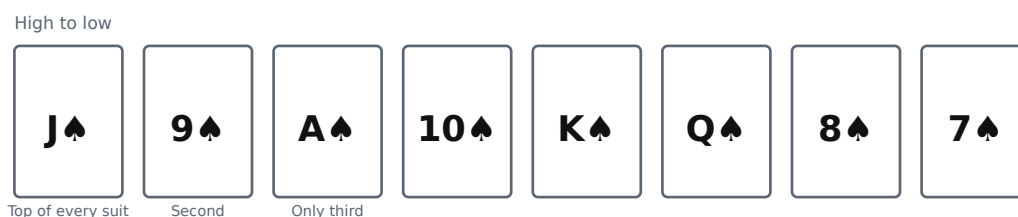
The player to the dealer's left leads. Follow suit while you can. Until trumps are out in the open they do nothing at all: a trick played before the reveal

goes to whoever put down the best card in whichever suit opened it, and a card belonging to the still-hidden trump suit is, for that trick, just a card.

The reveal is triggered by shortage, not by choice. The first player who cannot follow suit asks the bidder to declare, and the bidder turns the indicator over for everybody to see. If it is the bidder who runs out first, they must announce it themselves. From that trick onwards the game behaves normally — a trump beats any plain card, the biggest trump beats the other trumps, and where nobody trumps at all the trick goes to whoever played highest in the suit that opened it.

Two things about the reveal catch people out. It costs nothing to be the one who asks — you may still play any card you like to the trick, and there is no obligation to trump even though you are the reason everyone now knows what trumps are. And it is possible for the reveal never to happen at all, if every player holds two cards of every suit. In that case the deal is dead: neither side scores and the cards are gathered up.

Royals. A player still holding both the king and the queen of trumps may declare them — the pair is called Royals — but only once trumps have been shown, and only immediately after their own side has won a trick. Both cards must still be in hand; declaring is impossible if either has already been played. What Royals does is move the target rather than score anything: declared by the bidding side it takes 4 points off what they need, and declared by a defender it adds 4 to what the bidders need. Neither adjustment can push the requirement below the minimum bid or above 28.



Every suit ranks this way, trump or not, and it is the one thing to fix in mind before the first hand: the jack and the nine both climb over the ace.

## Goal & scoring

Once the eighth trick is over, each side adds up the card points it has taken. The bidding side has one question to answer — did they reach the number they promised, adjusted for any Royals — and the answer is worth exactly one game point either way. Making it earns one; missing it costs one. The defenders' score does not move at all: they are playing to stop a contract, not to build a total of their own.

That single game point is what makes the bidding sharp. A side is never



rewarded for overshooting, so bidding 16 and taking 24 is no better than bidding 16 and taking 16 — while bidding 24 and taking 23 is a disaster. The auction is a judgement about four cards you have seen and four you have not.

The scoreboard is a pleasing piece of physical design, and worth doing properly. Each partnership takes one red six and one black six from the discarded cards and overlaps them so that a number of pips shows: red pips for a positive score, black pips for a negative one. Nothing showing means zero. Win a hand and you uncover another red pip, or cover a black one if you are below the line; lose and do the reverse. The first side to show six red pips has won the match. A side that reaches six black pips has lost it, which is the same event from the other direction and happens often enough to be worth watching for.

There is no running total of card points across hands. Every deal is settled and forgotten, and only the sixes remember.

| Scores                          | Value                      | Notes                                                   |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Each jack                       | 3                          | and the top card of its suit                            |
| Each nine                       | 2                          | second in its suit, above the ace                       |
| Each ace                        | 1                          | —                                                       |
| Each ten                        | 1                          | —                                                       |
| Kings, queens, eights, sevens   | 0                          | 28 card points in the pack altogether                   |
| The last trick                  | 1 extra                    | the original 29th point; most tables no longer count it |
| Lowest bid allowed              | 15                         | some tables start at 16                                 |
| Highest bid allowed             | 28                         | —                                                       |
| Royals, declared by the bidders | 4 off their target         | —                                                       |
| Royals, declared by a defender  | 4 onto the bidders' target | —                                                       |
| Contract made                   | 1 game point               | —                                                       |
| Contract failed                 | minus 1 game point         | —                                                       |
| Winning the match               | 6 game points              | six black pips instead means the match is lost          |

## Variants

**Double, redouble and set** — A doubling ladder, and the commonest addition to the game. Once trumps have been chosen but before the second four cards are dealt, either defender may call double if they fancy the contract will fail, which makes the hand worth two game points instead of one, won or lost. The bidding side may answer redouble for four. Where the ladder goes further, a defender may then call set, taking it to six — enough to decide the whole match in one deal from a standing start. Tables that give the trump maker the entire pile of spare low cards use it as a counter, flipping one card face up for a

double and two for a redouble; which cards they are means nothing.

**No trumps and reverse** — Two escapes for a bidder holding a flat hand, indicated by which spare card goes under the pile. A joker at the bottom means no trump suit at all, and Royals cannot be declared because there is no trump king or queen to hold. In West Bengal a two is used to mean reverse: still no trumps, but the ranking of every suit turns upside down from the moment it is revealed, so the seven becomes the best card in its suit and the jack the worst. Point values are untouched, which is the joke — the jack is still worth 3 and now cannot win a trick with it. Some Delhi tables combine the two, using twos for reverse with the two's own suit as trump and jokers or threes for the no-trump forms.

**Seventh card** — For a bidder who wants the contract but has one card of each suit and no basis for choosing. Instead of naming a suit, call for the seventh card: when the deal resumes, your penultimate card goes under the indicator pile and its suit is trumps. You may look at it; nobody else may. It is not part of your hand for following suit until trumps are declared, so you cannot lead it — except to the very last trick, when there is nothing else left — and if its suit is led you must follow from your hand if you can. Unable to follow from hand, you may either discard or turn the seventh card over, declaring trumps and playing it.

**Single hand** — After all eight cards are dealt but before the opening lead, a player holding something extraordinary may declare single hand: an undertaking to take all eight tricks alone, with no trump suit, their partner's cards laid face down and out of the game. The lone player leads. Bring it home for three game points, fail for minus three, and in parts of West Bengal both figures are doubled to six. Some tables add a sporting condition — you may not declare it on a hand that literally cannot lose, so at least one card must be beatable in principle.

**Under half** — Played across Bengal, Bihar and Jharkhand. A bidding side that finishes with less than half the points it called loses two game points rather than one. It punishes the specific failure of bidding on four good cards and being handed four useless ones, which is otherwise the cheapest kind of disaster in this game, and it makes an ambitious auction meaningfully riskier than a cautious one.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, GameRules.com.

# Whist

|                      |                                                  |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Straight Whist, Partnership Whist, English Whist |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4 players                                        |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed       |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                    |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                           |
| <b>Category</b>      | Trick-taking                                     |

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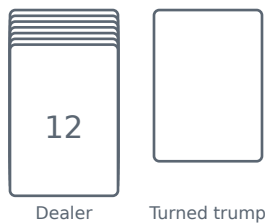
## Setup

Whist seats exactly four, playing as two fixed partnerships, with partners opposite each other. Use a 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. In play the cards rank ace high down to 2 low.

Draw for partners and for the first deal at the same time. Spread the pack face down and have everyone take a card, counting the ace as low for this purpose only. The two lowest cards play against the two highest, and the lowest card of all deals first. Anyone who draws a duplicate rank or the bottom card of the pack draws again. After the first hand the deal moves one seat to the left.

Shuffle, offer the cut to the right, then deal the whole pack out singly and clockwise, first card going to the dealer's left. Everyone ends up with 13. The last card dealt belongs to the dealer, but rather than being tucked into their hand it is laid face up on the table. Its suit is trumps for that hand. It stays face up where everyone can see it until the dealer plays to the first trick, at which point the dealer takes it into hand and it becomes an ordinary card. From that moment on, remembering what it was is your own problem.

There is no bidding, no exchange of cards and no stock. As soon as the trump is turned, play begins.



The whole pack is dealt. The dealer's thirteenth card is turned face up to fix trumps and is taken into hand at the first trick.

## Play

Whoever sits to the dealer's left opens the first trick, and may lead absolutely any card. Play then goes clockwise, one card from each player.

You must follow the suit that was led if you hold a card in it. Only when you are void may you play something else, and then you may play anything: a card of a third suit, which cannot win, or a trump, which can. Trumps outrank everything else, so if any were played the highest of them takes the trick; if none were, the highest card of the led suit does. Each trick is opened by whoever won the last. All thirteen tricks are played out; there is no way to end a hand early, no concession and no discard pile.

How the tricks are stored matters more than beginners expect. One player from each partnership gathers every trick that side wins and stacks them face down in front of them, squared up and countable, rather than scattering them. Once a trick has been turned over and covered by the next one it is closed, and you are not allowed to look back through earlier tricks. Remembering what has gone is the whole skill of the game. Tables vary on

whether the trick just completed may be re-examined before the next card is led; the strict rule is that only the trick currently in progress is public.

There is nothing to say during a hand. Whist is deliberately silent: no signalling, no remarks about your holding, no reaction to a partner's card. The turned trump and the fall of the cards are the only information anyone is entitled to, and drawing inferences from them is what you are there to do.

Playing off-suit when you could have followed suit is a revoke. It becomes established once the offending side has led or played to the following trick, and it has to be claimed before the cards are gathered and cut for the next deal. The non-offending side then picks one of three remedies: take three of the offenders' tricks and add them to their own pile, add 3 points to their own score, or take 3 points off the offenders'. Whichever is chosen, the revoking side cannot win the game on that deal, so a revoke made while sitting on 4 points in a 5-point game is expensive twice over. A revoke spotted and corrected before the trick is turned is usually just fixed on the spot, with the withdrawn card left face up as information for the opponents.

When the thirteenth trick is done, each side counts the tricks it won and the deal is scored. The deal then passes one seat to the left and the next hand is dealt.

## **Goal & scoring**

Six tricks is the book and is worth nothing at all. Only tricks beyond six count, at 1 point each, which means a single hand is worth at most 7 points and only one side can ever take trick points from a given deal.

A game is 5 points in the standard British short whist. American play traditionally used 7 and dropped honours altogether, while the older long whist ran to 10, which is where the game's reputation for endless sessions comes from. Whichever target you use, a rubber runs until one side has won two games, and taking it adds 2 bonus points. If one side wins the first two games the third is not played. The rubber is settled by the difference between the two sides' point totals once the bonus is added.

Honours are the ace, king, queen and jack of the trump suit, and what counts is where they were dealt, not who captured them during play. Add up what the two partners held once the hand is over: holding three of them pays the pair 2 extra points, and holding the lot pays 4. Two limits apply. Trick points are always counted before honours, so a side that reaches the target on tricks wins immediately. And a side already standing at 4 points towards a 5-point game may not score honours at all, on the principle that you should not be carried over the line by cards you merely held. Because tricks are settled before honours and only one side can score tricks in a

deal, a game can never finish level: whichever side reaches the target on tricks has already won before any honours are added.

Many modern groups drop honours entirely and score tricks only, which makes the game a cleaner test of play. Decide which you are using before the first deal.

## Variants

**Bid Whist** — The American partnership game built on whist, played hard and fast. Both jokers join the pack as a big and a little joker, each player is dealt 12 cards and six go face down as the kitty. Bidding runs from 3 to 7, meaning tricks above the book of six, and the winning bidder names trump or no-trump plus a direction: uptown, with the ranks in their usual order, or downtown, with them inverted so that after the ace the 2 is the strongest card and the king the weakest. The high bidder takes the kitty into hand and buries six cards face down; in the usual house rule those buried cards are credited to the bidding side as one trick. Scoring is one-sided: the bidding side takes 1 point for each trick it wins above the book when it makes its contract and loses the full value of its bid when it is set, while the defenders normally score nothing and are playing purely to set the bid. Game is 7 points, and a side driven to minus 7 loses outright.

**Knock-Out Whist** — A short elimination game for three to seven players and a staple of British family card play. The first hand is seven cards each, with the top card of the undealt remainder turned to set trump. Tricks are played as in ordinary whist, but nothing is scored: any player who wins no tricks at all is knocked out. The player who took the most tricks deals the next hand, names trump outright after looking at their cards instead of turning one, and leads to the first trick, with ties for most tricks settled by a cut of the pack. Hands shrink by one card every round, seven down to one, and the last player standing wins. A common kindness is the dog's life, which lets the very first player eliminated stay in with a single card each round, played to whichever trick they choose.

**German Whist** — The two-player version, and the best-known one. Deal 13 cards each and put the remaining 26 face down as a stock with the top card turned up; its suit is trump for the entire hand. The first thirteen tricks are played for the stock rather than for score: the winner of each trick takes the exposed card, the loser takes the next card unseen, and a fresh card is turned. When the stock is exhausted both players hold 13 known-quality cards and play them out, and only these last thirteen tricks count, at 1 point for each trick above six. The first half is a card-drafting duel, the second half is pure technique.

**Solo Whist** — Four players, but each hand becomes an auction of individual contracts rather than a partnership affair. Cards are dealt in batches of three,

then a final four, with the last card turned for trump. The bids in ascending order are: a proposal to take eight tricks with whoever accepts it, solo for five tricks alone in the turned trump, misere for losing every trick with no trump, abundance for nine tricks alone with a trump suit of your own choosing, royal abundance for the same nine tricks but in the suit that was turned up, open misere with your hand face up on the table, and a declared abundance for all thirteen. The player to the dealer's left leads to the first trick in every contract except a declared abundance, where the declarer leads. Results are settled in chips or units paid between the players hand by hand instead of accumulating on a score sheet.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Trickster Cards, Gamerules.com, Card Game Rules.

## RUMMY FAMILY

# 500 Rummy

|                      |                                                                                                    |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Rummy 500, 500 Rum, Pinochle Rummy                                                                 |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                                                          |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards) for 2 to 4 players; 2 decks shuffled together (104 cards) for 5 or more |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                                      |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                                             |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                                                                                       |

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## Setup

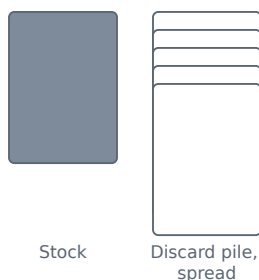
Two to eight can play. Up to four players use a single 52-card pack; from five players up, shuffle two packs together and treat identical cards as interchangeable. Draw for the first deal, high card deals, and pass the deal to the left after each hand.

Deal 7 cards to each player, one at a time, clockwise from the dealer's left. In the two-player game deal 13 each instead. Place the remainder face down as the stock and turn its top card face up to begin the discard pile.

The discard pile is the heart of this game, so lay it out properly. Stagger each new discard against the one beneath it, building a long overlapping ladder in which no card ever hides another. Anyone at the table should be able to read the pile from top to bottom at any point in the hand, which means it must never be squared up or gathered into a neat stack.

Aces work high or low but never both in the same run: A-2-3 and Q-K-A are legal, K-A-2 is not. Point values are what you will be adding up all game. An ace is worth 15, except when it is melded low in a sequence with the 2, where it counts 1. Kings, queens and jacks are 10 each. Every other card is worth its number. The player to the dealer's left starts.





The discard pile is staggered into an overlapping ladder, never squared up, because any card in it can be taken along with everything above it.

| Players | Each player gets |
|---------|------------------|
| 2       | 13 cards         |
| 3       | 7 cards          |
| 4       | 7 cards          |
| 5       | 7 cards          |
| 6       | 7 cards          |
| 7       | 7 cards          |
| 8       | 7 cards          |

## Play

Melds come in the usual two shapes: a set of three or four matching ranks, or a run of at least three cards that follow one another within a single suit. Unlike most rummies, melds are laid face up in front of you and stay yours, because at the end of the hand you are paid for the cards sitting on the table in front of you.

A turn is draw, then meld or lay off, then discard.

Drawing is where 500 Rummy differs from everything else in the family. You may take the top card of the stock, or you may reach into the discard pile

and take any card in it, however deep. If you take a buried card, you must also take every card lying above it, and all of those go into your hand. The price of digging is an obligation: the card you reached for has to go straight onto the table this turn, either as part of a fresh meld you lay down or laid off onto a meld already showing. If you cannot place it immediately, you are not allowed to take it. Everything you scooped up on top of it is yours to keep and use later, or to be caught with.

That obligation is what makes the pile dangerous. A convenient discard early on can sit there for ten turns and then be dragged out from under a stack of eight cards by an opponent who wanted the one card underneath, and they get all eight.

The one card you may take freely is the uppermost discard, which comes with no obligation to use it — the basic Rummy rule, unchanged. Some groups apply the melding obligation to the top card as well, so settle it before you deal.

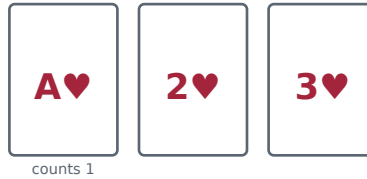
After drawing you may lay down as many melds as you like, and you may lay off cards onto any meld on the table, including melds belonging to your opponents. A card laid off onto somebody else's meld counts for you, not for them, so feeding an opponent's run is a perfectly good way to bank points; keep it in front of you rather than pushing it into their spread, because at scoring time you need to see whose card it is. Nothing has to be melded; a card kept in hand is only a liability at the end of the hand.

Finish by discarding one card face up, adding it to the fan.

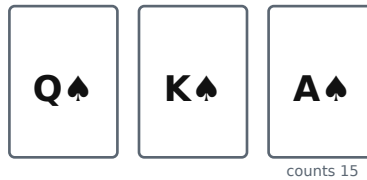
The hand ends the moment one player has no cards left, whether their last card went down in a meld, was laid off, or was discarded. Everyone else is caught with whatever is still in hand.

A hand can also end without anyone going out. Once the stock is empty the discard pile is not turned over to make a new one, so from that point the pile is the only source of cards. A player who takes from it plays an otherwise normal turn, melding or laying off and then discarding, and the hand goes on; the usual conditions still apply, so a buried card must still be used at once. The moment the turn reaches a player who cannot take anything useful, or who simply declines to take, the hand stops there and is scored where it stands.

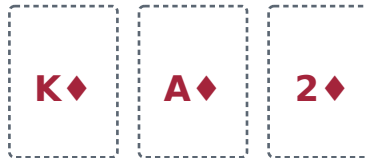
Run, ace low



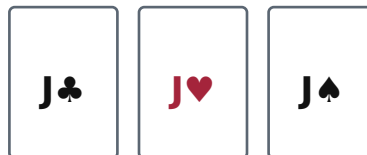
Run, ace high



Not a run



Set



An ace plays high or low, but never both ends of the same run. Melded low against the 2 it counts 1 point; anywhere else it is worth 15.

## Goal & scoring

Score each hand separately, then keep a running total. The first player to reach 500 points wins. If two or more cross 500 in the same hand, the highest total takes it, and if those totals are equal the tied players play further hands until one of them is ahead on their own.

A player's score for the hand is a difference between two figures: what is showing in front of them, less what is trapped in their hand. Everything on the table feeds the first figure, whether it arrived there in a meld of their own or as a card laid off onto somebody else's spread; every card never played feeds the second. Aces are 15, or 1 when melded low against a 2; face cards are 10; everything else is its number.

The result can easily be negative, and negative scores really are subtracted from your running total, so a player caught with two aces and a couple of kings while holding nothing on the table goes backwards. That is the game's main pressure: melding early banks points but tells everyone what you are collecting, while sitting on cards to build a bigger play risks handing back more than you make.

Going out is worth having but carries no bonus in the standard game. Its value is that it ends the hand while everyone else is still holding cards.

## Variants

**Going-out bonus** — Award the player who sheds their last card a flat bonus, most commonly 25 points, on top of their melds. Some tables also pay a bonus for going out in a single turn without having melded anything earlier in the hand. Either rule pushes play toward finishing hands quickly rather than grinding out meld points, which shortens the game considerably.

**Deal and target adjustments** — Plenty of groups deal 7 cards in the two-player game rather than 13, which makes for shorter, tighter hands with a deeper stock. Targets move too: 200 or 300 for a quick session, 1000 for a long one. Some also stop the game after a fixed number of deals and simply take the highest score.

**Wild jokers** — Add one or two jokers as wild cards that can stand for any card in a meld. Fix their value before you start, usually 15 or 20 points, counting for you on the table and against you in hand. A common companion rule lets a player who holds the natural card a joker is standing in for swap it into the meld and take the joker.

**Lay-offs on your own melds only** — A common tightening of the standard game: you may only extend melds you laid down yourself, so an opponent's run is no longer a place to park spare cards. It removes the tactic of scoring off other people's spreads, makes a long run in front of you much safer to own, and pushes players to lay down their own three-card melds earlier so that they have somewhere to build.

**Persian Rummy** — A four-player partnership relative using 52 cards and four jokers, with partners sitting opposite and their scores combined. Aces rank high only, so A-2-3 is not a run. Jokers count 20 apiece and are treated as their own rank rather than as wild cards. The game runs to 500 like the parent game, but partnership play changes the calculation on laying off, since helping your partner's meld helps your own side.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Cool Old Games, Game Rules.

# Canasta

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Classic Canasta                            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 4)                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 2 standard decks plus 4 jokers (108 cards) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 60-120 minutes                             |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                    |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                               |

---

## Setup

Four players, paired off across the table and staying paired all game. Shuffle two full 52-card decks together with four jokers: 108 cards. Cut for seats and first deal if you want a formal start, high card choosing; after that the deal passes clockwise each hand.

Deal 11 cards to each player, one at a time. Set the remaining cards face down in the middle as the stock and turn its top card face up beside it to begin the discard pile. If that upcard is a joker, a two, or a red three, turn another card on top of it and keep going until an ordinary card is showing. When that happens the pile starts the hand frozen; leave the wild card or red three sticking out crossways so everyone can see it stays frozen.

Before the first turn, every player puts any red threes from their dealt hand face up on the table in front of them and draws one replacement card from the stock for each, repeating if a replacement is itself a red three. The player to the dealer's left plays first.

Melds belong to the partnership, not the player, so keep them all in one group in front of one partner where both of you can reach them. Score is kept per partnership across as many deals as the game takes.

## Play

Play goes clockwise, and a turn has three parts: take cards, meld if you want to, then throw one card onto the discard pile to close it. Melding is optional; taking and discarding are not.

Taking cards. Either draw the top card of the stock, or take the whole discard pile when you are entitled to. If you ever draw a red three, lay it down face up at once and draw another card to replace it.

Melds. A meld is a rank collected three deep or more, anything from a four up to an ace, with suits playing no part. Jokers and twos are wild and may be included, but a meld must always hold at least two natural cards and may never hold more than three wild cards. There are no sequences in Canasta. Your side may have only one meld of any given rank, so instead of

starting a second you add to the one already on the table; either partner may add to any of the side's melds at any time. Cards on the table stay there and cannot be taken back into hand.

Threes. Red threes are never melded or held in hand; they sit face up in front of you doing nothing but scoring. Black threes may be melded only on the turn you go out, and only as a natural set of three or four with no wild card among them.

The first meld. Neither partner may put anything down until the side lays out melds whose card points reach a minimum set by their score at the start of the deal: 15 points if the score is below zero, 50 from 0 to 1,495, 90 from 1,500 to 2,995, and 120 at 3,000 or above. The whole requirement must be satisfied in one turn, and only the face value of the cards counts toward it. Red threes, canasta bonuses, and the going-out bonus do not help. If you make the initial meld while taking the discard pile, the top card counts but the buried cards do not.

Taking the discard pile. You must use the top card immediately in a meld, and you always take the entire pile, never part of it. If the pile is not frozen against you there are two ways in: meld the top card with two cards of that rank out of your hand, either two natural cards or one natural card plus a wild card, or add the top card to a meld your side already has on the table. If the pile is frozen against you the second route is closed and a wild card is no help in the first: you need two natural cards of the top card's rank in your hand, and you meld all three together. The pile is frozen for everyone once a wild card or red three lies buried in it, it is frozen against any side that has not yet made its initial meld, and it starts frozen if the first upcard was a wild card or red three. A frozen pile stays frozen until somebody takes it.

Black threes. Discarding a black three stops the next player from taking the pile no matter what they hold, but that block lasts one turn only and does not freeze the pile.

Canastas. Seven cards of one rank, or more, makes a canasta. Square it up and mark it with a red card on top if it is natural (no wilds) or a black card if it is mixed. You may keep adding cards afterwards, but laying a wild card on a natural canasta turns it into a mixed one.

Going out. You go out when you play the last card from your hand, whether as a discard, a new meld, or an addition to an existing one; finishing with a meld and no discard is allowed. Your side must have completed at least one canasta first. Before you touch anything on your turn you are allowed one question across the table — "may I go out?" — and whichever answer

comes back binds you. Once you have melded or reached for the pile, you have given up the right to ask.

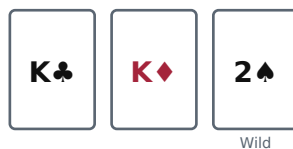
If your side has not melded yet and you draw from the stock into a hand you can lay down complete, canasta included, you may go out concealed on the spot without meeting the minimum count. Take the pile instead of drawing and that concession disappears: you must make the minimum, and the concealed bonus is not yours to claim.

When the stock runs out. If the last stock card is a red three, the player shows it and the hand ends immediately with no discard. Otherwise play carries on with no stock to draw from, so the discard pile is the only source of cards. Taking it is now compulsory rather than optional: if the top card can be added to one of your side's melds and the pile is not frozen against you, you must take the pile, meld, and discard as usual. You may still take it by the ordinary two-cards-from-hand route if that is open to you, but only the add-to-a-meld case is forced. The moment a player has no legal way to take the pile, the hand stops there: nobody goes out, no going-out bonus is scored, and the deal is counted as it stands.

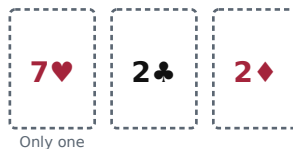
Natural meld



Mixed meld



Too few naturals



Sequences never count



A meld is three or more cards of the same rank, four through ace; suits are irrelevant. It must hold at least two natural cards and never more than three wild cards. There are no sequences in Canasta.

## Goal & scoring

The partnership target is 5,000 points, played out over as many deals as it takes. Each deal is scored for the side as a whole.

Every card carries a point value fixed by its rank, wild cards counting for most and the low cards for least. Add up everything your side has melded and subtract the value of every card still in either partner's hand.

Bonuses: 500 for each natural canasta, 300 for each mixed canasta, and 100 for going out. Going out concealed is worth 200 instead: you lay your whole hand down in one turn, canasta included, having put nothing on the table earlier in the deal, neither a meld of your own nor an addition to your partner's. Your partner may already have melds down; some rule sets are stricter and require the whole side to have stayed off the table.

Red threes count 100 each for the side that laid them down, but only if that side made its initial meld; a side that never melded has the same 100 per red three deducted. Holding all four doubles it to 800 for or 800 against.

A deal can easily come out negative. Add each deal to the running total, since that total sets the next deal's minimum meld. The game ends when a side reaches 5,000 or more once a deal has been fully scored; if both sides cross 5,000 in the same deal, the higher total wins, and if the two totals are level as well, play one more deal to break the tie.

| Scores                       | Value    | Notes                                           |
|------------------------------|----------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Joker                        | 50       | —                                               |
| Two                          | 20       | —                                               |
| Ace                          | 20       | —                                               |
| King down to eight           | 10       | —                                               |
| Seven down to four           | 5        | —                                               |
| Black three                  | 5        | —                                               |
| Natural canasta              | 500      | —                                               |
| Mixed canasta                | 300      | —                                               |
| Going out                    | 100      | —                                               |
| Going out concealed          | 200      | instead of the 100                              |
| Red three                    | 100      | each; deducted instead if the side never melded |
| All four red threes          | 800      | for or against                                  |
| Cards left in hand           | deducted | at face value, both partners                    |
| Initial meld, score below 0  | 15       | —                                               |
| Initial meld, 0 to 1,495     | 50       | —                                               |
| Initial meld, 1,500 to 2,995 | 90       | —                                               |
| Initial meld, 3,000 or above | 120      | —                                               |
| Game                         | 5,000    | —                                               |



## Variants

**Two- and three-player Canasta** — With two players, each is dealt 15 cards, a stock draw takes two cards rather than one (you still discard only one), everyone plays alone, and you need two canastas to go out. With three, deal 13 cards each and again play as individuals with the standard one-canasta requirement. Everything else follows the four-hand game.

**Samba** — Three decks and six jokers, 162 cards, usually four players in two partnerships, dealt 15 each. Alongside ordinary rank melds you may build sequences in a single suit running anywhere from the four up to the ace; a sequence of seven is a samba, counts as a canasta for going out, and scores 1,500. Sequences never accept wild cards, and ordinary melds are held to two wild cards rather than three. Stock draws take two cards, going out needs two canastas, and the game runs to 10,000 with the initial meld minimum climbing to 150 once a side passes 7,000.

**Hand and Foot** — The most popular North American descendant, usually four to six decks with jokers. Each player gets two packets of equal size, most often eleven cards each though thirteen is just as widely played; you play the hand first and only pick up the foot after emptying it. Melds are built toward books of seven, clean (no wilds) or dirty (with wilds), and going out typically demands a set quota of each, so a partnership cannot finish early on a thin table.

**Modern American Canasta** — The version most tournament and club play now uses. The initial meld must be made entirely from the hand, with no help from the discard pile, and a partnership needs two canastas rather than one before it may go out. Wild cards may be gathered into a meld of their own: a canasta of seven wild cards pays a bonus far larger than a natural one, most published rule sets putting it at 1,000, and an unfinished pile of wilds is penalised at the end of the deal instead. A rank whose remaining copies are all buried or already melded elsewhere can no longer reach seven cards and is treated as dead, which changes what is safe to throw. League rule sets differ on the exact bonus figures, so check whose rules the table is using.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Hoyle's Rules of Games, Canasta League of America, GameRules.com.

# Conquian

|                      |                                                                         |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Conquián, Coon Can, Cooncan, Colonel                                    |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2 players                                                               |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 40 cards (A to 7 plus J, Q, K in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-25 minutes                                                           |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                  |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                                                            |

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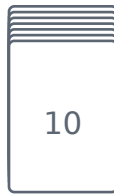
## Setup

Two players, forty cards. A Spanish pack works exactly as it comes. From an ordinary deck, take out the jokers and every eight, nine and ten, which leaves ace through seven plus jack, queen and king in each suit. That gap is not cosmetic: with the middle ranks gone the seven and the jack are neighbours, so a sequence can run 6-7-J. Aces are always low.

Pick a first dealer any way you like and alternate afterwards. Deal ten cards to each player, traditionally in packets of two, and set the remaining twenty face down between you as the stock. Nothing is turned face up to begin with, and there is never a discard pile: exactly one card is on offer at any moment, and a card that both of you refuse is turned face down and is dead for the rest of the deal.

Melds are laid face up in front of you as you make them and stay there for the rest of the deal, in plain view and — as you will discover — usable against you.

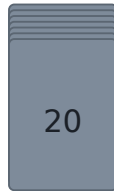
The target is eleven melded cards, not ten. Since you only ever hold ten, you cannot win out of your own hand: the eleventh card has to arrive from the stock or from what your opponent leaves behind.



Opponent



Opponent's  
melds



Stock



Your melds



Your hand

Ten cards each and twenty in the stock. Nothing is face up at the start; from the first turn onwards exactly one card is on offer, and refused cards are turned down and dead.

## Play

A meld is what it is everywhere else in rummy: three or four cards of one

rank, or three or more cards of one suit in sequence. Aces are low and the sequence climbs from the seven straight to the jack, because the ranks between them are not in the pack.

What makes Conquian its own game is that no card ever reaches your hand from the table. Anything you take goes face up into a meld the moment you take it, or you do not take it.

Play opens with the non-dealer, who turns the stock's top card face up. Two choices: use it — as part of a fresh meld laid down with cards out of hand, or added to a meld already showing in front of you — or refuse it and leave it lying face up. Using it obliges you to throw one card from your hand face up afterwards, and that thrown card is what your opponent is offered next, so your holdings never grow. You never lay a meld down except with the card you have just taken, and you never add anything to your opponent's melds.

After that the two players alternate through an identical turn. Exactly one card lies face up when your turn begins — your opponent's throw-away, or the stock card they would not have — and it is offered to you first. Take it, meld it, and throw a card of your own face up in its place, which ends your turn; or wave it away, in which case it is turned face down at once and is out of the deal for good. Having waved it away you turn the next card of the stock yourself and face the same two choices with that one: use it and throw a card as before, or refuse it and leave it lying face up, which ends your turn and hands your opponent that card to consider.

That is the entire engine, and it is startlingly tight. There is no drawing to improve a holding, no keeping a card back for a turn or two, no discard pile to mine later. Twenty stock cards and two ten-card hands are the whole world, and every card either goes on the table at once or is dead.

Forcing. If the face-up card could legally join a meld already in front of you and you decline it, your opponent is entitled to make you take it, and must say so before you turn the next stock card; you take it, add it to the meld, and still owe a card from your hand. This is not politeness, it is a weapon: an exposed meld is a standing liability, because your opponent can spend a card of their choosing to rip one out of your hand at a moment when you have none to spare. It is worth thinking twice before laying a long sequence down early.

Rearranging. Cards already melded are not frozen in place. You may move them between your own melds and borrow from one to build another, as long as everything left on the table is still a legal meld of at least three cards. A five-card sequence can lend a card to start a set; a four-card set

can spare one and survive.

Winning. Because every card you take is paid for with a card you throw, ten is the ceiling on what you can hold and show: hand plus table never adds up to more. The target sits one above that ceiling deliberately. Put all ten down and you have an empty hand, a complete table, and no victory — there is simply nothing left to throw, so your turns become a matter of waiting. What settles the deal is a card that extends something already in front of you: when one is offered or turned and you take it, no discard is owed in return, and that eleventh melded card finishes the hand on the spot.

Running out. The deal is a draw when the last card of the stock has been turned, both players have finished with it, and neither has eleven cards on the table. There is nothing left to turn, so play stops there and neither player has lost.

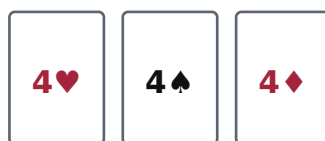


The 40-card pack in sequence order. With no eight, nine or ten in it, the seven and the jack are neighbours, and the ace sits at the bottom and never wraps round to the king.

Legal sequence



Set



Aces do not wrap



Sets and sequences behave normally; it is the missing ranks that produce the sequence beginners misread.

## Goal & scoring

Conquian keeps no score. A deal is won outright by whoever first has eleven cards melded face up, and that is the end of it — traditionally the game was played one deal at a time for a stake settled beforehand.

Draws are frequent and they are the interesting part. When the stock is spent and the last exposed card goes begging, nobody has won; the stake stays where it is and rides on the following deal, and plenty of players double it instead. Two or three draws in a row can leave a single hand worth a great deal, which is precisely why the game rewards a player who waits rather than one who reaches.

For a session played without money, the simplest arrangement is a point to the winner of each deal and a race to a fixed number, five or seven. Some groups instead count the cards the loser never managed to get onto the table and total those across deals, with the low score winning; the effect is much the same, but it gives a losing player something to salvage from a hand that went wrong early.

## Variants

**Nine-card deal** — Several published rule sets deal nine cards apiece and set the target at ten melded rather than eleven. The deal runs shorter, the stock is two cards deeper, and draws become a little less common. Nothing else changes, but since the sources genuinely disagree about which is standard, agree on the number before the first card is dealt.

**Full 52-card pack** — Leave the eights, nines and tens in. Sequences then behave the way every other rummy player expects, the stock grows from twenty cards to thirty-two, and draws become rare. It is a friendlier introduction, at the cost of the tension that comes from a pack small enough to track card by card.

**Three or more players** — Shuffle two 40-card packs together and deal ten each. The card in play is offered to each player in turn order, anyone who could add it to one of their own melds can be forced to take it, and the first player to eleven melded cards wins the pot. The game loses much of its shape beyond two, since the exact-card tension depends on knowing where everything is.

**Panguingue** — Conquian's gambling descendant, known as Pan, played for decades in card rooms across the American southwest. Five to eight players use eight 40-card packs shuffled together — 320 cards — and melds pay out in chips the moment they are laid down rather than at the end of the deal. The melding rules acquire a thicket of exceptions about which sequences and which sets are worth a payment, and a player who does not like their hand may fold out before play begins.

## Background

Conquian is the oldest game in the rummy family that anyone can still put a name to. It was being played in Mexico by the middle of the nineteenth century, crossed into the English-speaking United States as Coon Can in the 1880s, and card historians — David Parlett among them — treat it as the root that every western rummy game grew out of. Playing it feels like reading a first draft of Gin Rummy, with the drawing and the hoarding not yet invented.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Denexa Games, Cool Old Games, GameRules.com, David Parlett, card game histories.

# Contract Rummy

|                      |                                                                                    |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Combination Rummy, Joker Rummy, Deuces Wild Rummy                                  |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-8 players (best with 4)                                                          |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 2 standard decks plus jokers for 3 or 4 players; 3 decks plus jokers for 5 or more |
| <b>Time</b>          | 60-120 minutes                                                                     |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                             |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                                                                       |

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## Setup

Contract Rummy is a rummy game with a syllabus. A full game is seven deals, and each one names in advance the exact combination you have to assemble before you are allowed to put a single card on the table. The requirement grows harder as the game goes on, opening at two sets and closing on three runs, so an early deal is a sprint and the last one is a slog.

Three to eight can play, and it is at its best with four or five. Up to four players shuffle two 52-card decks together with two jokers; from five up, use three decks and three jokers. The jokers are the wild cards, and a table that wants a looser game simply shuffles in more of them. Treat identical cards as interchangeable.

Draw for the first deal and pass it to the left afterwards, so with seven deals in a game everyone deals at least once at most player counts. The number of cards dealt is not the same throughout: ten each for the first three deals, twelve each for the last four, the step coming where the fourth contract begins asking for three combinations instead of two.

After dealing, stack the rest face down as the stock and turn its top card face up beside it to open the discard pile. The player to the dealer's left goes first.

A set is three cards of the same rank, suits ignored. A run is four cards of one suit in sequence. Aces work at either end — A-2-3-4 and J-Q-K-A are both fine — but they do not turn the corner, so K-A-2-3 is not a run. Everything else follows from that. Keep a running score across all seven deals; the pad matters more here than in most rummy games, because nobody wins a deal outright.

## Play

A turn is draw, meld or lay off if you are entitled to, then discard — the ordinary rummy shape, with two large complications bolted on.

Drawing. Take the top card of the stock or the top card of the discard pile,



as usual.

**Buying.** This is where Contract Rummy stops resembling its relatives. A discard the player in turn does not want is not dead: anyone else at the table may speak up for it, and must do so before that player has drawn. What a buy costs is bulk. The buyer collects the card they asked for and a stock card charged on top of it as the price, which leaves them carrying more cards than anybody else, and none of it entitles them to act — no meld, no lay-off, no discard, since their own turn is still somewhere ahead of them. The interrupted turn simply picks up where it stopped, and the player whose turn it was draws off the stock. Where several people speak at once, seating decides: the claim belongs to whichever of them will be in turn soonest. The player in turn never buys; for them, taking the top discard is simply their draw. Buys are rationed, most tables allowing three to a player per deal; some allow only two, so settle it beforehand. Buying is the whole texture of the game. You will hold a hand that is one card short of the contract for six turns, watch that card land on the pile out of turn, and have to decide whether it is worth going a card deeper to get it.

**Melding.** Your first appearance on the table has to be the deal's contract, laid down complete in a single turn, and nothing more than the contract — no extra cards attached to the sets, no fifth card on a run. Until you have done that you may not put down anything at all, so a hand that is one card short of the contract is a hand with nothing on the table and everything counting against you. Laying the contract down is the whole of that turn's melding: nothing may be laid off, on your own melds or anybody else's, until your next turn comes round. Where a contract asks for two runs, most tables require them to be in different suits; a table that allows both in one suit still insists they be genuinely apart, since 3-4-5-6 and 7-8-9-10 of spades is one eight-card run wearing a disguise and never counts as two.

**Jokers** stand in for any card. A meld may hold more than one, though most groups frown on a contract met largely with wilds. Many tables let a player who holds the natural card a joker is representing swap it in and take the joker to use elsewhere; some restrict that to your own melds, others allow it against anybody's.

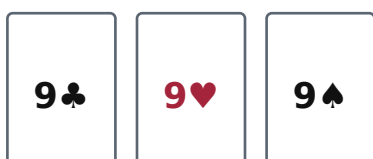
**Laying off.** Once your contract is down, later turns open up: you may add cards to any meld on the table, your own or anyone else's, and this is how you shed the rest of your hand. Nothing obliges you to lay off, but every card left in your hand at the end of the deal is a penalty, so there is rarely a reason to sit on one.

**Discarding.** Finish the turn by putting one card face up on the pile, which is the card the whole table is about to be offered.

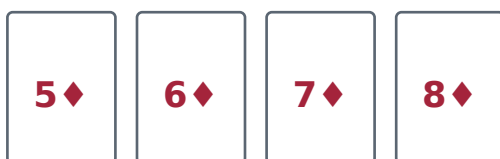
Going out. The deal ends the moment somebody has no cards left. In the first six deals that means melding or laying off everything but one card and discarding it. The seventh deal is different: there is no final discard, so the whole hand has to go down at once in the three runs the contract asks for, which is why the last deal is the one most likely to finish with nobody out at all.

Running out of stock. When the last stock card is drawn, lift the discard pile, leave its top card lying where it is, shuffle the rest and set them face down as a fresh stock, and play on. If that stock empties too and still nobody has gone out, the deal stops there and everybody counts their hand — in that deal nobody escapes with zero.

Set



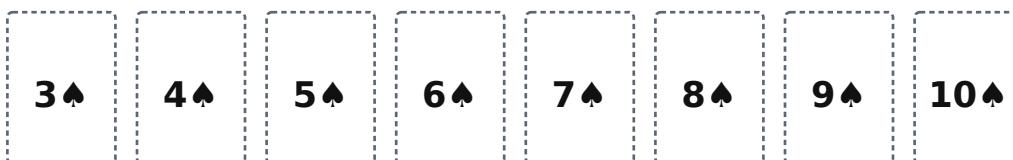
Run



Not a run



Same suit, and they join up



The two shapes a contract is built from, and the two mistakes people actually make: an ace bridging king and two, and a second run that merely continues the first.

## Goal & scoring

There is no winner of a deal, only a player who escapes it cheaply. When somebody goes out, everyone else counts what is still in their hand and takes it as penalty points, and the totals run cumulatively through all seven deals. Whoever has fewest points once the seventh deal is scored wins, and no standard rule breaks a tie — agree beforehand whether level players share it or play one more deal of the seventh contract to settle it. A player

who goes out scores nothing for that deal, which is the best result available.

Cards count against you at these values:

- Each joker: 15
- Each ace: 15
- Each king, queen or jack: 10
- Everything else: 5

Two of those figures are worth a word before the first deal, because published rule sets genuinely disagree: some groups price jokers at 25 rather than 15 to discourage sitting on them, and some count tens with the face cards at 10 rather than with the low cards at 5.

The pressure the scoring creates is specific to this game. In an ordinary rummy you can meld a set early and reduce your exposure straight away. Here you may not put down anything at all until you have the entire contract, so an unlucky deal is one in which you hold twelve scoring cards from beginning to end and pay for every one of them. Buying a card to complete the contract two turns sooner is often worth going a card heavier, because the alternative is being caught with the lot.

| Scores | Value                | Notes                                               |
|--------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Deal 1 | Two sets             | 10 cards dealt; 6 go down                           |
| Deal 2 | One set and one run  | 10 cards dealt; 7 go down                           |
| Deal 3 | Two runs             | 10 cards dealt; 8 go down, different suits          |
| Deal 4 | Three sets           | 12 cards dealt; 9 go down                           |
| Deal 5 | Two sets and one run | 12 cards dealt; 10 go down                          |
| Deal 6 | One set and two runs | 12 cards dealt; 11 go down, runs in different suits |
| Deal 7 | Three runs           | 12 cards dealt; the whole hand, no discard          |

## Variants

**Shanghai Rummy** — The best-known relative and in many places the more popular game. Ten deals rather than seven, eleven cards dealt every time, and twos are wild alongside the jokers. Going out in a single turn without having melded earlier in the deal — going out blind — earns a bonus subtracted from your score, doubled if you did it without a wild card. The extra deals stretch a session considerably, so it suits an evening rather than an hour.

**Zioncheck** — The 1930s American ancestor of the whole family. Its deals do not all follow one uniform procedure — each has quirks of its own — which makes it more of a curiosity now than a game anybody organises an evening around, but the fixed-contract idea starts here, and everything else in this group is a tidied-up version of it.

**Progressive and Liverpool Rummy** — Two widespread loosening of the same skeleton. Progressive Rummy grows the deal size with every contract instead of stepping it up once, so the last hands are large and unwieldy on purpose. Liverpool Rummy runs a shorter list of contracts and throws in more jokers, which makes the contracts easier to fill and shifts the interest onto the buying. Both are usually played to the same cumulative low-score finish.

**Extra deals and house contracts** — Tables routinely bolt on an eighth deal, commonly four sets, or reorder the list so that the runs come earlier. Some also add a going-out bonus of 25 points deducted from the winner's total, which speeds up the endgame considerably: without it there is no reward for going out beyond avoiding penalties, so a player with a hopeless hand has little reason to hurry.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, GameRules.com, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games, The Rummy Rulebook, Gambiter.

# Gin Rummy

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Gin                                        |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2 players                                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                               |

---

## Setup

Gin Rummy is a two-handed game using a full 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Pick the first dealer by drawing from the shuffled pack: low card deals. After that whoever lost the previous hand deals, though plenty of tables hand it to the winner instead, so agree which before you start.

The dealer shuffles, the opponent cuts, and ten cards go to each player one at a time, non-dealer first. Put the rest of the pack face down in the middle as the stock and turn its top card face up next to it. That upcard is the whole discard pile for now, and it leaves 31 cards in the stock.

Ranks run from ace low up to king, and they do not wrap. A-2-3 is a legal sequence; Q-K-A is not. For counting, an ace is 1 point, a numbered card is worth its number, and each jack, queen and king is 10. Keep your hand hidden. Nothing goes on the table until somebody ends the hand.



Ten cards each leaves 31 in the stock; its top card is turned up beside it as the whole discard pile.

## Play

There are two kinds of meld. A set is three or four cards that share a rank. A run is three or more cards of a single suit in unbroken order. Each card can only work in one meld at a time, so holding 7♣ 7♠ 7♥ 8♥ 9♥ you may count the set of sevens or the heart run, not both. Everything outside your melds is deadwood, and its point total is what the whole game turns on.

The first turn has its own procedure. The non-dealer may take the upcard or refuse it. If they refuse, the dealer gets the same offer. If both refuse, the non-dealer opens by drawing the top card of the stock. Whoever takes a card then discards, and the players alternate normally from there.

An ordinary turn is two actions with nothing in between. Draw exactly one card, either the face-down top of the stock or the face-up top of the discard pile, then discard exactly one card face up onto the pile. You are back to ten cards at the end of every turn. You may not take the top discard and throw the same card straight back on that turn; a handful of modern rule sets, the Gin Rummy Association's among them, do permit it, so settle that one before the first deal. Melds are never laid on the table during play; they stay in your hand until the hand ends.

You end the hand by knocking. You may knock on any turn, including your first, as long as your deadwood after discarding comes to 10 points or less. To do it, lay your final discard face down instead of face up, then spread your hand with the melds grouped separately from the deadwood and state your count. Knocking is optional. With a low count you are allowed to keep playing and hunt for a bigger score, at the risk of being knocked on first.

Zero deadwood is gin. Declare it the same way, spreading a hand in which every card is melded once the discard is gone.

Your opponent now spreads too. They arrange their own melds and then lay off: any loose card of theirs that fits one of your melds can be pushed onto it, adding a fourth card to a set or extending either end of a run. Every card laid off comes out of their deadwood. Two restrictions matter. Nothing can be laid off against a gin hand, and nothing can ever be laid off onto the other player's deadwood.

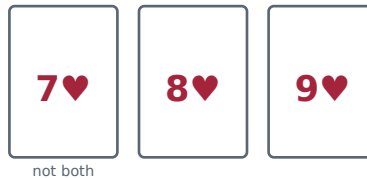
Once the laying off is finished the two deadwood counts are compared, which decides who scores the hand.

The stock can run out. If a player draws the card that leaves only two cards in the stock and then discards without knocking, the hand is dead: neither player scores, and the same dealer deals again. Those last two stock cards are never drawn.

Set of sevens



Or the heart run



Run, ace low



Not a run



Each card counts in one meld only. Holding 7♣ 7♠ 7♥ 8♥ 9♥ you may take the set of sevens or the heart run, not both. Aces are low and do not wrap, so A-2-3 is a sequence and Q-K-A is not.

## Goal & scoring

Hands are only steps toward the match target, which is 100 points. Longer sessions sometimes set it at 250 or 500; nothing else about the scoring changes.

A knock that survives scores the knocker the difference between the two deadwood counts. Knock with 6 against an opponent left holding 21 and you take 15. If the opponent's count after laying off is lower than yours, or exactly equal to it, they have undercut you: they score the difference plus a 25-point undercut bonus, and an equal count still counts as an undercut, worth the flat 25. Gin scores 25 plus every point of deadwood in the opponent's hand, and it can be neither laid off against nor undercut. Those

25s are the modern figures and not the original ones: the older official values were 20 for gin, 10 for an undercut and 20 a box, and rule sets giving them are still about. Agree which you are using, since it changes what a close hand is worth.

Keep running totals. The game ends as soon as either player's total reaches 100 at the end of a hand. Then add the bonuses: each player scores 25 for every individual hand they won, called a box or line bonus, and whoever reached 100 first adds a 100-point game bonus. If the loser never won a single hand, the winner doubles their entire total, game bonus included, which is known as a shutout, blitz or schneider. The higher total after bonuses wins the match, and the gap between the totals is the margin that gets settled. A dead hand scores nothing and counts as a hand won by neither player, so it earns no box. In the rare case that the two totals finish exactly level, the match goes to whoever crossed 100 first.

| Scores           | Value           | Notes                                                        |
|------------------|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Knock            | difference      | opponent's deadwood after lay-offs, less the knocker's       |
| Gin              | 25 + deadwood   | opponent's full deadwood; nothing may be laid off against it |
| Undercut         | 25 + difference | to the defender; an equal count still undercuts              |
| Dead hand        | 0               | stock down to two cards; no box for either player            |
| Box (line) bonus | 25              | per hand won, added once the game ends                       |
| Game bonus       | 100             | to whoever reaches the target first                          |
| Shutout (blitz)  | double total    | if the loser won no hand; game bonus included                |
| Match target     | 100             | 250 or 500 for a longer session                              |

## Variants

**Oklahoma Gin** — The first upcard fixes the knock limit for the whole deal instead of the standard 10. If it is a 6, nobody may knock with more than 6 points of deadwood; face cards set the limit at 10, so an ordinary deal. Most tables add that an ace as the upcard means only gin ends the hand, and many use a spades-double rule where a spade upcard doubles everything scored that deal. This is the most widely played competitive form of the game.

**Hollywood Gin** — A scoring frame rather than a rules change: three games are tracked at once in three columns. The first hand a player wins is entered in their first column only, their second win goes into the first and second columns, and every win after that goes into all three. Each column is a separate race to 100 with its own bonuses, so a match runs longer and an early lead is worth



much more.

**Straight Gin** — Knocking is abolished. The only way to end a hand is to go gin with all ten cards melded, which means no undercuts, no laying off and no partial scores. Hands run much longer and the whole discard-reading side of the game gets sharper, because you cannot bail out of a bad hand with a cheap knock.

**Big Gin** — An extra bonus recognised at many tables. If the card you draw gives you eleven melded cards with no discard needed, you declare big gin and score 31 plus your opponent's deadwood instead of the usual 25. Some groups score it at 25 like ordinary gin, so settle the number in advance.

**Three- and four-handed gin** — For three, the usual arrangement is that one player sits out each deal and the two active players use the standard rules, with the winner staying in and the loser swapping out. For four, play as two partnerships: each player faces one opponent in a separate two-handed hand, then the partners' results for that round are combined and only the net difference is entered on the score sheet.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Cool Old Games.

# Hand and Foot

|                      |                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Hand & Foot, Hand and Foot Canasta                                                                                            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                                                                                                     |
| <b>Deck</b>          | One more deck than there are players, jokers included: 5 decks and their 10 jokers (270 cards) for the usual four-player game |
| <b>Time</b>          | 90+ minutes                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                                                                                                                  |

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## Setup

Hand and Foot is the North American Canasta that took over the kitchen table. It keeps Canasta's melds of seven, its wild twos and jokers and its red threes, and adds one idea of its own: you are dealt two packets of cards instead of one, and you have to work your way out of the first before you are allowed to look at the second.

Two to six can play. Four is the standard game, two partnerships sitting opposite one another; six splits into three pairs, and at two, three or five everyone plays alone. The usual formula for the pack is one deck more than there are players, jokers left in, so four players shuffle five decks together and get 270 cards. Plenty of groups simply keep five or six decks bagged up and use them whatever the turnout.

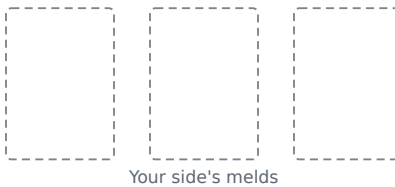
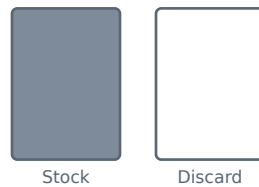
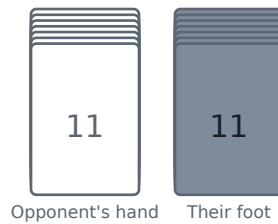
Cut for the first deal, high card taking it, and pass the deal one seat to the left for each of the four hands; play runs clockwise throughout. Deal two packets of eleven to every player. The first is the hand, which you pick up and sort. The second is the foot, which goes face down in front of you untouched, and stays there until the hand is gone. Many tables skip the dealing entirely and have each player cut their own two packets out of the shuffled pile, counting them afterwards to check.

What is left goes face down as the stock — with a pack this size it is normally split into two or three separate draw piles so everyone can reach one. Turn one card face up to start the discard pile; if it is a red three or a wild card, bury it and turn another.

Before anyone plays, each player lays any red threes from their dealt hand face up in front of them and draws a replacement from the stock for each, repeating if a replacement is itself a red three; red threes that turn up later in a foot are treated the same way when that foot is picked up. The player to the dealer's left takes the first turn.

Melds belong to the partnership rather than the player, so keep them in one group between you where both can reach. A full game is four deals with a

rising entry price, and the score is cumulative.



Eleven cards in each packet. The hand is picked up and played; the foot lies face down and unseen until the hand has been emptied.

## Play

There are no sequences in this game. A meld is three or more cards of one rank, four up to ace, and suits never matter. Jokers and twos are wild. Once a meld reaches seven cards it is a canasta and takes no more; to go on melding that rank, start a fresh pile beside it. The two kinds are counted separately all game: a clean canasta is seven natural cards with no wild among them, a dirty canasta is seven cards with at least one wild in it. Most tables cap a dirty meld at two wild cards and insist the naturals always outnumber them; a few allow three. Square a finished canasta up and mark

it — a red card on top for clean, a black one for dirty — so both partnerships can see at a glance where each side stands.

A turn is draw, meld if you like, discard one. You draw two each turn rather than one.

Taking the pile instead. Rather than drawing, you may claim the discard pile, but you only get the top card and the six beneath it — seven cards, not the whole heap, and only what is there if the pile is shorter. The price is that you must hold two natural cards of the top card's rank and put all three down as a meld straight away; the other six cards go into your hand. Wild cards are no help in qualifying, which means a wild card on top is as untakeable as a black three on top, and a black three on top blocks the pile completely — the only thing black threes are good for. Taking the pile replaces your draw, and the turn still ends with a discard.

The entry price. Neither partner may put anything on the table until the side lays out melds reaching the deal's minimum in card points, all in one turn: 50 in the first deal, then 90, then 120, then 150. When you meet the minimum by taking the pile, only the top card counts toward the total; the six cards underneath are yours to keep but contribute nothing to the requirement.

Threes. A red three drawn into your hand goes face up in front of you at once and you draw a replacement. Black threes are never melded during play and cannot be melded onto; they sit in hand as dead weight until you throw one, and their only use is the turn they spend blocking the next player.

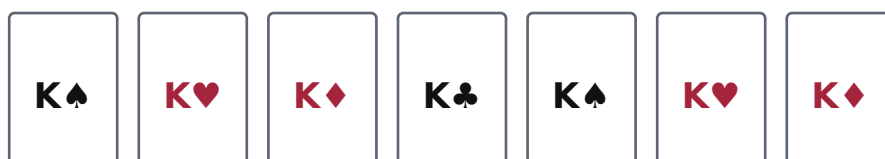
Getting into the foot. This is the pivot the whole game turns on. When your hand is finally empty you pick up the foot and go on playing from it — and how you emptied it decides when. Empty it by melding, with no card left to throw, and the foot comes up immediately and your turn continues from the new cards. Empty it by discarding your last card and the turn is over; the foot waits for you until next time. That one-turn difference is worth planning several turns ahead, because a partner stuck in their hand while you are in your foot cannot help you finish.

Going out. To end the deal you must be playing from your foot, your side must have completed its quota of canastas, and you must clear your hand, which usually means laying off everything except a final discard. The usual quota is two clean and two dirty canastas, the same in every deal, which stops a side from finishing early on a thin table; plenty of tables raise it for the fourth deal or cut it for a shorter game, and the quota is the single most house-ruled thing in the game. Before you commit, ask your partner

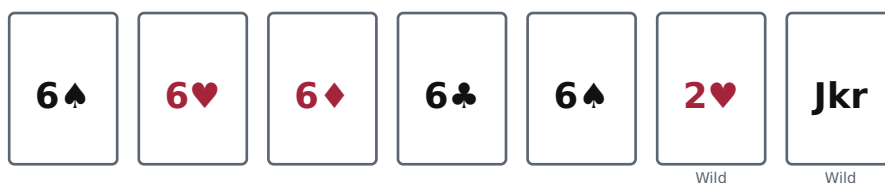
whether you may go out, and abide by the answer — a no usually means they are holding cards that will cost the side more than your finishing is worth.

The stock running out. If the draw piles empty before anyone goes out, play stops there. Nobody gets the going-out bonus and the deal is scored as it lies, which normally hurts whichever side has the most left in hand.

Clean canasta



Dirty canasta



Too many wilds



Sequences never count



Melds are ranks only, never sequences, and the difference between a clean and a dirty canasta is worth 200 points at the end of the deal.

## Goal & scoring

A game is four deals and the highest cumulative total wins; there is no target to race to, which means a side that falls behind early has a genuine reason to keep playing, since the bonuses are large enough to swing a deal at any point.

Each deal is scored for the partnership as a whole. Add the bonuses for every canasta the side finished, add 100 if one of your players went out, add the red threes, then add the face value of every card you have melded and subtract the face value of every card still sitting in either partner's hand or unopened foot. An unplayed foot is expensive — eleven untouched cards can wipe out a canasta — which is why getting into it early matters more than melding pretty.

Red threes are the field's biggest disagreement. The version described here pays 100 each to the side that laid them face up. Many groups instead pay them only to a side that finished at least one canasta, some charge a flat penalty of several hundred points to anyone caught holding one when the deal ends, and a few pay a large bonus for collecting all of them. Black threes are worth 5 against you and nothing at all for you.

The scoring is the reason a partnership talks. Two clean canastas and a quick exit will usually beat a table full of dirty ones, and a partner who says no to going out is normally saying they are sitting on a foot they have not opened yet.

| Scores                     | Value    | Notes                                      |
|----------------------------|----------|--------------------------------------------|
| Joker                      | 50       | —                                          |
| Two                        | 20       | —                                          |
| Ace                        | 20       | —                                          |
| King down to eight         | 10       | —                                          |
| Seven down to four         | 5        | —                                          |
| Black three                | 5        | against you only; never melded during play |
| Red three                  | 100      | each, to the side that laid it face up     |
| Clean canasta              | 500      | —                                          |
| Dirty canasta              | 300      | —                                          |
| Going out                  | 100      | —                                          |
| Cards left in hand or foot | deducted | at face value, both partners               |
| Minimum meld, first deal   | 50       | —                                          |
| Minimum meld, second deal  | 90       | —                                          |
| Minimum meld, third deal   | 120      | —                                          |
| Minimum meld, fourth deal  | 150      | —                                          |

## Variants

**Hand, Knee and Foot** — Three packets instead of two, worked through in order, usually eleven in the hand, eleven or thirteen in the knee and thirteen in the foot. The game runs half again as long and the pack grows to match, six or seven decks being normal. Everything else is unchanged, but the penalty for never reaching your last packet becomes severe enough that partnerships plan their whole deal around opening the knee.

**Pennies from Heaven** — A widely played cousin in which sevens are singled out: the side must complete a canasta of sevens before it may go out, and finishing one pays a bonus far larger than an ordinary clean canasta. Some versions add a card drawn from the stock and set aside whenever a canasta is completed, which is where the name comes from. It makes low cards suddenly precious and changes what is safe to discard for the whole table.

**Two, three and five players** — With any count that does not split into pairs, everyone plays alone, and many groups deal larger packets — thirteen or fifteen in each of the hand and the foot — to make up for having no partner to build with. Going-out quotas are usually cut to one clean and one dirty canasta, because a single player cannot realistically produce four.

**House rules that actually differ** — Hand and Foot has no governing body and its rule sets disagree loudly. Common points to settle first: whether melds are capped at seven cards or may keep growing, whether a canasta may be started with wilds before its naturals arrive, how many wild cards a dirty canasta may hold, whether the pile is taken as seven cards or in its entirety, whether red threes pay or penalise, and how many canastas of each colour the going-out quota demands. A table that agrees these before the first deal will avoid the argument that otherwise arrives in deal three.

**The exact cut** — A popular flourish at the dealing stage. Instead of being dealt to, each player cuts their own hand and foot off the shuffled stack in one grab and counts afterwards; cutting the exact number needed earns a bonus, commonly 100 points. It costs nothing and gives the deal a small ceremony, which is part of why the game spread through clubs and cruise ships the way it did.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, GameRules.com, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games, World of Card Games, Gambiter.

# Indian Rummy

|                      |                                                                                                             |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Paplu, 13 Card Rummy                                                                                        |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 2 standard decks with one printed joker each (106 cards); a third deck once there are more than six players |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                                                      |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                                                                                                |

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## Setup

This is the rummy of Indian trains, clubs and afternoon kitty parties — thirteen cards, two decks, and one requirement that separates it from every other member of the family. It also answers to Paplu, and it is played for small stakes about as often as it is played for nothing.

Two decks and their printed jokers, 106 cards, will cover a table of up to six. Seven players or more want a third deck shuffled in.

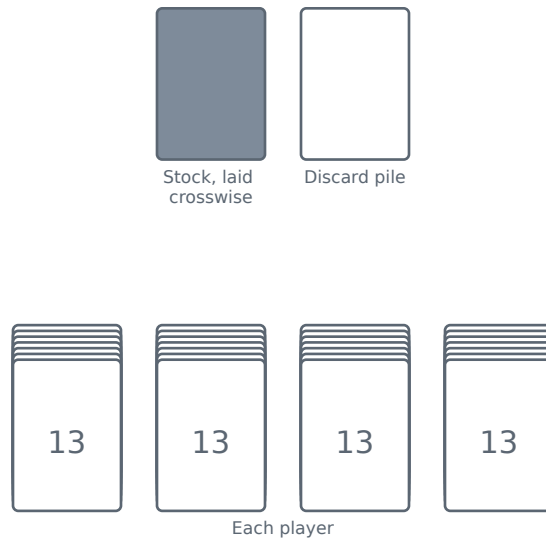
The wild cards are appointed fresh every hand and this is the first thing to settle. One card is pulled blind from the shuffled pack and turned face up, and its rank goes wild for the hand — every card of that rank, in any suit and from either deck, along with both printed jokers. So if a nine comes up, all eight nines are wild and so are the two jokers, which makes ten cards in the pack that can be anything at all. The exception is when the card turned happens to be a printed joker: then the whole hand has exactly one wild card in it, that joker's twin, and it plays very differently.

Deal thirteen cards to each player, singly. Turn one more face up to start the discard pile. What is left becomes the stock, and it does not go down flat — lay it face down at right angles across the turned-up card, so the rank that is wild stays readable to everybody for the rest of the hand and nobody has to trust their memory.

One piece of orientation before the first turn: both the deal and the play run anti-clockwise. The deal passes to the right, and the player on the dealer's right goes first. Nearly everything else in this collection goes the other way, so it is worth saying out loud at the table.

Seats and the first deal are drawn for rather than argued over. Everybody takes a card; the highest picks their seat, the next highest sits to their right, and so on down; the lowest ends up on the highest's left and deals first.





Thirteen cards each. The stock lies at right angles over the turned-up card, so the rank that is wild this hand stays visible to everybody throughout.

## Play

Turns are the ordinary rummy pair of actions and nothing more. Take one card, either the top of the face-down stock or the top of the discard pile, and then put one card from your hand face up on the discard pile. Take from the discards and you may not throw that same card away again in the same turn; something else has to go.

What is unusual is that nothing is ever laid on the table. No melds are put down as you go, no cards are added to anyone else's combinations, and your thirteen stay in your hand until the moment you win. Everything you learn about the other players comes from what they pick up and what they throw.

The combinations are these:

- A run: three consecutive cards of one suit, or more than three. An ace can anchor either end, giving A-2-3 at the bottom and Q-K-A at the top, but it will not do both jobs in the same run — K-A-2 is nothing.
- A set: one rank, three cards, all in different suits. With two decks on the table, two identical cards make no set between them; the suits have to differ.

No card can do two jobs. A holding of 7-8-9 in diamonds alongside two more nines is a run with two spare cards or a set with two spare cards, whichever you prefer, and never both.

Wild cards stand in for whatever is missing. If the turned card was an eight, then any eight, along with either printed joker, can be a card it is not.

Which brings us to the distinction the whole game is built on. A run is straight — pure — when no wild card is doing duty as something else in it. The test is not whether a wild card is present but what it is being asked to do: with eights wild, the run 7-8-9 in one suit is straight, because that eight is simply an eight, while J-Q-8 is a run only in the ordinary sense, since the eight is pretending to be a king.

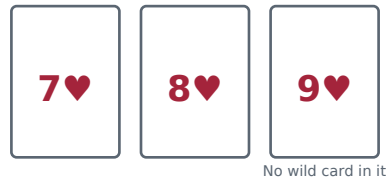
Declaring requires two runs among your thirteen cards, no fewer, with a straight one among them. The rest of your hand has to be in valid combinations too — runs or sets, wild cards welcome. Those two runs have names, and the names are the point: the straight one is your original life and the other is the second life. Until the original life exists, nothing else you are holding is alive either. The usual winning shape is four combinations of four, three, three and three, though three combinations of five, four and four will do just as well.

Winning is declared, not built up to. Having drawn, you discard your fourteenth card, say "Rummy" and lay all thirteen out for inspection.

If the stock runs out and the turn in which the last card was taken ends with nobody having declared, the hand is void and nobody wins anything.

Packing. A hand going nowhere can be abandoned — packing, or dropping. There is only one moment for it, your own turn, and you do it instead of drawing rather than as well as. Do it on your very first turn, before you have drawn anything at all, and it costs 10 points; your cards are shuffled back under the stock and may come round again. Do it later and it costs 40, and your cards are set aside out of the game for good. If everyone but one player packs, that player wins on the spot and collects.

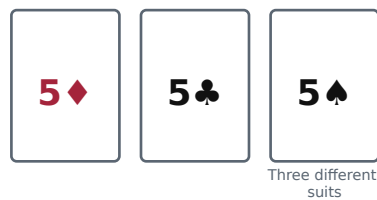
Straight run



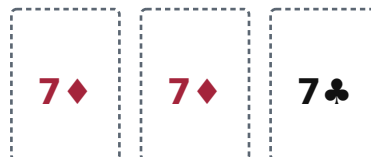
Ordinary run



Set



Not a set: suit repeats



Two runs are required before any of your other cards count, and one of them must be straight — built without a wild card standing in for something missing.

## Goal & scoring

Nobody accumulates points in this game. The winner scores nothing and everyone else pays, so the whole score sheet is a record of other people's failures.

When somebody declares, every player who did not pack works out what their own hand is worth. Aces and the court cards and the tens are 10 apiece; everything from the nine down is worth its face value; and wild cards, printed or appointed, are worth nothing.

How much of your hand you have to count depends entirely on how far you got, and this is where the two lives earn their name:

- No original life. Count every card. This is why a hand with no straight run in it is worth abandoning early — you are exposed to the full value of thirteen cards.
- An original life and nothing more. The cards in that straight run come out of the count. Everything else is charged for, sets included.
- Both lives. Now every valid combination in your hand is free — the two runs, any further runs, any sets — and you pay only for what is genuinely loose.

So the difference between one life and two is not a few points; it is usually most of the hand. A player holding a heart run, a spade run needing one card, and a completed set of fours can be paying for eleven cards or for two, depending on a single card in the middle.

Packers pay their 10 or their 40 regardless. Nobody pays anything if the stock ran out and the hand was void.

Two rarities are worth knowing before they happen to you. A player who declares immediately after their very first draw collects only half from anybody who has not yet had a turn — they never had a chance to pack. And a player dealt thirteen cards that are already a complete valid hand may announce Hand-Rummy at their first turn instead of drawing: anyone who has already played a turn then pays double, packers still pay their 10, and anyone yet to play pays the ordinary rate.

One hand is a complete game and settles itself. For a session, the common arrangements are to fix the money value of a point and settle after every deal, to agree a number of deals and total up at the end, or to play a pool in which anybody whose running total passes 101 or 201 is out and the last player standing wins. In the pool formats a hand is usually capped, so that a total above 80 is simply recorded as 80.

| Scores                                            | Value       | Notes                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Ace, king, queen, jack, ten                       | 10 each     | —                                                   |
| Nine down to two                                  | face value  | —                                                   |
| Any wild card                                     | 0           | printed jokers and every card of the turned-up rank |
| Cards in your original life                       | not counted | —                                                   |
| Every valid combination, once you have both lives | not counted | —                                                   |
| Packing on your first turn                        | 10          | —                                                   |
| Packing later                                     | 40          | —                                                   |
| Caught by a declaration on the first draw         | half rate   | only for players who had not yet had a turn         |
| Caught by Hand-Rummy                              | double      | only for players who had already taken a turn       |

## Variants

**Tanala** — Where three decks are in use, three genuinely identical cards — same rank and same suit, from different packs — form a combination of their own, the tanala, and it is treated as the equal of a straight run. It is the one place in the game where duplicate suits are a virtue rather than a mistake, and since a tanala can serve as your original life, holding one turns a hand that looked dead into a live one. Not available in the two-deck game, where identical cards are simply two copies.

**Paplu, the bonus wild card** — As well as making every card of the turned-up rank wild, some tables promote the next card up in that same suit to a special wild card called the Paplu. It works like any other wild, but whoever ends the hand holding one collects a bonus from each opponent — 10 points is the usual figure, rising to 25 for holding two. It rewards keeping a specific card that you might otherwise have played away, which is a small and pleasant tension to add to a hand you are already trying to close.

**Points, Deals and Pool** — The three ways a session gets organised, and the difference is only in how long you are committed for. Points fixes a cash value per point and settles after every single deal, which is the quickest and the easiest to join late. Deals fixes a number of hands — two or three is usual — and the lowest total at the end wins. Pool sets a ceiling of 101 or 201, knocks out anybody whose running total reaches it, and runs until one player is left; it is much the longest of the three and the only one where a bad early hand really matters.

**Only one run required** — Drop the second life and require just one straight run to validate the hand, with everything else free to be sets or ordinary runs. It makes hands close markedly faster and takes a good deal of the sting out of the scoring, since the gap between one life and two is what turns a middling hand into an expensive one. Reasonable for teaching the game, and worth being explicit about, because a player who learned it this way and a player who did not will disagree about a declaration rather than about a rule.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, GameRules.com.

# Rummy

|                      |                                  |
|----------------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Rum, Straight Rummy, Basic Rummy |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)        |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)       |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                    |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                             |
| <b>Category</b>      | Rummy family                     |

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## Setup

Use one 52-card pack with the jokers removed. Any fair method picks the first dealer; drawing cards and giving the deal to the highest is common, with tied drawers drawing again. The deal then passes to the left after each hand, which means it simply alternates in the two-player game.

How many cards you get depends on the size of the table. With two players, deal 10 each. With three or four, deal 7 each. With five or six, deal 6 each. Deal one card at a time, face down and clockwise, beginning on the dealer's left.

What is left becomes the stock, face down in the middle, with a single card turned beside it to open the discard pile. Only the top card of that pile is ever available, so keep it squared up rather than spread.

Aces are low. A-2-3 is a run and Q-K-A is not, unless you agree otherwise before the first deal. For scoring, an ace is 1 point, each numbered card is worth its number, and a jack, queen or king is 10. The player to the dealer's left takes the first turn.

| Players | Each player gets |
|---------|------------------|
| 2       | 10 cards         |
| 3       | 7 cards          |
| 4       | 7 cards          |
| 5       | 6 cards          |
| 6       | 6 cards          |

## Play

You are trying to get rid of every card in your hand by arranging them into melds. A set is a rank collected up: three nines, or all four of them. A run is three or more cards of one suit in sequence, such as 5♠ 6♠ 7♠. A card can only belong to one meld at a time.

A turn has three parts and always happens in this order.

First, draw. Take either the top card of the stock, sight unseen, or the top card of the discard pile, which everyone can see. You draw exactly one

card, and you may not dig deeper into the discard pile.

Second, meld if you want to. Lay any complete set or run from your hand face up in front of you. You may also lay off: add a card to any meld already on the table, yours or an opponent's, by putting a fourth card on a set or extending either end of a run. Laying off is how single cards get used up late in a hand; the card you add simply becomes part of that meld, and since melds score nothing for anybody in the basic game it does not matter whose spread it joined. Melding is always optional, even when you can. Holding a completed meld back keeps your options open but risks getting caught with it.

Third, discard. Put one card face up on the discard pile. That ends your turn and passes play to the left. The one thing you cannot do is take the top discard and immediately throw the same card back.

Two points worth agreeing before you deal, because tables differ and the accounts of the game differ with them. One meld a turn is the older rule and the one still written down as standard, though plenty of groups let you lay down as many as you like. Laying off runs the other way: some accounts let you add to anybody's melds from the start, and others hold you back until you have laid down a meld of your own.

The hand ends when somebody goes out, which means playing their last card. You can go out by melding, by laying off, or by discarding your final card, and any mix of those in one turn. In the basic game you do not need to keep a card back for a final discard, though a good number of households insist on it.

If nobody has gone out by the time the stock is empty, take the discard pile, leave its top card where it is as the only card of a new discard pile, and turn the rest face down as a fresh stock. Shuffling that new stock first is common and harmless. The player who found the stock empty draws from the new one and finishes their turn as normal, and play continues to the left. A stubborn hand can in principle circle for ever, so cap it before you start: ending after the stock has run out for the third time, or allowing the discard pile just one reuse, are both suggested. When the cap is reached the hand ends and the cards are scored as they stand.

Going out in a single turn, with no previous melds or lay-offs at all, is going rummy and pays double. To do it you must put your entire hand down on one turn, having laid nothing on the table earlier in the deal.

Set



Run



Run, ace low



Not a run



A set is three or four cards of the same rank; a run is three or more cards of one suit in sequence. Aces are low, so A-2-3 is a run and Q-K-A is not unless you agree otherwise before the first deal.

## Goal & scoring

The object of each hand is to be first to shed every card. Play runs to an agreed target, over as many hands as that takes. No figure is standard, so pick one before the first shuffle — or agree a fixed number of deals instead, which works just as well.

When a player goes out, everyone else counts the cards still in their hand. Melds already on the table do not count for or against anybody, and neither do cards you laid off. Aces are 1, numbered cards are face value, and jacks, queens and kings are 10 each. The winner of the hand scores the sum of everything all the other players are left holding.

Going rummy doubles the whole amount collected for that hand.

The common alternative is penalty scoring: instead of the winner collecting, each losing player writes down the value of their own leftover cards as a plus score, the winner writes zero, and the game runs until someone crosses an agreed limit, at which point the lowest total wins.

Ties are settled the same way under either method: if two or more players are level for the win once the target has been passed, deal again and keep



playing until one of them is clear on their own.

## Variants

**Block Rummy** — The discard pile is never recycled. When the stock runs out and the next player does not want the top discard, the hand stops there and nobody goes out. Everyone counts the cards in their hand as penalty points, including the player who would otherwise have won. It makes hoarding a big hand far more dangerous and speeds the game up noticeably.

**Boathouse Rum** — A sharper two-player version. If you take the top discard you must then draw a second card, either the next discard or the top of the stock, but you still discard only one, so your hand grows. An ace may be used high or low, but not both ends at once, and it costs 11 points if you are caught holding it. You may not meld or lay off at all until the turn on which you go out, so every hand is played entirely from concealment.

**Knock Rummy** — Also called Poker Rum. Nothing is laid on the table during play. Instead, any player may end the hand on their turn by discarding face down and knocking, then spreading their hand. Everyone reveals, counts their unmelded cards, and the lowest count wins the difference from each of the others. A knocker who turns out not to be lowest usually pays a flat 10-point penalty to the player who is, on top of the differences, and a tie for lowest is normally judged against the knocker. Many tables also pay the knocker an agreed bonus, commonly 25, for knocking with a count of zero. The bluff is in deciding how early you dare to stop the hand.

**Wild cards** — Add one or two jokers, or nominate a rank such as deuces, as wild cards that can stand in for anything in a meld. A common accompanying rule lets a later player swap the natural card for a wild one sitting in a meld on the table and take the wild card into hand. Wilds usually carry a heavy penalty value, often 15 or 20 points, if you are caught holding one at the end of a hand.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games.

## SHEDDING

# Big Two

|                      |                                                                                      |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Big 2, Big Deuce, Deuces, Choh Dai Di, Chor Dai Di, Dai Di, Pusoy Dos, Capsa Banting |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 4)                                                            |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed                                           |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                                                                        |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                               |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                             |

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## Setup

Use the whole 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Two things about this deck have to be fixed in your head before you sort your hand, and both cut against ordinary card sense.

The rank order climbs 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, jack, queen, king, ace, 2. The two is therefore the best card and the three the worst, which is where the game gets its name. On top of that, suits are ranked as well, and the ranking is live in every comparison the game makes: spades over hearts, hearts over clubs, clubs over diamonds. Between them, rank and suit give all 52 cards a single unbroken order with no ties anywhere in it, running from the three of diamonds at the very bottom to the two of spades at the very top.

Choose the first dealer however you like; after that whoever won the last hand deals the next. Deal and play both run anticlockwise, so the cards go out to the dealer's right — American and Indonesian tables commonly reverse that and play clockwise, which changes nothing except who sits downstream of whom. Give thirteen cards to each player, one at a time. Four players use the entire pack. Three take seventeen each, with the fifty-second card turned in the middle and added to the hand of whoever holds the three of diamonds, so nothing goes missing from the count; two-handed practice varies between seventeen, twenty-one and thirteen cards each, and there the remainder is set aside unseen.

Whoever holds the three of diamonds opens every deal, and their opening play must contain that card, either on its own or inside a pair, a triple or a five-card hand built around it. Where cards have been set aside and the three of diamonds is not in play, the opening belongs to whoever was dealt the lowest card that is — lowest rank first, lowest suit between equal ranks — and that card has to appear in the opening play in the same way. Many groups instead apply the lowest-card rule only to the first deal of a session and let the winner of each hand open the next, free to lead any legal play

at all. Agree which convention is in force before the first shuffle.

## Play

Every play is one of exactly four sizes: a single card, two cards of the same rank, three cards of the same rank, or a five-card hand. Four cards on their own are not a legal play in the standard game, and neither is any other number.

Going round from the opening lead, each player either passes or beats the play sitting on the table. A beat has to be the same size as the play it answers. Singles answer singles, pairs answer pairs, triples answer triples, five-card hands answer five-card hands. There is no way to change the size part way through a round, and no number of extra cards helps.

How plays of the same size are compared:

- Singles: rank first, and the suit ranking settles two cards of the same rank. The two of spades is the top card in the pack, so a single two of spades can never be beaten.
- Pairs: rank first; when two pairs share a rank, the one containing the higher suit takes it.
- Triples: rank alone, since no two triples can share a rank.
- Five-card hands: the shape of the hand decides first. From weakest to strongest they go straight, flush, full house, four of a kind with any odd fifth card, straight flush. Only when two hands are the same shape do you look inside them, and then a full house goes by its triple, a four of a kind by its quartet, a straight or straight flush by its highest card and, if that card is the same rank in both, by its suit, and a flush by its suit before anything else, with the highest card separating two flushes of the same suit.

Sequences are the one place where the two stops being the best card in the pack. In the basic game it ranks below the three for this purpose alone, so the highest straight is 10-J-Q-K-A and the lowest is A-2-3-4-5, with 2-3-4-5-6 just above that and 3-4-5-6-7 above that again. An ace may sit at either end of a sequence but never in the middle, which rules out K-A-2-3-4 and J-Q-K-A-2. Where exactly the two and the ace belong is the most argued-over rule in Big Two, and it changes from country to country and from table to table, so settle it out loud before the first deal; the reported orders are set out in the variants.

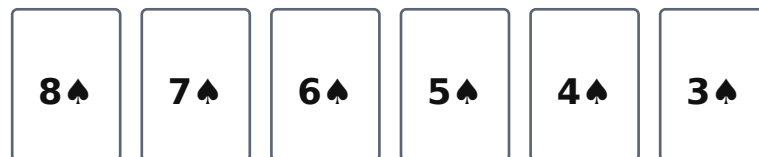
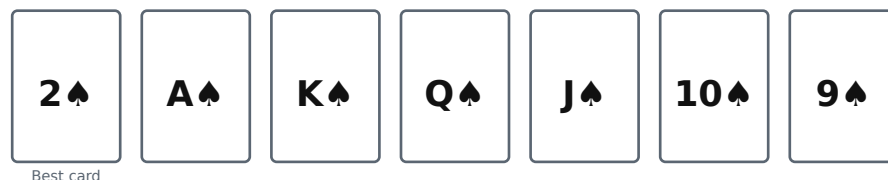
What a pass costs you is the other rule to settle before the first lead, because two answers are in circulation and they produce quite different hands. Ordinarily a pass gives up only that one turn. You are never obliged

to beat a play just because you can, and if somebody else beats it you may come back in when the turn next reaches you. Indonesian play uses the strict rule instead: a pass puts you out of the round altogether, even if the play comes back to something you could have beaten with ease. That makes a pass a genuine decision rather than a way of waiting to see what happens, and it lets a player whose lead nobody beat go on to beat their own cards, with everyone else already shut out of the round.

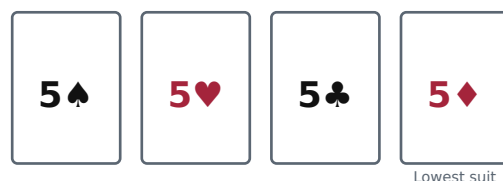
Either way, the round ends as soon as nobody will beat the cards on the table: under the looser rule when the turn has gone right round without a beat, under the strict one when everyone still in has passed. How many cards each player is holding stays public throughout: ask, and you must be answered truthfully. The player whose cards are on top then sweeps the pile face down out of the way and leads again with anything at all: any size, any shape, with no relation whatever to the play that just won.

The hand ends the instant somebody lays down their last card. Nobody plays on to sort out the remaining places. Your final play may be one that nobody at the table could have beaten, and there is no obligation to leave yourself a card that others still have a chance against.

Ranks, high to low

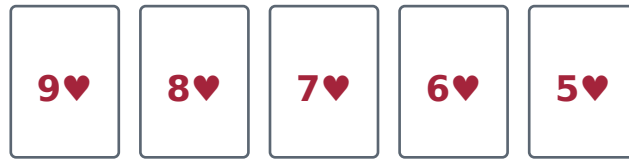


Suits, high to low

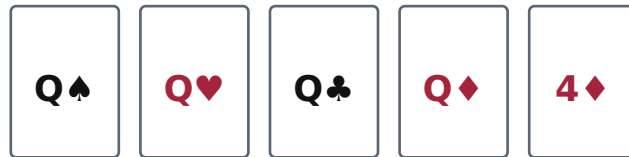


Rank decides first, and the 2 sits above the ace. Suit then separates cards of equal rank, so no two cards in the pack are ever tied.

Straight flush



Four of a kind



Any odd card

Full house

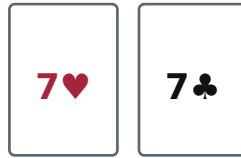


Flush

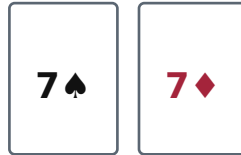


Five-card hands, strongest first. A plain straight is the weakest five-card play of all and loses to every shape drawn here.

On the table



Beats it



Not a beat



Not a beat



A play can only be answered by one the same size. Two pairs of the same rank are separated by their better suit, so a pair topped by a spade beats a pair topped by a heart.

## Goal & scoring

The hand belongs to the first player to get rid of every card they hold, and it stops there. Everyone else is charged for whatever they are still holding, and the charge climbs steeply against a player who barely got started, which is what stops people sitting on their twos all evening waiting for a clean run.

The simplest bookkeeping is a straight payment: each loser gives their penalty to the winner. Groups playing for money more often settle every pair of players separately, each paying everyone with a smaller penalty the difference between the two totals, which lets a close second finish the hand ahead of the field without having won it.

The usual schedule is one unit for every card still in hand, doubled for a player caught with ten to twelve of them and tripled for one still holding all thirteen. Where those multipliers kick in is regional and worth agreeing on beforehand. Plenty of tables set the bar lower, so that being caught with eight or nine cards already doubles the charge and holding all thirteen quadruples it.

There is no target score in the traditional game. Play an agreed number of deals, or simply until people have had enough, and add up: the lowest running total wins the session. If two players finish level and it matters to anyone, deal one more hand and let that settle it.

| Scores                             | Value | Notes                                            |
|------------------------------------|-------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Each card left, holding 9 or fewer | 1     | —                                                |
| Each card left, holding 10 to 12   | 2     | —                                                |
| Each card left, holding all 13     | 3     | The player never managed a single play all hand. |

## Variants

**Honour hands as bombs** — An honour hand — four of a kind with its odd fifth card, or a straight flush — may be dropped on a single, a pair or a triple, ignoring the usual size-matching rule, and takes the round outright. It gives a player who has been frozen out by high singles a way back into the hand, and it makes splitting a natural four of a kind into a full house a much harder decision than it looks. A separate and smaller variation simply lets four cards of a rank be played without any fifth card, as a size of their own that only a higher four can beat.

**Where the sequences stop** — The top and bottom of the sequence order is the game's least settled rule, and the reports do not agree even within one country. One account of Hong Kong play puts A-2-3-4-5 highest, then 2-3-4-5-6, then 10-J-Q-K-A and on down to 3-4-5-6-7, with J-Q-K-A-2 no sequence at all; another calls the commonest Hong Kong version the one where the two simply ranks high and is never consecutive with a three, making J-Q-K-A-2 the highest and 3-4-5-6-7 the lowest. Elsewhere some tables crown 2-3-4-5-6 with A-2-3-4-5 second, some crown A-2-3-4-5, some refuse A-2-3-4-5 as a sequence at all, and some rank J-Q-K-A-2 over 2-3-4-5-6 over 10-J-Q-K-A on the reasoning that you compare the cards in descending order of ordinary rank. Indonesian play puts any sequence containing a two above every sequence that does not, and separates two of them by the suit of the two. Any of these is playable; what is not playable is two people at the same table using different ones.

**Steeper penalties** — A harsher charge for the cards left in hand, common wherever the game is played for real stakes: double for a player left with eight or nine cards, triple for ten to twelve, and quadruple for anyone still holding the full thirteen. It raises the pressure to unload low cards early and makes a hand of scattered singletons genuinely frightening rather than merely bad.

**Dragon wins** — In Hong Kong some play that a player dealt a dragon — one card of every rank, the three right up through the ace and the two as well, which accounts for all thirteen cards — wins the deal on the spot. Each of the other three is then charged the full thirty-nine points, exactly as though they had sat the hand out without playing a card.

**Short-handed play** — Three players are normally dealt seventeen cards each, with the fifty-second card turned in the middle and added to the hand of whoever holds the three of diamonds — or to the holder of the three of clubs, if the turned card is itself the three of diamonds. Nothing is missing from the count that way. A smaller variation deals thirteen each and leaves the rest as a stock: anyone who passes must draw a card from it, and some groups make you draw as many cards as the play you declined to make. Two-handed practice varies between seventeen, twenty-one and thirteen cards each with the remainder always set aside unseen, which makes the two-handed game the one where a large block of the pack really is unaccounted for.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Cool Old Games, Gambiter, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Cats at Cards, Group Games 101, HobbyLark.



# Crazy Eights

|                      |                                                                                                            |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Eights, Crazy 8s, Swedish Rummy, Rockaway, Last One, Craits                                                |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-7 players (best with 4)                                                                                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards) for two to five players; 2 decks shuffled together (104 cards) for six or seven |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                                                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                                                   |

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## Setup

Take the jokers out. One 52-card pack handles up to five players; with six or seven, shuffle two packs together and treat them as a single deck of 104. Duplicate cards cause no trouble, since suits and ranks only ever have to be matched, never compared.

Rank order is irrelevant while you are playing. Nothing beats anything else, and an ace is neither high nor low. Rank matters only at the end of the hand, when you count up what is left in the losers' hands.

Pick a first dealer any way you like; cutting for the high card is the usual method. The deal then moves one seat to the left after each hand. The dealer shuffles and deals one card at a time, clockwise, starting with the player on their left. In a two-player game each side gets seven cards. With three or more, everyone gets five.

Put the undealt cards face down in the middle as the stock, then turn the top one face up next to it. That card is the starter and it forms the beginning of the discard pile. If the starter happens to be an eight, slide it back into the middle of the stock and turn a fresh card, because nobody wants the hand to open on a wild card. Repeat until you get an ordinary starter.

The player to the dealer's left goes first, and play runs clockwise.

| Players | Each player gets |
|---------|------------------|
| 2       | 7 cards          |
| 3       | 5 cards          |
| 4       | 5 cards          |
| 5       | 5 cards          |
| 6       | 5 cards          |
| 7       | 5 cards          |

## Play

On your turn you add exactly one card to the top of the discard pile. The card you play must agree with the card currently showing in either its suit

or its rank. A ten of hearts, for example, can be covered by any other heart or by any other ten. That is the whole of the matching rule.

Eights are the exception, and they are wild. You may play an eight on top of anything at all, whatever the suit or rank showing, and you may do it on any turn. When you put an eight down you immediately name a suit out loud. The next player has to follow that named suit as though the eight were a card of it, and the named suit stays in force until somebody legally changes it. You are free to name the suit the eight itself belongs to, and you are free to name a suit you hold nothing in. You cannot name "eights" or a rank; only a suit. The only card that can be laid on an eight without regard to the suit called is another eight, which resets the naming.

If you have no legal play, you draw. The common rule is that you keep drawing one card at a time from the stock until you turn up something you can play, and you then play it and your turn ends. Groups vary here: some let you draw only a single card and pass whether or not it helps, and some cap the draw at three. Whichever you use, agree on it before the first deal, because it changes the game noticeably. A player who has a legal play in most versions must make it rather than draw by choice; if your group allows drawing when you could have played, say so up front.

When the stock runs out, take the discard pile, leave its top card in place, shuffle the rest and set them down as a new stock. Several widely printed rule sets skip this refill entirely and treat an empty stock as permanent, so decide which you are using before you start. If you do refill and the discard pile has nothing to spare, or if you are playing without refills, then the stock is simply gone. From that point a player with no legal play passes their turn instead of drawing. If the turn goes all the way around with every player passing, the hand is blocked and ends immediately with nobody going out.

Otherwise the hand ends the moment a player lays down their last card. The standard rule lets you go out on an eight, naming a suit that nobody will ever have to follow; plenty of groups ban this, so settle it in advance. Some tables also require a player down to one card to announce it before their next turn, with a penalty draw for forgetting, exactly the way the commercial versions of the game do.

## **Goal & scoring**

Your aim in each hand is to be the first to run out of cards. Over a session, the aim is to be first to an agreed point target.

When someone goes out, every other player counts the value of what is still in their hand. Eights are punished hardest, which is the price of holding the game's most useful card too long. The player who went out scores the

combined total of all the opposing hands. A target of 100 makes for a short game; 500 is the other common choice, and some groups simply agree on a fixed number of deals and add up as they go.

If the hand blocks because the stock is exhausted and nobody can play, the player with the smallest hand total is credited with the difference between their own total and each opponent's, which is usually a much thinner score than going out cleanly.

A popular alternative flips the bookkeeping. Instead of the winner banking the opponents' cards, each player records the value of the cards left in their own hand as penalty points. Play stops as soon as anyone hits 100, and the lowest score at that moment wins. The card values are identical either way; only who receives the points changes.

Finish the deal you are in rather than stopping the instant somebody crosses the line. If two players end that deal past the target, the higher total takes it when the winner is collecting points and the lower total takes it when players are recording penalties. If they are exactly level, deal once more and let that hand decide.

| Scores                        | Value      |
|-------------------------------|------------|
| Each eight                    | 50         |
| Each king, queen, jack or ten | 10         |
| Each ace                      | 1          |
| Each 2 through 9              | face value |

## Variants

**Special-card eights** — The house-rule package that most tables end up adopting, and the one that commercial versions were built from. A two forces the next player to draw two cards and lose their turn, unless they can lay a two of their own, in which case the penalty stacks and passes along. A queen skips the next player. An ace reverses the direction of play, so it works as a skip in a two-handed game. A jack is sometimes used as a second skip. The eight stays wild through all of this. Once you have these on the table you are effectively playing Uno with a standard pack, which is roughly how Uno came about: it was designed in 1971 by an Ohio barber named Merle Robbins after arguments about exactly these kinds of Crazy Eights house rules.

**Mau-Mau** — The German game that Crazy Eights descends from, still played across central Europe and sold under other names in Switzerland and the Netherlands. It is usually played with a 32-card pack. The jack, not the eight, is the wild card that lets you name a suit. A seven makes the next player draw two, and those penalties stack if they hold a seven of their own. An eight skips a turn. You must call out "Mau" as you play your second-to-last card and "Mau-Mau" as you play the last, and forgetting costs you a penalty draw.

**Switch** — The British form, and the one most often meant when someone talks about playing Switch or Black Jack. The suit-changing wild card is the ace rather than the eight. Twos make the next player pick up two, and stack if that player also holds a two. Eights or jacks skip a turn depending on the group, and the black jacks are often a heavy pick-up penalty that only a red jack can cancel. A player down to their last card must announce it before their turn ends.

**Crazy Eights Countdown** — Each player carries a personal countdown number and everybody starts on eight. The rank matching your current number is your own private wild card, so at the start the eight is wild for all. What moves you down the countdown is winning a hand, not playing the wild card: shed your last card and your number drops by one, so the seven becomes your wild card for the next deal, then the six, and so on. The first player to get their number below one wins the session outright and no points need to be counted. Extra powers are usually layered on top: a jack skips the next player, a two forces a draw of two, and the queen of spades forces a draw of five.

**Draw-one Eights** — The most common single point of disagreement about this game, played as a deliberate rule rather than a mistake. A player who cannot follow suit or rank draws exactly one card from the stock. If it plays, they may play it; if it does not, their turn is over and the next player goes. Hands stay much smaller than in the draw-until-you-can version, deals run quicker, and blocked hands become far more frequent, so the tie-break scoring for a blocked hand actually gets used.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, Dice Game Depot, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Ducksters, PlayingCardDecks.

# Dou Dizhu

|                      |                                                                                                      |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Fight the Landlord, Landlord, 斗地主                                                                    |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-4 players (best with 3)                                                                            |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck with both jokers (54 cards); the four-player version wants two decks and four jokers |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                                                                                        |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                                               |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                                             |

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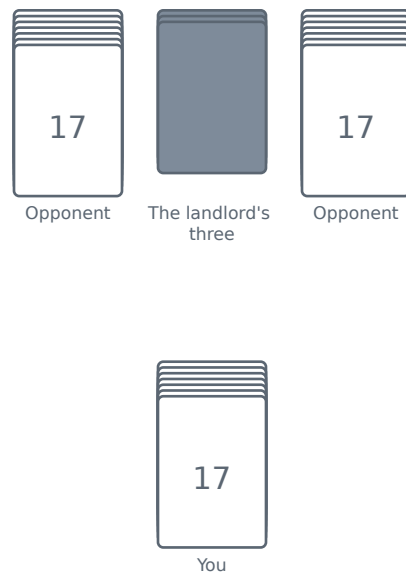
## Setup

Three players, and the shape of the game is one of them against the other two. Whoever wins the auction becomes the landlord, picks up three extra cards nobody else has seen, and plays a hand of twenty alone; the other two are peasants, allied for that hand and no longer. Those three face-down cards are what the auction is really for.

The pack is all fifty-four cards, both jokers included, and the jokers have to be distinguishable from one another — one red and one black. Suits are irrelevant everywhere in this game, for combinations, for beating and for anything else.

The ranking takes a minute and then never troubles you again. Bottom to top: 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, jack, queen, king, ace, two, black joker, red joker. The two sitting above the ace is the piece that catches people, and the twos are correspondingly precious.

Nobody deals here; everyone draws for themselves. Somebody shuffles, the player on their left cuts, and the pack goes face down in the middle. Turn one card face up and push it back into the middle of the stack — whoever happens to draw it will open the auction. Players then take cards off the top in turn, anti-clockwise, looking at each as they go, until every hand holds seventeen. Three cards stay on the table, face down and untouched.



Seventeen cards each and three face down. Whoever wins the auction becomes the landlord, adds those three to make twenty, and plays alone against the other two working together.

## Play

The auction settles who plays alone. Whoever drew the face-up card speaks first, and the only bids available are 1, 2 and 3 — a number of stake units, not of cards or tricks. Each player in turn passes or names a figure above the last. It ends when two players pass in a row, or the moment somebody says 3, since nothing beats it. Everyone passing throws the hand in for a fresh deal.

Whoever bid highest is the landlord. They pick up the three cards waiting on the table, which brings their hand to twenty against seventeen apiece, and the remaining two players are peasants allied for the duration.

The landlord leads, playing any single card or any legal combination. Each player after them, going anti-clockwise, must either pass or beat what is on the table — and beating it means playing the same type of combination with the same number of cards and a higher rank. Not a different shape of the same size: the same shape. A pair answers a pair and a five-card run answers a five-card run, and nothing else will do.

Bombs and rockets are the exception, and the only one. A bomb is four cards of a rank and beats any combination at all except a bigger bomb or a rocket. A rocket is the two jokers together and beats everything in the game.

Play goes round for as many circuits as it takes until two players pass in succession. The cards on the table are then cleared away and whoever played last starts again with anything they like. Passing does not shut you out — you may come back in on a later circuit of the same round.

The combinations, thirteen of them:

- Single card.
- Pair, two of a rank.
- Triplet, three of a rank.
- Triplet plus one loose card, such as 6-6-6-8. The triplet's rank is what counts, so 9-9-9-3 beats 8-8-8-A.
- Triplet plus a pair, a full house in all but name, again ranked on the triplet.
- Sequence, five or more consecutive cards from the 3 up to the ace. Twos and jokers are barred from every sequence in the game.
- Sequence of pairs, three or more consecutive pairs.
- Sequence of triplets, two or more consecutive triplets.
- Sequence of triplets with a loose card attached to each. The attachments must differ from every triplet, though they may happen to pair up with one another. A two or a joker may be attached even though neither can be part of the sequence; both jokers at once may not.
- Sequence of triplets, each one carrying a pair. Only the triplets need to run consecutively. The pairs must differ from one another and from the triplets, and loose cards and pairs may never be mixed inside one play.
- Bomb, four of a rank.
- Rocket, both jokers.
- Quadplex set: a quad carrying two extras. Either two loose cards, whose ranks must differ from each other, or two pairs, likewise differing. The quad fixes the rank. This is the awkward one, and it is worth reading twice: the only thing a quadplex set can defeat is a weaker quadplex built the same way. It takes down no other combination in the game, and any bomb whatever — the very lowest will do — takes it down.

Triplet plus one



The 6s decide rank

Triplet plus a pair



The queens decide it

Sequence of five



Three up to ace only

Not a sequence: the 2



Attached cards ride along without affecting rank — the triplet decides that. Sequences run from the 3 up to the ace and stop there: no two and no joker may ever join one.

Bomb



Beats all but a rocket

Rocket



Beats everything

The two plays that ignore the matching rule entirely, and the two that double what the hand is worth every time either appears.



## Goal & scoring

Empty your hand. If the landlord does it first, the landlord has won. If either peasant does it first, both peasants have won together — which is the rule that makes them genuine partners rather than two people who happen to be losing to the same person.

That has a consequence worth stating plainly, because it is the single thing newcomers get wrong. As a peasant, helping your partner go out is worth exactly as much as going out yourself. So you do not beat your partner's cards, you feed them the lead when they are close, and if one of you clearly has the stronger hand the other plays entirely in service of it. A peasant who plays to win personally is playing the wrong game.

The money settles per opponent rather than into a pot. The landlord winning collects the stake from each of the other two; the landlord losing pays it to each of them. The stake starts at whatever the winning bid was — one, two or three units — and then gets multiplied.

Every bomb and every rocket played in the hand doubles the payment, no matter who played it or which side they were on. They stack. A hand bid at 3 that saw two bombs and a rocket is settled at twenty-four units each way, so the arithmetic escalates far faster than the bidding ever suggested and a single defensive bomb can turn a routine hand into the biggest of the evening.

There is a doubling for humiliation at each end. If the peasants never got a single combination onto the table, that is a spring, and the landlord's winnings double again. If the peasants win having let the landlord play nothing beyond their opening combination, the landlord's payment doubles in the same way.

Nothing carries over between hands. Each deal is settled in units and the next auction starts clean.

| Scores                      | Value                          | Notes                                                       |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Base stake                  | the winning bid: 1, 2 or 3     | —                                                           |
| Landlord out first          | each opponent pays the stake   | —                                                           |
| Either peasant out first    | the landlord pays each of them | —                                                           |
| Each bomb or rocket played  | doubles the payment            | by anyone, on either side, and they stack                   |
| Spring                      | doubles it again               | the peasants never got a combination down at all            |
| Spring against the landlord | doubles it again               | the landlord played nothing after their opening combination |

## Variants

**Four-player Fight the Landlord** — Played mainly around Zhejiang, Jiangsu and Shanghai. Two packs and four jokers, 108 cards: twenty-five to each player and eight to the landlord, who holds thirty-three against three opponents in partnership. The combinations change to suit the bigger hand. Attaching single cards is dropped entirely, as are quadplex sets. A bomb may be four cards or more, and more cards beats fewer regardless of rank, so a five-card bomb of threes takes out a four-card bomb of aces. A rocket now needs all four jokers, and a red and a black joker cannot be paired together — though two reds or two blacks can, as a pair on their own or attached to a triplet. Only bombs of six cards or more, and rockets, double the payment.

**Showing the landlord's three** — The older practice was for the landlord to pick the three face-down cards up privately, so nobody else ever learned what they were. Turning them face up for everyone to see before the landlord takes them has become the normal custom in many groups and is standard in most online rooms. It is a real change rather than a courtesy: the peasants learn three of the fifty-four cards and, more usefully, know exactly which cards the landlord did not have when they bid.

**Choosing who opens the auction** — The face-up card buried in the stack is one way of picking the first bidder and not the only one. A common house rule gives the opening bid to whoever holds the three of hearts, falling to the four of hearts if nobody has it, and so on upwards. Others simply rotate the privilege one seat per deal in the direction of play, which is the tidiest arrangement for a long session. Online rooms generally just pick somebody at random. It matters more than it sounds, since bidding first means bidding with the least information.

## Background

The name is a fossil. Dou Dizhu means fighting the landlord, and it dates from the land reform campaigns of the 1950s, which set peasants against landlords in earnest. The game came out of Hubei and is now one of the most played in China, and nobody hears the name that way any more.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, GameRules.com.

# Durak

|                      |                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Podkidnoy Durak, Perevodnoy Durak, Fool                                                                                |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                                                                                              |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 36 cards (6 up to ace in each suit); five or six players use the full 52-card pack instead |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                                                                          |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                                                               |

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## Setup

Strip a standard pack of everything below the six, leaving thirty-six cards. Inside a suit the order is the ordinary one, six lowest through ace highest. Cards carry no point values whatever; they exist only to be compared with one another.

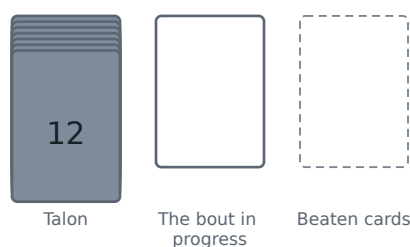
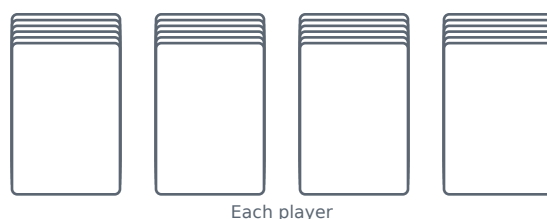
Two to six can play and four is the number the game sits best at. Do the arithmetic before you sit down, because six hands of six cards use all thirty-six: there is no card left to turn for trumps and no talon at all, so six players need the full 52-card pack. Five players leaves a talon of only six cards, which is why five is often moved to 52 as well.

Cut for the first dealer, low card dealing. Deal six cards to each player, going clockwise. Turn the next card face up, lay it on the table, and set the rest of the pack down across it so a corner of it stays in view. That card fixes the trump suit for the whole deal, and it is also the very last card anyone will be able to draw. The pile is the talon.

Whoever holds the lowest trump attacks first. Claim the role, or show the card if the table wants proof; if every trump happens to be sitting in the talon and nobody can claim it, gather the cards and deal again. On later deals the previous loser attacks first, which most groups combine with making the loser deal.

A courtesy rule worth adopting: the holder of the lowest trump in the pack — the six in the 36-card game — may take the turned-up trump into hand and slide the six underneath the talon in its place. Do it between bouts, and only while at least one face-down card still lies on top of the turned card.

There is no score sheet and nothing to write down. A deal simply runs until one player is left holding cards.



Six cards each, shown for four players. The trump lies face up crosswise under the talon and is the last card drawn. Attack cards and the cards beating them stay paired until the bout ends.

| Players | Each player gets |
|---------|------------------|
| 2       | 6 cards          |
| 3       | 6 cards          |
| 4       | 6 cards          |
| 5       | 6 cards          |
| 6       | 6 cards          |

## Play

A deal is a run of bouts. In each bout one player attacks one other, and the defender is always the player to the attacker's left. Everyone else at the table is a potential attacker.

The attack. The principal attacker lays one card from hand, face up, where the defender can reach it. Nothing is being led and nothing is being won: no suit has to be followed, the card competes with nothing, and it is simply a problem the defender now has to solve.

The defence. To beat a card, cover it with something stronger: within its own suit, anything ranking above it; failing that, any trump. Once a trump is on the table only a higher trump will beat it. Beaten cards and the cards that beat them stay on the table in pairs where everybody can read them.

Throwing in. As soon as a bout is under way, any card of a rank that already appears somewhere on the table may be added to the attack — the ranks of the defending cards count too, not just the attack cards. The principal attacker may keep throwing in, and so may the other players, which is where the game's usual name comes from: podkidnoy means thrown in. The principal attacker always has first refusal; once they pass, the others

may throw in, taking their turn clockwise from the defender's left. Each new card has to be beaten separately.

Two limits, and neither is optional. A bout may never contain more than six attacking cards in total. It also may never contain more attacking cards than the defender held in hand when the bout opened — count them at that moment, not later, so a defender who started the bout with two cards faces at most two. Many tables cap the opening bout of a deal at five attacking cards, since defending first in a crowded game is punishing enough on its own.

Ending a bout. There are exactly two outcomes and they could not be more different. If the defender covers everything and the attackers have nothing left to throw in or decline to continue, the defence held: the whole heap goes face down onto a discard pile that nobody ever touches again, and those cards are gone from the deal. If the defender gives up at any point, they take every card on the table into hand, including the ones they had already beaten, and are that much further from getting rid of them.

Refilling. Between bouts everyone tops their hand back up to six from the talon. The order matters once the talon is nearly empty: the principal attacker draws first, then everyone else in clockwise order from them, and the defender last of all, however few cards that leaves. Nobody draws once the talon is exhausted, and the face-up trump is the final card taken.

Who attacks next. A defender who held takes over the attack, aiming the next bout at the player on their own left. A defender who picked up is passed over: the attack skips them and falls to the player beyond.

The endgame. Any player whose hand empties, with no talon left to refill from, is finished and drops out; the rest carry on around the gap. Play continues until one person is still holding cards.

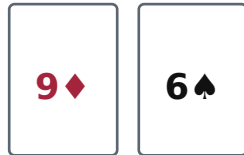
Beaten



Attack

Higher, same suit

Beaten



Attack

Any trump will do

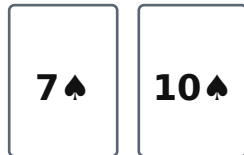
Not beaten



Attack

Wrong suit, no  
trump

Beaten

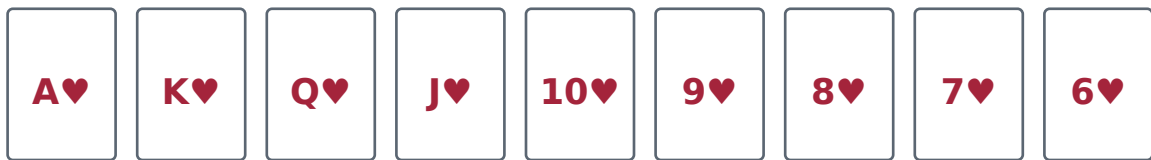


Trump attack

Only a higher  
trump

Beating an attack card, with spades as trump. Suit and trump are the only things that matter — nothing about rank alone will do it.

Any suit



Lowest card

The 36-card pack, high to low within every suit. Nothing outside the trump suit ever beats anything inside it.

## Goal & scoring

Nobody wins Durak. Everyone who empties their hand while cards are still moving walks away clean, and the single player left holding cards at the end is the durak — the fool. That is the whole result of a deal.

Two things follow from a game shaped that way. There is no score, no ranking of the players who got out, and nothing to argue about afterwards; the fool traditionally shuffles and deals the next hand, often with the pack pushed at them. And because nothing is being collected, a bout you defend brilliantly is worth precisely nothing in itself. The only question that ever matters is whether cards left your hand or arrived in it.

Once the talon is empty the character of the game changes completely. Hands stop being replenished, so every pick-up is permanent damage, and the player who can force an opponent to take three cards near the end has usually decided the deal. Trumps hoarded through the early bouts are what make that possible, which is the standing tension of the game: a trump spent to defend cheaply is a trump you no longer have to attack with.

A deal can also end with no fool at all. If the last two players both run out on the same bout — the defender covers the final attack with their last cards, and the attacker has nothing left either — the hand is a draw. Not every group plays it that way, so settle it before you start.

Where a running tally is wanted, write down who was the fool each deal and play an agreed number of deals, or until somebody has been the fool a set number of times.

## Variants

**Perevodnoy Durak (passing on)** — The dominant form in Russia today, and the one that most changes how a bout feels. Instead of beating the attack or picking it up, a defender holding a card of the same rank as the attack card may play it alongside and shove the whole attack sideways onto the next player, who becomes the defender. That player may add a further matching card and pass it on again, so an attack of one card can arrive at the fourth seat as an attack of four. The safeguard is that you may never pass to somebody holding fewer cards than the number of undefended cards they would face. Some tables also let a defender pass simply by showing a trump of the matching rank without parting with it.

**Podkidnoy Durak (throw-in only)** — The plain form described above, with no passing at all: the defender's only choices are to beat every card or to take the lot. It is the version most non-Russian players learn first and the one online implementations usually default to, and it puts far more weight on the six-card cap, since a defender who survives the opening card knows exactly how much worse the bout can get.

**Team Durak** — Four players in two partnerships seated alternately, or six in two teams of three. Partners never attack one another, and they do throw in to help each other's attacks, so the six-card cap becomes a coordinated weapon rather than an individual one. A side is finished when both or all three of its

members are out, and the losing partnership are the fools together. Signalling is not allowed, but discarding to help a partner obviously is, which gives the partnership game a cooperative texture the free-for-all does not have.

**52-card Durak** — For five or six players, use the full pack with the two low and the ace high and still deal six cards each. The extra sixteen cards guarantee a talon exists at all, which the 36-card game cannot promise at those numbers, and they stretch every suit out so that a middling card is far less likely to hold. The swappable lowest trump becomes the two rather than the six. Everything else about attacking, defending and throwing in is unchanged.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Official Game Rules, Gambiter, Wikibooks Card Games, Nordic Card Games, PlayJoy, Group Games 101.



# Fan Tan

|                      |                                                                    |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Sevens, Parliament, Play or Pay, Card Dominoes, Sjuan              |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-8 players (best with 5)                                          |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards); counters or chips if you want the pool |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                      |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                             |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                           |

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## Setup

One warning about the name. There is a Chinese banking game called fan-tan, played by covering a heap of beads or buttons with a bowl and betting on how many will be left when they are counted off in fours. It has no cards in it and nothing to do with this. If you want to be unambiguous, ask for Sevens, which is what most tables call it anyway.

Three to eight can play; five or so is the sweet spot, since a short table makes the game too easy and a long one leaves you waiting. Anyone deals first and the deal moves left afterwards.

Deal every card out, one at a time and clockwise, starting to the dealer's left. Unless there are exactly four of you the hands will come out uneven, and that is fine — the larger hands sit earliest in the rotation and get their turns first, and the deal moves round anyway.

Aces rank above kings, so each suit runs from the two at the bottom to the ace at the top, with the seven in the middle where the game starts.

Keep the middle of the table clear. It has to hold four rows of thirteen cards before the game is over, so if space is tight, agree now to stack the high cards on the eight and the low cards on the six rather than spreading everything out.

If you are playing for chips — the version Hoyle prints under the name Fan Tan — everybody antes one into a pool before the deal.

## Play

The card at the centre of everything is the seven. A seven is the only card that can start a suit off, and once one is down, that suit's row grows outwards from it a card at a time: the eight and then the nine and so on up towards the ace on one side, the six and then the five and so on down towards the two on the other.

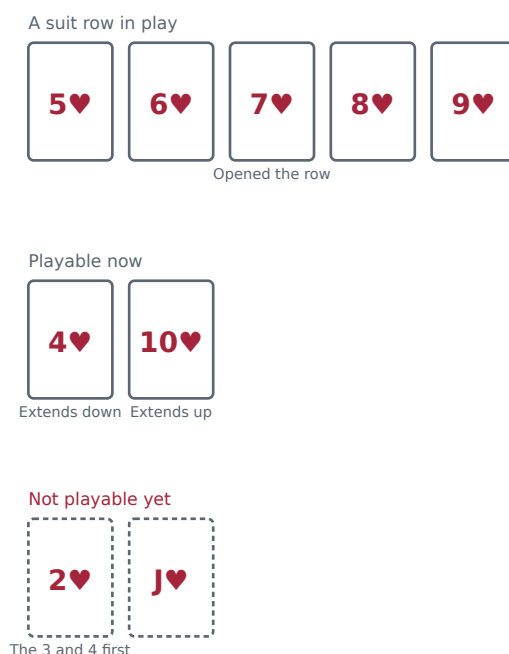
The player to the dealer's left goes first and, since the table is empty, can only put down a seven or pass. Play then goes clockwise.

At your turn you play exactly one card, and you have no choice about whether to play. If anything in your hand fits — a seven to open a new suit, or a card that sits immediately next to the end of a row already going — you must put it down. Only when nothing in your hand fits may you pass, and passing with a playable card is cheating rather than tactics. In the chip version it is also expensive.

That single restriction is what makes the game more than an exercise in doing as you are told. You usually have a choice of several legal cards, and which one you let go decides what everyone else can do next:

- Holding a seven back is the strongest thing you can do and the hardest to get away with, since it shuts a whole suit down for as long as you can avoid being forced. You can only do it while some other card of yours is playable.
- Cards close to a seven open a suit up for everybody. Cards near the ends of a row close it down. Playing towards the middle is generous; playing at the extremes is not.
- The player who is short of a suit entirely has nothing to fear from it, and the player holding the two and the ace of one suit will be stuck with them until the whole of that row is laid.

The hand ends the moment somebody plays their last card. Many tables carry on afterwards to settle who came second, third and last, which matters if you are scoring by what is left in hand.



Each suit forms one row, opened by its seven and extended one card at a time in both directions until it runs from the two up to the ace.

## Goal & scoring

Empty your hand before anyone else does. At a table playing for nothing that is the whole of it, and the game is perfectly good played that way.

If you want a running score there are two established ways of keeping one, they pull play in opposite directions, and it is worth choosing between them deliberately rather than by whatever is nearest to hand.

Counting the cards you failed to shed prices the extremes. Everyone still holding cards when the winner goes out totals them as penalty points — pip value for the numbers, ten apiece for the courts, fifteen for an ace — and the lowest total after an agreed number of deals wins. Since the dear cards are precisely the ones stranded at the far ends of a row, it pushes the whole table towards laying rows out fast and shedding aces and kings early. Loose, quick and forgiving.

A pool prices being stuck. Chips go in before the deal and again each time somebody passes; the winner takes the pool and is then paid for every card still sitting in everyone else's hand. Nothing in that arithmetic cares which cards you hold, only how many, so blocking stays worth doing and the game stays tight. This is the version Hoyle prints, and the reason the game carries the second name Play or Pay.

One thing to settle before the first deal either way, rather than after the argument: what it costs to pass when you could have played. The temptation is specific and hard to prove after the fact — a player quietly sitting on a seven can bottle a suit up for rounds at a time. Make the fine unpleasant, and make it worse for a seven.

| Scores                      | Value                | Notes                                            |
|-----------------------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Ante, before the deal       | 1 chip               | —                                                |
| Passing your turn           | 1 chip to the pool   | —                                                |
| Passing when you could play | a heavy agreed fine  | heavier again if the card you sat on was a seven |
| Going out first             | the whole pool       | —                                                |
| Each card left in your hand | 1 chip to the winner | —                                                |

## Variants

**A named seven leads** — Rather than letting the player on the dealer's left choose which suit opens, the holder of one particular card must lead it, and everything else follows from there. The seven of hearts is the usual nomination in Britain and Sweden, the seven of diamonds in some American descriptions, and the seven of clubs in Finland. It removes the game's first decision, which is a small loss, and guarantees somebody can move on turn one, which at a big table is a real gain.

**Six and eight before anything else** — Once a seven is down, the six and the eight of that suit must both be played before any further card of it is allowed. Played in Finland as Ristiseiska and in Germany as Siebener raus, among others. The effect is much stronger than it sounds: a suit cannot start running away in one direction, three specific cards have to surface before the row does anything at all, and holding the six or the eight becomes as powerful as holding the seven itself. Expect more passing and a longer game.

**Shichi Narabe** — The Japanese form, and the most-changed of the family. Everyone lays every seven they hold onto the table before the first turn, so all four rows are open from the start and there is no suit to strangle. In exchange, passing becomes a scarce resource: you may pass three times, and on the fourth you are out, laying your remaining cards into their places on the table. Since the sevens are spent immediately, the game is entirely about which end of which row you feed.

**Cinquillo** — The Spanish version, played with the 40-card Spanish pack — an ordinary deck with the 8s, 9s and 10s removed will do. Each suit has ten cards rather than thirteen, so the rows are opened by the fives instead of the sevens, and the five of coins must be the first card of the game. Shorter and tighter than the full-deck version, and the standard four-player game in Spain.

**Ace low** — Put the ace at the bottom of each suit, below the two, rather than at the top above the king. Each row then runs from the ace up to the king. It changes nothing structurally and quite a lot practically, since the ace stops being a card that can strand you at the far end of a row and becomes just another awkward extreme. Worth agreeing before the deal rather than discovering mid-hand.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards.

# Kings in the Corner

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Kings Corner, Kings Corners, King's Corner |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                   |

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## Setup

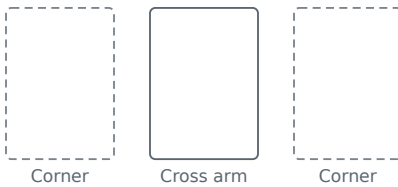
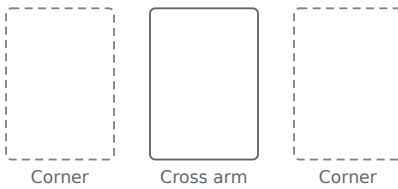
Two to six can play. Three or four is the sweet spot. Six is the practical ceiling, because forty-two cards go out in the deal and four more form the layout, leaving a stock of just six. Use a standard 52-card deck with the jokers taken out. Aces are low. The ranking runs K-Q-J-10-9-8-7-6-5-4-3-2-A, and nothing can ever be played on an ace because there is no rank below it.

Pick a dealer any way you like and pass the deal to the left after each round. Deal seven cards to each player, one at a time, clockwise. Put the remainder face down in the middle of the table as the stock.

Turn the top four cards of the stock face up and set them around the stock in a cross: one above, one below, one to the left, one to the right. Those four are the starting piles. The four diagonal positions between the arms of the cross stay empty. Those are the corners, and only a king may ever be placed in one.

If a king turns up among those first four cards, most groups slide it straight into a corner space and turn up a replacement for the arm of the cross, so the round starts in the usual shape. Leaving it where it landed is also playable, since a queen of the opposite colour goes on it either way. Agree which you are doing before the first turn.

Leave plenty of space around the cross. Piles grow outward as cards are added, and whole piles get picked up and relocated during play, so a cramped table gets confusing fast.



Four cards turned face up around the stock form the cross. The four empty corners take kings only; each player holds seven cards.

## Play

The player to the dealer's left goes first and the turn passes clockwise.

Begin your turn by drawing one card from the stock into your hand. Then make as many plays as you can find, in whatever order you like, and stop when you choose. You are never obliged to play, and never obliged to stop while you still have legal moves. When you are finished, say so and pass.

Four kinds of play are legal.

1. Play a card from your hand onto a pile. It must be one rank lower than that pile's exposed card and the opposite colour. A red 9 goes on a black 10; a black 4 goes on a red 5. You may run several cards from your hand onto the same pile in one turn as long as each one continues the alternating sequence.
2. Start a corner pile with a king. A king from your hand may be placed in any empty corner space, and that pile then builds down in alternating colours exactly like the others, beginning with a queen of the opposite colour. Because no rank outranks a king, a king can never be laid on top of another card at all; the only places one can go are a corner space or an empty arm of the cross.

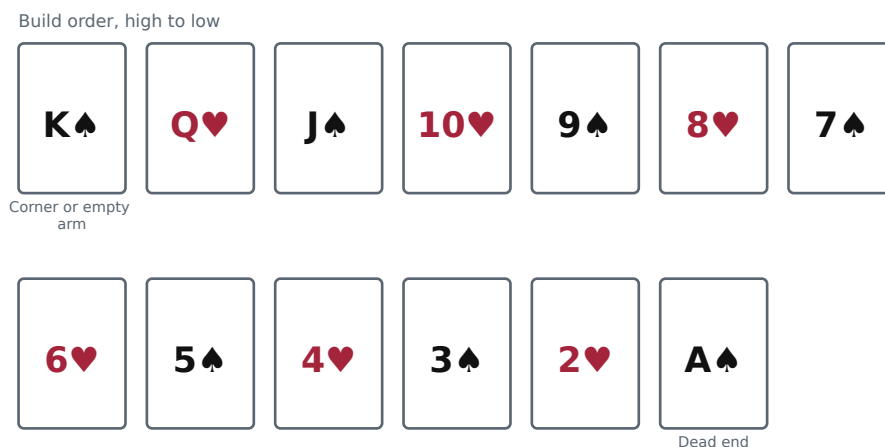
3. Fill an empty arm of the cross. If one of the four original positions has been vacated, any card from your hand may be laid there to start a fresh pile, a king included, though most players save theirs for a corner. This applies only to the arms of the cross. An empty corner still requires a king.

4. Move an entire pile onto another pile. Look at the highest card of a pile, the one it started with. If that card is one rank lower and the opposite colour to the exposed card of some other pile, you may pick the whole pile up as a block and drop it on. A pile headed by a red 4 can go onto a pile whose exposed card is a black 5, taking everything below the 4 with it. You must move the pile intact; splitting it is not allowed. A pile headed by a queen can be dropped onto a corner king of the opposite colour in the same way, but a corner pile itself can never be moved, because nothing in the game accepts a king. The point of the move is usually the space it leaves behind, which becomes somewhere to dump an awkward card.

There is no limit on how many of these you combine in one turn, and consolidating piles to open spaces is the main source of long turns.

The round ends the instant a player puts down the last card from their hand. If the stock runs out first, play carries on without drawing; anyone who cannot or will not move simply passes. Once the stock is gone and the turn has gone all the way around with nobody playing a card, the round is dead and everyone scores what they are still holding.

One alternative is worth knowing because it changes when a round is allowed to finish: a few written rule sets say nobody may go out while the stock still holds cards, so a player who puts down their last card draws again and keeps playing. Most tables do not use it. Settle which way you are going before the first deal.



Aces are low, and every pile builds down in alternating colours. Nothing can be played on an ace, and a king only ever goes into a corner or onto an empty arm of the cross.

## Goal & scoring

You are trying to empty your hand. The first player to do it wins the round and scores nothing.

Everyone else counts the cards still in hand: 1 penalty point per card, except kings, which cost 10 each. If the round ended in a stalemate with the stock exhausted and nobody out, every player scores their remaining cards the same way and no one takes the round.

Add the penalties across rounds and play to an agreed target. Twenty-five makes a short game and 100 a long one. When any player crosses the target, the game stops and the lowest total wins; if two or more players are level on that lowest total, either share the win or deal one more round between them to settle it. A single deal scored on its own works perfectly well too.

The 10-point king penalty drives the tactics. A king never goes on top of anything, so the only way to shed one is into a corner or an empty arm of the cross; get one down as soon as a space opens, and think twice about filling the last corner yourself while you still hold another king.

## Variants

**Chip pot** — The version sold in a box, and the usual gambling form. Everyone antes one chip before the deal. The winner of the round takes the pot, and losers pay in one chip per card left in hand plus ten for each king. Some groups also charge a chip whenever you end a turn without making any play at all, which pushes people to keep the layout moving.

**Draw at the end of the turn** — Instead of drawing first, you play what you want and then draw a single card to close your turn. The card you pick up cannot be used until your next turn, so you go into everyone else's turns holding one more unknown card. It slows the game slightly and removes the free look you normally get before deciding what to play.

**Compulsory play** — You must make a play whenever a legal one exists, rather than holding cards back for a better moment. Many groups pair this with a king penalty: if you fail to place a king in an open corner and another player spots it, you pay a forfeit of three chips or three points. It cuts out defensive hoarding and shortens rounds noticeably.

**Bigger hands for two** — With only two players, deal ten cards each instead of seven. The seven-card deal leaves a very deep stock in a two-handed game, which drags the round out and makes it hard for either player to build momentum. Some groups go further and deal thirteen. The rest of the rules are untouched.



Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Geeky Hobbies, Dice Game Depot, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games.

# Mau-Mau

|                      |                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Mau Mau, Tschau Sepp, Auflegen                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 32 cards (A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7 in each suit); a full 52-card pack works too, and two packs suit six or more players |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                                                                                           |

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## Setup

The usual pack is the German 32: take a standard deck and remove everything below the seven, leaving ace, king, queen, jack, ten, nine, eight and seven in each suit. A full 52-card pack is perfectly playable and simply makes the hands longer. From six players upwards, shuffle two packs together and play them as a single deck of 64. Having a card twice over changes nothing here, because no card in this game is ever measured against another; it is only ever laid beside the one showing to see whether they agree.

Rank order does nothing during play. No card outranks any other. A rank is worth knowing for two reasons only: a handful of ranks carry a special power, and every rank has a point value that is charged against whoever is still holding it when the hand ends.

Deal five cards to each player, one at a time, clockwise. Six is also common and makes for a slower, more tactical hand. The undealt cards become the stock, face down in the middle, and the top one is turned up beside it as the first card of the discard pile. Bury any jack that appears there back in the stock and turn the next card instead, because a hand should not begin on the wild card. If the card that opens the pile is a seven, an eight, a nine or an ace, its power is ignored: it is simply a suit and a rank for the first player to match.

Pick the first dealer any way you like. The player to the dealer's left goes first, play runs clockwise, and the deal moves one seat left after each hand.

| Players | Each player gets |
|---------|------------------|
| 2       | 5 cards          |
| 3       | 5 cards          |
| 4       | 5 cards          |
| 5       | 5 cards          |
| 6       | 5 cards          |
| 7       | 5 cards          |
| 8       | 5 cards          |

## Play

A turn is one card, laid face up on the discard pile. What you lay has to share either a suit or a rank with the card already showing: a club covers a club, and a nine covers a nine, and either match is as good as the other. Nothing more is asked of an ordinary card. Holding a card you could legally lay, you are expected to lay it rather than draw in order to keep it, though a few groups do allow a voluntary draw and it is worth saying which way you play.

Jacks are the wild card. A jack goes on top of anything at all, and as you play it you name a suit out loud; the next player must follow the suit you named, and that suit holds until somebody legally replaces it. The suit you call need not be one you hold anything in, and calling the jack's own suit is allowed. Most German households do not permit a jack to be laid on a jack, so once a jack is showing the named suit has to be answered properly.

The other special cards, in the set most commonly played:

- Seven: the next player picks up two cards and forfeits their turn. If that player has a seven of their own they may lay it instead of drawing, in which case the debt moves along with two more added to it, and the sevens can stack around the table until somebody runs out of them.
- Eight: the next player is skipped.
- Ace: either the player takes an immediate second turn or the next player is skipped, depending on the house. Both are widespread and they are not compatible, so pick one.
- Nine: where it is used at all, it reverses the direction of play, which in a two-handed game amounts to another skip.

Stop and agree the list before the first deal. Every family has its own, and half the arguments this game generates come from someone assuming the eight does what it did at their grandmother's table.

With no legal card in hand you take one from the stock. A drawn card that fits may go straight down; a drawn card that does not fit stays in your hand and the turn moves on. Some tables have you keep drawing until something playable turns up, which keeps hands moving but swells them alarmingly. When the stock is empty, lift the top card of the discard pile, shuffle everything under it and set it down as a fresh stock. If there is nothing underneath to shuffle, because every other card is in somebody's hand, the stock stays empty: a player with nothing to lay simply passes, and if the turn goes right round with nobody able to play, the hand is blocked and ends with no winner, each player counting what they hold if you are keeping score.

The announcements are what give the game its name. The word "Mau" goes with your second-to-last card and "Mau-Mau" with your last, spoken as the card lands. Forget either one and any opponent may call you on it before the next card is played, at which point you draw a penalty of two cards and, if you had been going out, carry on playing. Some tables charge a single card instead. A number of groups also refuse to let you go out on a seven or a jack, on the reasonable ground that a penalty or a suit call aimed at nobody is a poor way to finish a hand.

## Goal & scoring

A hand is won by the first player to empty their hand. Many families stop there, deal again, and never write anything down; the game is short enough that keeping score is optional.

Where a score is kept it is generated by the cards the losers are still holding, and the jack, the most useful card in the pack, is also much the most expensive one to be caught with. Two conventions are in circulation and they run in opposite directions. Under the first, the winner takes the combined total of everyone else's leftovers, and the session belongs to the first player past an agreed figure; 100 and 150 are both common choices. Under the second, every player books their own leftovers against themselves, the game stops the moment anyone passes the agreed figure, and the player with fewest points at that moment has won. Neither scheme alters what a card is worth. All that changes is who ends up owning the number.

A simplified set of values is nearly as common as the traditional one: jacks 20, aces, kings and queens 10 apiece, and everything else at face value. It is easier to remember and slightly flattens the difference between the court cards.

Once somebody crosses the line, play the deal in progress out to its end rather than stopping mid-hand. Should two players be past the figure when it finishes, the winner is whichever of them has more points if the winner has been collecting them, and whichever has fewer if players have been counting against themselves. If those two are exactly level, one more deal settles it.

| Scores     | Value | Notes |
|------------|-------|-------|
| Each jack  | 20    | —     |
| Each ace   | 11    | —     |
| Each 10    | 10    | —     |
| Each king  | 4     | —     |
| Each queen | 3     | —     |

|                |            |                                               |
|----------------|------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Each 9, 8 or 7 | face value | —                                             |
| Each 2 to 6    | face value | Only when playing with the full 52-card pack. |

## Variants

**Neunerln** — The Austrian and Bavarian form, whose name simply means "nines". A joker joins the 32-card pack and the nine, not the jack, is the wild card that lets you call a suit. Everything else runs much as usual, but moving the wild card to a rank with no other job changes the feel of a hand considerably: the jack becomes an ordinary card and there is one more wild in the deck than most players are used to.

**Tschau Sepp** — The Swiss version, played with Jass cards rather than French-suited ones and named after its two announcements: you call "Tschau" as you lay your second-to-last card and "Sepp" as you lay your last. The under, the Swiss equivalent of the jack, is the card that changes suit. It is one of the best-known card games in Switzerland and is often the first one children there learn.

**Sevens that do not stack** — The single most common point of disagreement. In the strict version a seven is simply a two-card penalty, and holding a seven of your own does not save you: you draw and the game moves on. Hands stay smaller and the seven becomes a card you play for tempo rather than a weapon to be saved. In the stacking version a run of three or four sevens can hand somebody six or eight cards at once and effectively end their chances for the deal.

**The house-rule layer** — The reason no two tables play the same game. Extra ranks pick up powers: a queen may reverse direction, a ten may let you play a second card, a specific card may force everyone but you to draw. Some groups let a card be laid out of turn if it exactly matches the rank showing, which turns the game into a scramble. None of it touches the underlying matching rule, and all of it should be settled before the cards go out rather than argued over mid-hand.

**Draw until you can play** — Instead of taking one card and passing, a stuck player keeps drawing from the stock until something playable appears, then plays it and ends their turn. Deals last longer, the stock is exhausted more often, and a player who has been unlucky twice in a row can end up holding a dozen cards. It rewards keeping a spread of suits in hand rather than hoarding a wild card.

## Background

Mau-Mau is the traditional German shedding game that the modern commercial matching-card games descend from. If you have played one of those you will recognise the shape of it within a turn or two, but this one needs nothing except an ordinary pack of cards. It appeared in Germany in

the years after the Second World War, was in print by the late 1950s, and has been a fixture of family card tables in German-speaking countries ever since, which is why almost every household plays it slightly differently.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, Gambiter, CardgamesHub, German Culture, Palace of Cards.

# Nertz

|                      |                                                                                         |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Nerts, Pounce, Racing Demon, Peanuts, Squeal                                            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                                               |
| <b>Deck</b>          | One standard 52-card deck per player, each with a different back design; jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                           |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                    |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                                |

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## Setup

Every player needs a full 52-card deck of their own with the jokers out, and the backs must be visibly different from one another. That is not a nicety: everybody's cards end up jumbled together in the middle of the table, and at the end of each round you sort them out again by back design in order to score. Matching packs make a round unscorable.

You also need a table everyone can reach across at once, which is the real limit on how many can play. Four is comfortable, six is crowded, and beyond that you want a partnership game or a bigger table.

Everyone shuffles their own deck and builds an identical layout in front of themselves, at the same time:

- Count thirteen cards face down into a pile on your right and turn the top one face up. This is your Nertz pile, and emptying it is the object of the game.
- Deal four cards face up in a row beside it. These are your work piles, one card deep to begin with.
- The remaining thirty-five cards are your stock. Keep them face down; most players hold them in one hand.

The centre of the table stays bare. Foundations are never dealt — they appear during play as aces are put out, and they belong to everybody.

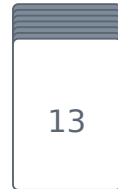
When every player says they are set, somebody counts down and the whole table starts on the same word. There is no dealer, no first player and no turn order at any point.



Stock



Work piles



Nertz pile

One player's side. Everyone builds this facing the centre, which starts bare: four foundation spaces are drawn, but in play every ace put out opens one of its own.

## Play

Nobody takes turns. Everybody plays simultaneously and at whatever speed they can sustain, and the round never pauses once it has started.

### THE CENTRE

An ace played into the middle starts a foundation, and it may come from anywhere: the face-up card of your Nertz pile, the top of a work pile, or the top of your waste. Foundations build upward in suit, ace through king, one card at a time, and any card you can legally place may likewise come off the top of a work pile, the top of your waste, or your Nertz pile.

There is no fixed number of foundations and no one-per-suit rule. Every ace that appears starts a foundation of its own, and since there is a whole deck per player, four separate spade foundations can be running side by side at different heights, each entirely independent of the others. That is why the centre sprawls, and why a 4 you cannot place now may have somewhere to go a moment later.

Foundations are common property — you play onto other people's aces exactly as freely as onto your own, which is where the whole contest lives. A foundation that reaches its king is finished, so turn it over or push it aside to keep the middle readable. Cards played to the centre never come back to anyone.

### YOUR OWN SIDE

The four work piles build downward in alternating colours, red on black and black on red, overlapped so that everything underneath the top card stays readable. You may shift the top card of a work pile, or a whole ordered run



off one, onto another work pile that continues the sequence. Clear a work pile out and the space is yours to fill with any single card or any run you like, taken from your other work piles, your stock or the top of your Nertz pile.

### THE NERTZ PILE

Only the face-up card on top is live. It can go to a foundation or onto a work pile, and the moment it leaves you turn the next card up. A Nertz pile that sits untouched is a Nertz pile you are not emptying, so the standard beginner's error is to play beautiful solitaire on the work piles and forget what the round is actually about.

### THE STOCK

Turn cards off the stock three at a time, face up, into a waste pile beside it. Only the top card of that waste is live, and it may go to a foundation or onto one of your work piles; play it and the card beneath it becomes the live one, and you may keep playing down into the waste as long as the cards keep going somewhere. When the stock runs out, pick the waste up, turn it face down without shuffling it, and go through it again as often as you like.

Be clear about what turning three does, because it is widely misunderstood: two cards in every three stay buried, and which ones they are is fixed by how many cards the pile holds. Cycle a stock you have taken nothing from and the identical cards come up again in the identical places, however many times you go round. Playing a single card off the waste is what shifts the count and re-groups everything behind it. So a fruitless pass is not bad luck to be ground out by cycling faster — it means the stock is closed to you until something else on your side frees a card you can take.

### THE ETIQUETTE THAT KEEPS IT HONEST

One hand only. You may switch hands but never use both at once. Move a single card at a time into the centre and let go of it before reaching for the next. Nobody touches anybody else's piles for any reason. Collisions in the middle are constant, and they settle themselves without adjudication: whichever of the two cards ended up underneath got there first, so that is the one that counts. Whoever played the loser simply retrieves it, restores it to the pile it left, and plays on. Nothing is forfeited and nobody owes anybody anything, which is the entire point of settling it by physical position rather than by argument.

### ENDING IT

The first player to empty their Nertz pile completely calls "Nertz", and everything stops on the word — hands off the cards mid-reach if necessary.

The call ends the round for everybody, whatever they were about to play.

A round can also end the other way, which most write-ups forget to mention. Occasionally every player gets stuck at once: each stock has been cycled right round with nothing coming loose, no work pile will accept anything, and no Nertz card fits. When everyone agrees there is no move left anywhere on the table, the round is finished with no Nertz called. Score it exactly as normal — cards in the middle still count, cards still in Nertz piles are still penalised — and nobody takes the call bonus.

## **Goal & scoring**

Two things pay. Emptying your Nertz pile ends the round and cuts everyone else off from scoring anything further, and every card you get into the middle scores while the round lasts. Those two aims pull against each other, which is the whole game.

When play stops, break the centre foundations apart and sort the cards by back design so that each player gets back exactly the cards they played. Count them: 1 point for each card of yours that reached the middle. Then count whatever is left in your Nertz pile and subtract 2 for each of those. A player who never got going can finish a round on minus twenty, and negative round scores are completely normal.

Most groups also give 10 points to the player who called Nertz, on top of their card count. It is not universal — plenty of tables play the bare arithmetic and nothing else — so settle it before the first round, because it decides how hard you should chase the call rather than quietly feeding foundations while somebody else races.

Rounds repeat until somebody passes an agreed target, 100 being the usual figure; if two players cross it in the same round, the higher total takes the match, and if they are level on that total, play one more round and settle it there. Between rounds each player reclaims their own deck and should count it, since a stray card with somebody else's back in your pile is the standard way the next round goes wrong.

The tension is worth stating plainly. A card played from your stock scores exactly the same as a card played off your Nertz pile, so pure point-scoring says play whatever is available. But only the Nertz pile ends the round, and whoever ends it decides how much time everybody else gets. Play wide and you score more per round while handing the timing to an opponent; go straight at the Nertz pile and you take the bonus and the clock, but you will have left cards unplayed that were worth a point each.

## Variants

**Partnership Nertz** — For an even number of players from four upwards, and the usual answer to a table too big for a free-for-all. Partners sit next to each other and share a score. Each player still keeps their own Nertz pile, work piles and stock, but you may play cards onto your partner's work piles, so a partner who is blocked can be unblocked from outside. Either partner emptying their Nertz pile ends the round and earns the call, and both partners' remaining Nertz cards are penalised against the shared total.

**Racing Demon and the other names** — The same game travels under several names, and they are not quite identical. Racing Demon is the British name and is usually treated as the older form; it is named after Demon, the Victorian patience whose thirteen-card reserve it lifts wholesale and hands to several players at once. Pounce is the American name, and Peanuts and Squeal are regional. Firm first-recorded dates for any of them are hard to stand behind, so take that ordering as the received account rather than as a documented one. The layout is the same everywhere: a pile of thirteen, four work piles, shared foundations from aces. What differs between them is scoring convention and small details like whether the stock turns one card or three.

**Shorter Nertz pile** — Deal ten or twelve cards to the Nertz pile instead of thirteen. Rounds finish noticeably sooner, which suits a crowded table where the centre fills fast anyway, and it takes some sting out of the penalty for a player who gets stuck. It is common enough in modern play that you should ask which size a new group uses rather than assuming thirteen.

**Adjusted scoring and targets** — Set the target to 50 for a quick session or 200 for a long one. Some groups score 2 points per card played to the centre instead of 1, which flattens the value of the Nertz bonus, and games with children often drop the minus 2 penalty entirely so that nobody finishes a round with a negative score. Turning the stock one card at a time rather than three is the other common softening, and it makes the game markedly easier for everybody at once.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Group Games 101, Gambiter, DKM Games, Game Rules Hub.

# Palace

|                      |                                                                                                |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Shithead, Karma, Shed, Castle, Idiot, China Hand, Bastard                                      |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                                                                      |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; 2 decks shuffled together for five or more players |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                                                  |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                           |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                                       |

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## Setup

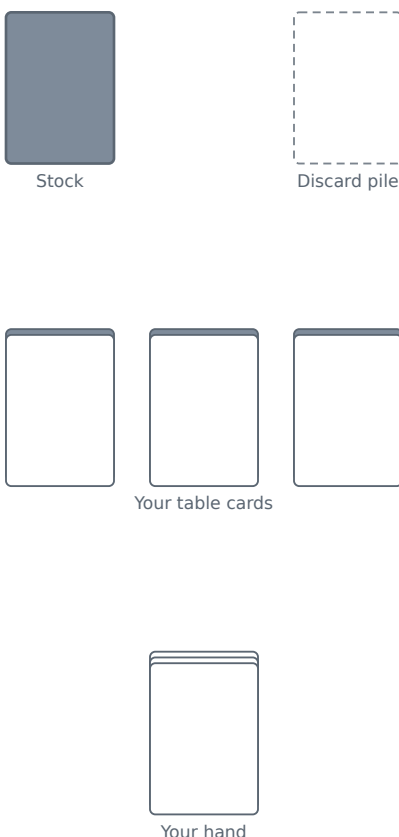
Remove the jokers. One pack comfortably serves two to four players. At five or more the stock runs dry almost immediately, so shuffle two packs together.

Cards rank in the ordinary ascending order with the ace on top: 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, jack, queen, king, ace. Only two ranks sit outside that ladder completely, the 2 and the 10, because either of them may be laid on any card whatsoever. The 7 keeps its normal place in the order, above the 6 and below the 8, but it puts a restriction on whoever plays next. All three of these ranks are explained under play.

Pick a dealer any way you like for the first hand; after that the loser of the previous hand deals. The dealer gives each player three cards face down in a row, and nobody may look at these. On top of those three, deal each player three more cards face up, so every player has three face-down cards with a face-up card covering each one. Then deal three cards to each player as a hand. That is nine cards per player. The rest goes face down in the middle as the stock.

A quicker way to reach the same layout, and the one most groups use: deal the three face-down cards, then deal six more cards to each player's hand. Look at your six, pick any three of them, and lay those three face up on your face-down cards. The other three stay in your hand. This lets you choose what sits on your table rather than taking whatever the deal gave you, and it is worth thinking about, since your face-up cards are what you will be stuck with in the endgame. Once the first card has been played, your face-up cards are locked and cannot be rearranged.

The player holding the lowest ordinary card in hand starts, and opens by playing that card. Ignore any 2, 7 or 10 when comparing, so in practice this comes down to whoever holds the lowest 3, 4 or 5. If two players hold the same lowest rank, the one sitting nearer the dealer's left starts. Groups that cannot be bothered to check simply let the player to the dealer's left open with anything. Play runs clockwise.



Every player gets the same nine cards: three face-down cards with a face-up card squared on top of each, plus a hand of three. The discard pile starts empty.

## Play

On your turn you play one card, or several cards of the same rank at once, from your hand onto the discard pile in the middle. Your card must be equal to or higher than the card showing on top of the pile. Equal is enough, so a nine covers a nine. If you play more than one card, they must all be the same rank as each other. After you play, and only while the stock still has cards in it, draw back up to three cards in hand. If you played three at once, draw three.

If you cannot play, you pick up the entire discard pile into your hand and your turn ends. You draw nothing that turn, and the middle of the table is now bare, so the next player may open with any card they like. Groups differ on whether you may also pick the pile up by choice while holding a legal play, usually to avoid surrendering a card you want to keep: some allow it freely, others rule that if you can play you must. Settle that one before the first deal. Either way this is the engine of the game: the pile grows, someone eventually swallows it whole, and they are suddenly holding fifteen cards while everybody else holds three.

Three ranks break the equal-or-higher rule.

The 2 resets. You may play a 2 on absolutely any card, and once it is down the pile counts as clear: the next player may play anything they like on top of it. Nothing leaves the table, though. Every card stays in the pile, so whoever ends up picking it up still collects the lot.

The 7 reverses direction of the requirement. You may play a 7 on any card of 7 or lower, and the player after you must then play a 7 or lower, not higher. A 2 or a 10 still gets you out of it, because those two can be played on anything.

The 10 burns. A 10 is legal on top of anything. Everything sitting in the middle, plus the 10 that just landed on it, leaves circulation for the rest of the hand: push the lot into a dead heap at the edge of the table, where it never rejoins the stock and can never be picked up by anyone. With the middle now empty, you top your hand back up to three and take another turn immediately, leading whatever card suits you.

Four of a kind does exactly what a 10 does. It makes no difference how the four got there — one player slapping all four down together, or three of a rank already showing and somebody adding the last one. The moment the top four cards of the pile share a rank, the pile is dead and joins the same heap as a burn, and the player who supplied that fourth card refills to three and leads again.

The hand runs through three stages. While the stock lasts you always refill to three cards, so you play out of your hand and the layout in front of you is untouched. Once the stock is empty you stop drawing and simply play your hand down. When your hand is empty, you start playing your three face-up cards, and you may play any of them, or two or three of the same rank together. Only when the face-up cards are also gone do you touch the face-down ones.

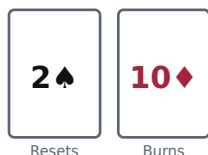
Face-down cards are played blind, one per turn. Pick one without looking, turn it straight onto the pile, and see what happens. If it legally covers the top card, it stays and play carries on. If it does not, you take it back along with the whole pile into your hand, and you are back to playing out of a hand until you empty it again. You may not look at a face-down card before committing to it, and you may not play two on the same turn.

If you pick up the pile at any stage you must clear your hand out again before returning to your table cards. The order is always hand, then face-up, then face-down.

Low to high



Play on anything



The ordinary ladder, ace on top; equal is enough to cover. The 2 and the 10 sit outside it and go on any card. The 7 keeps its place but forces the next player to play a 7 or lower.

## Goal & scoring

You are trying not to be last. A player is finished the moment their hand, their three face-up cards and their three face-down cards are all gone. The first player out is the winner, but the result everyone actually cares about is at the other end: play continues after the winner leaves until only one player still holds cards, and that player is the loser. The loser deals the next hand, and in most groups is on the receiving end of whatever name the group uses for the game.

There is no point scoring. Each hand stands on its own and you simply play as many as you feel like, though some groups keep a tally of how many times each person has finished last across an evening.

One finishing detail is worth agreeing in advance. If your last card is a 10, or completes four of a kind, you burn the pile and go out, but there is now nothing on the table for the next player to beat. Most groups treat you as out and let the next player lead anything. Others rule that you cannot go out on a burner and must pick the card back up, which makes the endgame considerably meaner.

## Variants

**Simple Palace (no sevens)** — The pared-down version published under the Palace name and the easiest one to teach. Only two ranks are special: the 2 resets the pile so the next player may play anything, and the 10 burns it out of the game. Sevens are ordinary cards with no power at all. Four of a kind still burns. Removing the seven takes out the one rule newcomers reliably forget, at the cost of the pressure that a forced low play creates.

**Extra special cards** — Groups pile more powers onto more ranks, and almost nobody plays exactly the same set. Common additions: the 3 is transparent or

glass, meaning it sits on the pile but the next player must beat whatever card is underneath it; the 8 is invisible in the same way, or else skips the next player entirely; the 9 forces the next play to be equal or lower, doing the job the 7 does elsewhere; and jokers, when left in the pack, either burn the pile or force the next player to pick it up. Decide the full list before dealing, because arguments about a single rank are how this game gets its rude names.

**Big-table version** — For five or six players, shuffle two packs together and deal four face-down cards, four face-up cards and a hand of four, refilling to four rather than three. The pile grows much faster with more players feeding it, so burns matter more and picking up is far more punishing. Duplicate cards make four of a kind noticeably easier to complete, which keeps hands from stalling.

**Open swapping** — Instead of locking your three face-up cards once play begins, you may swap a card between your hand and your face-up row at the start of any of your turns while the stock still holds cards. It softens the game considerably, because a bad opening layout can be repaired rather than suffered, and it gives you somewhere to park a 2 or a 10 for the endgame. Groups that use it usually limit you to one swap per turn.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Cats at Cards, Gambiter, Bar Games 101.



# President

|                      |                                                                                                             |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Scum, Asshole, Presidents and Assholes, Bum, Rich Man, Poor Man, Capitalism, Warlords and Scumbags, Daifugō |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-8 players (best with 5)                                                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers usually removed; add a second deck above about seven players             |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                                                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                                                                    |

---

## Setup

Use a full 52-card pack with the jokers taken out. Suits do nothing at all in this game; only rank matters. The order runs, from strongest down, 2, ace, king, queen, jack, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3. The two is the top card and the three is the bottom one, which catches out anyone expecting the usual ace-high order.

For the opening deal of a session, pick a dealer by drawing cards. Deal the entire pack out one card at a time, clockwise. Unless the player count divides into 52 evenly, some players end up with one card more than others, and that is simply accepted rather than corrected. Nobody has a stock or a discard pile of their own; everything is in hand.

The first hand of a session starts with the player to the dealer's left, since no social ranks exist yet. A common alternative is that whoever holds the three of clubs must lead it as the first play.

Every hand after the first begins with an exchange and, usually, a reshuffle of the seating. Once the ranks exist, players sit in order around the table: the President takes the best chair, the Vice-President sits to their left, then the Citizens, with the Vice-Scum and finally the Scum on the President's right. The Scum collects, shuffles and deals the cards for the next hand, which is part of the point of being the Scum.

Add a second pack once you get past about seven players so hands do not shrink to nothing.

## Play

Whoever is on lead sets the shape of the round: one card, or several of matching rank — a pair of fives, three jacks, four sevens. Suits are ignored, so a pair is just two cards of matching rank. Whatever the leader plays sets the size of that round.

Going clockwise, each player in turn must either pass or beat the play on the table. Beating it means matching the count exactly — same quantity as

the lead, all one rank between them, and that rank higher than what is showing on top. A single nine is beaten by a single ten or higher. A pair of nines can only be beaten by a higher pair, never by a single card and never by three of a kind. The size of the play cannot be changed part way through a round.

In the standard game passing is always allowed even when you could legally play, and passing does not shut you out. If the round comes back to you, you may play again. A great many groups play the stricter version in which a pass takes you out of the round for good, so agree on this before you deal; it makes a real difference to how you hold your twos.

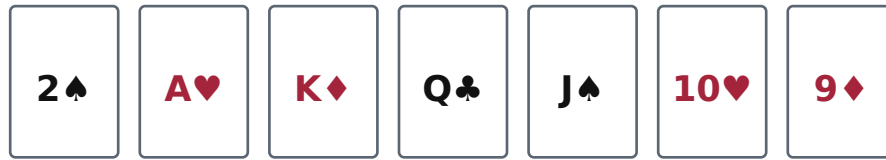
Play keeps circling the table for as long as somebody can top what is showing. The moment it runs the full way round without anyone beating the play on top, that play has taken the round. Those cards are finished with: flip the whole lot over, push it clear of the playing area, and it takes no further part in the hand. Whoever owned the winning play now opens the next round, free to lead a single, a pair or any larger set they fancy. If that same play happened to empty their hand, the opening passes clockwise to the nearest player who still has cards.

You are out as soon as you play your final card or cards, and you take the highest social rank still unclaimed. The first player out is the President, the second is the Vice-President, everybody in between is a Citizen or Neutral, the second-to-last is the Vice-Scum, and the very last player, left sitting with cards nobody wanted, is the Scum. Some groups stop the hand the moment the Scum is the only player left; others make them play their remaining cards out for the entertainment value. It makes no difference to the result.

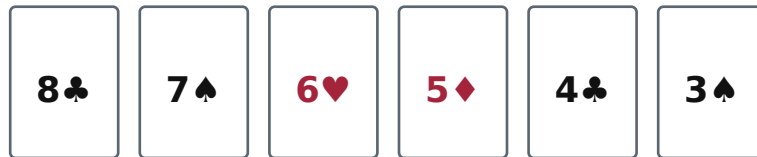
Before the next hand is played, the ranks pay out. Whoever finished as Scum must surrender their two strongest cards to the President, strongest by the actual rank order, with no quietly holding a two back. In return the President passes down two cards of their own choosing, in practice their two least useful; there is no rule against sending back exactly what just arrived, odd as that would look. One card each moves the same way between the Vice-Scum and the Vice-President. Anyone ranked Citizen neither gives nor receives. In a three-handed game the Vice tier does not exist, so only the President and the Scum swap, two cards each way. All of this is settled once the cards are dealt and before the first lead.

Once the exchange is settled, the President leads to the first round of the hand. Some groups instead give the opening lead to the Scum as a small consolation. Either convention works as long as everyone uses the same one.

High to low



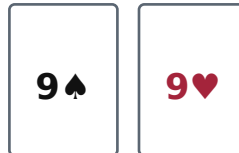
Strongest



Weakest

Rank order, with suits ignored completely. The 2 is the strongest card and the 3 the weakest, which catches out anyone expecting the usual ace-high order.

On the table



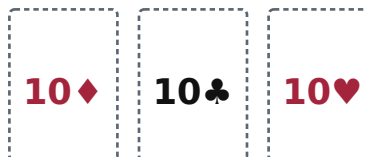
Beats it



Not a beat



Not a beat



To beat the play on the table you must match its size exactly, with cards all of one rank, all higher. The size of the play cannot change part way through a round.

## Goal & scoring

The immediate goal in each hand is to shed your cards before everyone else and come out as President. The longer-term goal is to stay at the top, because the card exchange means the President starts each new hand with better cards than they were dealt and the Scum starts with worse. Most

groups play with no written score at all: the game is about holding the President's chair, and it ends when people have had enough.

If you want a score, the usual method is to award 2 points for President, 1 for Vice-President, 0 for each Citizen, and nothing to the Vice-Scum, with the Scum sometimes charged -1. Play a fixed number of hands, or to a target such as 11 points, and the highest total wins. Playing an agreed number of hands rather than to a target is fairer, since the last few hands otherwise favour whoever is already President. Break a tie on points by counting who took the President's chair more often over the session, and if that is level too, play one more hand and let it settle the matter.

Two details worth settling early. A player who goes out on their last play still ranks ahead of anyone still holding cards regardless of how the rest of the round finishes. And if two hands in a row leave the same person as Scum, some groups apply an extra penalty such as a three-card exchange, while others leave it alone.

## Variants

**Passing locks you out** — Once you pass, you are finished for that round and cannot play again until the pile is cleared and a fresh lead is made. This is probably the more widely played version, particularly in North America, and it is closer to how the Chinese and Vietnamese climbing games in the same family work. It rewards patience: holding a two back becomes far more valuable when a single pass cannot be taken back, and a player who is running low on cards can be frozen out of a round with a well-timed high play.

**Bombs and revolution** — Four of a kind, played all at once, is a bomb. Depending on the group it either clears the pile immediately, letting the bomber lead again, or it turns the entire rank order upside down for the rest of the hand so that threes become the strongest card and twos the weakest. A second four of a kind restores the normal order. Some tables run a lighter version in which any single two, or a set of twos, clears the pile on its own without having to beat what is on the table.

**Completing the set clears the pile** — If your play makes four cards of the same rank sit on top of the pile, counting what previous players contributed rather than just your own cards, the pile is swept away at once and you lead the next round. Playing a pair of kings onto a pair of kings does it. This adds a lot of tactical bite, because it gives a low-ranked player a way to seize the lead without owning the highest cards, and it makes people think twice about splitting a set.

**Daifugō (Dai Hinmin)** — The Japanese game that President descends from, still widely played and considerably more developed. Jokers are included as wild cards. Playing an eight clears the pile immediately, the rule known as

eight-cut, and the player who did it leads again. Four of a kind triggers a revolution that reverses the rank order, and a second one reverses it back. Sequence runs of three or more cards in the same suit can be played as a unit in some versions. Several rules ban going out on a two, a joker or an eight, so a hand that ends on one of those forces the player to take the bottom rank instead of the top.

**Table rules and the party version** — The reason the game is more often called Asshole than President. The Scum shuffles, deals, clears the pile between rounds, and fetches drinks. The President may invent a rule that holds until they are dethroned, commonly something like a ban on using players' real names or on speaking out of turn. Breaking a rule costs a drink, and so does being caught with a card you should have played. None of this touches the underlying card game, but it is how most people actually encounter it.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Britannica, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, Cats at Cards, Gambiter, Denexa Games.

# Speed

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Slam                                       |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 2)                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 5-15 minutes                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                   |

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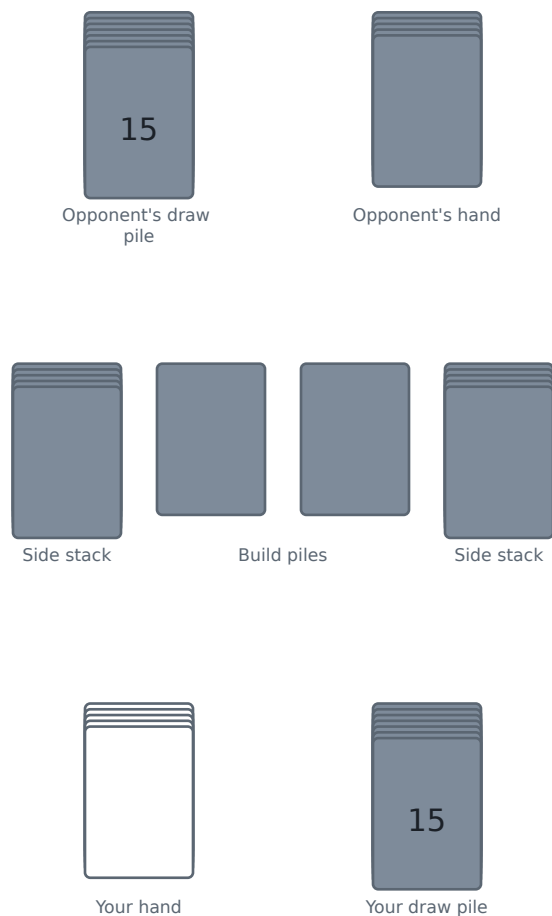
## Setup

The standard game is for two players and uses all 52 cards with the jokers taken out. Anyone may deal; over a match, either alternate the deal or let the loser of the previous round deal, since it confers no advantage. Shuffle and deal 20 cards to each player: 15 face down as a personal draw pile, and 5 more as a hand you pick up and look at. That accounts for 40 cards; the remaining 12 build the middle.

Lay the middle out as a single row between you, running left to right: a face-down stack of 5, a single face-down card, a second single face-down card, then another face-down stack of 5. The two single cards in the centre will become the build piles that everyone plays onto. The stacks of five on either end are the side stacks, held in reserve for when play jams.

Put your draw pile face down at your right hand, where you can reach it without looking, and pick up your five-card hand. The two side stacks sit at opposite ends of the row, and each player takes charge of exactly one of them; the usual convention is that you own the stack at your left-hand end, which means the two of you are using opposite ends. Settle this before you start so that nobody flips the same stack twice.

When both players say they are ready, each of you puts a hand on one of the two centre cards and you flip them face up together. The game starts the instant they land, so agree on a count first if you want it fair.



The middle is one row of four: side stack, the two single build cards, side stack. The build cards are flipped face up together to start, and each player owns the stack at their own left.

## Play

There are no turns. Both players play at the same time, as fast as they can manage, and the game runs continuously until someone goes out.

A card is legal on a centre pile if its rank is exactly one higher or one lower than the pile's current top card. Suits are ignored completely. Ranks wrap around at the ace: an ace plays on a king or on a 2, and a king or a 2 plays on an ace. The wrap does not let you skip, so a king can never go straight onto a 2. If the two centre piles show a 9 and a queen, the only cards you can put down are an 8 or a 10 on the first and a jack or a king on the second.

You play from your hand only, one card at a time, and your hand holds a maximum of five cards. Whenever you have fewer than five you may draw from your own 15-card draw pile to top back up. You can do this at any moment and as often as you like, so most players fall into a rhythm of play a card, draw a card. There is no obligation to draw immediately, but hoarding an empty slot only starves you of options. Once your draw pile is exhausted you simply play out whatever is left in your hand.

Because both players are reaching for the same two piles, collisions happen constantly. The standard convention is that the card underneath wins: whichever card physically landed first counts, and the other player picks their card back up and returns it to hand. Play one card at a time with one hand and do not stack several cards down at once.

When neither player can play anything, the game is stuck. Both players then take the top card of their own side stack and flip it face up onto the centre pile next to it, doing so at the same time. That gives two fresh top cards and play resumes instantly. Note that being stuck means neither player has a legal card in hand, not that either of you has run out of cards.

Work through the side stacks a card at a time as further jams occur. When both side stacks are empty and play jams again, gather the two centre piles, shuffle each one, set them face down as new side stacks, and turn one card from each into the middle to start two fresh build piles. Play then continues exactly as before. If by then the middle holds only two or three cards in total, just split them as evenly as you can and carry on; late in a round the middle is thin because most of the pack is sitting in the losing player's hand and draw pile.

Nothing here is compulsory. You may hold a playable card back if you can see a better use for it, and you need not top your hand up the instant a slot opens. The only hard constraints are that a card must fit the pile you put it on, that your hand stays inside its five-card limit, and that the side stacks come out only when both players are stuck.

A round ends the moment a player puts down the last card they have, meaning both hand and draw pile are empty. That player calls out *Speed*, or in some circles slams a hand down on a centre pile, and the round is over immediately. Anything still in the other player's hand is irrelevant; there is no consolation for being close.

One warning about names. In some regions this game is called *Spit* or *Slam*, but the game filed under *Spit* in this collection is a different one: there you have no hand at all, you play off the top of a row of five stock piles in front of you, and the round ends with the two players grabbing for the centre piles. If someone offers you a game of *Spit*, check which layout they mean before you deal.

## **Goal & scoring**

Be the first to get rid of all twenty of your cards. That is the whole win condition, and there is no point scoring in the basic game.

A single round takes one to two minutes, so *Speed* is nearly always played



as a match: best of three or best of five is the usual arrangement, and some players simply keep going until someone wants to stop and count round wins.

If you want a running score, the two simple methods are one point per round won, or a margin score where the winner of the round scores the number of cards the loser still had in hand and draw pile combined. The margin version rewards a decisive win over a photo finish and makes a comeback across several rounds possible, but it also means the deal has to be counted out carefully every time.

## Variants

**Jokers wild** — Leave both jokers in, giving 54 cards, and deal the extra pair into the draw piles. A joker can be played onto either centre pile at any time regardless of what is showing. The player who plays it announces the rank it stands for, and building continues up or down from that rank. Jokers are the standard escape hatch for a hand that has gone dead, and they cut down on how often play jams.

**Three or four players** — For three players, give each person their own side stack of five and put three single cards in the middle as build piles. That is 18 cards in the middle, so add the two jokers and the remaining 36 split evenly into hands of five plus draw piles of seven; play the jokers as wild, since ordinary jokers would just be two cards nobody can ever put down. For four, shuffle two decks together and use four centre piles with a side stack of five behind each, which leaves exactly 80 cards, or the standard five-card hand and fifteen-card draw pile each. More build piles keep the game from locking up, but they also make it very hard to watch every pile at once.

**Refill only when empty** — You may not top your hand up card by card. Instead you play until your hand is completely empty and only then draw five fresh cards. This slows the game down and puts a real cost on dumping playable cards carelessly, since you can strand yourself with one useless card and no way to replace it. It is a common way to level the field between a fast player and a slower one.

**No ace wrap** — Some households rank the cards strictly from 2 up to ace with no wrap-around, so an ace can only be played on a king and nothing can be played on an ace except a king. This makes aces near-dead cards and lengthens rounds considerably. Agree on it before dealing, because it is the single most common source of mid-game arguments in Speed.

**Spit** — The nearest relative, and in some places simply another name for this game, though the layout is quite different. Each player deals themselves a row of five stock piles holding one to five cards with the top card of each turned face up, keeps the remaining eleven cards as a face-down spit pile, and holds

no hand at all. The same build-up-or-down rule applies to two centre piles, but when you are stuck both players turn a spit card instead of a side-stack card, and the round ends with a scramble for the centre piles rather than a simple win. It is the harder of the two, because you can only ever play five specific cards.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Gambiter, Group Games 101, Learning Board Games, Gather Together Games, PlayingCardDecks.

# Spit

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Slam                                       |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2 players                                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-25 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                   |

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## Setup

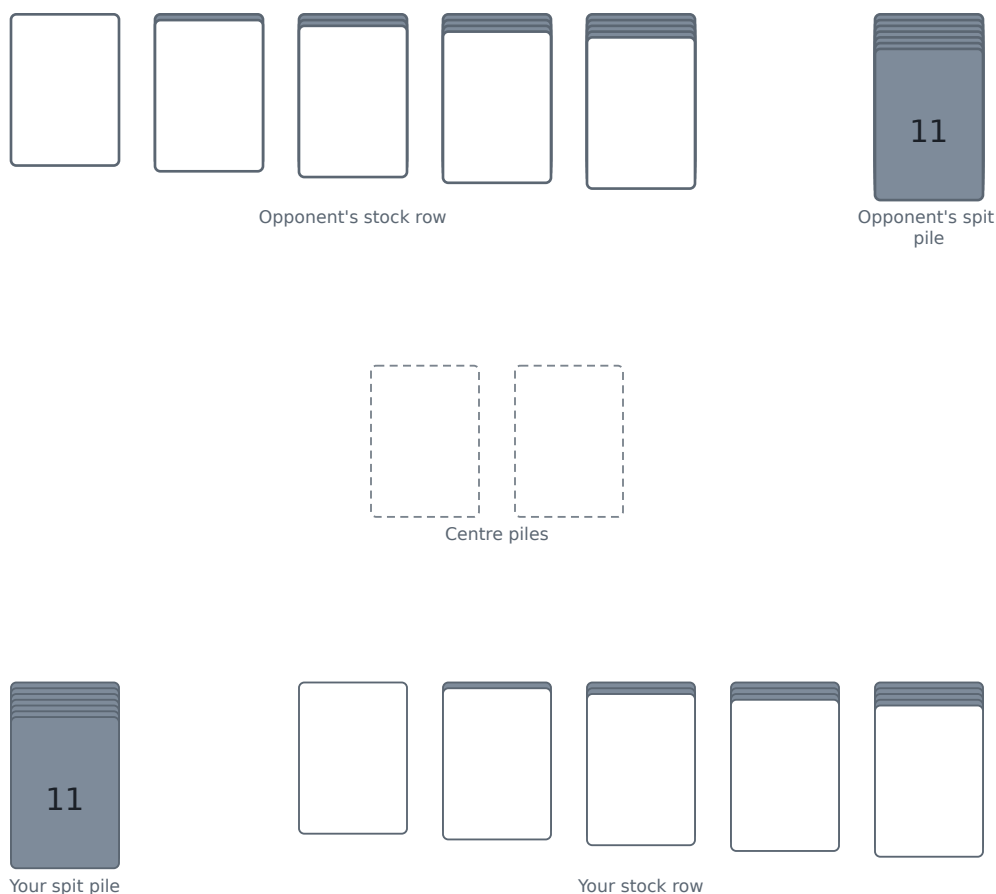
Spit is for exactly two players and uses a full 52-card deck with the jokers taken out. Shuffle and deal 26 cards to each player. From here you each build your own side of the table independently, and it is worth doing this at the same time so neither player gets a head start.

Out of your 26 cards, lay a row of five stock piles in front of you, face down, containing 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5 cards from left to right. That is 15 cards. Turn the top card of each of the five piles face up, so you have five face-up cards showing in a row.

The 11 cards you have not used stay squared up face down beside your row. These are your spit cards, your reserve. You are not allowed to look at them.

Leave a gap between the two rows, in the middle of the table, with room for two piles. Nothing goes there yet; the two centre piles are created by the first spit rather than dealt.

The layout mirrors on both sides of the table, so each player can see the other's five face-up cards throughout. That visibility is the point: you can watch what your opponent is about to need and take it first.



Each side is identical: five squared piles of 1 to 5 cards with only the top card face up, plus an 11-card spit pile. The two centre piles are empty until the first spit.

## Play

When both players say they are ready, you both call spit together and each of you turns the top card of your reserve face up into the middle, side by side. Those two cards start the two centre piles, and play begins the moment they land.

There are no turns and no waiting. Both players play simultaneously and as fast as they can. Both centre piles belong to both of you: either player may add to either pile at any moment, and the only thing that attaches a pile to a player is which one they spit onto. For a card to go down, its rank has to sit immediately beside the rank showing on that pile, one step up or one step down, and suits play no part whatsoever. The sequence closes into a loop at the ace, so an ace covers a king or a 2 and a king or a 2 covers an ace, but that join is the only shortcut and you can never jump from a 2 straight to a king. Concretely, on a pile showing a 6 you may place a 5 or a 7 and nothing else.

You may only play the face-up card on top of one of your five stock piles, never anything buried and never a card from the other end of your row that

happens to be visible. As soon as you move a face-up card, turn up whatever was underneath it so that pile is live again. Move one card at a time and use a single hand to do it; sliding two cards down together is not a legal play. When both players go for the same centre pile at the same instant, the card that landed first stands and the other player takes theirs back and returns it to the pile it came from.

Clearing a pile out of your row leaves a gap, and gaps can be filled. Take any one of the face-up cards elsewhere in your row, slide it across into the vacant spot, and expose whatever was hiding under it. The privilege covers that single card and nothing else: the pile it had been resting on stays put. Shuffling cards into gaps this way is your main tool for prising open a blocked row, and it pays even when you are not blocked at all, since five live cards to choose between beat four.

If the moment comes when neither player can play, you spit again. Both players simultaneously turn the top card of their reserve onto the centre pile on their own side, giving two fresh top cards, and play resumes at once. Either player may call for the spit, but it is only correct when both of you are genuinely stuck: if your opponent still has a legal card they simply play it and the call lapses. There is no gain in calling early, because a spit hands your opponent a fresh card at exactly the same moment it hands you one. Repeat this whenever play jams.

If your reserve is empty but your opponent still has spit cards, only they spit, so only one of the two centre piles gets a new top card and the other sits frozen until somebody can play on it.

Later rounds rarely start with 26 cards a side, so you lay out whatever you finished the last round holding. Build the row of one, two, three, four and five from the left as far as your cards reach, turn the top card of every pile you managed to complete, and keep any surplus as your spit pile. With 20 cards that is the full row and a reserve of five; with exactly 15 it is the full row and no reserve; with 12 it is piles of one, two, three and four cards, no fifth pile and no reserve at all. A player with no reserve cannot spit, so if that is already true when a round begins, only one centre pile is ever created, started by the other player, and both of you build on that single pile for the whole round.

Emptying your stock row ends the round, and everything stops the instant that final card lands. Priority over the two centre piles goes to whoever got out: put a hand on whichever of the two looks shorter, and the pile left over is your opponent's. A jammed round is settled on a different basis. Should both of you run out of legal plays with no reserve left to unstick things, the round dies where it stands; compare what each of you still has spread out,

and the smaller row picks first. Level counts give neither of you a claim, so you each simply take whichever centre pile sits on your own side of the table. None of this applies to a round fought over a single centre pile, since there is nothing to choose between: that pile goes to the player who did not go out, on top of everything still lying in front of them.

Each player then gathers everything they own: the centre pile they claimed, whatever is left in their stock piles, and any unused spit cards. Shuffle it all together and lay out a new row for the next round, and go again.

Spit is often confused with Speed, and they are close cousins, but the layouts are different. Spit gives each player five stock piles laid in a row, every one showing its top card, and no hand to hold; in Speed each player holds a hand of five cards drawn from a single face-down draw pile, and the reserve cards sit in the middle as side stacks rather than in front of each player.

## Goal & scoring

The aim is to shed all your cards, and there is no point scoring anywhere in the game. Rounds are just a mechanism for moving cards from the player who is losing to the player who is winning.

Winning a round matters because it lets you take the smaller centre pile, so your next layout is smaller than your opponent's. Shrink it far enough and you reach fifteen cards or fewer, at which point your entire holding goes into the stock row and you have no spit pile at all; below fifteen you cannot even fill all five piles.

That is how the game actually ends. Once you have no reserve, clearing your stock row leaves you with nothing at all in front of you and nothing to pick up, so you have run out of cards and you win outright. Your opponent, meanwhile, is stuck with a full spread and rounds that get harder every time.

If you would rather not play to a finish, agree on a fixed number of rounds and give the game to whoever holds fewer cards at the end, or simply count round wins.

## Variants

**Free-for-all slap** — Instead of giving the player who went out first choice of centre pile, both players race for them the moment the round ends. Whoever gets a hand on a pile first takes it, so a player who lost the round can still grab the smaller pile with a fast reaction. This adds a second reflex contest to every round and rewards keeping half an eye on how tall each centre pile is getting

while you play.

**Speed** — The closest relative, sometimes sold under the same name. Each player gets a hand of five cards and a face-down draw pile of 15, the two build piles sit in the middle with a five-card side stack beyond each of them, and you refill your hand from your draw pile as you play. There is no stock row and no slapping for piles: the first player to empty hand and draw pile simply wins the round.

**Nertz** — The multiplayer descendant, also called Pounce or Racing Demon. Each player uses their own full deck with a distinguishable back, lays out a solitaire-style tableau plus a 13-card Nertz pile, and everyone races to build shared foundation piles in the centre starting with aces. The real-time free-for-all feel is the same, but it supports four to eight players and adds a genuine scoring system based on cards played and cards left in your Nertz pile.

**No moving into empty spaces** — Once a stock pile is cleared, the space stays empty for the rest of the round rather than being refilled from your other piles. This makes rounds shorter and considerably more prone to deadlock, so it works best combined with a generous house rule on spitting. Many people learn Spit this way and are surprised to find that shifting a card into a gap is standard.

**Three or more players** — Spit proper is strictly a two-player game, so treat this as a house extension rather than a rule anyone codified. Shuffle two decks together and give each player a stock row and a reserve, with one centre pile per player created by a simultaneous spit. Everyone can play onto every centre pile. It is chaotic and the table gets crowded, so many groups shorten the stock rows to four piles per player to keep every pile within arm's reach. If you want a real multiplayer game of this shape, play Nertz instead.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Gamerules.com, Card Game Wiki, Game On Family.

# Tien Len

|                      |                                                              |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Tiến Lân, Thirteen, Vietnamese Cards, VC, Killer 13, Advance |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 4)                                    |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed                   |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                                                |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                       |
| <b>Category</b>      | Shedding                                                     |

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## Setup

An ordinary 52-card pack with the jokers out. Choose a first dealer any way you like; the deal then moves one seat along in the direction of play at the end of each hand. Thirteen cards go to each player, dealt one at a time in the direction of play, and thirteen is the hand size whatever the player count: at two or three players the leftover cards are set face down to one side and take no part in the game.

The rank order runs 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, jack, queen, king, ace, 2, so the two is the strongest rank and the three the weakest. Suits are ranked too, and unlike most Western games the ranking is used constantly: hearts are highest, then diamonds, then clubs, with spades lowest. Put the two together and every card has its own rung on one long ladder, from the three of spades at the bottom to the two of hearts at the very top. That top card is the reason the game needs bombs, since nothing in the ordinary run of play can touch it.

Whoever was dealt the three of spades leads the first hand of a session, that card being the lowest in the pack. Many groups require the opening play to actually contain it; others let that player lead whatever they please. At two or three players the three of spades is often among the cards set aside, and the lead then belongs to whoever holds the lowest card that was dealt, by rank first and by suit between cards of equal rank. Later hands are opened by whoever won the previous one, though some tables hand the lead to the player who came last instead, as a small mercy.

## Play

A play is one of six shapes, and only these:

- A single card.
- A pair, two cards of the same rank.
- A triple, three of the same rank.
- A four of a kind.
- A run of three or more cards in consecutive ranks, suits freely mixed.



- A chain, three or more consecutive pairs, such as 6-6-7-7-8-8.

Runs and chains climb from the three up to the ace and stop there. Twos sit outside sequences altogether in the standard game, and nothing wraps around the ends, so A-2-3 is not a run and neither is Q-K-A-2.

Going round the table, each player either passes or beats what is showing. A beat must be the same shape and, for runs and chains, the same length. Comparison is by the highest card in the play, and when two plays have the same top rank the suit of that top card decides. Two runs of four therefore settle on their fourth card and, if that is a nine in both, on which nine is the better suit. Vietnamese players usually pass the turn counter-clockwise; the direction changes nothing so long as everyone agrees on it before the first lead.

Passing puts you out of the round. You take no further part until the round is finished, however tempting the play that comes round afterwards. When everyone still in has passed, the last player to have put cards down clears the pile away and leads again with any shape they like.

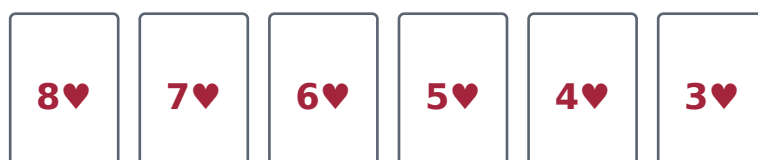
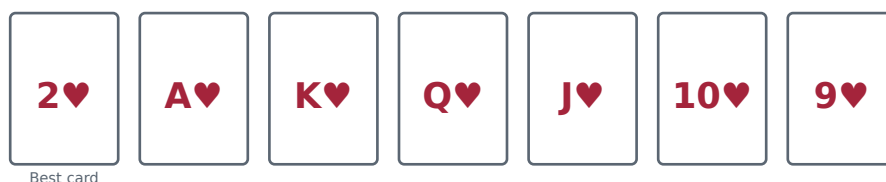
Bombs, or chops. Since the two of hearts cannot be beaten by any ordinary single, the game supplies plays that break the shape-matching rule specifically to kill twos. Outside that job they are ordinary combinations: a four of a kind may be led like any other shape, and a chain of pairs the same. It is only as an answer to a two that either ignores the shape it is beating.

- A four of a kind, or a chain of three consecutive pairs, beats any single two. Neither can be dropped on any other single card.
- Between those two, the four of a kind is the stronger, so it also beats a chain of three consecutive pairs.
- A chop that has been played can itself be chopped by a stronger one, four of a kind over four of a kind, ranked by the quad itself, and a four of a kind over a chain of three pairs. Whoever lays the chop that nobody answers takes the round in the ordinary way and leads next.
- More twos demand more, and this is where tables differ most. The usual line is that a pair of twos falls only to a chain of four consecutive pairs, and three twos only to a chain of five. A common alternative sets the price of a pair of twos at five consecutive pairs; a few tables also accept two fours of a kind in consecutive ranks. Fix the schedule before dealing, because a player holding four sevens has already made plans around it.

The first player to run out of cards has won, and the rest carry on playing to sort out the remaining places, right down to the player who is left holding

cards when everyone else is clear. A player who has gone out is skipped in the rotation, and if they were the one who won the last round, the lead passes on to the next player still holding cards.

Ranks, high to low



Suits, high to low

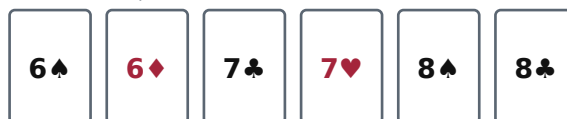


The 2 is the strongest rank, above the ace, and suits are ranked as well: hearts, diamonds, clubs, spades. The 3♠ is the lowest card in the pack and the 2♥ the highest.

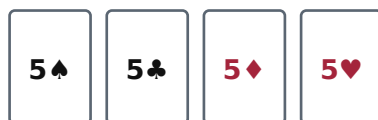
Run of three



Chain of three pairs



Four of a kind



Not a run



Runs may mix suits, stop at the ace and never wrap round. The middle two rows are the chops that answer a single 2; neither may be played on any other single card.

## Goal & scoring

Shedding all thirteen cards first wins the hand outright. Everything after that is about placing, because Tien Len keeps no running score of its own: what people actually record is the order of finish, and in most circles a settlement based on how much you were still holding when the hand ended.

The common measure is one unit for every card left in hand, paid by each player to the one who went out first. Since the last player standing is often sitting on twos and broken runs they never found a use for, the difference between second and last can be large even though neither of them won anything.

Plenty of tables ignore units altogether and keep no score whatever, playing hand after hand purely for the order of finish and treating coming last twice running as its own punishment. If you do want a session result, agree a number of deals in advance and count first-place finishes, which suits the game better than a target score does; a target rewards whoever gets a hot deal late.

A hand claimed by an instant win, where the rules allow them, normally pays a fixed premium to the holder rather than being counted card by card, on the grounds that nobody had a chance to play at all.

## Variants

**Instant wins** — Certain dealt hands are shown immediately and take the hand before a card is played. The usual list is all four twos, six pairs among the thirteen cards, and a dragon: a run of all twelve ranks from the three up to the ace. Groups that use dragons often rule that only a dragon with a higher-suited ace can answer one, which makes a dragon topped by the ace of hearts unbeatable. Far from universal, so check before you fan your cards out in triumph.

**Twos at the top of a run** — Some southern Vietnamese tables let a two cap a sequence, so J-Q-K-A-2 becomes a legal run and the two counts as the highest card in it. A two still may not sit at the bottom, since the three is low. Northern practice is stricter and keeps twos out of sequences entirely, which is also the more widely published rule. Allowing it noticeably weakens the bomb rules, because twos become easier to shed and less often need chopping.

**Chopping out of turn** — Many groups let a bomb be dropped the moment a two is played rather than waiting for the player's proper turn, with the rotation then resuming from whoever chopped. It makes leading a two a considerably more nervous act and speeds the hand up. Tables that require bombs to be played in turn get a slower, more positional game in which the order of seats matters a great deal.

**Penalties for what you never played** — An extra charge on top of the count of cards left, aimed at players who hoarded. Twos still in hand at the end are the usual target, at a couple of units each with red twos sometimes charged double, and an unplayed four of a kind or chain of pairs is charged more heavily still. Some tables also fine anyone who failed to put down a single card during the whole hand. The schedules vary wildly from group to group and are worth writing down before the first deal.

**Two- and three-handed play** — Thirteen cards each and the remainder set aside unseen, exactly as at four players. It works, but a large block of unknown cards means the counting that makes the four-handed game rewarding barely functions, and bombs turn up far less predictably. The two-handed game in particular becomes a contest of who can force the other to break up a run first.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Gambiter, Cool Old Games, Cats at Cards, Game Rules, CardRules+, Play Party Game, Everything2, Great Group Games.

## MATCHING & COLLECTING

# Beggar-My-Neighbour

|                      |                                                                                           |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Beggar My Neighbor, Strip Jack Naked, Beat Your Neighbour Out of Doors, Draw the Well Dry |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 2)                                                                 |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed                                                |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-45 minutes                                                                             |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                                    |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                                                     |

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## Setup

One 52-card pack with the jokers taken out, two players for the standard game, and a clear patch of table between them. Shuffle and hand the pack round singly until none is left, which comes to twenty-six apiece. No card is looked at by anybody at any stage, including its owner. Square your half into a face-down stack and keep it squared.

Only four ranks do anything at all. Everything from the 2 up to the 10 is an ordinary card: inert, interchangeable, no different in play from any other. The jack, queen, king and ace are the exceptions, and the game calls them pay cards because turning one puts the other player in debt. Beyond that distinction nothing about a card matters — no card beats another, sequence never comes into it, and suits are ignored from the first turn to the last.

Whoever shuffles deals, and the non-dealer turns the very first card of the game. Fix that between you before you shuffle rather than after, because although neither player will make a single choice all game, who starts is one of the two things — the shuffle being the other — that decides the whole result. Leave the middle clear: a single face-up pile grows there and changes hands over and over until somebody is cleaned out.

With three or four players, deal the pack round as evenly as it will go and set aside nothing — an odd card or two makes no difference to a game with no scoring in it.

## Play

Turn the top card of your stack face up into the middle and leave it there. Your opponent lays their next card on top of it, then you again, and so on. As long as only ordinary cards appear, that is the whole game: two people alternately feeding one growing pile.

A pay card interrupts it. Whoever turns one is owed cards by the other player, and the rank of the card sets the size of the debt, running from a

single card for a jack up to four for an ace.

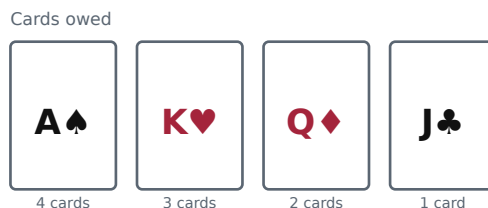
The player in debt then turns cards one at a time onto the same pile, counting them out, and one of two things happens.

- Nothing but ordinary cards comes out. The debt is discharged, and the pile belongs to the player whose pay card went unanswered. They gather up every card of it, slide the lot face down beneath their own stack, and open a fresh pile with their next card.
- A pay card comes out. Payment halts on the spot, whatever was still owed is written off, and the obligation rebounds: the other player now owes for the card just turned. Three and four rebounds in a row are ordinary, and the pile can grow enormous before anybody collects it.

Cards you win go under your stack in the order you scooped them up. The traditional game involves no shuffling whatever after the deal, which is worth knowing because it is the reason a game can run as long as it sometimes does.

Running out of cards mid-payment is the one edge case worth settling in advance. The usual reading is that you are beaten at the moment you are required to turn a card and have none. A debt is therefore paid as far as it will go: owe four, hold two, and you turn both of them, and only when the third is demanded and there is nothing to turn are you out. Play your last card as an ordinary one and you have lost; but if your last card happens to be a pay card, you are still alive, because your opponent now owes you and may fail to answer, in which case the whole pile comes across and you carry on with it. Plenty of households simplify and call a player out as soon as their stack empties.

With more than two players, the debt always falls on the next player round the table, and it keeps moving in that direction as it rebounds; a player already knocked out is skipped over. Anyone whose cards run out drops out and the rest continue, and the pile still goes to whoever played the last pay card nobody could answer — that player then opens the next pile. The last player left with cards has all fifty-two and has won.



What each pay card costs the next player. These four ranks are the only ones that do anything; suits are irrelevant and the 2 through 10 are inert.

## Goal & scoring

You win by ending up with all fifty-two cards, which happens the instant your opponent is asked to turn a card and cannot produce one. Nothing is scored, nothing is written down, and no pile is worth more than any other.

It is worth being blunt about what this game is. There are no decisions in it anywhere. You never pick which card to play, because the card you play is whichever one the shuffle left on top of your stack; you never pick whether to pay, because paying is compulsory; and since won cards go back in a fixed order and are never shuffled, everything that will happen is fixed by the deal. Two children could in principle hand the pack to an adult, be told who wins, and skip the game entirely. For a five-year-old that is precisely the appeal — all of the suspense with nothing to learn — and for anybody older it is why the novelty lasts about twenty minutes.

The same determinism makes the length wildly unpredictable, and it turned the game into a genuine mathematical curiosity. Think of the two stacks together as a single state of fifty-two cards. Every turn maps one state to exactly one next state, so if a deal ever arrives back at a state it has occupied before, it is trapped: the stretch between the two visits must now repeat, unaltered, without end. Whether any deal actually does this went unanswered for decades, and John Conway used to pose it as an anti-Hilbert problem, a question of no importance at all that nobody could crack. Searches turned up longer and longer finite games, the record standing at well over a thousand pile-collections and several thousand card turns, until a non-terminating deal was finally published in 2024.

If you want a game that certainly ends, cap it before you start: play for a fixed ten or fifteen minutes and give it to whoever holds more cards, or agree that the first player reduced below some number has lost. Counting is quick, because the two stacks always add up to fifty-two.

## Variants

**Jokers in** — Leave both jokers in the pack and rank them above the ace as pay cards worth five. Fifty-four cards deal out at twenty-seven apiece with nothing left over, and a joker turned mid-payment is the most brutal rebound in the game, since the opponent has to find five cards and any one of them can bounce it straight back. It makes the pile swing more violently without adding a single decision.

**Slapping** — Add a reflex layer: when two cards of the same rank land on top of one another, the first player to slap the pile takes it, regardless of who owes what and regardless of any payment in progress. This is the doorway to the noisier games in the same family — Slapjack and Egyptian Ratscrew both grew

out of this idea — and it is the cheapest way to give Beggar-My-Neighbour something a player can actually be good at.

**Shuffling your winnings** — When you collect a pile, shuffle it before putting it under your stack instead of returning it in order. This is a house fix rather than the traditional rule, and it changes the character of the game: no deal can then cycle forever, because the order is randomised every time cards change hands, so the game ends with certainty. The price is that it destroys the mathematical curiosity that makes the game interesting to anybody over ten.

**Paying from a hand** — A rare version in which players hold their cards as a hand they can see and choose which cards to hand over when a debt falls due, rather than paying blind off the top of a stack. It supplies the only decisions the game can have — you hold your own pay cards back for when they will rebound most usefully — at the cost of the thing that makes the ordinary game usable by children who cannot yet fan a hand.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Gamerules.com, Official Game Rules, Denexa Games, Dummies, Casella and others, A Non-Terminating Game of Beggar-My-Neighbor.



# Casino

|                      |                            |
|----------------------|----------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Cassino                    |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 2)  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-40 minutes              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting      |

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## Setup

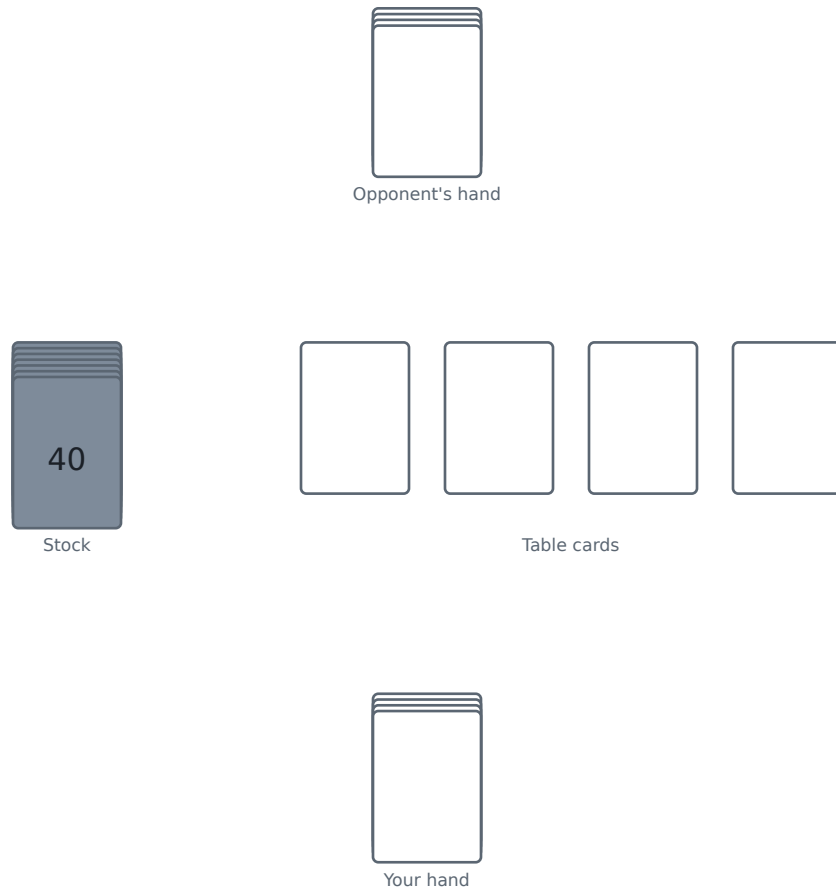
Two to four players and one standard 52-card deck. Despite the name, nothing is bet and nobody banks: this is a fishing game, where you catch cards off the table with cards from your hand. It plays best head to head. With four, partners sit opposite each other and pool their captures; with three, everyone plays alone.

Pick a first dealer however you like — low card on a cut is the usual method — and pass the deal to the left after each round.

Deal in twos. Two cards to each player, then two face up to the middle, then two more to each player and two more face up. Everyone ends up holding four cards, with four lying face up in the centre. Put the rest of the deck face down beside the dealer. It is used to top hands up later; no further cards are ever added to the table.

Card values in play: an ace is 1 and numeral cards are worth their pips, which includes the two of spades counting 2 and the ten of diamonds counting 10, regardless of what they are worth at scoring time. Jacks, queens and kings have no numeric value and never take part in any addition.

Each player (or partnership) keeps captured cards in a face-down pile, out of play until the round is scored. The player to the dealer's left starts.



The two-player deal, made in twos: four cards to each player and four face up in the centre. No further cards are ever added to the table.

## Play

A turn is a single card, laid face up, and it has to do one of three things: capture, build, or trail. Then play passes to the left. Never more than one card, never fewer.

**Capturing.** Put your card down and take the table cards it wins, adding them and it to your capture pile.

- By rank: any table card matching what you just laid down. A numeral card takes every match at once, so a 7 collects both 7s if two are showing. A face card takes only one matching face card per turn, even when two or three of its rank are sitting there.
- By sum: any group of numeral table cards whose values add up to your card. A 9 can lift a 4 and a 5, or an ace, a 3 and a 5. Face cards can never be part of a sum.
- Several at once: a single card may take a matching rank, one or more separate summing groups, and any build worth that number, all in the same turn. A 9 could take a loose 9, a 6 with a 3, and a build of nine together.

You are never obliged to take everything on offer. Take whichever legal captures you want.

**Building.** Lay a card onto one or more table cards, push the lot together into a pile, and announce what it is now worth: "building eight." You must keep a card in hand capable of capturing that number, and you may not build using only cards already on the table.

A single build is one combination adding to the announced number, such as a 3 and a 5 built to eight. Any player holding the right card may capture it, and a single build may be raised by adding one card from hand — laying an ace on a build of eight and announcing nine takes it over, so long as whoever announces nine holds a nine. Raising an opponent's build is legal everywhere. Raising your own is allowed here too — you may add to a build you already own, so long as you still hold a card matching the new number — but some rule sets bar it outright, Royal Casino among them, so settle which you are playing before the first deal.

A multiple build is two or more separate groups worth the same number stacked together, for example an 8 from hand laid on a 5-and-3 build, still worth eight. Once a build is multiple its value is fixed; nobody may raise it, and only a card of that number takes it. Court cards can never go into a build.

You may not trail while a build stands on the table to which you played the most recent card. On such a turn you must capture, add to a build, or start another build — and one of those is always open to you, because the card that made your build legal in the first place is the card that captures it. Once an opponent has added to that build the restriction becomes theirs and not yours.

**Trailing.** When you cannot capture or build, or simply prefer not to, lay a card face up on the table by itself. It becomes a loose card that anyone may take. Trailing is legal even when a capture was there for the taking; the build rule above is the only thing that ever forces your hand.

**Sweeps.** A capture that clears the table completely is a sweep. Turn one card in your capture pile face up to record it. The player after a sweep faces an empty table and can only trail.

**Refilling and the last trick.** Once every hand is empty, four fresh cards go to each player out of the stock, two at a time, with nothing added to the middle. Play carries on the same way. The dealer is obliged to call "last" aloud as the final round goes out, and it is not a formality: play changes once there is nothing more to come. After the very last card is played, whoever made the most recent capture sweeps up whatever is still lying on

the table — but that is not counted as a sweep. A real sweep made with the final card of the deal does count.

## Goal & scoring

Casino is usually played to 21 points across several rounds. Eleven is the common short target, and some groups simply play one round for the points on offer and call it a game.

At the end of each round, sort your captured cards and score:

- 3 points for taking the most cards. A tie scores nobody: 26 apiece head to head, or any tie for the lead when three or four play separately.
- 1 point for taking the most spades. Thirteen is odd, so two sides can never tie it; three or four playing separately can, and then nobody scores it either.
- 2 points for big casino, the ten of diamonds.
- 1 point for little casino, the two of spades.
- 1 point for each ace, four in total.
- 1 point for each sweep.

That is 11 fixed points a round, plus however many sweeps were made.

If two players pass the target in the same round, the plain answer is that the higher total wins, and a dead tie means another round. Groups who would rather see the finish decided item by item count them in a fixed order instead — most cards, most spades, big casino, little casino, then the aces of spades, clubs, hearts and diamonds, and the sweeps last of all — and whoever reaches the target first in that sequence takes the game. If the aces have not settled it, the greater number of sweeps does; if those are level too, play a further round.

| Scores             | Value | Notes                                                    |
|--------------------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Most cards         | 3     | a tie scores nobody                                      |
| Most spades        | 1     | two sides cannot tie it; three or four playing alone can |
| Big casino (10♦)   | 2     | —                                                        |
| Little casino (2♠) | 1     | —                                                        |
| Each ace           | 1     | four in total                                            |
| Each sweep         | 1     | —                                                        |

## Variants

**Royal Casino** — Court cards get numeric values and join the arithmetic: jack 11, queen 12, king 13. They can be built, captured by sums, and used to capture combinations, which makes builds far more flexible. The ace is usually

worth 1 or 14 at the discretion of whoever plays it. Everything else follows the standard game.

**Spade Casino** — The spade suit carries the scoring instead of a single point for holding most of it. Each spade you capture is worth a point on its own, the jack of spades scores an extra one, and the rest of the values are unchanged. Game is 61 and is normally pegged on a cribbage board as the points come in, since the totals move so much faster.

**Draw Casino** — A two-handed game in which the undealt cards stay as a face-down stock and you draw one after every play to keep your hand at four, so there are no separate deals and no announced last round. Once the stock is empty the hands in play are simply played out with no further draws, and as in the standard game whoever made the last capture takes any cards still lying on the table, without it counting as a sweep. It removes most of the counting advantage of the standard game, since you cannot track how many rounds remain.

**Partnership Casino** — The standard four-handed form: two teams of two, partners facing each other across the table, captures thrown into one shared pile and scored as a unit. A build made by one partner may be captured by the other, so builds become a way of passing information and setting your partner up rather than a private plan.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Britannica, Hoyle's Rules of Games, Denexa Games, GameRules.com.

# Concentration

|                      |                                                                |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Memory, Pelmanism, Pairs, Match Match, Pexeso, Shinkei-suijaku |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 3)                                      |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards)                                     |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-20 minutes                                                  |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                         |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                          |

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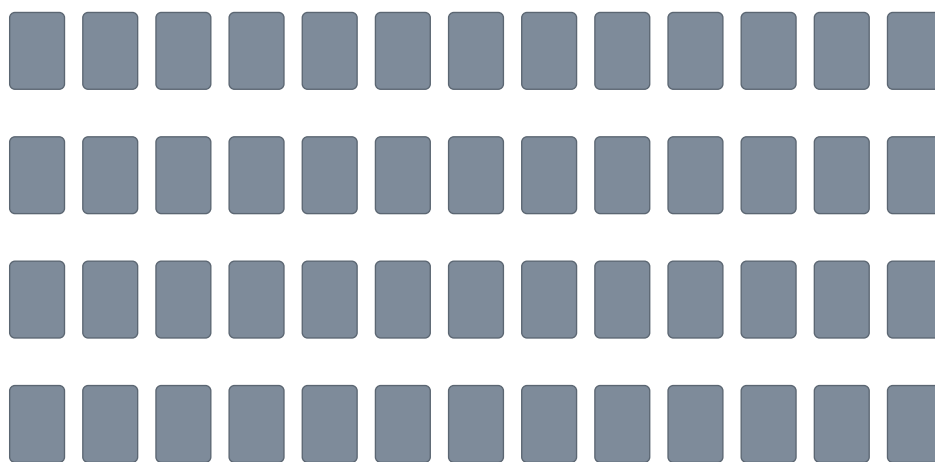
## Setup

Two or more can play and three or four is the sweet spot; beyond that the wait between turns gets long for the young players the game is usually aimed at. What you really need is a large flat surface, because the layout is the game and a cramped one ruins it.

Shuffle a full 52-card pack thoroughly, then lay every card face down in four rows of thirteen. Leave a small gap on all sides of each card so that no card overlaps another and so that a card can be turned up and set back down in precisely the square it came from. A tidy grid is not decoration: everybody at the table is memorising positions, and a layout that drifts as it is played robs whoever has been paying the closest attention.

Settle what counts as a match before the first card is turned, because traditions genuinely differ here. This entry assumes rank alone, so any two sixes go together and suits are ignored. The stricter form requires rank and colour to agree, which gives every card exactly one partner in the pack.

For small children, lay a smaller grid instead: keep the twos through the sevens and put the other seven ranks aside, which leaves 24 cards for four rows of six. Choose a starting player however you like, and play moves to the left.



Every card lies face down and separate from its neighbours, and an unmatched card goes back into exactly the square it

came out of.

## Play

On your turn, pick two cards from the layout and turn them face up where they lie, one after the other. Turn them so the whole table sees them rather than shielding them toward yourself; hiding a card you have exposed is the one thing that genuinely breaks the game, because everyone is entitled to the information a turn produces.

If the two cards match, take them, stack them in front of you, and turn two more. A run continues as long as you keep matching, and a player with a good memory routinely clears six or eight cards on one turn once the layout has been picked over a few times.

If they do not match, leave them face up long enough for everyone to have actually looked, then turn both back down without shifting them a hair from where they sat. The turn then passes to the left. The gaps left by cards that have been won stay open for the rest of the game: never close the layout up or slide the survivors together to tidy it, since the empty squares are part of what everyone is memorising. Watch for a grid that is being squared up, nudged or slid, whether or not anyone means anything by it, because a card's position is worth exactly as much as its rank.

Picking the first of your two cards is where the game is won. When you already know where the partner of some face-down card is, turn that known card first and go straight to its partner. When you know nothing useful, turn a card you have never seen before, learn what it is, and only then choose your second card from among the ones you already know. Turning two complete unknowns is right for the opening couple of turns and essentially never again, because a wasted turn spent looking at two cards you cannot use is a turn spent handing information to the player after you.

Play carries on round the table until the last card has been taken. Nobody can ever be stuck: any two face-down cards make a legal turn.

## Goal & scoring

You are collecting pairs, and the player holding the most when the layout is empty wins. Matching by rank alone, a full pack yields 26 pairs, so two players can genuinely tie at thirteen each; replay the deal or share the win, whichever the table prefers.

Count pairs rather than cards, and count at the end rather than as you go, so that nobody spends a turn totting up other people's stacks. Any of the usual session shapes fit: play three deals and add the totals, or set a target such as forty pairs and play as many deals as it takes to get there.



Once the cards are down, very little about the result is luck. The shuffle decides which blind turn happens to strike a pair, and that is the whole of it: every card is on the table and every card turned up is public, so the player who watches other people's turns as attentively as their own beats the one who only concentrates when it is their go. That is the reason this game gets handed to children so often. It rewards a single habit, and it rewards it immediately.

## Variants

**Rank and colour** — A match must agree in rank and in colour, so the six of hearts pairs only with the six of diamonds and the queen of clubs only with the queen of spades. Every card now has exactly one partner anywhere in the pack, which removes the accidental matches that the rank-only game throws up and makes remembering a card genuinely useful rather than approximately useful. Many references treat this, not rank alone, as the standard rule.

**Two packs** — Lay out 104 cards for a much longer and more punishing game. The kindest form uses two packs with different backs, shuffled separately and dealt into alternating positions like a chequerboard, so a red-backed card can only ever be matched with a blue-backed one. That halves the number of candidates you have to hold in your head and makes an otherwise unmanageable layout playable.

**Solitaire Concentration** — Lay out the grid and play alone against your own record. Turn two cards at a time under the usual rules and keep count of how many turns you needed to clear the whole layout, or of how many turns failed to produce a pair. Fewer is better, and the running total is a surprisingly precise measure of how much attention you were actually paying.

**Quartets** — Hunt for all four cards of a rank instead of two. A turn continues while every card you expose agrees with the ones already up, and ends the moment one does not, at which point all of them go back down where they came from. Expose all four and you take the set and start a fresh turn. Thirteen sets rather than 26 pairs means far fewer scores and much longer memory chains, and it is a good way to make the game interesting for adults.

**Fancy layouts** — Nothing requires a rectangle. Circles, triangles, spirals and diamond shapes are all traditional, and the dealer picks. They are harder than they look: a grid gives every card an implicit row and column to hang the memory on, and an irregular shape takes that scaffolding away, so the same 52 cards become considerably more difficult to track.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Gambiter, Game Rules, Classic Games and Puzzles, Card Game Database Wiki.

# Cribbage

|                      |                                                                       |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Crib, Six-card Cribbage                                               |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 2)                                             |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), plus a cribbage board or pencil and paper |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-45 minutes                                                         |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                                 |

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## Setup

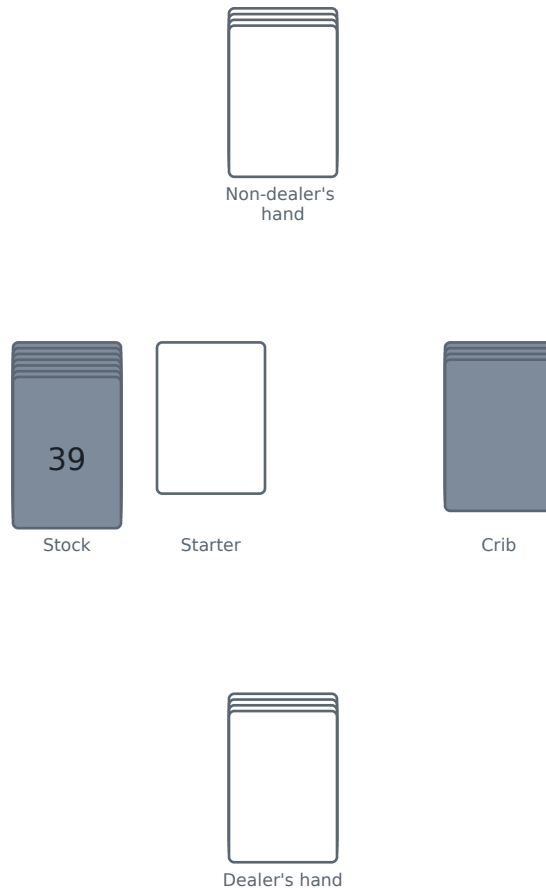
Two players, one standard 52-card deck, and a cribbage board with two pegs each. Cards rank king high down to ace low, and for counting purposes an ace is 1, a face card is 10, and everything else is worth its index. The ace is always low and runs never turn the corner: ace-two-three is a run, queen-king-ace is not.

Cut for the deal: low card deals first, and the deal alternates every hand afterwards. Cutting for the first deal matters, because the dealer's edge is real and it swaps every deal.

Deal six cards to each player, one at a time, and put the rest of the deck face down to one side. Look at your six and lay two of them face down in a pile off to the dealer's side of the board. Those four cards are the crib, an extra hand that the dealer alone will score at the end of the deal, so the non-dealer throws to it defensively and the dealer throws to it generously. Neither player looks at the crib until the hands have been played out.

Once both hands are down to four cards and the crib is out of the way, the non-dealer makes a cut; the dealer lifts the upper half clear, takes whichever card the cut has exposed underneath, and sets it face up on the reassembled deck. This is the starter, and it is shared: both hands and the crib count it as a fifth card at the end of the deal. It sits out the pegging entirely. A jack turned as the starter is worth 2 to the dealer there and then, called two for his heels; strict play wants it claimed before the opening lead, and a dealer who forgets forfeits it.

Both pegs start off the board. Score by leapfrogging the back peg ahead of the front one, so the gap always shows what you just scored.



Six cards are dealt to each player; after both discard two, the crib sits face down on the dealer's side and the starter is turned face up on the deck.

## Play

A deal has two phases: the play, usually called pegging, and then the show.

The play. The non-dealer leads a card face up in front of them and announces its value. The dealer plays a card and announces the new running total, and so on alternately, each of you keeping your own played cards in a personal row rather than a shared pile so the hands can be picked up again afterwards. The running total may never exceed 31.

You peg immediately as you lay a card down: 2 for taking the total to exactly 15; 2 for taking it to exactly 31; 2 for matching the rank just laid; 6 if you make it three of that rank; 12 for a fourth. A run of three or more scores a point per card, counting backwards through the cards played since the last reset, in any order, as long as no unrelated card sits among them and no rank is repeated. A duplicate kills the run: once 2, 3, 4 has pegged three, a second 3 played on top scores nothing at all, because the four cards contain two 3s and the last three played are not a run either. Runs can be lengthened by either player: after 6, 4, 5 has scored three, a 3 or a 7 scores four. Suits are irrelevant during the play, and a pair is only a pair if

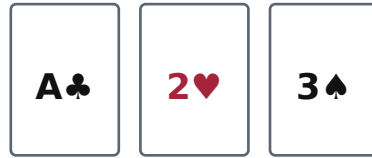
the card just before it matched, not merely if the rank appeared earlier.

Go. You must play whenever you legally can; passing by choice is not allowed. If every card left in your hand would push the total past 31, say "go". Your opponent then keeps playing on their own for as long as they legally can. Once the count is stuck and no legal card can follow, a single point goes to the player who put down that final card, or 2 where the count happens to have stopped dead on 31. The count then resets to zero and the player who did not lay that last card leads to the new count, with whatever cards remain. This is the same point people call "last card": when both hands run dry, the player who laid the final card of the deal takes that single point, or 2 if it happened to make 31. It is one point, not a go point plus a last-card point.

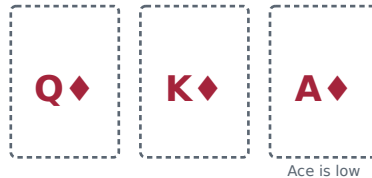
The show. When both hands are empty, everyone picks their four cards back up and scores them together with the starter, treating it as a fifth card. Counting happens in a fixed order and must be done aloud: the non-dealer's hand first, then the dealer's hand, then the dealer's crib. That order decides close games, because play stops the moment a peg reaches the game hole. A non-dealer sitting on 118 counts first and can win before the dealer's hand and crib are ever counted.

The deal then passes to the other player, all fifty-two cards are gathered up and shuffled, and the next hand begins. Points are pegged as they are earned, never totalled at the end, and a peg once advanced cannot be moved back; if you overlook points and start the next stage, they are lost, unless you are playing muggins, in which case your opponent takes them.

Run of three, 3



Not a run



Ace is low

Double run of three, 8



Two runs, pair

Highest hand, 29



His nobs

Starter

Scoring the show. A run is three or more consecutive ranks; the ace is low and runs never turn the corner. Every distinct combination in the five cards scores, so a card counts again and again.

## Goal & scoring

First to 121 points wins, which is twice around a standard board plus the game hole. Points are pegged continuously, and the game ends instantly when a peg reaches 121, mid-count if necessary.

A hand or crib is scored as those four cards plus the starter, and every scoring combination that can be made from those five counts, including the same card used again and again in different combinations:

- Fifteen: any group of cards adding to exactly 15 scores 2, and you count every distinct group.
- Pair: 2 per pair. Three of a kind is three separate pairs and so scores 6; four of a kind scores 12.

- Run: 3 or more in consecutive rank scores 1 per card, and each distinct run counts. A double run of three (a run plus a duplicated rank) scores 8 in all, since it is two runs of three plus a pair.
- Flush: 4 if all four cards in hand share a suit, 5 if the starter matches too. In the crib only the full five-card flush scores; four matching crib cards on their own are worth nothing.
- His nobs: 1 for holding the jack of the starter's suit, in hand or in the crib.
- His heels: 2 to the dealer, pegged at once, when the starter turned is a jack.

The highest possible hand is 29: three fives and the jack matching a starter five. Zero-point hands are common enough to have their own name, a nineteen.

In match play, a loser still short of 91 is skunked and the win is usually worth double; short of 61 is a double skunk.

| Scores              | Value          | Notes                                             |
|---------------------|----------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Fifteen             | 2              | a count of exactly 15, in the play or at the show |
| Thirty-one          | 2              | in the play                                       |
| Pair                | 2              | three of a kind 6, four of a kind 12              |
| Run                 | 1 per card     | three or more consecutive ranks                   |
| Double run of three | 8              | —                                                 |
| Flush in hand       | 4              | 5 if the starter matches the suit                 |
| Flush in the crib   | 5              | only the full five-card flush scores              |
| His nobs            | 1              | jack matching the starter's suit                  |
| His heels           | 2              | to the dealer when the starter turned is a jack   |
| Go or last card     | 1              | 2 where the count stopped on exactly 31           |
| Game                | 121            | —                                                 |
| Skunk               | loser under 91 | the win is usually worth double                   |
| Double skunk        | loser under 61 | —                                                 |

## Variants

**Five-card cribbage** — The original English form. Five cards are dealt to each player, both discard two, and hands of only three are played, so pegging is short and the crib carries a lot of the scoring. Game is 61, once around the board, and the non-dealer pegs 3 straight away at the start of the game as compensation for not having the first crib.

**Three-handed cribbage** — Each player is dealt five cards and discards one to the crib. Because that leaves the crib a card short, the dealer also deals one card face down to it straight off the deck. Everyone plays alone on a triangular board, the deal rotates left, and the player to the dealer's left leads the first card and counts first at the show.

**Partnership cribbage** — The standard four-player game: two teams of two, partners facing each other, one peg line per team. Deal five cards each and everyone discards one to the dealer's crib. Play proceeds clockwise around the table, and either partner's points advance the shared peg. First side to 121 wins.

**Muggins** — An optional rule that punishes sloppy counting. If you finish counting a hand or crib and have missed points, your opponent may call "muggins" and peg those points instead. It is common in club and tournament play and worth agreeing on before the first deal rather than after somebody undercounts.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Britannica, American Cribbage Congress, Masters of Games.

# Egyptian Ratscrew

|                      |                                                                                                                                |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Egyptian Rat Screw, ERS, Egyptian War, Egyptian Rat Slap, Slaps                                                                |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                                                                                      |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards); some groups leave the jokers in so the deal comes out even, or add a second deck above six players |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-45 minutes                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                                                                                          |

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## Setup

You need a flat surface everyone can reach and hit. A table is better than a floor, and a hard surface is better than a bed, because the pile has to stay square enough to see the top card.

Pick a dealer any way you like; if you play a second game, pass the deal to the left. Shuffle and deal the whole pack out one card at a time, face down, going clockwise, until the cards run out. A 52-card pack comes out level only at two, four or thirteen players, and a one- or two-card difference does not matter anyway. Some groups leave the two jokers in so that 54 cards divide evenly at three, six or nine. If you do leave them in, say what they are: the default is that a joker is an ordinary card that never matches anything and never triggers a slap, though some tables make it slappable on sight.

Nobody looks at any card at any point, their own stack included. Square your cards into a neat face-down stack in front of you and keep it squared: you play off the top and add winnings to the bottom, so a sloppy stack slows you down and lets people see cards early.

Before the first card is turned, agree on two things out loud. First, which slap patterns are live. Doubles and sandwiches are near-universal and top-bottom is close behind; marriages, tens and runs are extras, and every group plays a different set. Second, what a false slap costs, normally one card burned to the bottom of the pile, sometimes two. Arguments about these mid-game are what the game is famous for.

The player to the dealer's left turns the first card. Play runs clockwise.

## Play

On your turn, take the top card off your own stack and flip it face up onto the pile in the middle. Grab it by the far edge and turn it away from you, so that everyone sees it at the same moment. Turning a card toward yourself gives you a fraction of a second's head start on slapping and is treated as cheating.



If the card is a 2 through 10 and does not complete a slap pattern, nothing happens and the turn simply passes to the next player.

### FACE CARD CHALLENGES

Jacks, queens, kings and aces stop the normal rotation. When you turn one, the next player owes you a face card, and the rank you played sets how many attempts they get:

- jack: 1 card
- queen: 2 cards
- king: 3 cards
- ace: 4 cards

That player flips cards from their own stack onto the pile, one at a time, up to that limit. Two outcomes are possible.

If one of the cards they flip is itself a face card or an ace, they stop immediately, even if they had attempts left. The challenge now passes to the player after them, with the count reset by whatever rank was just turned. Challenges can chain around the table several times and the pile gets fat.

If they use up all their attempts without turning a face card or ace, the challenge is over. The player who turned the most recent face card takes the entire pile, puts it face down under their own stack, and turns the first card of a brand-new pile. Play then carries on clockwise from that player, exactly as it does after a slap.

Note that the cards flipped during a challenge are ordinary cards on the pile. They can and do complete slap patterns, which is where most of the chaos comes from.

### SLAPPING

Slapping outranks everything, including a challenge in progress. The instant the top of the pile completes a live pattern, anyone at the table may slap it, including the player who just turned the card and including players who are not part of the current challenge. The first hand onto the pile takes the whole thing, adds it face down to the bottom of their stack, and turns the first card of the next pile. Play then continues clockwise from them. Any face-card challenge that was in progress dies with the pile: once the cards have been carried off, nobody owes anybody a face card. You may square the won cards up any way you like and shuffle them into your stack if you want to, but you never look at them.

The two patterns every table plays:

- Double: the top two cards are the same rank, for example 7 then 7.
- Sandwich: two cards of the same rank with exactly one card between them, for example 9, 4, 9.

Top-bottom is nearly as common and is the first one to add: it is live when the card just turned matches the rank of the card at the very bottom of the pile. It only works if somebody remembers what that bottom card was, which is why some groups drop it.

Further additions, all of which must be agreed before the first card is turned: marriage, a king and queen next to each other in either order; tens, two consecutive cards whose ranks add to exactly ten, counting an ace as one and giving jacks, queens and kings no value at all, so 6 then 4 is live and so is ace then 9; and runs, three cards in consecutive rank order either up or down with suits ignored, ace low unless you also allow it to run king-ace-two.

Suits never matter for any pattern.

If several hands land at once, the bottom hand wins, meaning whoever is actually touching the cards rather than the back of someone else's hand.

## BURNING

Slap when there is no pattern and you burn a card. Take the top card of your own stack, without looking at it, and slide it face down underneath the pile. You get nothing for it; it becomes part of whatever pile the next winner collects. Some groups burn two cards, and some make a player who false-slaps repeatedly sit out slapping for the rest of the game.

## RUNNING OUT OF CARDS

Playing your last card does not eliminate you. You stay at the table with an empty space in front of you and you may still slap. Win a slap and the entire pile comes to you, and you are back in with a large stack. This is why the game can run so long: a player who is down to nothing can be the leader thirty seconds later.

While you have no cards you are skipped in the rotation: nobody waits for you to turn anything, and the turn passes straight on to the next player who still has a stack. You are out when someone else claims the pile while you are cardless, because your chance to slap back in has gone. If you run out in the middle of answering a face-card challenge, whether you had attempts left or not, you cannot produce what you owe, so the challenge ends there and the player who turned the last face card takes the pile. A cardless player who false-slaps has nothing to burn; the usual ruling is that they are out on the spot.

Groups vary on how generous to be here. Some let eliminated players, and even people who were not playing, keep slapping in indefinitely.

Double



Sandwich



Not a sandwich

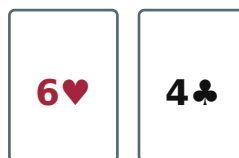


The two patterns every table plays, reading left to right up to the top of the pile. A sandwich needs exactly one card in between; two cards in between is not one, and slapping it costs you a card.

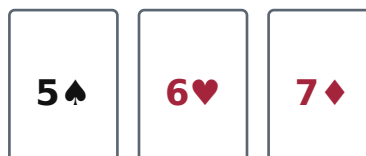
Marriage



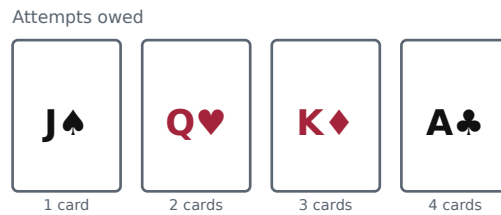
Tens



Run



Extras, live only if the table agreed them before the first card was turned. Tens means two cards adding to exactly ten, with an ace as one and jacks, queens and kings as nothing.



Turning one of these stops the rotation: the next player owes you a face card, and the rank you turned sets how many cards they get to find one.

## Goal & scoring

There is no scoring. You win by holding every card in play, which is 52 with a single pack, 54 if you left the jokers in and 104 with two packs. In practice that means everyone else has been knocked out and you are the only player with a stack in front of you.

Getting all the way there can take a while, because a cardless player who slaps well comes straight back into the game, and a full-table game can swing several times before anyone is genuinely eliminated. It is entirely normal for one player to hold forty cards and lose ten minutes later.

Because of that, plenty of groups set a stopping point in advance: play for a fixed twenty or thirty minutes and give the win to whoever has the biggest stack, or stop as soon as the table is down to two players and call the larger stack the winner. Decide before you start rather than when someone is winning.

The skill is not really reflexes. It is watching the pile rather than your own hand, knowing the pattern list cold so you are not thinking about it, and resisting the twitch slap, because burned cards add up faster than anyone expects.

## Variants

**Long slap list** — Beyond doubles and sandwiches, groups pile on extra patterns: marriage (king and queen adjacent, either order), tens (two consecutive cards adding to exactly ten), top-bottom, three or four cards in consecutive rank order, jokers as an instant slap, and a designated card such as the queen of spades that is always slappable. More patterns mean more piles change hands and fewer long face-card chains, but they also mean far more disputed slaps, so write the list down if it goes past four items.

**Flat face-card counts** — Instead of jack one, queen two, king three, ace four, every face card and ace gives the next player the same number of attempts, usually one. This is much easier to teach, and it is what most people default to when nobody at the table remembers the real counts. Challenges resolve faster and piles stay smaller, which makes the game shorter but takes away

the tension of watching someone burn through four chances on an ace.

**Harsher false-slap penalty** — Instead of burning one card to the bottom of the pile, a false slapper burns two, or hands a card face down to every other player, which on a full table is brutal. A milder alternative used with children is a strike system: three false slaps and you lose the right to slap until the next game. All of these exist to stop the one player who slaps at everything and wins on volume.

**Slapping in from outside** — Eliminated players, and sometimes spectators who never dealt in at all, are allowed to keep slapping the pile. A successful slap brings them in with the whole pile as their stack. It keeps everyone involved instead of leaving knocked-out players watching, at the cost of a game that may never actually end. Groups that use it usually cap it, for example allowing a player one re-entry only.

**Two packs for a big table** — Above six players a single deck gives everyone six or seven cards and the game turns over almost instantly, so shuffle two packs together. Duplicate ranks make doubles and sandwiches noticeably more frequent, so the pile moves faster and face-card chains break sooner. Deal it out the same way and keep every other rule identical.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Denexa Games, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Gambiter, Group Games 101, Wikibooks, PlayingCardDecks.

# Go Fish

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Fish                                       |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-20 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                      |

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## Setup

Use a standard 52-card deck with the jokers out. Suits do not matter at any point; only rank does. Two to six can play, and four is a good number.

Choose a dealer however you like. The deal passes to the left between games. Deal one card at a time, clockwise.

How many cards each player gets depends on the size of the table. With two or three players, deal seven each. With four or more, deal five each. The smaller hand keeps enough cards in the middle to fish from once the table gets crowded.

Spread the undealt cards face down in a loose pile in the centre. This is the pool, also called the pond or the ocean. Keep it spread out rather than squared up so everyone can reach it without knocking it over.

Pick your hand up and sort it by rank so you can see what you already hold. Some groups have everyone lay down any complete book of four they were dealt before the first turn; others require you to wait until you have taken a turn. Either is fine, so long as you agree first. Play starts with the player to the dealer's left.

## Play

Turns pass clockwise. On your turn you ask one specific opponent, by name, for one specific rank. Say who you are asking and what you want: "Priya, do you have any sevens?"

Two restrictions govern the ask. Ask only for a rank you are already holding — no fishing for sevens unless a seven is sitting in your hand. And you must direct the question at a single named player, not at the table in general.

If the player you asked holds any cards of that rank, they must hand over every one of them, not just one. You add them to your hand and your turn continues: ask again, of anyone at the table, for any rank you now hold. A good run can strip several opponents in one turn.

If the player you asked has none of that rank, they say "Go fish." You draw

the top card of the pool. If it happens to be the very rank you just asked for, show it to the table and take another turn. Otherwise you keep the card quietly and your turn ends, passing to the player on your left.

Whenever you complete a book, meaning all four cards of one rank, lay it face up in front of you straight away. Completing a book does not end your turn and does not earn you an extra one; carry on with whatever you were doing. Cards in a laid-down book are out of play and cannot be asked for.

If your hand runs empty while the pool still has cards, refill it straight away: take five, or whatever is left if fewer than five remain. Do this the moment your last card leaves your hand, so if it empties in the middle of your own turn you draw and carry on asking without a break. Some groups have you draw only one card in that situation, which is harsher but keeps the pool alive longer; settle it before you start. If your hand is empty and the pool is empty as well, you are out, and the remaining players carry on without you. You can only put a question to a player who is actually holding cards, so anyone who is out is skipped from then on.

One detail worth agreeing up front: if you ask a question and the pool is already empty, there is nothing to fish for, so a "go fish" answer simply ends your turn.

The game finishes when all thirteen books have been laid down. Since a book is four cards and the deck holds thirteen ranks, that accounts for every card, and there is nothing left to hold or draw.

## **Goal & scoring**

You are collecting books, and a book is four cards of the same rank. Suits are irrelevant. The player with the most books when all thirteen have been made wins.

There is no point scoring beyond counting books. Seven books wins outright, but nobody usually gets that far in a full table. If two or more players tie for the most books, they share the win, or you can play a decider hand.

Emptying your hand first is not a win condition and carries no reward. A player who runs out early has simply stopped being a target, which is often a disadvantage, because holding cards is what lets you keep asking.

The skill in the game is memory. Every question tells the table what you hold and what you were missing, and every handover tells them what you just gained. Track who asked for what, and go after players you know are sitting on a rank you need.

## Variants

**Ask for the exact card** — Instead of naming a rank, you name a single card by rank and suit, such as the nine of clubs. You still have to hold at least one card of that rank to ask. The tighter target means far fewer successful requests, so hands last longer and remembering exactly which cards have surfaced matters much more. This is the older parlour game Authors, which Go Fish descends from and which is still sometimes used as another name for it.

**The blocker plays next** — When someone tells you to go fish, the turn moves to them rather than to the player on your left. Turn order becomes unpredictable, which stops players from timing their questions around a fixed rotation, and it rewards answering "go fish" honestly and fast. Widely played as a house rule and worth agreeing on before the deal, since it changes the flow completely.

**No requirement to hold the rank** — Drop the rule that you must already hold a card of the rank you ask for. Young children find the restriction hard to police and hard to remember, and removing it lets them fish for anything they fancy. It weakens the memory element considerably, because a question no longer tells the table anything about your hand.

**Pairs instead of books** — Collect pairs of matching rank rather than sets of four, laying each pair down as you make it. There are twenty-six pairs in the deck instead of thirteen books, so cards leave hands much faster and a game finishes in a few minutes. This is the usual simplification for players too young to hold a large hand or keep track of four-card sets.

**Happy Families and other purpose-made decks** — Dedicated illustrated packs replace ranks with themed sets, most famously the Victorian English game Happy Families, whose deck has eleven families of four members each. Play is identical, but matching by picture rather than by rank makes it accessible to children who cannot yet read card ranks. Many modern children's Go Fish decks work the same way.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Geeky Hobbies, Ducksters, Solitaire Paradise.



# Koi-Koi

|                      |                                                                      |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Koi Koi, Hanafuda Koi-Koi                                            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2 players                                                            |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 hanafuda pack (48 flower cards, four to each of the twelve months) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-40 minutes                                                        |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                               |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                                |

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## Setup

Koi-Koi is played with hanafuda, and there is no substituting a Western pack: the cards have no ranks and no numbers on them, only pictures, and the whole game turns on which of four picture types a card is. Buy the pack or you cannot play. Hanafuda cards are small, thick and stiff, and they are meant to be snapped down flat rather than fanned.

The pack holds forty-eight cards in twelve months, four to a month, and the month is the only thing that makes two cards match. January is pine, February plum, March cherry, April wisteria, May iris, June peony, July bush clover, August pampas grass, September chrysanthemum, October maple, November willow and December paulownia.

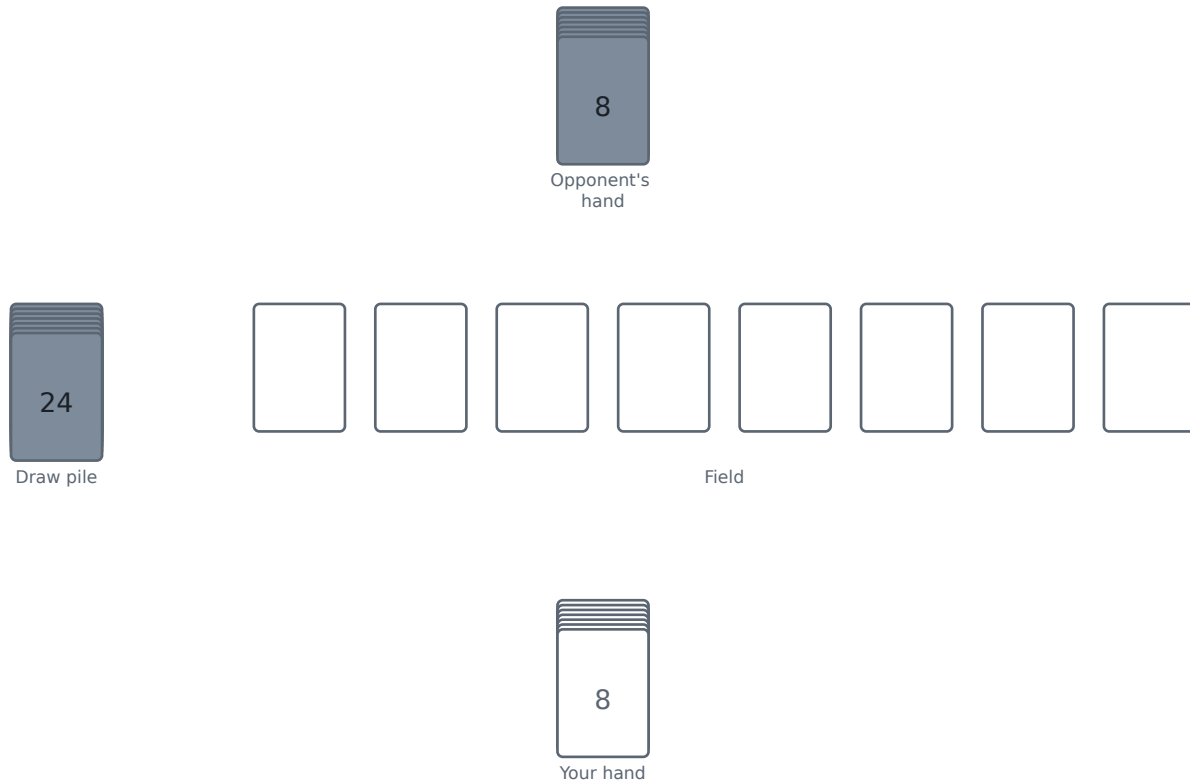
Cutting across the months are the four card types, and these are what score. Five cards are brights, the large ceremonial pictures: the crane, the cherry-blossom curtain, the full moon, the rain man under his umbrella in the willow month, and the phoenix. Nine are animals, from the bush warbler and the cuckoo through the boar, the deer, the butterflies and the sake cup. Ten are ribbons: three red ones carry writing on them, three are blue, and the remaining four are plain red. Everything left over, twenty-four cards, is plains — worth nothing individually and quite capable of winning you the round in bulk.

Pick a first dealer any way you like; the traditional method is that each player draws a card and the earlier month deals. The dealer gives eight cards to each player and lays eight face up in the middle to form the field, dealing in batches of four rather than singly, and the remaining twenty-four go face down as the draw pile. The dealer then takes the first turn — which, since the winner of a round normally deals the next, is a small compounding advantage and the reason winning early rounds is worth more than the raw score suggests.

If all four cards of one month land in the field, nobody can ever match them, since no player and no draw can produce a fifth. Most rule sets therefore scrap the deal, shuffle and start again. Three of a month in the field is fine and is in fact a prize, because the player who produces the

fourth takes all four.

One consequence of those numbers is worth noticing before you start: the draw pile is never used up. Eight cards each means eight turns each and sixteen draws in all, so eight cards are still face down when the round ends. A round is bounded by the hands, not by the pile.



Eight cards each, eight face up in the field, twenty-four left in the draw pile. Captures are laid out face up in front of the player who took them, so both sides see what is being built.

## Play

A turn comes in two halves, and both halves are the same simple matching.

First, lay one card from your hand face up. Playing a card is compulsory — if nothing in your hand matches anything in the field you must still put one out, and choosing which one to give away is a real decision. If the field holds a card of the same month, take both and add them to your captures. If the field holds nothing of that month, your card stays in the field and is now available to your opponent.

Second, turn the top card of the draw pile face up. It behaves identically: a month match takes both cards, no match leaves it lying in the field. The drawn card can match the card you have just played out, in which case you capture the pair you have only this second created.

Where three cards of one month are already sitting in the field, the fourth takes all four at once, whether you play it from hand or turn it off the draw

pile — the biggest single match the rules allow.

A single turn therefore takes nothing, two cards or four in each half, and on a rare turn where both halves land on a three-card month it can take eight. Where a month offers two possible matches you choose which card to take, and choosing well is most of the ordinary skill in the game — the field is public, so you can see what your opponent needs almost as clearly as they can. Captures are laid out face up in front of you and grouped by type, never hidden.

## THE DECISION

After the draw, check what you have captured. If your captures now complete a scoring combination — a yaku — that you did not have when the turn began, or extend one you already had, play stops and you must choose one of two things.

- Stop, which is called *shōbu*. The round ends immediately. You score everything your captures are worth and your opponent scores nothing at all.
- Call *koi-koi* and carry on. Nothing is banked. Play resumes, and you may only stop later if you have improved on what you already had.

*Koi-koi* means roughly "come on, come on", and it is a bet made against yourself. It is the only real decision in the game and the reason the game has a name. Calling raises what you might take, but it also opens a door for your opponent: complete a yaku before you complete another and they will simply stop, taking the round while you take nothing, and your call will have made their score bigger.

When you stop, or when your opponent stops after your call, the round is over even if both players still hold cards.

## RUNNING OUT

If both hands empty with nobody having stopped, the round is dead. Neither player scores for their captures, however good they look on the table, and the same dealer gathers the cards and deals again. Some tables pay the dealer a point or two to compensate for the wasted round; that is an add-on rather than the base rule, so say whether you are using it before the first deal.

A full game is twelve rounds, one per month of the hanafuda year. Six and three are both common when time is short, and it is worth agreeing the number before the first deal, since it changes how recklessly you should be calling *koi-koi* late on. In most rule sets the winner of a round deals the next one.

## Goal & scoring

Each round goes entirely to the player who stops with a yaku; there is no splitting and no consolation. Add the rounds up and the higher total wins the game.

Everything you have captured counts at once, so a set of captures can satisfy several yaku together and each one pays. Holding the three red poetry ribbons scores for that combination, and those same three cards still count toward the five-ribbon total, and the sake cup can be earning its keep in two viewing combinations and the animal count simultaneously. The exception is the brights, which are graded rather than cumulative: you score the single best bright combination you hold and not the lesser ones underneath it. The rain man of the willow month is the awkward card there, because it blocks the top-scoring versions while still rescuing a hand that would otherwise be one bright short.

The three counting yaku — animals, ribbons and plains — pay at their threshold and then a further point for each card past it, so they keep growing for as long as the round runs. This is what makes koi-koi tempting: a player already holding five animals gains a point for every additional animal captured, without needing anything new to appear.

Once your total is settled, two multipliers may apply. A total of seven or more is doubled, which is why the difference between six points and seven is worth more than one point. The koi-koi call is the other, and it is the most variable rule in the game. The version most widely used is that your call doubles your opponent's score if they are the one who ends up stopping, so the punishment for a greedy call is severe; many tables also double the caller's own score if the call comes good, and some double again for every extra call. Where a koi-koi doubling and the seven-point doubling both apply to the same score, they multiply rather than replace each other: a nine-point hand taken after a call is worth thirty-six. Fix which of these you are using before the first round, because on a big hand it is the difference between a comfortable game and a decided one.

Games are often played for a stake per point rather than a running total, which is the traditional way and the reason so many of the scoring options exist.

| Scores                         | Value | Notes                                      |
|--------------------------------|-------|--------------------------------------------|
| Gokō — five brights            | 10    | —                                          |
| Shikō — four brights           | 8     | not including the rain man                 |
| Ame-shikō — rainy four brights | 7     | four brights, one of which is the rain man |

|                                            |         |                                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sankō — three brights                      | 5       | not including the rain man                                                               |
| Ino-shika-chō — boar, deer and butterflies | 5       | —                                                                                        |
| Tane — any five animals                    | 1       | +1 for each further animal; the boar, deer and butterflies count here too                |
| Akatan — the three red poetry ribbons      | 5       | pine, plum and cherry                                                                    |
| Aotan — the three blue ribbons             | 5       | peony, chrysanthemum and maple                                                           |
| Akatan and aotan together                  | 10      | simply 5 + 5; they stack, and all six ribbons still count toward tan                     |
| Tan — any five ribbons                     | 1       | +1 for each further ribbon                                                               |
| Kasu — any ten plains                      | 1       | +1 for each further plain                                                                |
| Tsukimi-zake — moon viewing                | 5       | August moon with the September sake cup; optional, and often barred or reduced           |
| Hanami-zake — blossom viewing              | 5       | March curtain with the September sake cup; optional, and often barred or reduced         |
| Total of 7 or more                         | doubled | —                                                                                        |
| Koi-koi having been called                 | ×2      | commonly doubles the opponent's score if they stop; conventions vary, so fix yours first |
| Teshi or kuttsuki — lucky hand             | 6       | optional rule; claimed from the deal, before a card is played                            |

## Variants

**Sake cup rulings** — The chrysanthemum sake cup is the most argued-over card in the pack. By default it is an animal, and it also forms the two viewing yaku with the moon and the cherry curtain. Common alternatives: let it count as a plain instead, at the holder's choice, which quietly boosts the ten-plain count; disallow the viewing yaku altogether, since a five-point pair of cards makes early rounds swing hard; or halve them, or allow them only alongside another yaku. Japanese tables frequently ban them outright, so ask before you count on them.

**Lucky hands** — An optional pair of instant wins claimed from the dealt hand before anybody plays. Teshi is all four cards of one month in your hand; kuttsuki is four separate pairs. Either is declared at once and takes the round for a flat six points, with the claimant dealing next. The reasoning is that both hands are close to unplayable — the cards are locked together and can only be shed in matched pairs — so the rule pays you off rather than making you grind through a hopeless round.

**Multiplier conventions** — The most house-ruled corner of the game. Some tables drop the doubling at seven points, so a big hand pays only what it is worth on the card. Others make each koi-koi call double the final score cumulatively, so a second and third call push the stakes to four and eight times and make late-round play genuinely dangerous. A gentler version caps all multipliers at a single doubling however many calls are made. These choices matter more than any yaku value, since they decide whether one bold round can win the game.

**Round count and the dealer** — Twelve rounds, one for each month, is the standard length, but six and three are both common and a single round on its own is a reasonable filler. Who deals next also varies: winner deals is usual, but the deal may simply alternate, and a drawn round in which nobody scored is normally redealt by the same dealer, sometimes with a point to them for the privilege. Longer games favour steady small yaku; a three-round game rewards calling koi-koi far more often.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Fuda Wiki, Board Game Arena game help, Sloperama hanafuda rules, Gambiter, Hanafuda Legends, GameDesign.jp.

# Old Maid

|                      |                                                          |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Scabby Queen, Black Peter, Schwarzer Peter, Old Bachelor |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck with one queen removed (51 cards)        |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-20 minutes                                            |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                   |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                    |

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## Setup

Take a standard 52-card deck and pull out one queen, setting it aside face down where nobody can see which one it was. That leaves 51 cards: twelve ranks still complete at four cards each, and queens reduced to three. Everything can be matched into 25 pairs except one queen, which has nothing to go with. That leftover queen is the old maid.

Choose a dealer any way you like; cutting for high card works, and the deal passes to the left between games. Shuffle and deal the entire pack out one card at a time, face down, going clockwise, starting with the player on the dealer's left and finishing with the dealer. It will not come out even. Some players end up with one card more than others, and that is fine and does not affect play.

Everyone picks up their hand and looks at it privately. Before the first turn, each player lays down every pair they were dealt, face up in front of them, and takes no further interest in those cards. A pair is two cards of the same rank; suit and colour are irrelevant. If you hold three of a kind, you may only discard two of them and must keep the third. If you hold all four of a rank, put down two pairs. A player whose whole hand pairs off in this opening discard is left with nothing, and is out and safe before the first turn is taken.

## Play

Play moves clockwise. The dealer goes first, though many families instead start with the player to the dealer's left; agree before you begin, since it changes nothing but who is exposed first.

On your turn you hold your hand out to the player on your left, spread face down like a fan so the backs are toward them and no faces show. That player takes one card of their choice, blind, and adds it to their hand. If the card they drew makes a pair with something they already hold, they lay that pair down face up at once. If it does not, they simply keep it.

The player who just drew then becomes the one who offers, fanning their

own hand face down to the player on their left, and so on around the table. Cards therefore move steadily around the circle, each player always drawing from the neighbour on their right and always offering to the neighbour on their left.

Shuffling your hand before you offer it is the whole skill of the game. Keeping the old maid in one spot, glancing at it, or holding it slightly proud will get it read instantly, especially by children, who are usually better at spotting a tell than adults expect.

When a player's hand becomes empty, whether by laying down a pair or by having their last card drawn away, that player is out and safe. Skip them from then on. Offering and drawing simply pass to the next player who still holds cards, closing the circle up as it shrinks.

The hand ends when every card that can be paired has been paired. At that point exactly one card is left in the game, held by exactly one player: the odd queen. There is no scoring round and no way to unload it once you are the last player holding cards, so the ending is always the same shape.

## Goal & scoring

Your aim is to get rid of every card in your hand and, above all, not to be the one holding the unmatched queen at the end.

There is no point scoring. Everyone who empties their hand wins equally, and the single player left with the old maid loses that hand. Position or order of going out does not matter; being out first carries no extra credit.

Because the loser is decided entirely by blind draws and by how well people disguise their hands, results swing wildly from deal to deal. Groups that want a longer session usually play a fixed number of hands and count how many times each person was stuck as the old maid, with the lowest count winning overall. Some play instead until one player has been the old maid three times and is out.

## Variants

**Dedicated Old Maid deck** — Purpose-made children's decks replace the standard pack with illustrated character pairs plus one unpaired Old Maid card. Play is identical, but the matching is by picture rather than rank, which makes it far easier for very young players who cannot yet read card ranks reliably.

**Joker as the odd card** — Instead of removing a queen, leave the deck complete at 52 and add a single joker, giving 53 cards. All four queens stay in and can be paired; the joker is the card nobody wants. This is how the game is usually played in Japan, where it is known as *babanuki*, and it saves you from fishing a card out of the pack.



**Scabby Queen** — A British version in which three queens are removed so that the queen of spades is the doomed card, and the loser takes a forfeit. Traditionally the loser cuts cards from the pack and is rapped across the knuckles with the deck a number of times set by the card drawn. Most groups now drop the physical penalty and keep only the named target card.

**Black Peter** — The continental European form, called Schwarzer Peter in Germany and Svarte Petter or Svarteper in Scandinavia. A jack, usually the jack of spades, is the unpairable card rather than a queen, and the loser is often marked with a smudge of soot or a drawn-on moustache. Many countries sell dedicated Black Peter decks in the same spirit as illustrated Old Maid packs.

**Any odd card** — Remove a card at random, face down, without anyone seeing which one it was, so nobody knows what the unpairable card is until the hand is nearly over. This kills the strategy of tracking one known queen and stops experienced players from reading the table so easily. A Philippine version, ungguy-ungguyan, is played this way.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Gambiter, Card Game Wiki, Ducksters.

# Scopa

|                      |                                                                         |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Scopa Italiana                                                          |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                                               |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 40 cards (A to 7 plus J, Q, K in each suit) |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-40 minutes                                                           |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                  |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                                   |

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## Setup

Scopa is a fishing game: you catch cards off the table with cards from your hand, and the scoring happens once at the end of the round rather than trick by trick.

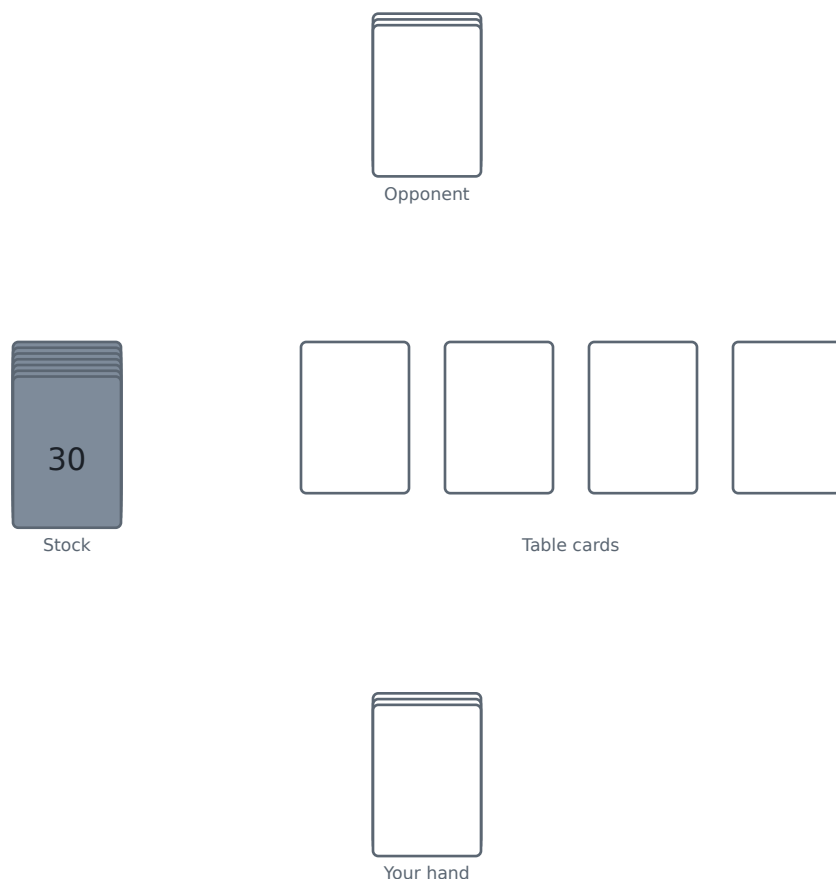
The pack is forty cards. Use an Italian deck as it comes, or take an ordinary one and remove the jokers and every eight, nine and ten. Each card has a capture value: ace 1 up through seven 7, then jack 8, queen 9, king 10. The suit of coins carries scoring weight of its own, and on a French-suited pack that job falls to diamonds — agree on this out loud before you start, because half the scoring depends on it.

Two, three, four and six can all play; five cannot, because the pack will not divide evenly once the table cards are laid out. At four and six the players form partnerships, partners spaced so that no two of them sit next to each other, and each side throws its captures into one shared pile; at two and three everybody plays alone and keeps their own pile. Deal and play run counter-clockwise, and the turn to deal passes one seat to the right each time the pack is used up. Pick the first dealer however you like — cut and give it to the low card — and have the pack cut by the player on the dealer's left before every deal.

The dealer gives three cards to each player, starting on their right, and lays four face up in the middle, then puts the undealt remainder face down to one side as the stock. Those four are the only cards the table ever starts with; nothing more is ever dealt to the middle.

One opening is thrown out. Count the kings in the middle before anybody plays: three of them, or all four, and the deal is unplayable. A king can only ever be taken singly and only by another king, and there are not enough kings left in the pack to strip that many off the table, which means no sweep can occur at any moment in the round. So the deal is abandoned rather than played out. The cards all go back together and the same dealer shuffles and starts again.

Captures go face down in front of you and stay unexamined until the round is scored. The player to the dealer's right goes first.



The two-handed deal: three cards each and four face up in the middle. The stock only ever refills hands, never the table.

## Play

A turn is one card from your hand, played face up, and nothing else. Either it catches something or it does not.

Catching by rank. If the card you play has the same value as a card lying on the table, you take that card, and both go into your capture pile. Only the one card: when two cards of the same rank are lying there, a third of that rank takes whichever of them you name, not both, and picking the coin one over the other is a real decision.

Catching by sum. If it has the same value as two or more table cards added together, you take that whole group. A seven lifts a five and a two, or a four, a two and an ace. Court cards join in on their numbers like everything else, so a king can be caught by a seven and a three.

When both are available, rank wins. A player holding a six who sees a six on the table alongside a four and a two must take the six; the choice of which group to lift only exists when no single card matches. This is the standard

Italian rule and the one point where house rules most often drift, so settle it first.

When more than one group of the same total is lying there, you pick which group you take, and that choice is most of the skill in the game.

Capturing is not optional in the sense you might hope. You choose freely which card to play, but a card that can catch something must do so — you cannot play a seven onto a table with a seven on it and simply leave both lying. What you can do is play a card that catches nothing at all, in which case it stays face up in the middle and joins the pool for everyone. Feeding the table on purpose, to set up a sum only you can complete, is a normal and often necessary move.

Sweeps. A capture that empties the table completely is a *scopa*. Turn one card of your pile face up so the sweep can be counted later. Whoever plays next faces bare wood and can only add a card to it, which is why leaving a table your opponent can clear is the cardinal sin.

Running the pack out. When every hand is empty, the dealer deals three more to each player from the stock, and again nothing goes to the middle. This repeats until the stock is gone. Once the final card of the round has gone down there is normally something still sitting in the middle. It is not left there and not returned to the pack: claiming it falls to whichever player captured most recently, who simply adds the lot to their pile. That can be a fat handful, and every card of it counts toward the majorities for cards and for coins. What it does not do is score as a *scopa* — nor does a genuine clearance made with that closing card.

## Goal & scoring

The round ends when the pack runs out, and then each side sorts the pile it has been building all round. Play continues over as many rounds as it takes to pass the target, which is 11 points in most of Italy; 21 is the other common figure, and it suits the variants that hand out extra points.

Four points are contested each round, plus a point for every sweep:

- Most cards captured: 1 point. There are forty, so 21 takes it and a 20-20 split scores for nobody.
- Most coins: 1 point. Ten in the suit, so six wins it, and five apiece goes unscored.
- The *settebello*, the seven of coins: 1 point to whoever caught it. Never tied, never worth giving away.
- The best *primiera*: 1 point.

- Each scopa: 1 point, banked during play rather than counted at the end.

Primiera is the one that needs explaining. Take the single best card you captured in each of the four suits, rate each on the prime scale — a scale used for nothing else in the game, on which the small pip cards outrank every court card and the order is not the one the capture values would suggest — and add the four figures. High total wins the point. A side that captured nothing at all in some suit cannot compete for it, which is why a lone seven of an otherwise ignored suit is quietly valuable — and if both sides are missing a suit, the one holding cards in more suits takes the point. An exact tie on the prime total scores for nobody, like the other two countable points.

At three players, where there are no partnerships, the same points are contested but the two counting ones turn on a plurality rather than a majority: most cards and most coins go to whoever simply has more than the other two, and a tie for the lead on either scores for nobody.

Sweeps are the swing. The four fixed points tend to split, so a round is usually decided by who cleared the table more often, and a player who never watches for it will lose steadily without ever understanding why.

If two sides pass the target in the same round, the higher total wins; if they are exactly level, play another round.

| Scores                           | Value | Notes                                                           |
|----------------------------------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Most cards captured              | 1     | forty in the pack, so 21 takes it; level scores for nobody      |
| Most coins captured              | 1     | ten in the suit, so six takes it; level scores for nobody       |
| Settebello (seven of coins)      | 1     | cannot be tied                                                  |
| Best primiera                    | 1     | highest total on the prime scale below; level scores for nobody |
| Each scopa (sweep)               | 1     | not available on the final card of the round                    |
| Prime value: seven               | 21    | the scale below is used only to settle the primiera point       |
| Prime value: six                 | 18    | —                                                               |
| Prime value: ace                 | 16    | —                                                               |
| Prime value: five                | 15    | —                                                               |
| Prime value: four                | 14    | —                                                               |
| Prime value: three               | 13    | —                                                               |
| Prime value: two                 | 12    | —                                                               |
| Prime value: king, queen or jack | 10    | —                                                               |

## Variants

**Scopone and Scopone Scientifico** — The serious four-handed forms, always two against two with partners opposite. In Scopone the whole pack is dealt out, nine to a player, with four to the table as usual. Scopone Scientifico deals ten each and leaves the middle empty, so the opening player has no choice but to feed the table, and every card in the game is accounted for from the first move — no stock, no refills, nothing hidden but the three other hands. The scientific version also allows a sweep on the very last card of the deal, which the ordinary game does not.

**Asso piglia tutto** — Also called Scopa d'Assi. An ace played from the hand takes the entire table, whatever is on it, and this counts as a sweep. The exception is a table with an ace already sitting on it, where the normal rank rule applies and your ace simply pairs with it. Four guaranteed sweeps a round makes for a much louder and much luckier game.

**Scopa di Quindici** — Captures are made not by matching your card but by combining it with table cards to total exactly fifteen, court cards counting eight, nine and ten as usual. A five takes a king, or a seven and a three. The Spanish game Escoba is essentially this version, and the constant arithmetic makes it noticeably harder than plain Scopa despite the shorter rule.

**Neapolitan extras** — Two bonus points seen mainly around Naples. Re bello, the king of coins, is worth a point to whoever captures it, like a second settebello. Napola pays a side that captured the ace, two and three of coins: the point value is the length of the unbroken run of coins they hold counting up from the ace, so ace through five is worth five. Both inflate the round considerably, and tables using them normally play to 21 rather than 11.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Gambiter, Board Game Arena, GameRules.com, Official Game Rules.

# Six-Card Golf

|                      |                                                                                                           |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | 6 Card Golf, Six Card Golf, Hara Kiri                                                                     |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                                                                                 |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards) for two to four players; 2 decks shuffled together (104 cards) for five or six |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                                             |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                                      |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                                                                     |

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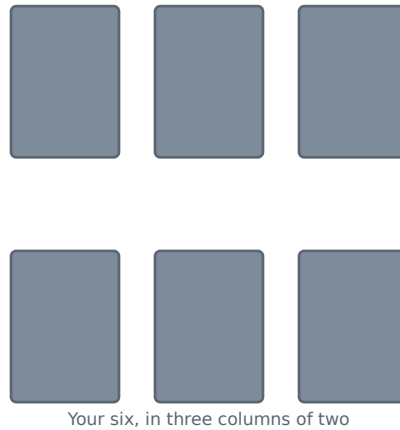
## Setup

Two to four players share one 52-card pack. With five or six, shuffle two packs together and treat the 104 cards as a single deck; duplicate cards cause no trouble because ranks are only ever matched, never compared. Take the jokers out unless your group has agreed to score them.

Pick a first dealer any way you like. The dealer shuffles and gives each player six cards face down, one at a time, clockwise. Each player lays their six out in front of them in two rows of three without looking at any of them, so everyone can see six backs. Then, before anyone takes a turn, each player chooses any two of their own six and turns them face up. Those two stay face up. The other four stay hidden, from their owner as much as from anybody else, until play exposes them.

The undealt cards go face down in the middle as the stock, and the top one is turned beside it to start the discard pile. The player to the dealer's left takes the first turn and play runs clockwise. The deal moves one seat to the left for each new hand, and a full game is nine hands.

One thing to settle before you go looking for rules elsewhere: at the table this game is usually just called Golf, and so is a well-known one-player patience that is nothing like it. The two share only the habit of counting a score as strokes over nine holes. The solitaire deals seven columns of five and asks you to unload them onto a single waste pile, one rank up or down; it has its own entry in this collection. If the page in front of you talks about columns, a stock and holing out, it is describing that game rather than this one.



Every player has their own grid of six. Two cards of your choice are turned face up before the first turn; the columns are what matter for scoring.

## Play

A turn is one card in and one card out. You take a single card, from the top of the stock or the top of the discard pile, and you finish by laying a single card face up on the discard pile. Everything interesting happens in between.

Take the discard and you are committed to using it. Put it face up into any one of your six positions, whichever you like and whether that position was face up or face down, and the card it displaces goes onto the discard pile face up for the whole table to see. What you may not do is pick the top discard up and put it straight back down, since that would leave the game exactly as it was and cost you nothing.

Take from the stock and you have that same option plus one more. You may swap the card into any position and discard whatever it displaces, or you may refuse it, put it on the discard pile unused, and turn one of your own face-down cards face up. Refusing and flipping is the ordinary way of opening up your grid when the stock offers you nothing worth keeping. Rule sets genuinely differ here, and the difference is not cosmetic. Some leave the flip out altogether, so swapping is the only thing that ever exposes a card and hands run a great deal longer. Others make the flip compulsory: discard a stock card unused and you must turn one of your face-down cards, no choice about it. That version is worth knowing, because with the



flip merely optional nothing in the rules obliges anybody to expose anything, and a table content to shuffle cards between face-up positions could in principle keep a hand alive indefinitely. It does not happen often, since a hidden card is usually worse than what you could put in its place, but the compulsory flip is the clean fix if your table stalls. Agree which of the three you are using before the first deal.

A card swapped into a hidden position arrives face up and stays that way. Cards never turn back over, and the grid is never rearranged; a card sits where it was put until something replaces it.

Since every card you get rid of is seen, your opponents learn what you rejected as well as what you removed. Lifting a king off the discard tells the table you have just secured a zero somewhere; refusing a stock card tells them almost nothing, which is part of why the flip is a useful move even when it exposes something ugly.

If the stock is exhausted, take the top card of the discard pile aside to start a fresh discard pile, shuffle the rest and set them down as a new stock.

The hand ends when one player has all six of their cards face up. Every other player then takes exactly one more turn, so going out first is not by itself a win: a well-timed final swap can undercut the player who finished. Some groups end the hand the instant the last card is exposed, which makes going out first considerably stronger. Pick one and keep to it for the whole game. When the last turn has been taken, everybody turns up whatever is still hidden and the hand is scored.

## **Goal & scoring**

Golf is played low. In each hand you are trying to leave the smallest total showing in your grid, and across nine hands, one per hole, the lowest running total takes the game. Eighteen holes is the longer alternative and the totals simply keep accumulating. Nothing about a hand is worth anything on its own: there is no bonus for going out first and no prize for winning a hole, only the number you add to your column. Keep the running totals on paper, since negative hands make them awkward to hold in your head. If two players finish the ninth hole level, play a tenth and settle it on that hand alone; a tie there is played off the same way.

Cards are worth roughly what you would expect, with two exceptions that shape the whole game. A king counts nothing at all, which makes it the best card in the pack and the one players race each other for. A 2 counts minus two, so a hand with a couple of them in it is actively good rather than merely cheap. Aces are one, every numeral card from 3 to 10 counts its pips, and jacks and queens are ten apiece.

The pairing rule is where hands are won. Your six cards read as three columns of two, and any column holding two cards of one rank is cancelled outright — a cancelled column contributes nothing to the hand, and what the two cards would have been worth separately stops mattering entirely. That is why a stranded jack or queen is worth hunting a partner for: ten points apiece turns into nothing at all the moment the second one lands under the first. Cancellation is vertical only, so a rank repeated along a row or a diagonal buys you nothing. Beginners are caught by the reverse of the rule just as often — two 2s in one column cancel to zero rather than standing at minus four, so the cards already working in your favour are exactly the ones to leave unmatched.

As a rough sense of the numbers, a hand in single figures is a good hole, a negative total is a very good one, and anything in the twenties has cost you more than two careful holes will win back. A grid left full of unpaired face cards can lose a nine-hole game on its own.

| Scores                     | Value      | Notes                                                              |
|----------------------------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Each king                  | 0          | —                                                                  |
| Each 2                     | -2         | —                                                                  |
| Each ace                   | 1          | —                                                                  |
| Each 3 through 10          | face value | —                                                                  |
| Each jack or queen         | 10         | —                                                                  |
| Matched pair in one column | 0          | Both cards cancel, whatever they would otherwise be worth.         |
| Each joker                 | -5         | Only if your group uses them; -3, -2 and 0 are all played instead. |

## Variants

**Four-Card Golf** — Also met as Polish Polka, Polish Poker or Turtle. Each player gets a two-by-two square with two cards turned up, so there are two columns of two to pair instead of three, and hands are short and sharp. Tables that play this version almost always bolt the knock below onto it rather than waiting for somebody to expose all four cards, since with four cards the hand would otherwise be over before anyone had a chance to react. It is the usual choice when you want several quick holes rather than a long game.

**Nine-Card Golf** — Sometimes called Crazy Nines. Three rows of three, with three cards turned face up to start, and one rule change that matters far more than it sounds: a column has to hold three matching cards to cancel, not two. Hands run much longer and a two-out-of-three column is an expensive near miss. Nine cards each also eats the pack fast: four players take 36 of the 52 before a single card is drawn, so shuffle in a second deck from four players upwards.

**Knocking** — A player who believes they are lowest may knock instead of drawing. Their turn ends at that point, every other player takes one further ordinary turn with no option to knock themselves, and the hand is then scored. The usual sting is that a knocker who turns out not to be lowest has their score for the hand doubled. It gives a good grid a way to close the hand before the table catches up, at the price of being punished for misjudging it.

**Jokers** — Shuffle two jokers in as the best card in the deck. Minus five is the most widely used value, but minus three, minus two and plain zero are all played, so fix it before dealing. Very low hands become much more common, and the discard pile turns dangerous: nobody wants to be the player who hands a joker to the seat on their left.

**Pairs anywhere** — Drop the column requirement and let any two cards of equal rank cancel each other wherever they happen to sit in the grid. Three of a kind then cancels two of them with the odd card still counting, and four of a kind clears the lot to nothing. It is a good deal more forgiving than the strict column rule and removes the particular frustration of drawing exactly the match you wanted into the wrong position.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, PlayingCardDecks, Game Rules, Bar Games 101, Official Game Rules.

# Slapjack

|                      |                                                                                               |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Slap Jack, Slap-Jack                                                                          |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                                                     |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; 2 decks shuffled together for six or more players |
| <b>Time</b>          | 10-30 minutes                                                                                 |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                                                                         |

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## Setup

Take the jokers out and clear a hard, flat surface everyone can reach. Two to eight can play. Three or more is better than two, because with two players the pile bounces back and forth and a game can run a long time.

Choose a dealer however you like; it matters very little, since nothing about the deal is an advantage, and pass the deal to the left if you play again. Deal the entire pack out one card at a time, face down, clockwise, until every card is gone. Hands do not need to come out even. With five players two people simply start with an extra card.

Nobody looks at any card, including their own. Square your cards into a tidy face-down stack in front of you. Keep it squared throughout: you play off the top and put winnings on the bottom, and a spilled stack costs you slaps.

Leave the centre of the table clear. That is where the pile builds, and it needs to be within slapping distance of every player, so push chairs in and get elbows off the table before you start.

The player to the dealer's left turns the first card, and play runs clockwise from there.

## Play

On your turn, lift the top card off your own stack and drop it face up in the middle of the table, on top of whatever is already there. Turn it away from you, holding the far edge, so that everybody sees the face at the same instant. Peeking at your own card before you play it, or turning it toward yourself, is the standard way to cheat at this game and is treated accordingly.

Almost every card does nothing. You turn it, and the turn passes to the player on your left. The pile just grows.

When a jack appears, everyone races to slap the pile. The first hand flat on the pile takes the whole thing: gather it up, square it, tuck it under your own stack face down, and shuffle that stack if you like. That player then

turns the first card of a new pile, and play continues clockwise from them. There are only four jacks in the pack, so piles can get big before one shows up.

If two or more hands land at what looks like the same moment, the bottom hand wins, meaning the one actually touching the cards rather than the back of somebody else's hand. If it is genuinely too close to call, do not split the pile: leave it in the middle exactly as it is, and let the player to the left of whoever turned the jack carry on turning cards onto it. The pile then goes to whoever wins the next jack.

A slap that lands on anything other than a jack costs you a card. Settling up works like this: whoever turned the card you wrongly hit is owed compensation, so you slide one card off the top of your own stack, sight unseen, over to them, and it goes underneath what they already hold. Where that forfeit ends up is the part people get wrong. It never goes into the centre for the next pile-winner to scoop up, which means a careless hand hands a measurable edge to one named opponent, and against somebody who swings at everything that trickle decides whole games. There is one hole in the rule, so patch it before you deal: a player who slaps a non-jack that came off their own stack owes a card to nobody in particular, and the simplest convention is to send it to their left-hand neighbour.

When you turn your last card you are not out yet. You stay at the table and you may still slap, so the very next jack is your way back: win that slap and the entire pile becomes your new stack. Miss it, meaning the pile is claimed by someone else while you have no cards, and you are out for good. You get exactly one chance, not an open invitation to keep slapping all game. While you are waiting on it you are skipped in the rotation, since you have nothing to turn; the turn passes to the next player who still has a stack.

A player who is out takes no further part. Their cards are already in circulation, so nothing needs to be redistributed and play carries on around the shrinking table.

One detail worth settling before you deal: a player with no cards who slaps a non-jack has nothing to hand over. The usual ruling is that they are simply out on the spot, having spent their one chance on the wrong card.

Play continues, jack by jack, until only one player is left holding cards.

## **Goal & scoring**

You are trying to finish holding every card in play: 52 with one pack, 104 if you dealt two. There is no scoring, no rounds and no partial credit. A player

who has been knocked out is out, and the last player still holding cards has by definition collected the lot.

A full game does take a while, especially with two players, because a large stack is not safe. One badly judged slap or one missed jack transfers a big pile and swings the whole game. Expect the lead to change hands several times.

If you want a guaranteed finish time, agree a stopping point before you start. Two common ones: play for a set fifteen or twenty minutes and give the win to whoever has the tallest stack, or play until the table is down to two and declare the larger stack the winner.

Speed matters less than people assume. What actually wins is watching the pile rather than your own hand, keeping your slapping hand hovering rather than resting, and not slapping at kings and queens, which at a glance look like jacks and account for most wasted cards.

## Variants

**More slappable cards** — Add extra triggers to the jack: a double, meaning the top two cards match in rank, and a sandwich, meaning two matching cards with exactly one card between them. Piles change hands far more often and the game finishes sooner. Keep piling on triggers and you arrive at Egyptian Ratscrew, which is the same idea with a longer pattern list and face-card challenges bolted on.

**Harsher false-slap penalty** — Instead of one card to the player who turned the card, a false slapper gives one card face down to every other player. On a full table that is a serious hit and it cures compulsive slapping in about two rounds. A gentler version used with young children replaces the card penalty with a warning and only starts taking cards on the second offence.

**Slap and call** — You must shout "jack" as you slap. Hitting the pile silently does not count, and calling "jack" when the top card is not one costs a card whether or not your hand landed. It slows the reflex race down slightly and gives a clear tiebreaker when two hands arrive together, since the caller is easier to judge than the hand.

**Two packs for a big table** — For six or more players, shuffle two 52-card packs together and deal them all out. Eight jacks in the pack instead of four means piles turn over about twice as often, which keeps a large table from sitting through long stretches of nothing. Every other rule stays the same, and the winner still needs every card in play.

Rules checked against: Bicycle Cards, Pagat, Wikipedia, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, PlayingCardDecks, Learning Board Games.

# Snap

|                   |                                            |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Players</b>    | 2-6 players (best with 4)                  |
| <b>Deck</b>       | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>       | 10-20 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b> | Simple                                     |
| <b>Category</b>   | Matching & collecting                      |

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## Setup

Snap takes two to about six players. Past six the table gets too wide to watch and too loud to judge, and the game stops being fun for whoever is refereeing it. Take the jokers out; only the thirteen ranks matter, and suit and colour are ignored from start to finish.

Any method of choosing a dealer will do, since dealing carries no advantage at all, and the deal can pass to the left if you play again. Shuffle well and deal singly, face down and clockwise, until the pack is gone. Hands rarely come out even, which changes nothing.

Nobody looks at a card at any point in this game, their own included. Square your cards into a face-down stack in front of you, with a clear space beside it. That space is where your face-up pile will grow, and it needs to sit where the rest of the table can see it, not tucked behind your arm.

The player on the dealer's left turns first, and the turn moves clockwise from there.

## Play

Your turn is one card: lift the top card of your own face-down stack and set it face up on your face-up pile. Flip it away from your body rather than toward it, so the face arrives for your eyes at the same instant it arrives for everyone else's instead of half a second early. Then the turn passes to your left.

What you are watching is not your own pile but the top card of every pile on the table. Two piles showing the same rank is a snap, no matter whose they are and no matter how far apart they sit. Rank only: a red six and a black six match, a six and a seven do not, and a card one layer down is dead for matching purposes however well people remember it.

The first player to shout "Snap!" takes both matching piles, turns the lot face down and slides it under their own stack. Winning a snap gains you cards and nothing else. The rotation carries on undisturbed, from whoever was next in order after the card that was turned.

Calling snap on nothing costs you, and the settlement runs outward rather than to one opponent: every other player gets a card from you, taken blind from the top of your stack and handed over face down, and each of them buries it beneath their own. If your face-down stack is empty when the bill comes, pay off the top of your face-up pile instead; if you cannot cover everybody, pay round the table to your left until you run out, and the rest is written off. If somebody swings at everything, three false calls and out is a reasonable patch.

Two people calling at once is what the game handles worst, because at real speed it is often genuinely undecidable. Where you can honestly separate the calls, the earlier one wins. Where you cannot, split nothing: push both matching piles into the middle, face up, as a snap pool, and carry on. The pool then behaves like an extra player's pile. Whenever a card turned onto any pile matches the pool's top card, the call is "Snap pool!", and the first player to make it collects the pool along with the pile that matched it. Pools only grow, so a table that argues a lot eventually plays for a very large prize.

When your face-down stack runs out, turn your face-up pile over without shuffling and keep going from it. A player with nothing in front of them at all, whose face-up pile has just been snapped away and whose stack was already empty, is out, and the rotation simply skips them from then on. Plenty of families let a knocked-out player stay at the table and keep calling snaps, on the reasonable grounds that a child eliminated in the first two minutes has a bleak evening ahead; settle which you are doing before you deal rather than in the middle of the argument.

Play continues until one player holds every card, or until whatever stopping point you agreed on. A snap pool left stranded in the middle when everybody else has been emptied out goes to the last player standing, since there is nobody left to race them for it.

## **Goal & scoring**

The aim is to finish holding all 52 cards, which happens once every other player has been emptied out. Nothing is scored, no rounds are played, and a tall stack earns you nothing by itself.

Left to run its course a game can take twenty minutes or end in two, depending entirely on how the ranks fall. Because a single snap moves two whole piles at once, a lead means very little until the table is down to the last two players.

Most groups fix a stopping point in advance instead of playing to the bitter end: ten or fifteen minutes on a timer, or an agreed number of snaps, with



the largest holding taking the win. Counting cards at the finish is the only counting the game ever asks for.

What actually wins is watching all the piles at once rather than the card in your own hand, and resisting the pull to call on near-misses. Court cards cause most of the wasted calls, since a jack and a king read as the same shape at a glance.

## Variants

**One pile in the middle** — Everyone turns their cards onto a single shared pile in the centre instead of keeping a pile each, and a snap is the top card matching the one immediately beneath it. Whoever calls first wins the entire central pile, buries it face down beneath their own stack, and then opens the next central pile with a card of their own, after which play resumes to their left. A player whose stack runs out has no face-up pile of their own to turn over, so they are out as soon as it happens unless you are using the convention that lets an empty-handed player carry on calling snaps. There is only one place to look, which makes it much kinder to very young children, and it is what a lot of households mean when they say Snap. Sources are split on which form is the real game, so say which you are playing.

**Snap pool as the penalty** — Rather than paying a card to each opponent, a player who calls snap wrongly forfeits their entire face-up pile to the middle of the table, where it forms or joins the snap pool. This makes a rash call genuinely expensive rather than a minor tax, and it feeds the pool steadily, so the game builds toward a few enormous swings instead of many small ones.

**Menagerie** — Each player picks an animal at the start, the sillier and longer the better. On a match you do not shout "snap" but the animal name belonging to the player whose pile matched yours, and only the correct name counts. The pause while you retrieve the name is the whole joke, and it puts adults and children on a far more even footing than a pure reaction test does.

**Speed Snap** — Drop the turn order. Everybody counts together and turns a card at the same moment, over and over, so several new top cards appear at once and matches come thick and fast. It is chaotic and short, and it works best with three or four players, since a full table produces more simultaneous calls than anyone can adjudicate.

**Grab instead of shout** — Put an object in the middle of the table, a spoon or a rolled-up handkerchief, and claim a snap by getting a hand on it rather than by calling. Ties become visible instead of audible, which is much easier to settle honestly, and the noise level drops enormously. Anyone grabbing when there is no match pays the usual false-call penalty.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Game Rules, Official Game Rules, PlayingCardDecks, Game On Family, Dummies.

# Spoons

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Pig, Donkey, Tongue                        |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-12 players (best with 8)                 |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-45 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                      |

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## Setup

Three players is the minimum and six or more is where the game comes alive; a dozen still works as long as everyone can reach the middle of the table. Take the jokers out.

Count the players and put out one spoon fewer: five spoons for six players, seven for eight. Any small object does the job, forks or poker chips or sugar sachets, provided they are all alike and none of them sits closer to one player than another. Cluster them tightly in the exact centre of the table. Nobody gets to rest a hand beside them while waiting.

Choose a dealer, shuffle, and deal four cards face down to each player. The dealer keeps the rest of the pack squared face down at their own right hand as a stock, and the dealer is the only person who ever draws from it. The player on the dealer's right is at the end of the chain and has nobody to pass to, so leave a clear space at their elbow for the discards that will pile up there.

Everyone picks up and looks at their four cards. Sort them fast, because nobody is going to say go.

## Play

There are no turns. Once the table has looked at its cards the dealer starts drawing, and from then on everybody runs continuously at whatever speed they can manage.

Only the dealer draws, and each draw sets off a chain down the circle. A fifth card in your hand is a card you are obliged to shed: whichever of the five does least for the set you are building goes face down to the neighbour on your left, who is now the one holding five and facing the same choice. The card keeps travelling in that direction for as long as the round lasts. Two rules keep it honest: one card at a time, and never fewer than four or more than five in hand. You may not let a queue build up so you can sift through it at leisure, and you may not shove two cards at once onto a neighbour who is drowning.

The player at the end of the chain, on the dealer's right, discards face down onto their own pile instead of passing. Should the stock run dry before anyone has four of a kind, the dealer takes that discard pile, picks it up exactly as it lies without shuffling, since nobody has seen a card in it, and carries on drawing from it, so the circle never actually stops.

What you are collecting is four of a kind. Four aces, four sevens, anything, and suits are irrelevant. The moment you have it, take a spoon. No announcement is required, and the entire art of the game is lifting one so smoothly that the table needs a second to catch up. As soon as any spoon leaves the middle, everyone may grab, regardless of what they are holding; you never need four of a kind to save yourself, only a spoon. One player ends up empty-handed, because the middle was one spoon short to begin with.

That player collects a letter, S on the first miss, then P, O, O, N, S. Complete the word and you are out. Every time somebody is eliminated, take a spoon out of the middle too, so the shortage stays at exactly one for the rest of the game.

Two situations come up often enough to be worth agreeing on before you deal. A player who grabs when no one has legitimately claimed a spoon takes the letter themselves, which is the standard cure for twitchy hands. And a spoon that has been touched and lifted belongs to whoever lifted it: no wrestling it back, however marginal the grab looked.

One deal is one round, and everything stops the moment the middle is bare: no more drawing, no more passing, whatever anyone is holding. Gather every card up, including the stock and the discard pile, shuffle the lot, deal four fresh cards each, and pass the deal one place to the left, skipping anyone who has already been knocked out.

## **Goal & scoring**

You are not really trying to win rounds, you are trying not to lose them. Assembling four of a kind guarantees you a spoon, but the far more common way to survive a round is simply to react quickly when somebody else does.

The scoring is the word itself, one letter for each round you finish empty-handed, and elimination on completing it. Six lives makes a long game with a big group: every round hands out exactly one letter, so eight players takes at least forty-two rounds, seven of them having to collect six letters apiece before the last one is standing. That is usually what you want at a party. Shorten it by using a shorter word, or drop the letters entirely and knock out the first player to miss.

The last player still holding letters to spare wins. What everybody actually remembers afterwards is not the winner but whoever was caught staring at a pair of kings while the middle of the table quietly emptied.

The players who last are rarely the fastest; they are the ones taking in the spoons and their own hand at the same time. Reading faces works too, which is the argument for gathering your four of a kind slowly and with a bored expression rather than pouncing on it.

## Variants

**Pig, Donkey and Tongue** — Play with no props at all. Instead of taking a spoon, a player completing four of a kind gives an agreed silent signal: a finger on the nose in Pig, hands held up beside the head as ears in Donkey, a stuck-out tongue in Tongue. Everyone else copies as soon as they notice, and the last to react loses a life, traditionally three lives in Pig and six in Donkey. Nothing can be knocked over or fought for, so this is the version for a car, a train or a small table, and it opens up the option of signalling when you have nothing.

**No stock, everyone passes at once** — Strip the pack down to exactly four cards per player, four ranks for four players and so on, and deal the whole thing out. There is no stock and no dealer advantage: on a signal, every player slides one unwanted card face down to their left and picks up the one arriving from the right, then does it again, as fast as the group can go. When a player is knocked out, remove a spoon and one rank's worth of cards together so the arithmetic stays right. This is the older shape of the game and the one usually printed under the name Pig.

**Sudden death** — Forget the letters. Whoever fails to get a spoon is out on the spot, and a spoon comes off the table with them. A game with eight players is over in six or seven quick rounds, which suits a group that wants the game as a filler rather than the evening's entertainment. It also raises the stakes on every single grab, since there is no cushion for one lapse of attention.

**Two packs for a crowd** — There are only thirteen ranks, so a very large group runs out of sets. Shuffle two packs together, deal four each as usual, and let a set be any four cards of the same rank, duplicates included. Beyond fixing the arithmetic it also puts more live ranks in circulation, so rounds end faster, which matters when a big circle can take a while to get a card all the way round.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Game Rules, Gambiter, Official Game Rules, Classic Games and Puzzles.

# War

|                      |                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | I Declare War, Battle, Bataille            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-4 players (best with 2)                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-45 minutes                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Matching & collecting                      |

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## Setup

Take a 52-card deck and remove the jokers. Shuffle well and deal the whole pack out face down, one card at a time, so that each player has an equal stack. With two players that is 26 cards each; with three, deal 17 each and set the odd card aside so the stacks are level; with four, 13 each.

Nobody looks at their cards at any point. Keep your stack squared up face down in front of you, and leave a clear space in the middle of the table where cards will be turned up.

Agree before the first battle on where won cards go, because the two usual methods behave differently. Either slide everything you win straight underneath your face-down stack, so you play from a single pile all game, or keep a separate face-down winnings pile beside it and only turn that pile over once your playing stack is exhausted. Whichever you choose, give the won cards a shuffle before they re-enter play; the reason is in the play section and it matters more than it sounds.

Ranking is the usual one with aces high: A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2. Suits are irrelevant from start to finish. There is no dealer advantage and no first player, because everybody acts at the same moment, so choosing who deals is purely a matter of convenience, and if you play several games in a row anyone may deal the next one.

## Play

Play is a series of battles. On each battle every player takes the top card of their stack and turns it face up in the middle at the same time. Whoever turned up the highest rank collects every card on the table and adds it face down to their own cards, using whichever of the two methods you settled on in setup. Suits never break a tie and never matter.

When the two highest cards are equal, that is a war. Each tied player puts three cards face down on top of the pile they are contesting, then turns one more card face up. The higher of the new face-up cards takes everything: in a two-player war that is ten cards, the two originals plus eight more.

If the face-up cards of the war are also equal, the war simply repeats. Each player again lays three down and one up, adding another eight cards to the pot, and again the higher card takes the lot. There is no cap on this. A second round is often called a double war and a third a triple war, and while three or four consecutive ties are rare, nothing in the rules stops the sequence from continuing.

Published rule sets differ on how many cards go face down, and both forms are in wide use. Three down and one up, often chanted as I-de-clare-war while the cards are dealt, is the version most people learn as children. Several standard references instead give a shorter form of a single card face down and a single card face up, which puts six cards at stake in a two-player war instead of ten and is noticeably quicker. Settle which one you are using before the first tie, since it changes how abruptly stacks change hands.

Running short of cards mid-war is the edge case that causes arguments. The usual ruling is that you put down as many face-down cards as you can spare and turn your very last card face up as your fighting card; if you have exactly one card left, that card is your face-up card and there are no face-down cards at all. A player who cannot produce a single card has lost. Some groups play the stricter version where failing to complete a full war loses the game outright.

When you play the last card of your face-down stack, pick up the cards you have won, shuffle them, and carry on with them as your new stack. If instead you have been putting winnings straight under your stack, shuffle each batch as you add it. The shuffling is not tidiness. War has no decisions in it, so a deal plus a fixed rule for returning won cards determines the whole game: if the cards always go back in the same order, a deal can enter a cycle in which the same sequence of battles repeats forever and neither player ever wins. Randomising the returned cards breaks any such cycle, and the game then ends with probability one.

With three or four players everyone flips at once and the highest card takes the whole table. Where the highest card is tied, only the players holding it fight the war; anyone who was beaten leaves their card in the pot and takes no further part in that battle. A player whose cards are gone is out, and the rest continue until one player holds everything.

## **Goal & scoring**

You win by taking every card in the deck. There is no scoring, no tricks to count and nothing to write down. No player ever makes a decision either: once the pack is dealt, the result depends only on the order of the cards

and on how won cards are put back, so there is no way to play the game well or badly.

Because cards keep circulating, a game can run far longer than beginners expect. Fifteen to thirty minutes is typical, but an hour is entirely possible, and a game between two evenly matched stacks can churn without either side making progress.

Most households therefore cap it. Play for a set time, or a set number of battles, and whoever holds the most cards at that moment wins. Counting is quick because the totals always add up to 52. Another common cap is to play three wars and stop, or to declare a win as soon as one player is reduced below some agreed number of cards.

## Variants

**One card down, one card up** — On a tie each player buries only a single card face down before turning up the deciding card, so six cards are at stake in a two-player war rather than ten. This is the form printed by several standard references and it shortens the game noticeably, since fewer cards are locked into each contested pot and players run their stacks down less abruptly. Repeated ties are handled the same way, one down and one up each time.

**Casino War** — The banked table-game version, played against a dealer. You bet, then you and the dealer each get one card and the higher card wins even money. On a tie you choose: surrender and forfeit half your stake, or go to war by matching your original bet, after which the dealer burns three cards and deals one more to each of you. Beating or tying the dealer on that second card wins even money on the raise while the original bet pushes. Where it is offered, a second tie pays a bonus, commonly equal to the original wager, but plenty of tables do not offer it at all. Most tables also carry an optional side bet that the first two cards will tie, typically paying 10 to 1.

**Three or more players** — Deal the pack out as evenly as possible, setting aside any remainder, and have everyone turn a card at the same time. The highest card sweeps the table. If two or more players tie for the lead, only the tied players fight the war, and cards already beaten stay in the pot as spoils for the eventual winner. Players drop out as their cards run out and the last one standing wins. Four players with two decks shuffled together keeps the same feel with more cards in motion.

**Timed War** — Set a timer, often ten or fifteen minutes, and play until it goes off. Whoever holds more cards at that point wins. This is the standard fix for the game's biggest flaw with young children, since it guarantees an ending and gives a clear result without anyone having to concede a stalemate that could otherwise go on indefinitely.

**Jokers wild** — Leave both jokers in the deck and rank them above the ace, so a joker beats every other card in the pack. With 54 cards the two-player deal is 27 apiece and the three-player deal is 18 apiece with no card left over. The two jokers are equal to each other, so if they meet you fight an ordinary war over them. Jokers make the sweeps more dramatic without adding any decisions, which is the whole appeal for younger players.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Bicycle Cards, Dice Game Depot, Geeky Hobbies, Gamerules.com, Wizard of Odds, Card Game Wiki.



## BLUFFING

# BS

|                      |                                                                                               |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Cheat, I Doubt It, Bullshit, Bluff, Doubt It                                                  |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-10 players (best with 5)                                                                    |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), jokers removed; 2 decks shuffled together for six or more players |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                                                 |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                                                      |

---

### Setup

Take the jokers out. One pack handles up to about five players comfortably. From six up, shuffle two packs together, which also raises the number of cards you can claim at once from four to eight.

Two can play, but the game is thin at that size: with only one opponent you know exactly where every card you do not hold must be, and there is almost nothing to hide. Four to six is where it works.

Pick a dealer any way you like; the deal passes to the left afterwards. Deal the entire pack out one card at a time, clockwise, until nothing is left. Hands will not come out even unless the player count divides into 52, and that is fine: a one-card difference has no effect. With four players everyone starts with thirteen.

Pick your cards up and sort them by rank. You want to be able to see at a glance how many of each rank you hold, because the whole game is a running calculation of what you can honestly play and what you will have to fake.

Leave the middle of the table clear for the discard pile. It starts empty and can grow to most of the deck.

The player to the dealer's left goes first and must claim aces. A common alternative is that whoever was dealt the ace of spades leads instead, again claiming aces. Either works; just say which one you are using before the first card goes down. Play runs clockwise.

### Play

Ranks are claimed in a fixed ascending cycle: ace, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, jack, queen, king, then back to ace and around again. The cycle belongs to the table, not to any player. Whatever rank the previous player claimed, you claim the next one up.

On your turn, place one to four cards face down on the pile, or one to eight

in a two-pack game, and say out loud how many and of what rank, for example "two nines". The rank is dictated by the sequence. The number is up to you, and so is whether the cards are actually what you said. You may play any cards you like under any claim.

You must play at least one card. You cannot pass and you cannot play zero. This is the engine of the game: sooner or later the sequence reaches a rank you hold none of, and you have to lie.

With a single pack the ceiling is four cards, since there are only four of each rank. With two packs it is eight. Claiming more than the pack allows is itself a giveaway.

Once your cards are down, any other player may challenge by calling "BS!" (or "Cheat!" or "I doubt it!"). The window stays open until the next player's cards hit the table, at which point the claim stands for good. Only one challenge is ever resolved, and it is the earliest one. Two people calling half a second apart is settled by ear. For a genuine dead heat there is no authoritative ruling anywhere, so pick a tie-break before you deal; the usual one is that the call from whoever sits nearest the challenged player's left is the one that stands.

A challenge is resolved by turning over only the cards that were just played, not the whole pile:

- If every one of them matches the claimed rank, the claim was honest and the challenger was wrong. The challenger takes the pile.
- If even one card is not the claimed rank, the player who played them takes the pile.

"The pile" means every card in the middle, including the cards that were just turned face up, and all of it goes into the losing player's hand. The rest of the pile is never exposed, so only the cards from the challenged play become public knowledge.

Either way the pile is now gone from the table and the next player starts a fresh pile. Picking up does not cost you anything else, and it does not skip anyone.

A challenge does not reset the rank cycle and does not change whose turn is next. Play carries on with the player to the left of whoever just played, claiming the next rank up, no matter who ended up with the pile. If the last claim was eights, the next claim is nines even if the eights turned out to be garbage and their owner is now holding twenty cards.

If nobody challenges, nothing is revealed. The cards stay face down on the pile and their true identity is never learned, which is exactly what makes

the game work: a successful lie is invisible.

Going out has one wrinkle. Playing your last cards does not finish you immediately; you are only out once the challenge window has closed. If someone calls BS on your final play and you were lying, you take the pile and you are back in the game with a fistful of cards. If you were telling the truth, the challenger takes the pile and you have won. If nobody calls, you are out and the game ends there.

## Goal & scoring

You are trying to empty your hand. The first player to get rid of every card, and survive any challenge to that last play, wins.

There is no point scoring at all. A game is a single deal and takes as long as it takes.

Many groups do not stop at the winner. Once someone is out, the rest keep going and note the order in which they finish; whoever is left with the only unplayed hand at the end takes last place. Anyone who has already finished is passed over on later circuits, and the rank sequence continues from wherever the last claim left it rather than starting over. Ranking the whole table this way keeps the people still in it invested after the first person leaves, and it turns second-to-last into an outcome worth chasing rather than a consolation.

A few practical points that decide games. Lie small: claiming one card is far less suspicious than claiming four, and it also costs you less to be caught early when the pile is short. Watch the pile size, because a challenge is only worth making when the pile is small or when you are certain. And count: if you hold three queens yourself, anyone claiming three queens is caught before they finish the sentence.

## Variants

**Free choice of rank (Bluff)** — Instead of a fixed ascending cycle, the player who starts a pile names any rank they like, and every player after them must claim that same rank until a challenge happens. Whoever ends up taking the pile starts the next one with a rank of their own choosing. This removes the forced-lie pressure of the ascending version, since you can open on a rank you actually hold, but it makes reading other players harder because nobody is ever obliged to lie. This is the version usually meant by the names Bluff and I Doubt It in older books.

**Up or down** — You may claim either the next rank above or the next rank below the previous claim. After "two tens" the next player may claim nines or jacks. Some groups also allow repeating the same rank, which gives you three

choices every turn. It makes honest play much easier, so lies become rarer and correspondingly more valuable, and it kills the standard tactic of counting ahead to work out which rank will land on you.

**Restricted challenge window** — Rules differ on who may call and for how long. The most common version lets any player call until the next player's cards touch the pile. A tighter house rule allows only the player to the immediate left of the one who played, which keeps the game fast and stops the whole table ganging up. A looser one lets anyone call at any point before the pile is next collected, so a claim can be caught several turns later. Settle this before dealing; it is the single most argued-about rule in the game.

**Extra penalty for a bad call** — A wrong challenger takes the pile and additionally draws a card from the hand of the player they falsely accused, or from every player at the table. This clamps down on speculative calls made purely to keep the pile small, and it makes challenging a real decision rather than a free option. Groups that find their games stalling because everyone calls constantly usually add some version of this.

**Restart the cycle after a pickup** — In the standard game a challenge changes nothing about the sequence: the next claim is one rank above the last one made, whoever ended up with the pile. A widespread house rule instead restarts the cycle at aces whenever a pile is collected, with the player to the left of whoever took it leading. It makes the game longer, because low ranks come round again and again, and it hands a small advantage to anyone holding aces and twos at the moment a challenge lands. Decide which of the two you are playing before the first card goes down.

**Two-pack table** — For six or more players, shuffle two 52-card packs together. Everyone still gets roughly the same hand size, but each rank now has eight copies, so claims of five, six or more are legal and the arithmetic of catching a liar changes completely. Holding three of a rank no longer proves much. Piles grow much larger, which makes getting caught genuinely punishing.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Bicycle Cards, Wikipedia, Official Game Rules, Game Rules, Denexa Games, PlayingCardDecks, Gambiter.

# Five Card Draw

|                      |                                                                 |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Draw Poker, Five-Card Draw, Jackpots                            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 6)                                       |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), plus chips or counters for everyone |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-60 minutes                                                   |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                          |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                        |

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## Setup

This is the poker most people picture when they picture poker: five private cards, one chance to swap some of them, and nothing at all on the table. Nobody ever sees a card that is not their own until the hands are compared, which makes it the shortest set of rules in the family and the sensible one to learn first.

Two people can play and six is about the ceiling, and the arithmetic sets that ceiling rather than taste: a player can consume eight cards in a hand, five dealt and three drawn, and six times eight is forty-eight of the fifty-two. Seven or eight can sit down, but then the pack can run dry part-way through the draw, which is why six is both the usual stated maximum and generally reckoned the best game.

Cards rank ace high, with the ace also serving as the low end of a five-high run. Suits never break a tie; equal hands divide the pot.

Give everyone chips and agree the stakes before anything is dealt. Decide at the same time whether betting is fixed-limit, which is traditional and keeps a home game friendly, or no-limit.

Every hand opens with an ante: each player pushes a small chip into the middle before the cards come out, so there is a pot worth playing for from the first turn. Rotate the deal clockwise after each hand, since dealing last is a real advantage and should be shared.

The dealer shuffles, offers a cut to the player on the right, and deals five cards to each player one at a time face down, going clockwise and starting on their own left. What is left of the pack stays face down in front of the dealer; it is the stock the draw comes from.

## Play

### THE FIRST BETTING ROUND

Pick up your five cards and keep them hidden. Betting opens on the dealer's left and runs clockwise. On your turn you may check while nobody has bet, bet if the round is still unopened, call the current amount, raise it,

or fold and drop out. The round ends when every player who has not folded has put in the same amount and everyone has had a turn. Under the usual fixed limit a round allows a bet and four raises, after which the betting is capped and the remaining players may only call or fold. If nobody bets at all, the hand is over before it has begun: the cards are thrown in, the deal passes on, and the antes stay in the middle with everyone adding another to them, so the pot grows until somebody is willing to open.

## THE DRAW

Starting with the first active player clockwise from the dealer, each player in turn says how many cards they want to change, slides that many face down toward the dealer, and is immediately dealt the same number of replacements from the top of the stock. Announce the number rather than silently pushing cards out, and wait while the dealer counts them; when the exchange moves on to the next player you should be holding exactly five, and any other total kills the hand. Sequence matters as much as arithmetic. Discards leave first and replacements arrive second, with no overlap between the two, which is what makes it impossible to accuse anyone of picking what to throw once they had already seen what came back.

Keeping all five is standing pat, and it is announced out loud like any other choice. The dealer draws last and serves themselves.

How many you may change is a house matter, so settle it before the first deal, along with whether the dealer burns a card off the top before dealing replacements — some do and some do not. Three is the common cap. Many home games allow a fourth card if you show the ace you are keeping, and games of five or fewer players often let you change all five. At a full table of six the cap has to stay at three or the pack will not stretch.

A stock that empties partway through the draw gets rebuilt rather than abandoned. What comes back is what earlier drawers traded away, together with any card burned and the bottom card of the pack where a table sets those aside; that heap is shuffled and cut, and the deal resumes from where it stalled. Folded hands stay dead. One set of cards is deliberately held back from it: whatever the player currently waiting on replacements has just pushed out, since the whole point of the exercise is defeated if somebody is handed back the very cards they chose to be rid of. None of this is workable unless the discards have been stacked neatly face down all along, so keep them that way from the first exchange.

## THE SECOND BETTING ROUND

A second round, opening with the same player who opened the first and following exactly the same rules. This is the round that carries the game's

information: how many cards each opponent took is the only public fact anyone has, and it is the thing you are reading and the thing you are dressing up. A player who stood pat is claiming something very strong and may well hold nothing.

## THE SHOWDOWN

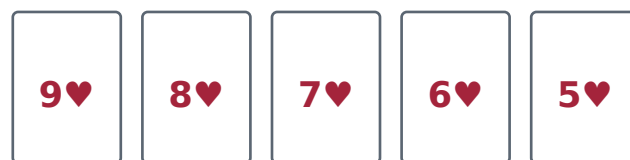
If two or more players remain, hands go face up. The player who made the last bet or raise shows first; if the round was checked around, the first remaining player clockwise from the dealer shows first. Anyone who is beaten may throw the hand in face down rather than reveal it.

The moment every other player folds, the last one standing takes the pot and shows nothing at all. That happens often, and it is a legitimate way to win rather than a lesser one.

Royal flush



Straight flush



Four of a kind



Full house

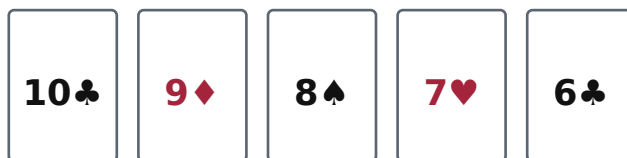


Hand rankings, part one: the four strongest categories. Any hand here beats every hand below it, whatever the individual card ranks.

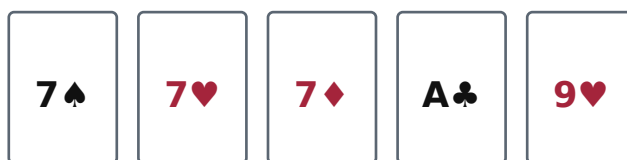
Flush



Straight



Three of a kind



Two pair

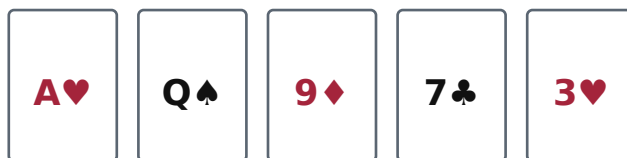


Hand rankings, part two: the middle four. A flush beats a straight, which is the ordering people most often get backwards.

One pair



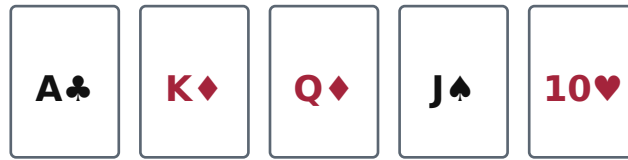
High card



Hand rankings, part three: the two weakest. Most showdowns are settled down here.



Broadway



The wheel



Not a straight



The ace does duty at both ends of a straight, but only at the ends. A run through the ace from king to two is not a straight.

## Goal & scoring

The object is the pot in the middle, and you get it one of two ways: by holding the best five-card hand when the hands are compared, or by betting in such a way that everyone else gives up first. Nothing is scored on paper and nothing carries from hand to hand; what you have is the chips in front of you.

Hands are compared by the standard poker categories. Ties within a category are broken by the ranks involved, highest first, and then by the remaining cards one at a time as kickers. Two hands that match on every card split the pot evenly, with any odd chip going to the player closest to the dealer's left. Since all five of your cards are yours alone, exact ties are far rarer here than in games built on shared cards.

A player who has run out of chips mid-hand may put in everything they have left and stay in for a proportional share: they can win from each opponent only as much as they themselves contributed, and any surplus is set aside as a side pot for the players still betting.

A session ends whenever the table decides. Count the chips, settle whatever the stakes were, and the person with the most in front of them has won.

## Variants

**Jacks or better (jackpots)** — The oldest fix for a game where everyone checks and nothing happens. No one may open the first betting round without

holding at least a pair of jacks, and the opener has to be able to prove it after the hand. If the whole table passes, the cards are gathered and dealt again with the antes left where they are, so the pot swells until somebody finally holds an opening hand. The requirement is sometimes raised to a pair of aces on a redeal.

**Lowball** — The ranking is turned upside down and the worst hand takes the pot, which changes what a draw is for entirely. Under the ace-to-five version the ace counts low and straights and flushes are ignored, so the perfect hand is five-four-three-two-ace. Under deuce-to-seven the ace is always high and straights and flushes count against you, making seven-five-four-three-two of mixed suits the best possible holding. Both are usually dealt with blinds rather than antes.

**Blinds instead of antes** — Borrowed from the modern casino games and now common online. Rather than everyone contributing equally before the deal, the two players clockwise from the dealer post a small and a big forced bet, and the first betting round opens with the player after them. It shifts the pressure onto rotating seats instead of taxing everybody every hand, and it pairs naturally with a no-limit betting structure.

**Wild cards** — A staple of kitchen-table games: some rank is declared wild and stands for whatever its holder needs, deuces wild being the usual choice, sometimes with jokers added to the pack. Agree beforehand whether five of a kind is possible and where it sits, since it beats even a straight flush. Wild cards inflate every hand at the table, so a full house stops being worth much and hand values need rethinking from scratch.

Rules checked against: Pagat, PokerNews, CardPlayer, PokerListings, Pokerology, Official Game Rules, Wikipedia.

# Mus

|                      |                                                                                          |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Musa                                                                                     |
| <b>Players</b>       | 4 players                                                                                |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 40 cards (8s, 9s and 10s removed), or a 40-card Spanish pack |
| <b>Time</b>          | 45-90 minutes                                                                            |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Complex                                                                                  |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                                                 |

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## Setup

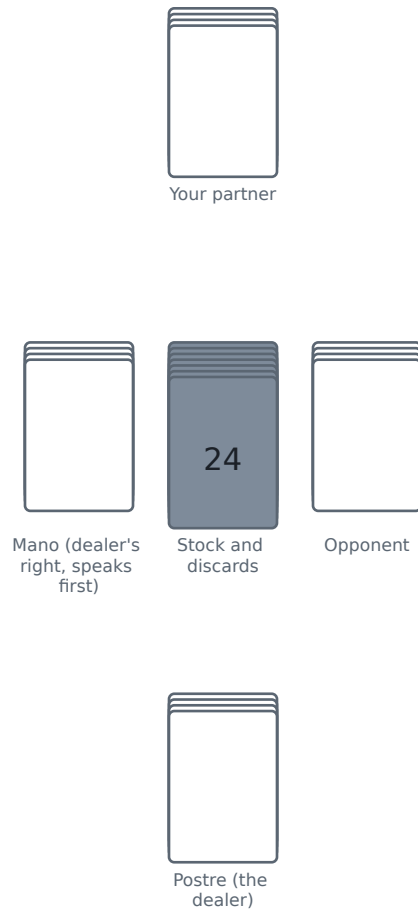
Mus is a four-player partnership game and that is the version everyone means by the name. Partners sit opposite one another so the two sides alternate round the table.

Use a forty-card Spanish pack, or an ordinary pack with the eights, nines and tens taken out, jack standing for the sota, queen for the caballo and king for the rey. Suits do not matter anywhere in the game — there are no flushes, no trumps, and nothing that asks what suit a card is.

Two ranks are impostors, and this single rule shapes almost everything else. Threes play exactly as kings and twos play exactly as aces, in all four betting rounds and for every purpose. The pack therefore behaves as though it holds eight kings and eight aces with only six ranks in between, which makes the highest and lowest cards common enough to fight over and the middle of the pack nearly worthless.

Choose a first dealer at random. The dealer gives four cards to each player one at a time, going anticlockwise, and the rest of the pack stays face down within reach. The player on the dealer's right is the *mano*: first to speak in every round and the winner of every tie. The dealer is the *postre* and always speaks last. Both roles move one seat to the right after each hand.

Score with small stones or beans, one pile per side. Points are called stones and five of them make an *amarraco* — *hamarreko* in Basque, a word that means a unit of ten rather than of five. The version described here runs to forty stones, eight *amarracos*. Thirty is the commoner target across most of Spain and forty the northern one, so agree which before the first deal. Twenty-two counters between the two sides cover a forty-point game, because no side ever has more than seven *amarracos* and four loose stones in front of it at once.



Four cards each, twenty-four left face down for the discard phase. Partners face each other, so an opponent sits on either side of you and every signal you send has to cross the table between them.

## Play

Mus runs in two phases: a public negotiation about whether to redraw, then four separate betting rounds fought over the same four cards.

The discard. Beginning with the mano and going anticlockwise, each player says mus or no hay mus. Only if all four say mus does anything happen: everyone then throws out between one and four cards face down — accounts differ on whether you may agree to mus and then keep all four — and the dealer replaces them from the stock, mano first. The question then comes round again, and there is no limit to how many times it can. The instant one player says no hay mus the discarding is over for that hand and the betting starts. If the stock runs short mid-replacement, shuffle the discards to make a new one — leaving out the discards of the player who is still owed cards, if only one player is short. Note what the question costs you: agreeing to mus tells three other people that what you were dealt is not good enough to keep, and refusing tells them that it is. Speaking first means giving that away first.

Signalling. Partners are allowed, and expected, to tell each other what they hold. The vocabulary is a fixed set of facial signals made across the table while the opponents watch for them: biting the lower lip is two kings, showing the tip of the tongue is two aces, raised eyebrows are duples, a wink is thirty-one, closed eyes are a hand with nothing in it at all. Lists vary by region and clubs publish their own, so settle which are in use before the first deal. What does not vary is the discipline. A signal has to be true: signing a holding you do not have is cheating, and so is inventing a sign the table has not agreed to. All the deception in mus happens in the betting; none of it happens in the signs. A sign may be made at any point in the hand, and catching an opponent mid-signal is a legitimate and much-enjoyed part of playing.

The four rounds. Grande, chica, pares and juego are played in that fixed order, each finished before the next begins.

- Grande is a contest for the highest cards. Compare best card against best card; if those match, compare the second, then the third, then the fourth.
- Chica is the same contest inverted, looking for the lowest hand and comparing from the bottom up.
- Pares is for matched ranks. Everybody first declares truthfully whether they hold anything at all, and only those who do take any part in the round. Two pairs (duples) beat three alike (medias), which beat a single pair (pares); inside a class the higher ranks win, and duples are compared on the better pair first and then on the other. Four alike has no name of its own and just counts as duples of that rank, so four sotas lose to a caballo pair alongside a pair of fives.
- Juego is for a hand whose four cards total thirty-one or more. Again everybody declares yes or no first. If nobody has juego, the round is played as punto instead — a contest for the highest total below thirty-one.

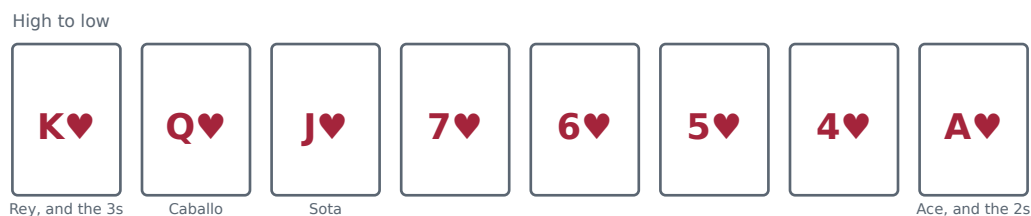
When a declaration round has nobody to argue with. If only one side declares for pares, or only one side for juego, there is nothing to bet against: that side takes the round outright and simply collects for what it holds. If nobody declares pares, the round is skipped and nobody scores from it at all. If nobody declares juego, the round is not skipped: punto is played in its place, betting and all.

Betting a round. The mano speaks first and each player in turn passes or bets. A bet is a number of stones, two at the minimum, and naming no number means two. Opponents may fold, accept, or raise. Folding closes the round with nothing shown and pays at once: one stone if the refused

call was the first bet of the round, otherwise the amount of the bet that was standing before it. Refuse a raise to twenty made over a bet of four and you pay four — not one, and not twenty. Accepting leaves the stake on the table to be settled when the cards come up. If all four pass, the round is still compared at the showdown and pays one stone to the better hand.

Ordago. In place of any bet or raise, a player may say ordago: an offer to settle the entire game on that one round. Refused, it pays like any other refusal: one stone if it was the first call of the round, otherwise the bet it was raised over. Accepted, all four hands go face up immediately and whoever wins that round wins the game outright, whatever the score happened to be.

The showdown. When the fourth round is over the hands are revealed and the rounds settled in the order they were played. A tie goes to whichever of the tied players sits nearest the mano, counting the mano first and then round anticlockwise — so the mano wins every tie and the postre loses every tie, while the two players in between beat each other in seating order rather than by side.



Card ranking, high to low. Only eight tiers, because the threes rank with the kings and the twos rank with the aces.

Duples



Medias



Pares



No pares



What counts in the pares round. Remember that a three is a king and a two is an ace, so K-3 is a pair of kings and A-2 is a pair of aces.

## Goal & scoring

A game is a race to forty stones and counters change hands twice over at the end of every hand.

First the stakes. Whichever side wins a round takes whatever was accepted on it. A round that was bet and then folded has already paid the bettor one stone during the betting and is never compared or shown, which is why folding cheaply on grande with a hand you intend to win chica with is an ordinary piece of play rather than a surrender. The one thing a refusal does not cancel is the pares and juego bonuses: the side whose bet went unanswered still won that round, so it still collects for the combinations its two members hold, and shows them to claim them. A round everybody passed on is still compared at the showdown and pays one stone to the better hand.

Then the combinations, and this is the part newcomers miss entirely. Pares and juego pay for the holding itself on top of any stake, and both members of the winning side collect for their own hands separately. A partnership that takes the pares round holding a pair on one side and three alike on the other is paid for both, so a strong hand can be worth several stones with

nobody having bet a thing. The scale pays most for what is hardest to hold, and juego is not ranked by size — thirty-one exactly is the best hand there is, and a hand of forty loses to one of thirty-two.

Counting. Five stones make an amarraco, usually shown by swapping five small counters for a large one, and eight amarracos — forty stones — win the game. Reaching seven of them obliges you to say dentro, warning the other side aloud that you are within five stones of the finish. A side that crosses forty stops the hand immediately, in the middle of a round if that is where it happens, so the order the rounds are settled in decides some games on its own. The best of three games is a vaca and three vacas usually take the match, though plenty of tables stop at the first vaca and call that the match.

The ordago is what all of this is really for. Because a single round can be made to carry the whole game, the ordinary stones are a currency you are spending to find out how your opponents behave, and the hand where you finally call one is meant to be the hand where you already know.

| Scores                     | Value                          | Notes                                                                    |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Grande, best hand          | 1                              | when nobody bet on the round                                             |
| Chica, best hand           | 1                              | when nobody bet on the round                                             |
| Pares: one pair            | 1                              | —                                                                        |
| Pares: medias, three alike | 2                              | —                                                                        |
| Pares: duples, two pairs   | 3                              | four of a kind counts as two pairs                                       |
| Juego of exactly 31        | 3                              | —                                                                        |
| Any other juego            | 2                              | —                                                                        |
| Punto, best hand under 31  | 1                              | played only when nobody has juego                                        |
| Minimum bet                | 2                              | —                                                                        |
| Bet or ordago refused      | 1 or the standing bet          | 1 if it was the first call of the round, else the bet it was raised over |
| Card value: rey or 3       | 10                             | —                                                                        |
| Card value: caballo        | 10                             | —                                                                        |
| Card value: sota           | 10                             | —                                                                        |
| Card value: 7, 6, 5, 4     | face value                     | —                                                                        |
| Card value: ace or 2       | 1                              | —                                                                        |
| Juego, best to worst       | 31, 32, 40, 37, 36, 35, 34, 33 | —                                                                        |
| Punto, best to worst       | 30 down to 4                   | —                                                                        |

## Variants

**Four kings (a cuatro reyes)** — In Navarre, La Rioja and parts of the Basque Country the game keeps its older form: the same forty cards, but threes and



twos counting as themselves rather than as kings and aces. The pack then holds four kings and four aces, the ranking runs rey, caballo, sota, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, ace, and in the juego a three is worth three points and a two is worth two. Good hands become much rarer, which is the whole point of it — less rides on being dealt an unbeatable hand and more on the betting. The ciego sign for a hopeless hand is generally not recognised in this version, and the four-king pack tends to travel with the forty-point game as the eight-king pack travels with the thirty-point one.

**Game length and vacas** — Thirty stones is the standard target across most of Spain and forty the northern one. Matches are variously the best of three games, three vacas of three games each, or five games and five vacas. It is worth agreeing before the first deal, because the target changes how reckless an ordago is: staking a game you are two stones from winning is a different proposition from staking one you have barely begun.

**Restricted or banned signalling** — Published lists of the signs do not agree with one another and none of them claims to be complete — one has a single shrug for a punto of thirty where another distinguishes thirty, twenty-nine and twenty-eight by which shoulder is lifted. In Navarre and many other places the first hand of every game is played without signs at all. Since the entire balance of the game rests on how much information a partnership can move across the table under the opponents' noses, agreeing the list is the thing most worth doing before you sit down.

**Three, five and six players** — Three or five play Encaje, also called Mus Francés: the same cards and the same four comparisons, but no partnerships, no ordago, and the object turned inside out. Everyone starts with an equal pile of stones, winning a round lets you throw stones out of the game, players drop out as they empty, and the last one still holding any is the loser. Six can play as two teams of three seated alternately, with the rules and the scoring exactly as in the four-handed game.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Naipes Heraclio Fournier, Gambiter, Denexa Games, Ludoteka, Torofun, Bizkaia.eus.

# Omaha

|                      |                                                                 |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Omaha Hold'em, Omaha Holdem, Pot-Limit Omaha, PLO               |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-10 players (best with 6)                                      |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), plus chips or counters for everyone |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-120 minutes                                                  |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                          |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                        |

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## Setup

Four cards each instead of two, and a rule about how many of them may be used. That is the whole difference from the shared-card game most people learn first, and it changes more than it sounds like it should.

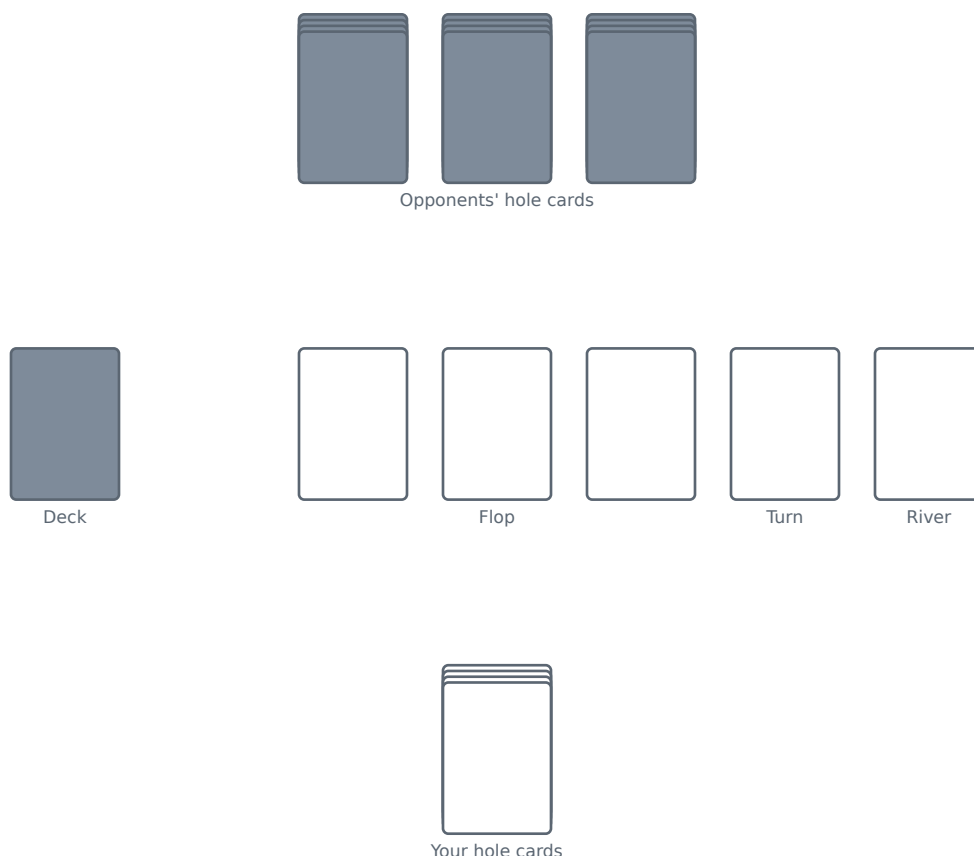
Everyone plays from a stack of chips in front of them. What is on the table is what you can lose in a hand and what you can win from anyone else; you never reach into a pocket mid-hand, though between hands you may usually top up to whatever the table allows. Six players makes the standard game and nine or ten fills a table, but it works down to two.

A marker called the button shows who is nominally dealing, and it moves one seat clockwise after every hand. It decides the order everyone speaks in, so moving it is what shares out the advantage of acting late.

Before any card is dealt, the two players clockwise of the button put in forced bets: the small blind first, then the big blind, usually double it. These exist so that the first hand of the night already has something in the middle worth playing for, and they are how stakes get named — a one-two game means blinds of one and two. Heads-up the order inverts, with the button posting the small blind and acting first before the shared cards appear and last after them.

The dealer then gives four cards face down to each player, one at a time clockwise from the small blind. Nobody sees anyone else's until a showdown, and a hand shown at a showdown must be shown in full — all four, not the two that played.

Cards rank ace high, and the ace also serves as the low end of a five-high run. Suits never break a tie. Equal hands split the pot.



Four cards in front of each player and five in the middle. A finished hand takes exactly two from your own four and exactly three from the board — no other combination is legal, however good it looks.

## Play

One rule governs everything else, so it comes first. Exactly two of your four cards, and exactly three of the five on the table. Not one, not three, not all four. It is not a maximum and not a minimum, and it applies to every hand you ever make here.

That single sentence is what people misread, and they misread it in the same direction every time. Holding three hearts with two more on the board is not a flush, because only two of yours may play and the board offers only two more. Holding an ace when the board shows four to a straight does not make you that straight either. Read the hand as a fixed shape rather than a pool of seven cards, and it stops catching you out.

A hand runs through four betting rounds, with the dealer turning more shared cards between them.

### WHAT YOU CAN DO ON YOUR TURN

- Check. Pass the turn along without staking anything, which is only open to you if nobody has bet yet this round.
- Bet. Be the first to put chips in.

- Call. Match the most anyone has staked this round.
- Raise. Put in more than that, which brings the turn back round to everyone still in.
- Fold. Give the hand up. What you have already staked stays where it is.

A round closes when everyone still holding cards has acted and everyone still in has staked the same amount for that round, all-ins aside. Chips already in the middle are never taken back.

## BEFORE THE FLOP

The blinds are live bets, so the round opens on the player clockwise of the big blind, who must at least match it to continue. It runs clockwise and ends on the big blind, who may raise even when nobody else has.

## THE FLOP, THE TURN, THE RIVER

The dealer burns a card face down and turns three face up in the middle; a betting round follows. Then a burn and a fourth card, and a round. Then a burn and a fifth, and the last round. From the flop onwards the first player still in clockwise of the button speaks first and the button speaks last.

## HOW MUCH YOU MAY BET

Pot limit is the usual structure and the one the game is named for in its commonest form. The ceiling on a bet is what the pot holds; the ceiling on a raise is what the pot would hold once you had called, which is the part worth doing slowly.

Work it in that order. Say the middle holds 50 and someone bets 50, so there is 100 out there. You call the 50 in your head first, making 150, and 150 is what you may raise by. Put in 200 altogether and the pot stands at 300. Repeat that twice and the reason people call pot limit a shove in slow motion is on the table in front of you.

The floor on a raise is the size of the last bet or raise. A short all-in below that does not reopen the betting for anyone who has already acted for the full amount, though it does not restrict a player yet to speak.

All-in works as it does anywhere: you may always put your last chip in, you can win from each opponent only as much as you staked yourself, and anything wagered past that is set aside in a side pot for the players who covered it.

## THE SHOWDOWN

If two or more are left after the final round, cards come face up. The last player to bet or raise shows first; if nobody bet, it is the first player clockwise of the button. Beaten hands may be mucked face down rather

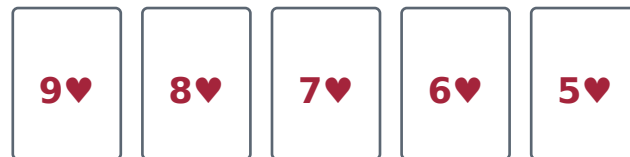
than shown.

Each player names their best five cards under the two-and-three rule, and a hand in contention has to be shown complete — all four hole cards, including the two that did nothing. A hand can also end long before this: the moment everyone else folds, whoever is left takes the pot without showing anything.

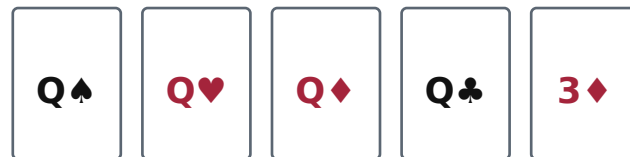
Royal flush



Straight flush



Four of a kind



Full house

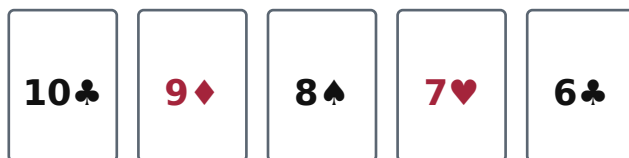


Hand rankings, part one: the four strongest categories. Any hand here beats every hand below it, whatever the individual card ranks.

Flush



Straight



Three of a kind



Two pair

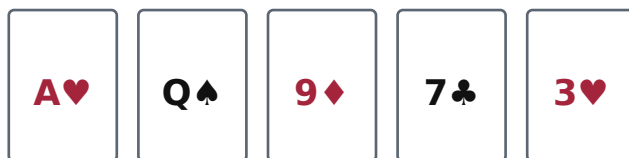


Hand rankings, part two: the middle four. A flush beats a straight, which is the ordering people most often get backwards.

One pair

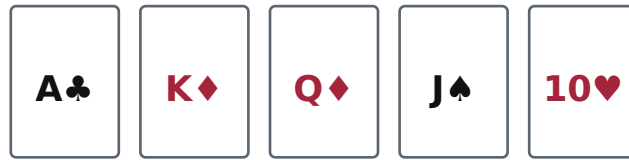


High card



Hand rankings, part three: the two weakest. Most showdowns are settled down here.

Broadway



The wheel



Not a straight



The ace does duty at both ends of a straight, but only at the ends. A run through the ace from king to two is not a straight.

## Goal & scoring

There is no running score. Each hand is a fight over one pot, and there are two ways to take it: hold the best five cards at the showdown, or be the last player who has not folded. Nothing distinguishes the two afterwards — an uncontested pot spends the same.

Hands are compared by the standard poker categories, and within a category by rank, with leftover cards settling near-ties in order. The categories are the ones on the strips above and mean here exactly what they mean everywhere else. What differs is which hands are reachable: because three of your five cards always come off the same board everyone shares, made hands run much bigger than players arriving from a two-card game expect. A flush that would win a Hold'em pot outright is an ordinary holding here, and two players making the same straight is common enough that splitting is a normal outcome rather than a curiosity.

The same board also means nobody can hold a hand the board does not offer. If the five shared cards contain no pair and no three of a suit, then nobody at the table has a full house or a flush, whatever they are representing. Reading what is impossible is most of what separates players here.

Equal hands split the pot; an odd chip goes to the first player clockwise of the button. Where all-ins have built side pots, each is settled on its own among the players who were in it, so a short stack can take the main pot while a stronger hand collects everything above it.

A cash game has no end: chips are stakes, you may join or leave between hands, and your result is whatever is in front of you when you stand up. A tournament ends when one player holds every chip, with equal starting stacks, blinds rising on a clock, and finishing position rather than chip count deciding where you came.

## Variants

**Omaha hi-lo, eight or better** — The pot is divided between the best high hand and the best qualifying low one. A low has to be five cards of different ranks, none higher than an eight, and straights and flushes do not count against it, so the best possible low is A-2-3-4-5 — which is also a straight, and can therefore win both halves at once. The two-and-three rule applies separately to each half, so the two cards making your low need not be the two making your high. When no low qualifies, the high hand takes everything. Sharing half a pot with another low is called being quartered, and it is how a hand that looked strong ends up losing money.

**Five-card Omaha, and Big O** — Five hole cards each rather than four, with the showdown rule untouched: still exactly two from your hand and three from the board. The extra card multiplies the possible two-card combinations from six to ten, which raises the winning hand again and makes the game markedly looser. Played high-only it is usually called five-card Omaha; played hi-lo eight-or-better it is Big O.

**Courchevel** — Five hole cards, and the first of the shared cards is turned face up before the opening bets rather than as part of the flop. Everyone therefore acts before the flop already knowing a fifth of the board, and the flop itself adds only two more cards. Played both high and hi-lo.

**No-limit and fixed-limit Omaha** — The same game with a different ceiling on the betting. Fixed limit, once the standard form, keeps every bet at a set size and caps the raises in a round, which suits hi-lo where hands are often split and building a huge pot serves nobody. No limit exists but is rare, because four cards make strong hands so often that threatening a whole stack loses much of its meaning.

Rules checked against: [Pagat](#), [Wikipedia](#).



# Seven Card Stud

|                      |                                                               |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Seven-Card Stud, 7-Card Stud, Down the River, Seven-Toed Pete |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 7)                                     |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), plus chips to bet with            |
| <b>Time</b>          | 60+ minutes                                                   |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                      |

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## Setup

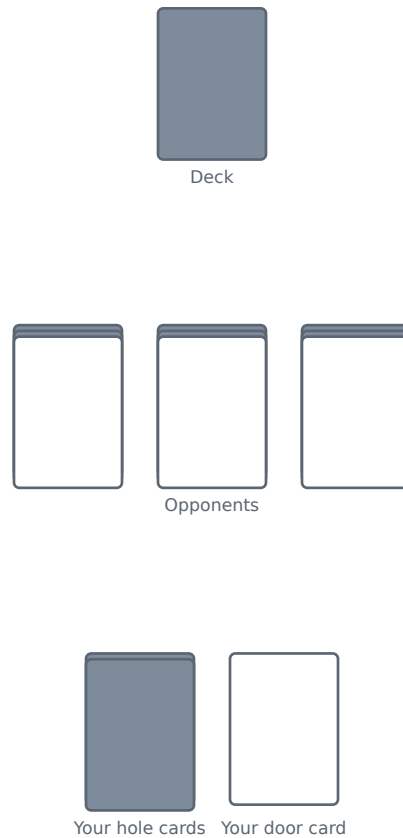
One 52-card pack, a stack of chips, and anywhere from two to eight players, with five to seven the range it plays best over. Eight is the ceiling, and it is a genuine limit rather than a habit: eight hands that all run to the end would want fifty-six cards, and the pack holds fifty-two.

Ordinary poker rankings apply, from high card up through one pair, two pair, three of a kind, straight, flush, full house, four of a kind and straight flush. The ace sits at either end of a straight, so A-K-Q-J-10 is the highest and 5-4-3-2-A the lowest, but it does not turn the corner and Q-K-A-2-3 is nothing at all. Suits never separate two hands of equal rank.

Before any card is dealt every player puts an ante into the pot. The ante is small — around a tenth of the smaller bet is usual — but it is what makes the first round worth fighting over, since there are no blinds in stud and nothing else is at stake.

Nearly every stud game is fixed limit, and the two bet sizes are named before you sit down. Take a 10 and 20 game as the working example: 1 to ante, 3 to bring in, bets and raises of 10 on the first two rounds and 20 on the last three. Most rooms cap a round at a bet plus three raises.

There is no button and no blind, so position does not rotate. A card room puts a house dealer behind the cards; at home the deal passes to the left after every hand, and the seat that dealt matters only as the starting point for the rare tie in who acts first. Otherwise who speaks first is decided fresh on every round by the cards lying face up, and that is the structural difference between stud and the flop games that pushed it aside.



Third street, with three of the up to eight seats shown. Everyone holds two cards nobody can see and one that everybody can, and that single exposed card is all you have to read an opponent by.

## Play

Third street. Three cards each, the first two hidden and the third turned up. That exposed one is the door card. The player showing the lowest door card has no choice about opening: they must post the bring-in, a forced part-bet. Ranks run in the ordinary order here, ace high, so an ace showing is never the bring-in and a deuce nearly always is. Two players showing the same rank have to be separated somehow, and suit does the separating: spades sit above hearts, hearts above diamonds, diamonds above clubs. Between a pair of exposed deuces, then, the obligation lands on whichever of them is a club. That player may instead put out a full small bet, which is called completing. Play then moves clockwise and each player folds, calls or raises in turn.

Fourth street. A fourth card, face up, to everyone still in. From here to the finish the round is opened by whoever shows the best board — the strongest poker hand among the exposed cards alone, hole cards ignored — and that player is free to check rather than being made to bet. Where two boards are exactly as strong as each other, the usual casino answer is position — the tied player sitting nearest the dealer's left goes first — though some accounts break the tie by suit instead, the way the bring-in is

broken. Worth agreeing on, because it is the only thing the dealer's seat decides all hand. The limit is still the small one, with a single exception peculiar to fixed limit: if any player's two exposed cards make a pair, this street may be played at either size, and the choice is open to everyone rather than to the pair alone. Whoever bets first picks the size; a player facing the small bet may raise to the big one; and once a big bet is in, every bet and raise for the rest of the street is big.

Fifth street. A fifth card, face up. The big bet takes over here and never goes back down.

Sixth street. A sixth card, face up, and another round at the big limit, opened again by the strongest board.

Seventh street, or the river. The last card comes face down. A hand that goes the distance therefore holds two hidden, four exposed and one more hidden. Since the river is dark, the boards have not changed, so the player who opened the sixth street round opens this one as well — or, if that player folded, the best board still live.

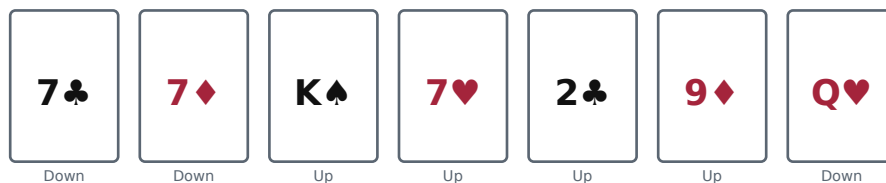
The pack is the one thing that can give out. Casino dealers burn a card off the top before each street after the first, four burns in a full deal, and a full table is tight to begin with: eight hands that all run to the end want fifty-six cards plus those four burns, against a deck of fifty-two. The remedy comes in two steps. First the burned cards are fetched back from under the pot and shuffled into what is left of the stub, which is usually enough. If it is not, the last street stops being dealt privately at all: a single card is exposed in the centre, every hand still live treats it as the seventh card it never personally received, and the round is opened by whoever that card makes the best board for. Cards thrown in by players who folded are dead and never come back, so what actually forces the community card is an eight-handed table with nobody folded by the time the last card is due — which is why it is a rule you will read far more often than you will see.

A betting round ends once every player still in has put in the same amount, or once it has been checked all the way round. A player without the chips to call is all in: they play for the portion of the pot they have matched, betting between the others carries on into a side pot beside it, and they take no further part in the betting while still being dealt their remaining cards. Should everybody but one fold at any point, that player collects the pot and is under no obligation to show anything.

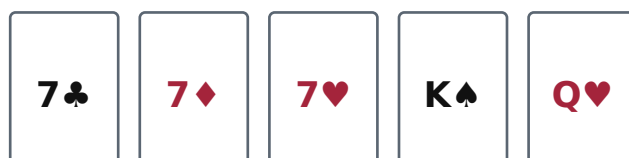
Watching the folded cards is not a flourish, it is the skill the game rewards. Every upcard that appears is information you keep, and it does not go away when its owner throws the hand in. Wanting the last king when three of

them have already been mucked is a different proposition from wanting it when none have.

The seven you hold



The five that play

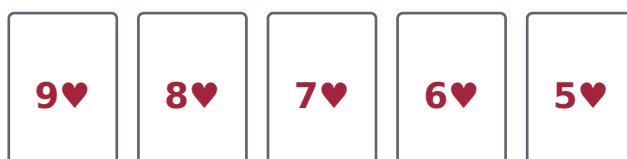


A finished hand: two down, four up, one down. Five of the seven make your hand and the other two are simply left out; there is no requirement to use any particular card.

Royal flush



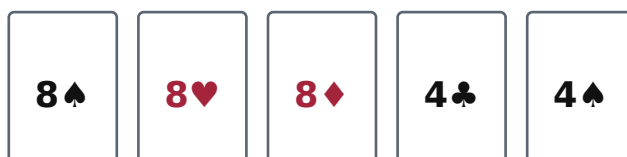
Straight flush



Four of a kind



Full house

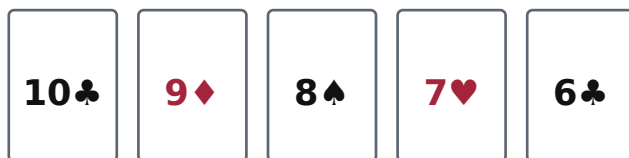


Hand rankings, part one: the four strongest categories. Any hand here beats every hand below it, whatever the individual card ranks.

Flush



Straight



Three of a kind



Two pair

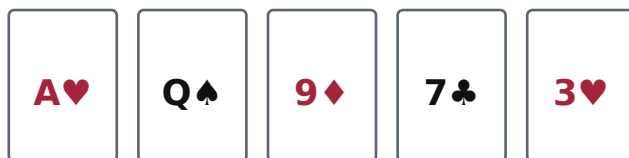


Hand rankings, part two: the middle four. A flush beats a straight, which is the ordering people most often get backwards.

One pair

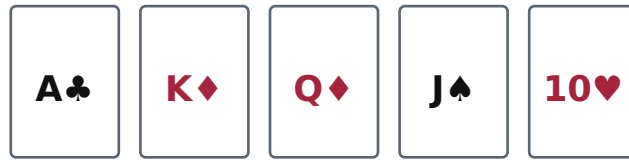


High card



Hand rankings, part three: the two weakest. Most showdowns are settled down here.

Broadway



The wheel



Not a straight



The ace does duty at both ends of a straight, but only at the ends. A run through the ace from king to two is not a straight.

## Goal & scoring

You win a pot one of two ways: everybody else folds, or you hold the best five-card hand when the cards go on their backs. Those five are the best you can pick out of your seven, and the leftovers count for nothing.

At the showdown the player who made the last bet or raise on the river turns their hand face up first, and the rest follow clockwise. Where the final round was checked all the way round, the player who opened it — the best board — shows first. Nobody is obliged to expose a hand they know is beaten; mucking it face down is allowed and forfeits any claim on the pot.

Rankings are the standard ones, and two hands in the same category are separated by the ranks inside them. Hands that are still identical after that split the pot. Suits do two jobs in stud and neither is ranking hands: they decide the bring-in, and they help settle an odd chip that will not divide. Between two equal hands that chip goes to whichever of them holds the highest card by suit; between a high hand and a low one in a split-pot game it simply goes to the high hand.

Nothing is scored cumulatively. Chips move pot by pot, you buy in for what you are willing to lose, and you leave when you want to. If you are playing at home for nothing, deal a fixed number of hands and see who has the biggest stack at the end.

| Scores            | Value | Notes                            |
|-------------------|-------|----------------------------------|
| Ante, each player | 1     | roughly a tenth of the small bet |

|                                    |                         |                                                                       |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bring-in, lowest door card         | 3                       | a third to a half of the small bet                                    |
| Third and fourth street            | 10                      | the small bet                                                         |
| Fifth, sixth and seventh street    | 20                      | the big bet                                                           |
| Open pair showing on fourth street | 10 or 20                | open to any player, not just the pair; the first bettor sets the size |
| Raises permitted per round         | a bet plus three raises | house rules vary, and the cap is often lifted heads-up                |

## Variants

**Razz** — The same seven-card structure played for the worst hand rather than the best. Straights and flushes are ignored entirely and the ace is always low, so the perfect holding is 5-4-3-2-A, called the wheel. Two rules flip with the objective: the bring-in falls on the highest door card rather than the lowest, and from fourth street onwards the round is opened by the lowest board, not the highest. The limits simply double at fifth street, with a pair showing making no difference to the size of a bet. Because there is no qualifier, somebody always wins the pot.

**Seven Card Stud Hi-Lo, Eight or Better** — The pot is cut in half between the best high hand and the best low one. To count as a low, a hand needs five cards of different ranks with nothing above an eight; straights and flushes do not spoil it, and the ace plays low. You are free to build your high and your low out of different fives from the same seven cards, which is why a single hand can take both halves, a result called scooping. When no low qualifies, the high hand takes everything. Marked 7-Stud 8/b on most rotation lists, and part of the eight-game mix.

**Five Card Stud** — The ancestor, and much starker: one card down and four up, with a betting round after each upcard, so four rounds instead of five. With four of your five cards on show there is almost nothing to conceal, which is exactly why it faded once seven-card stud arrived. It still turns up in home games and in old films, usually the one where somebody has a hidden ace.

**Pot-limit and no-limit stud** — The same deal with the betting unshackled: you may wager up to the size of the pot, or in no-limit anything in front of you. The fourth-street open-pair rule disappears along with the fixed limits, since there are no longer two sizes to choose between. Rare in card rooms, because betting big into four exposed cards is a good deal less forgiving than doing it in hold'em.

**High-low with declaration** — A home-game version of the split pot with no eight qualifier. After the last betting round, each player conceals their declaration in a fist and everyone opens at once: one chip for high, an empty hand for low, two chips for both. Only what you declared can win, so a player who declares both and then loses — or even ties — either half gets nothing at all. It adds a real bluffing layer that eight-or-better does not have, and it needs

a table that agrees in advance on what happens when a declaration goes wrong.

Rules checked against: Pagat, PokerNews, Card Player, Upswing Poker, Robert's Rules of Poker, PokerStars, Wikipedia.



# Teen Patti

|                      |                                                           |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Teen Pathi, Flash, Flush                                  |
| <b>Players</b>       | 3-8 players (best with 5)                                 |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards); chips or counters for the pot |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                             |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                      |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                  |

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## Setup

Teen Patti is Hindi for "three cards", and that is the whole of the equipment list: three cards each, a pot in the middle, and everyone playing against everyone else. Nobody banks it. It is close kin to the British game of Three Card Brag and a fixture of Diwali gatherings across India, which is where most people meet it.

Any sensible number can play — four to seven is where it sits best. An ordinary 52-card pack, aces high down to twos, and no jokers unless you have agreed otherwise.

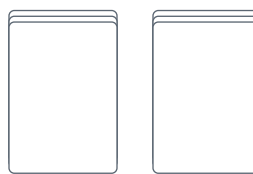
Agree the minimum stake before anything else, because every number in this game is a multiple of it. Call it one unit. Everyone puts one unit into the pot as the boot, and the pot is what the hand is played for.

The dealer gives out three cards each, singly, face down.

Then the choice that makes this game what it is. You may look at your cards, or you may leave them alone. A player who has looked is seen; a player who has not is blind. Blind players bet half what seen players do, which is a real and permanent discount for going in with no idea what you are holding — and going the other way is a one-way door. Once you look, you are seen for the rest of the hand.



Playing blind



Playing seen

Three cards each, and the only visible difference between two players is whether they have picked theirs up. Blind players bet half as much and cannot be forced to a show.

## Play

Betting opens to the dealer's left and travels clockwise for as many circuits as it takes. At your turn you either put money in and stay, or fold and lose whatever you have already staked. There is no equalising of bets here and no calling: this is not poker betting, and there is no such thing as a

showdown among three or more players.

What you must pay turns on a running figure called the current stake, which starts at one unit. Both rates are ranges, and each also decides what the next player inherits:

- Blind. Put in anything from one stake up to two, and no more. Whatever sum you lay down is passed on unchanged as the next player's stake.
- Seen. Put in anything from two stakes up to four. What gets passed on is half of it.

That halving is the mechanism behind the discount. A blind player is always paying about a unit where a seen player pays two, all the way down the table, and the stake climbs only as fast as somebody deliberately pushes it. A blind player may look at their cards when their own turn arrives, and pays the seen rate from that moment on.

The hand ends one of two ways. Everybody but one folds, and that player collects without exposing a thing — which is what makes bluffing pay. Or the field narrows to two and one of them buys a show.

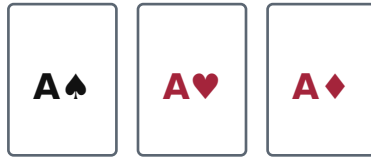
The show has its own rules and they are pointedly not symmetrical:

- Nobody can call for one while three or more players are still in.
- Blind, it costs you one stake, no matter what your opponent is. Your own cards stay face down until the money is in the pot.
- Seen, against a blind opponent, you are not allowed to ask at all. Bet on, or get out. That prohibition is the blind player's protection and it is worth a great deal.
- Two seen players: either of them may buy it, for two stakes.

Both hands then go face up and the better one takes the pot. On a tie the player who paid for the show loses, which is the price of being the one who asked.

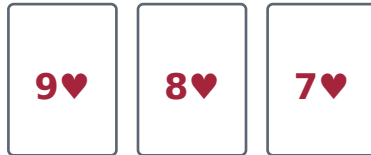
There is one more move, available only when every player still in the hand is seen. Immediately after putting in the minimum, you may ask the player who bet just before you for a compromise, also called a sideshow. They can refuse, in which case betting simply carries on with the next player and nothing is lost but information. If they accept, the two of you compare cards privately, and whoever is lower folds on the spot — and on a tie it is the asker who goes. It is a way of removing one opponent without exposing anything to the table.

Trio



The best hand

Straight run



A run in one suit

Normal run



Suits need not match

The three strongest hands. A run beating a colour is the thing that catches poker players out, and it is correct: with only three cards, runs are rarer than flushes.

Colour



One suit, no run

Pair



The odd card breaks ties

High card



Best of its kind

The three weakest. Category always settles it before rank does, so the feeblest run there is, 4-3-2, beats the finest colour there is.

## Goal & scoring

Win the pot. There is no running score and nothing carries between hands — each deal is settled in full and the cards go back in.

Six kinds of hand, and any hand of a better kind beats any hand of a worse one outright. Within a kind, you compare rank:

- Trio, three of a rank, ranked by that rank — aces at the top of them, twos at the bottom.
- Straight run, a three-card run with all three in one suit.
- Normal run, the same but with the suits not matching.
- Colour, three cards of one suit that do not run. Compare the top card, then the next, then the last: A-K-J is the best and 5-3-2 the worst.
- Pair. Compare the pair first and only then the spare card, so A-A-K is the best pair hand and 2-2-3 the worst.
- High card, none of the above. A-K-J is the best of these and 5-3-2 the worst.

Runs wrap at one end only. Both A-K-Q and A-2-3 are legal, and both are better than K-Q-J. Which of the two tops the other is a genuine disagreement between good sources — some rank A-2-3 highest, others A-K-Q — so settle it at your own table before the first deal rather than over an exposed hand. What nobody allows is going round the corner: K-A-2 is not a run at all, though three of a suit will still make a colour of it.

The pot goes to the last player standing, or to the better hand at a show. Some tables split the pot on a tied show instead of giving it to the player who did not ask; that is the other rule worth agreeing in advance.

| Scores                          | Value                       | Notes                                                       |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Boot, before the deal           | 1 unit each                 | —                                                           |
| A blind player's bet            | 1 to 2 times the stake      | —                                                           |
| A seen player's bet             | 2 to 4 times the stake      | —                                                           |
| New stake after a blind bet     | the amount just staked      | —                                                           |
| New stake after a seen bet      | half the amount just staked | —                                                           |
| Show demanded by a blind player | the current stake           | allowed against a seen or a blind opponent                  |
| Show demanded by a seen player  | twice the current stake     | only against another seen player, never against a blind one |
| Compromise, or sideshow         | nothing extra               | only when every remaining player is seen; may be refused    |

## Variants

**Jokers wild** — Shuffle in the two jokers and treat them as any card their holder likes, which lifts a middling three cards into a trio far more often than feels reasonable. It makes the game louder and shorter and materially devalues everything below a run, since a single wild card turns any pair into a trio. Some tables instead nominate an ordinary rank as wild for the hand — the deuces, or a card turned up before the deal — which has the same effect with less of the all-or-nothing feel.

**A limit on playing blind** — Cap how long anybody may stay blind: three turns is a common figure, after which you must look at your cards and pay the seen rate from then on. Without a cap, a stubborn blind player at a table of cautious seen ones is genuinely hard to shift, because they pay half price for every circuit and cannot be called to a show. The limit exists to stop that becoming the entire game, and it is worth agreeing at a table where somebody already knows this.

**Bigger bets** — Two ways to loosen the ceiling, often used together. Raise the caps, so a blind player may put in more than twice the current stake and a seen player more than four times it, which lets somebody with a trio actually build a pot rather than inching it upwards. And double what a show costs — the current stake becomes twice it for a blind player and four times for a seen one — which makes the final confrontation something you have to want rather than something to reach for out of impatience.

**Suits break the tie** — Rank the suits, spades highest and clubs lowest, and use that to settle two hands that are otherwise identical. It removes split pots and tied shows entirely, which some tables prefer to the alternatives of the asker losing or the money being divided. Worth stating out loud, because a player who has only met the game without it will assume a tie is a tie.

**Live Teen Patti** — Not really this game, and the reason people mistake Teen Patti for a casino game. Casinos offer a table game under the name that is essentially Three Card Poker played against the house: you bet against the dealer rather than the other players, there is no blind and seen distinction, no bluffing and no pot. What it borrows is the hand ranking, which is Teen Patti's rather than poker's, plus assorted side bets. Since 'teen patti' just means three cards, the name is not unfair — but the game across a kitchen table and the game in the casino have almost nothing in common.

Rules checked against: [Pagat](#), [Wikipedia](#), [GameRules.com](#).

# Texas Hold'em

|                      |                                                                 |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Hold'em, Holdem, Texas Holdem                                   |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-10 players (best with 6)                                      |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), plus chips or counters for everyone |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-120 minutes                                                  |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                            |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                        |

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## Setup

Everyone plays from a stack of chips in front of them, and every chip in that stack is live: you can lose all of it in one hand, and you may never reach into your pocket for more in the middle of one, though in a cash game you can top up as much as you like between hands. Nine or ten seats fill a table, six makes the liveliest game, and two people can play a perfectly good version of it.

Cards rank ace high, with the ace doubling as the low card at the bottom of a five-high run. Suits carry no rank at all. Two hands of identical rank divide the pot rather than one edging out the other, which surprises people who have come from games where spades beat hearts.

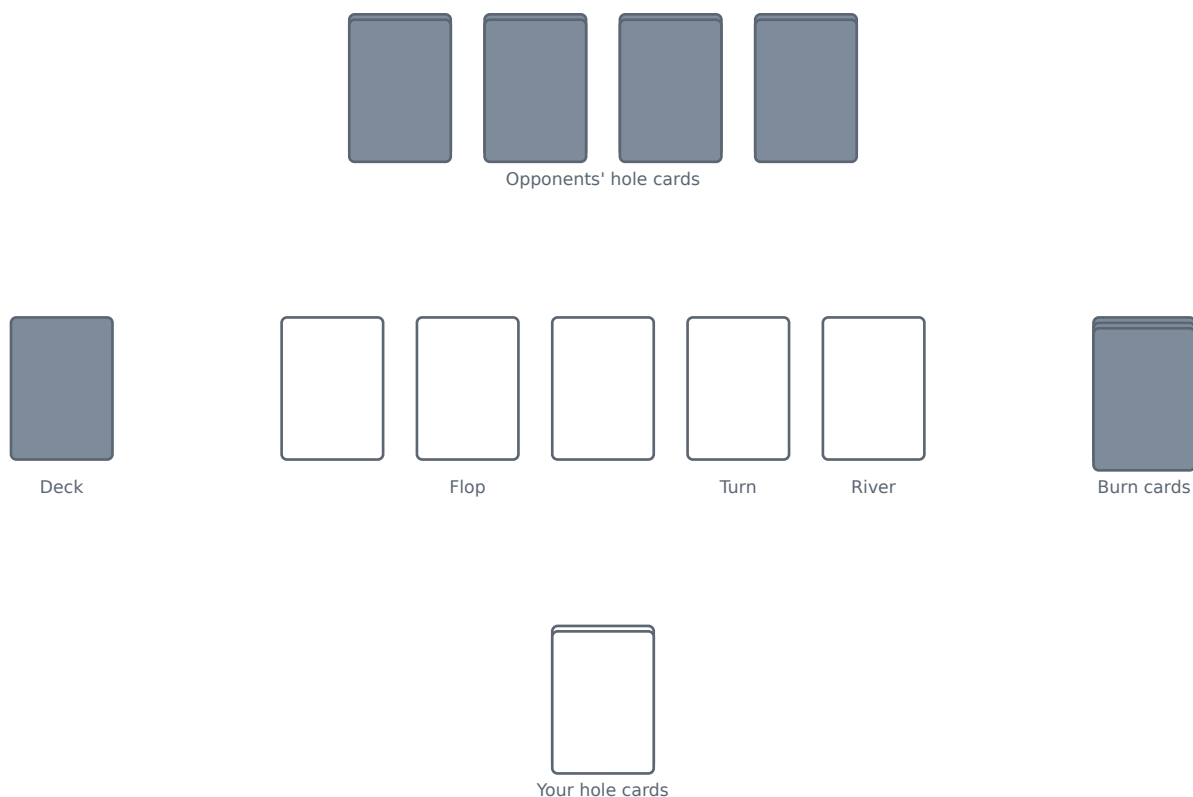
A marker called the button sits in front of one player and shows who is nominally dealing. After each hand it moves one seat clockwise, and because it decides who speaks first and who speaks last, moving it is what rotates the advantage of position around the table. In a home game the button also tells you whose turn it is to shuffle.

Two forced bets called the blinds are put in before any cards appear, so that the very first hand already has something worth contesting. The player one seat clockwise from the button posts the small blind and the next one posts the big blind, the small usually being half the big. The blinds are how the stakes are named: a one-two game means a small blind of one and a big blind of two.

With two players everything inverts. The button posts the small blind, the other player posts the big blind, and the button acts first before the community cards and last afterwards.

The dealer then gives two cards face down to each player, one at a time clockwise, beginning with the small blind. These are your hole cards and nobody else sees them until a showdown, if there is one.

Tournaments usually add an ante once the levels climb, most often a single ante the size of the big blind, posted by one player on the table's behalf rather than by everyone separately.



The table once the board is complete. The five shared cards arrive in three instalments with a betting round between each, and every player builds a hand from those five plus their own two.

## Play

A hand runs through four betting rounds. Everything in between is just the dealer turning over more shared cards.

### WHAT YOU CAN DO ON YOUR TURN

- Check. Pass the action along without putting anything in. Only legal when nobody has bet ahead of you in this round.
- Bet. Put chips in when nobody else has.
- Call. Match the largest amount wagered so far this round.
- Raise. Increase it, which puts everyone else back on the spot.
- Fold. Push your cards away and give up whatever you have already put in. Folding costs nothing further and is allowed at any turn.

A round is finished once everybody still holding cards has had a turn and everyone who has not folded has put the same amount into the pot for that round, all-ins aside. Chips already committed stay in the pot; you never take them back, and at the end of each round they are gathered into the middle.

### BEFORE THE FLOP

The blinds are already live bets, so the round opens with the player one seat clockwise from the big blind, who must at minimum call the big blind to continue. Action runs clockwise and finishes on the big blind, who gets a special privilege: if nobody has raised, that player may still raise rather than being forced to check, which is the option.

#### THE FLOP

The dealer discards the top card face down, which is the burn, and turns three cards face up in the middle. These belong to everybody. Betting now starts with the first player still in the hand clockwise from the button and ends with the last active player before the button, so the button speaks last, and that ordering holds for the rest of the hand.

#### THE TURN AND THE RIVER

Another burn and a fourth shared card, then a betting round. Another burn and a fifth shared card, then the last betting round.

#### HOW MUCH YOU MAY BET

The modern default is no limit. An opening bet must be at least the size of the big blind and may go as high as every chip you have. A raise has to increase the wager by at least as much as the previous bet or raise did, so against a bet of ten you may make it twenty or more, but not fifteen.

You may always put your whole stack in even when it falls short of the amount owed. Doing so caps what you are playing for: you can win from each opponent only as much as you yourself put in, and everything they wager beyond that is set aside in a side pot which the still-active players contest without you. Several all-ins in one hand can build several such pots, each settled separately.

An all-in that does not amount to a full raise is the one case that trips people up. It does not reopen the betting: a player who has already acted for the full amount may call the difference but may not raise again, while anyone yet to act still has a full set of options. So if the bet was ten and someone shoves for fourteen, the player who bet ten can only put in the extra four.

#### THE SHOWDOWN

If two or more players are still in after the final round, hands are revealed. Whoever made the last bet or raise shows first; if the last round was checked all the way round, the first remaining player clockwise from the button shows first, and anyone who knows they are beaten may fold face down instead of showing.



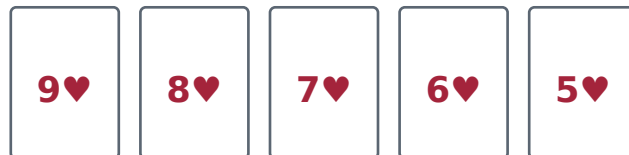
Seven cards are available to everybody still in — the two nobody else has seen plus the five in the middle — and the hand you hold is whichever five of those seven is strongest. Any combination counts. You may use both hole cards, only one, or neither at all, and using neither is called playing the board.

A hand can also end long before this. The moment everyone else folds, the last player standing takes the pot immediately and never has to show what they were holding.

Royal flush



Straight flush



Four of a kind



Full house

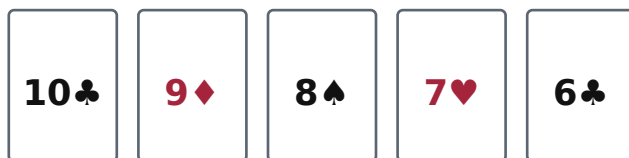


Hand rankings, part one: the four strongest categories. Any hand here beats every hand below it, whatever the individual card ranks.

Flush



Straight



Three of a kind



Two pair

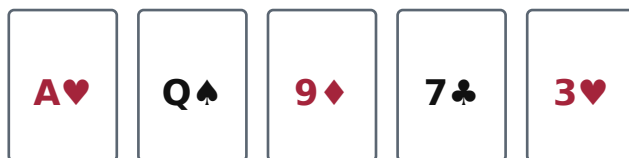


Hand rankings, part two: the middle four. A flush beats a straight, which is the ordering people most often get backwards.

One pair

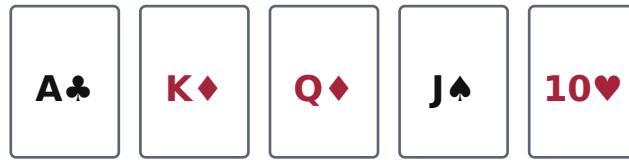


High card



Hand rankings, part three: the two weakest. Most showdowns are settled down here.

Broadway



The wheel



Not a straight



The ace does duty at both ends of a straight, but only at the ends. A run through the ace from king to two is not a straight.

## Goal & scoring

There is no running score in Hold'em. Each hand is a fight over a single pot, and there are exactly two ways to win it: hold the best five-card hand at the showdown, or make everybody else fold before you get there. The second way is why the game is not simply a race for good cards, since a pot taken uncontested is worth the same as one taken with the strongest hand.

Hands are compared by the standard poker categories. Within a category the ranks decide it, and a hand shorter than five distinguishing cards is settled by kickers, the leftover cards ranked in order until one side is higher. Two hands that match all the way down tie and split the pot; where the split leaves an odd chip, it goes to the first player clockwise from the button. Because five shared cards are on the table, ties are far more common here than in games where every card is private.

Where side pots exist they are settled from the outside in, each awarded to the best hand among the players eligible for it, so a short all-in stack can take the main pot while a bigger hand collects the rest.

A cash game has no ending condition. Chips represent stakes directly, you may sit down or stand up between hands, and where you finished is simply what is in front of you when you leave.

A tournament has a definite end. Everyone starts with an identical stack, the blinds rise on a clock so that no one can wait indefinitely, players are eliminated as they run out of chips, and play continues until one person holds all of them. Finishing positions rather than chip counts determine the

result.

## Variants

**Omaha** — Four hole cards each rather than two, and a rigid rule that exactly two of them play alongside exactly three from the board. That single constraint is easy to misread — four hearts in your hand and three on the table is not a flush, because only two of yours can count — and it changes the game enough that Omaha has its own entry in this collection rather than living here. Pot-limit betting is its usual companion.

**Short-deck (six-plus) Hold'em** — All the deuces through fives are stripped out, leaving a 36-card pack, and everything else about the deal and the betting stays put. The thinner deck rearranges the hand rankings: a flush becomes harder to make than a full house and outranks it, and three of a kind beats a straight. The ace still plays low, now completing a nine-high run with the six. Antes from every player commonly replace the blinds.

**Fixed-limit and pot-limit betting** — The same game with the bet sizes constrained rather than open. Under fixed limit every bet and raise is a set amount, the smaller unit before and on the flop and double that on the turn and river, with the number of raises in a round usually capped at four. Under pot limit you may bet anything up to the current size of the pot. Both reward patient value betting, because you cannot threaten anyone's whole stack in a single move.

**Home-game dealing without a house dealer** — With nobody employed to run the deck, the player on the button deals, and the deal moves with the button each hand. Keep the burn cards in one face-down pile away from the folded hands so that nothing gets picked up by mistake, and let whoever is not in the hand cut. Agree in advance whether a card exposed during the deal is simply reshuffled in or triggers a misdeal, since that is the argument every home game eventually has.

Rules checked against: Pagat, PokerNews, Upswing Poker, PokerListings, Wikipedia, World Poker Tour, Automatic Poker.

# Truco

|                      |                                                                                          |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Truco Argentino, Truco Uruguayo, Truco Paulista, Truco Mineiro                           |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-6 players (best with 4)                                                                |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck stripped to 40 cards (8s, 9s and 10s removed), or a 40-card Spanish pack |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                            |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Medium                                                                                   |
| <b>Category</b>      | Bluffing                                                                                 |

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## Setup

Truco needs forty cards. The Spanish pack is the traditional one — coins, cups, swords and clubs, each suit running ace through seven and then sota, caballo and rey. An ordinary pack does the job once the eights, nines and tens come out: jack stands for the sota, queen for the caballo, king for the rey. Match the suits as well, because four named cards depend on it — swords are spades, clubs are clubs, cups are hearts and coins are diamonds.

Four players in two partnerships is the standard table, partners facing each other so the sides alternate. Two play head to head with nothing changed at all beyond the absence of partners, and six play as two teams of three seated alternately. Three is the awkward number: where it is played, the mano takes a fourth card, discards one face down, and plays alone against the other two. Five does not work at all; an odd fifth player sits out or keeps the score.

Deal three cards each, one at a time, to the right. Nothing is turned up in the Argentine game, nothing is drawn and nothing is exchanged: the three cards you are handed are the three you play. The player on the dealer's right is the mano. They lead to the first trick and — this matters far more than it sounds — they win every tie they are part of. Priority runs from the mano anticlockwise round to the dealer, who loses every tie; and a hand in which all three tricks are drawn goes to the mano's side outright. The deal moves one seat right afterwards.

Learn the ranking before the first hand rather than during it, because almost none of it can be guessed. Four cards stand apart at the top and are called the bravas; the aces of swords and clubs and the sevens of swords and coins have been lifted clean out of their ranks to form them, which leaves the other two aces and the other two sevens stranded lower down as the ases falsos and sietes falsos. Everything else is compared by rank alone, suits being otherwise meaningless.

Score with beans or matchsticks in two visible groups — twenty-eight of them is the traditional kit, fourteen a side, all returned to the pot and drawn

out afresh when a side crosses into the second half. A game runs to thirty points, and the first fifteen are the malas and the second fifteen the buenas. Mostly that split is a way of saying the score aloud: nobody announces twenty-one, they announce six buenas. Some rule sets do hang the value of a bet on which half a side is in, and some do not, which is worth settling. A match is normally three games, best of them; playing just one to thirty — un treinta seco — settles an evening perfectly well.

## Play

A hand is three tricks, and the tricks are mostly there to give the betting something to be about.

The tricks. The mano leads, play goes to the right, one card each. The highest card takes the trick and its winner leads to the next. There is no trump suit and no obligation to follow suit — play whatever you like whenever it is your turn. A trick is a parda, a tie belonging to nobody, when the highest card played is matched by an opponent; two equal cards from the same partnership are not a parda, and that side simply takes the trick. Whoever led to a parda leads again to the next one.

Settling the hand takes five rules, and they are worth learning as a block because pardas turn up constantly. Take two tricks and the hand is yours. If the first trick is a parda, the hand goes to whoever wins the second, and if the second is a parda too, to whoever wins the third. If you won the first trick and the second is a parda, the hand is already yours and the third is not played. If each side has taken one trick and the third is a parda, the hand goes to whoever won the first. And if all three are pardas the mano's side takes it. As soon as the outcome is settled the remaining cards are thrown in unseen.

Two separate auctions run alongside those three tricks, and both are answered the same three ways: quiero to accept, no quiero to refuse, or a raise to the next rung.

Envido, on the cards you were dealt. Envido is a bet about who holds the best two cards of a single suit, and it is settled by saying a number out loud rather than by playing anything. Two cards of the same suit are worth their pips added together plus twenty, with sota, caballo and rey worth nothing at all; hold three of a suit and you count the best two of them. A hand with no two cards alike in suit counts only its highest single card, so three court cards in three different suits count zero. The floor is 0 and the ceiling is 33.

Any player may call envido and either opponent may answer for their side, but the window is narrow: you cannot open the envido once you have played your own first card, nor once you have accepted a bet on the truco.

In practice the call comes from the pie — the last member of each side to play to the trick, and usually its captain — who has seen two or three cards go down first. Once a call is accepted, count round from the mano: the mano says a number, and each player after them either beats it aloud or concedes with *son buenas*. The highest number wins, and a tie goes to whichever of the tied players comes first going anticlockwise from the mano, so the dealer loses every tie they are in. The points go down immediately and the tricks carry on regardless of who won them.

The *envido* ladder accumulates rather than replaces. *Envido* is 2; a second *envido* on top of it makes 4; real *envido* adds three more, so *envido* then real *envido* is 5. Above everything sits *falta envido*, worth whatever the leading side still needs to finish the game — a bet that shrinks as that side closes on thirty, so it is as often a defensive call as a greedy one. The detail is not settled: some accounts price it off the losing side instead of the leading one, and some stop it at fifteen while the side in question is still in the *malas*. Agree which before you deal. Refusing any *envido* bet pays the caller whatever had already been accepted below the refused call, and never less than one, which is why a *falta envido* gets called far more often than it gets taken.

*Truco*, on the tricks. *Truco* stakes the whole hand, not the trick sitting in front of you. Any player may call it when it is their turn to play, and either opponent may answer for their side. The opponents accept, refuse, or accept and push it up to *retruco* — and those last two halves are not optional, because a raise offered without the word *quiero* in front of it is not a bet at all. The first side may then accept in turn and push again to *vale cuatro*. Refusing does not lose you the hand — it ends the hand, and the caller banks the lower amount without another card being turned. That is the engine of the whole game: you are betting far less on your cards than on whether the other side believes you have them.

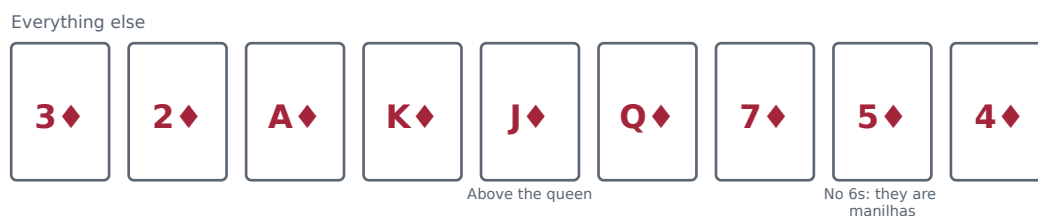
*Precedence*. If *truco* is called while the *envido* is still live, the opponents may put an *envido* bet in before answering it, and the *envido* is then settled in full first. The *truco* call is still standing afterwards and has to be answered then. A *flor* announcement outranks both, and wipes out whatever *envido* betting has gone on before it — which is how a player holding three cards of a suit kills an accepted *envido* bet with a single word.

*Talking*. *Truco* is loud and the talk is part of the game rather than decoration. *Verse*, taunts, and flat lies about what you are holding are all normal and none of them are cheating. What makes the chatter dangerous is that the betting words are reserved: say one of them at a moment when the corresponding bet would be legal and you have made that bet,

whatever you meant by it. Telling an opponent you do not want another drink has lost hands. Partners also signal their cards across the table with small movements of the face — raised eyebrows for the ace of swords, a kiss for a two, both eyes shut for a hopeless hand — and here, unlike in mus, a false signal is a legitimate weapon rather than an offence. The lists vary by region and a partnership may invent its own; the opposing pair are entitled to read anything they catch.



Argentine truco, every card in the pack from highest to lowest. Cups (hearts here) stand in for the ranks that hold no special card. Fourteen tiers, of which the top four are single cards.



Brazilian truco instead turns a card, the vira, and promotes the four cards of the next rank up to manilhas. With a five turned, the sixes are the manilhas and no six is left in the ordinary order.





Uruguayan truco turns a muestra and five cards of its suit become piezas, outranking even the bravas, which are called matas there. Shown with cups (hearts) as the muestra suit.

## Goal & scoring

A game is a race to thirty points and every one of them comes from a bet. The first fifteen are the malas and the last fifteen the buenas, which is mostly a way of saying the score aloud — six buenas rather than twenty-one — though some rule sets do price a falta envido or a contraflor al resto against which half a side is in.

The settlements are independent. The envido, the flor if you are playing with it, and the truco are three separate accounts, and a partnership can lose the tricks having already banked more from the envido than the hand was ever going to pay. That is a perfectly ordinary way to win a game, and it is why a hand with two high cards of one suit and nothing else is not a hand to fold.

Two principles govern the whole ladder. An accepted bet pays its own value to whichever side wins the thing it was about. A refused bet pays the caller straight away, at the value of the rung below the one refused, and closes that auction with nothing shown — so refusing an envido costs you almost nothing, and refusing a vale cuatro costs nearly as much as losing it would have. The consequence is that the ladder is not really a ladder of odds; it is a ladder of how much you are willing to be wrong by.

Score in the traditional way if you can, with matchsticks or beans laid out in groups and the malas kept on one side of the table and the buenas on the other. Everyone can then see at a glance what a falta envido is currently worth, which is information the game expects you to have.

| Scores | Value | Notes |
|--------|-------|-------|
|--------|-------|-------|

|                                    |                             |                                                                               |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hand won, truco never called       | 1                           | —                                                                             |
| Truco                              | 2                           | 1 to the caller if refused                                                    |
| Retruco                            | 3                           | 2 if refused                                                                  |
| Vale cuatro                        | 4                           | 3 if refused                                                                  |
| Envido                             | 2                           | 1 if refused                                                                  |
| Envido called a second time        | 4                           | 2 if refused                                                                  |
| Real envido                        | 3                           | on its own; refusal pays whatever was already staked, at least 1              |
| Envido, then real envido           | 5                           | the ladder accumulates; 2 if refused                                          |
| Falta envido                       | what the leaders still need | to reach 30; some price it off the losing side, or stop at 15 in the malas    |
| Flor                               | 3                           | 3 for each flor announced, to the side holding the best one                   |
| Contraflor                         | 3 per flor                  | a challenge rather than a raise; conceding pays the winners 3 per flor plus 1 |
| Contraflor al resto                | the game, plus 3 per flor   | what the leading side needs to finish, plus 3 for every flor in play          |
| Envido: two cards of one suit      | piPs added, plus 20         | —                                                                             |
| Envido: sota, caballo, rey         | 0                           | —                                                                             |
| Envido: no two cards alike in suit | highest single card         | —                                                                             |
| Best possible envido               | 33                          | the 7 and 6 of one suit                                                       |
| Worst possible envido              | 0                           | three court cards, no two of a suit                                           |

## Variants

**Con flor** — Three cards of one suit is a flor, and at tables playing with it the holder must announce it during the first trick. Flor overrides the envido entirely: announcing it cancels any envido bet outstanding and replaces that account with its own, which can be pushed up to contraflor and then to contraflor al resto, staking the remainder of the game. Argentine tables divide roughly evenly between con flor and sin flor, and the choice completely changes what a suited hand is worth, so it is the first thing to agree on.

**Truco Paulista (Brazil)** — The best-known Brazilian form, and structurally a different game above the same three tricks. After the deal a card is turned as the vira, and the four cards of the rank immediately above it become the manilhas, ranked among themselves by suit: clubs highest, then hearts, spades, diamonds. The order wraps, so a turned 3 makes the 4s manilhas. Below them the ranks run 3, 2, ace, king, jack, queen, 7, 6, 5, 4, the jack sitting above the queen. There is no envido — the whole hand rides on the tricks. An untrucoed hand is worth 1 tento, truco makes it 3, and the raises are vale seis, vale nove and queda, which is the whole twelve-point game; a refusal pays the caller the rung below. The sting is the mão de onze: a side reaching eleven

may pass its cards across the table to be read in silence, then choose either to play for three points or to throw the hand in for one, and calling truco at that score simply hands the opponents the game. With both sides on eleven it becomes a *mão de ferro*: nobody may look at their cards at all, each turns the top one over in turn, and the deal decides the match.

**Truco Mineiro (Brazil)** — Played like the Paulista game but with no vira turned. The four *manilhas* are fixed for every hand: the four of clubs, the seven of hearts, the ace of spades and the seven of diamonds, in that order, known as the *zap*, the *escopeta*, the *espadilha* and the *pica-fumo* — though the names travel badly and the south of Brazil calls the same four the *gato*, the *copas*, the *espadilha* and the *mole*. Removing the turn removes the one piece of shared information the Paulista game gives you, so every hand is read blind and the four special cards are memorised rather than worked out.

**Truco Uruguayo** — A card is turned as the *muestra* and left visible under the pack. Five cards of its suit — the two, four, five, *caballo* and *sota* — become *piezas*, outranking everything including the four *bravas*, which Uruguayans call *matas*. If the *muestra* card is itself one of those five, the *rey* of the suit is promoted in its place. *Piezas* count in the *envido* too, at fixed values well above anything an ordinary pair can reach, which pushes the best possible *envido* up to 37 and makes the *envido* round a far bigger part of the game than it is across the river.

**Two-handed truco** — Two players, three cards each, everything else identical: the same three tricks, the same *envido* ladder, the same truco ladder, the same thirty points. What changes is that no information can be signalled and none can be concealed behind a partner, so the whole hand is a direct reading contest, and the *mano's* tie-breaking advantage becomes the single most valuable thing on the table.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia, Mundigames, Naipes Heraclio Fournier, Ludoteka, Conecta Games, GameVelvet, Arcadia Games.

## CASINO

# Baccarat

|                      |                                                                                           |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Punto Banco, Baccara                                                                      |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-12 players (best with 6)                                                                |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 6 to 8 standard decks shuffled together; eight is the casino norm and six is usual online |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                             |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                      |
| <b>Category</b>      | Casino                                                                                    |

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## Setup

The version played almost everywhere is Punto Banco, and its defining feature is worth knowing before you sit down: after the bet is placed, nobody decides anything. Not the players, not the dealer, not the house. Every card that is drawn is drawn because a printed rule says so, which makes this the only major card game where reading the rules and playing perfectly are the same act.

Shuffle six or eight packs together — eight on a casino floor, six in most online rooms. At home a banker deals, covers the bets and does the arithmetic; the job is mechanical, so hand it round or leave it with whoever is most willing.

Cards are worth their pip value, an ace counts one, and a ten or a court card counts nothing whatever. Totals are taken modulo ten: add the cards up and throw away everything except the last digit, so eight and six is four rather than fourteen. Nine is therefore the best hand available and there is no such thing as going bust.

Two hands are dealt each round and neither of them belongs to anyone at the table. They are called Player and Banker, and those are the names of two piles of cards rather than of any person present — the punter who has staked the most does the honours of turning them over at a full-size table, and it changes nothing. Before the deal, everyone puts money on Player, on Banker, or on the two of them finishing level.

A casino burns cards off the top of a fresh shoe and buries a cut card sixteen from the bottom; at home, shuffle when you are running short.



Shoe



Player



Banker

Two hands, owned by nobody. However many people are at the table, one Player hand is dealt and everyone backs it, backs the Banker hand, or backs the tie.

## Play

Two cards go to each hand and both are turned up. If either shows a total of eight or nine it is a natural, and that settles the drawing question for both hands at once: no third card is dealt to either, whatever the other one holds.

Failing a natural, the Player hand is resolved first, on a rule with no exceptions. Six or seven, it stands. Five or less, it takes one card and only one.

The Banker hand then answers, and what it does depends on whether the Player hand took anything.

Where the Player stood, the Banker follows the same rule the Player just did: draw on five or less, stand on six or seven.

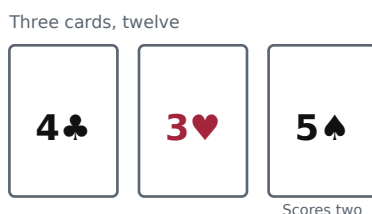
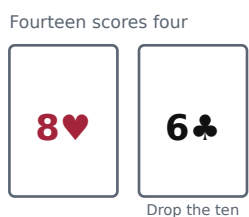
Where the Player drew, the Banker's rule takes account of the card the Player drew — the one piece of information a Banker hand has that a Player hand does not, and the whole reason the Banker bet is charged a commission:

- 7: stand.
- 6: draw only against a 6 or a 7.
- 5: draw against 4, 5, 6 or 7.
- 4: draw against anything from 2 to 7.
- 3: draw against everything except an 8.
- 0, 1 or 2: always draw.

No hand ever receives a fourth card, and the third card, where one is dealt, goes beside the two it is added to rather than replacing anything.

The table looks arbitrary because it is a fossil. Baccarat was once played with both two-card hands hidden and only the third card exposed, and these are the choices a good player would have made knowing exactly that much and no more. When the choices hardened into rules there was no longer any reason to hide the cards, so they came face up and the reasoning behind the table went out of view along with them.

With both hands complete, the totals are compared and the round is settled. Cards are cleared and the next round begins.



Only the last digit of the total counts, so no hand is ever worth more than nine, and a court card contributes nothing at all.

## Goal & scoring

Whichever of the two hands finishes nearer to nine takes the round. You played neither of them, so the only thing that matters is which one you put money on.

There are three things to put it on, they cost wildly different amounts, and choosing between them is the whole of the judgement this game asks for:

- Banker, at a long-run cost of about 1.06 percent of what you stake. Make this bet. There is nothing to add to the advice.
- Player, at about 1.24 percent. Entirely defensible, and the worse of the two by a whisker.

- The tie, at about 14.4 percent — some twelve times the price of either alternative, and one of the steepest wagers anywhere in a casino. It happens to be sitting on a table otherwise known for cheap ones, which is presumably the point.

Why only one of those is taxed: the Banker hand acts last, knowing whether the Player drew and what card it drew, and that extra sight of things makes it come out ahead slightly more often. The five percent taken from a winning Banker bet is what claws the difference back. It is rarely collected hand by hand — a marker goes out against your seat and the whole lot is settled when the shoe runs out. A tie leaves Player and Banker stakes sitting where they are rather than sweeping them away.

Nothing further is available to a player, and it is worth being blunt about that. No decision exists that could be made well. Card counting shifts the edge by a rounding error. The scorecard the casino hands out for recording past results records exactly that and predicts nothing, because a shoe has no memory of what it has already dealt.

No score accumulates between rounds. Play as many as suit you; what is in front of you at the end is the result.

| Scores                              | Value                      | Notes                                                             |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ace                                 | 1                          | —                                                                 |
| 2 through 9                         | pip value                  | —                                                                 |
| 10, jack, queen, king               | 0                          | —                                                                 |
| Banker bet                          | 1 to 1, less 5% commission | —                                                                 |
| Player bet                          | 1 to 1                     | —                                                                 |
| Tie bet                             | 8 to 1                     | a few tables, mostly British, pay 9 to 1                          |
| Tie, holding a Player or Banker bet | stake returned             | —                                                                 |
| Player pair or Banker pair          | 10 to 1                    | optional side bet: the first two cards of that hand match in rank |

## Variants

**Chemin de Fer** — The older game, still dealt in a few European casinos, and the one in the early Bond films. A player holds the bank rather than the house, stakes an amount, and the others bet against it up to that total; calling banco covers the whole bank single-handed. Only two hands are dealt and you cannot choose which to back — your money is on the players' side by definition. The player with the largest bet acts for everyone and, crucially, chooses whether to take a third card instead of being told, as does the banker; the two-card hands stay hidden until the decisions are made, which is what makes the choice worth anything. Win or tie and you keep the bank, with the whole of it staked again next time. Lose and it passes on.

**Baccarat Banque** — Also called Baccarat à Deux Tableaux, and the oldest form of the game. The table splits into a left half and a right half, three hands are dealt — one to each side and one to the bank — and each side plays the bank independently, never each other. Betting on either side is allowed at some tables, or à cheval to split a stake across both. The bank is not passed around: one person holds it until the shoe is exhausted, they run out of money, or they choose to stand down, and they have real latitude over drawing. Usually dealt from three packs.

**Mini-baccarat** — The same game and the same odds on a blackjack-sized table, with one dealer handling every card rather than passing the shoe around. It is much faster, which is a mixed blessing when the house has an edge on every hand, but the minimums are a fraction of the big table's and it sits on the main floor instead of behind a rope. Midi-baccarat is the identical arrangement on a larger table, generally in the high-limit room.

**Reduced commission on Banker** — Casinos occasionally shave the five percent to draw players in. Rates of four percent and 2.75 percent have both been offered, and one Las Vegas casino briefly charged nothing at all in 1989. A related London rule waives the commission on one specific winning hand — a Banker two-card three that beats a Player who drew an 8 — which takes the Banker bet's cost down to around 0.81 percent. Any of these makes the best bet in the house better still, so it is worth reading the felt.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wizard of Odds, Wikipedia.



# Blackjack

|                      |                                                                                             |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Twenty-One, 21, Vingt-et-Un                                                                 |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 5)                                                                   |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 to 8 standard decks shuffled together; six is the casino norm, one or two is fine at home |
| <b>Time</b>          | 30-60 minutes                                                                               |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                                                                        |
| <b>Category</b>      | Casino                                                                                      |

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## Setup

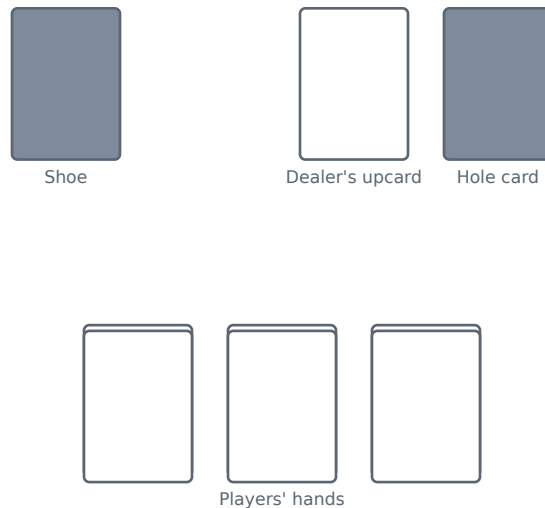
One person is the dealer and everyone else bets against them. A casino table seats up to seven players, so with a dealer you want between two and eight people. At home, either appoint a permanent dealer or rotate the role, since the dealer holds a small built-in advantage and rotating shares it around.

Shuffle the decks together. Casinos deal six decks from a shoe; one or two decks shuffled by hand is perfectly good for a kitchen table. Agree a minimum and maximum stake before you start, and give everyone chips or counters.

Card values: 2 through 10 count face value, jacks, queens and kings count 10, and an ace counts 1 or 11, whichever suits your hand better at the moment. A hand holding an ace that can still count 11 without busting is called soft, so ace-6 is a soft 17 and can be hit without risk. Once counting the ace as 11 would put you over 21 it reverts to 1 and the hand is hard. Suits are irrelevant throughout.

Every round starts with each player placing a bet in their betting spot. Once all bets are down, the dealer deals clockwise: one card to each player, one to themselves face up, then a second card to each player and a second to themselves face down. That face-down card is the hole card, and it is what the whole game turns on. In shoe games the players' cards are dealt face up and are not touched; in hand-dealt single-deck games they come face down and players pick them up. Neither changes the odds.

An ace plus any ten-value card in your first two cards is a blackjack, also called a natural. It is the best hand in the game and is settled at a better rate than an ordinary win.



Three of the up to seven players shown. Only the dealer's second card is hidden; in shoe games the players' two cards are dealt face up.

## Play

Before anyone acts, the dealer checks for a natural. If the upcard is an ace, the dealer first offers insurance: any player may put up a side bet of up to half their original stake, and it pays 2 to 1 whenever the hidden card proves to be worth ten. A player holding a blackjack against a dealer ace may instead take even money, which is the same wager in disguise and pays their hand 1 to 1 immediately. When the upcard is an ace or a ten-value card, the dealer then peeks at the hole card. If it is a natural, the round is over at once: insurance is paid, every ordinary hand loses, and any player who also holds a blackjack pushes.

Otherwise the first decision falls to whoever sits on the dealer's left, and the turn passes clockwise. Each player finishes their hand completely before the next one starts. Your options on your first two cards are:

**Hit.** Take another card. You may keep hitting as long as you are under 21. Where the cards are dealt face up you signal this by tapping the felt beside them rather than saying it out loud, so the decision is on camera.

**Stand.** Take nothing more and let the hand ride, signalled by waving a flat hand over your cards.

**Double down.** Double your original bet and take exactly one more card, then you are done whatever the total. Most tables allow this on any two cards; some restrict it to hard totals of 9, 10 or 11.

**Split.** If your two cards are a pair, put out a second bet equal to the first and separate them into two hands, each of which is dealt a second card and then played out in turn. Two cards of the same rank always count as a pair, and at nearly every table any two ten-value cards do as well, so a king

alongside a ten may be split even though the ranks differ. If a split hand pairs again you can usually split once more, up to a limit of three or four hands in total. Splitting is subject to two firm exceptions: split aces receive exactly one card each and cannot be hit again or resplit, and any two-card 21 made on a split hand counts as an ordinary 21 rather than a natural, so it pays 1 to 1, pushes against a dealer's three-card 21, and loses to a dealer's blackjack. Whether you may double after splitting varies by house.

**Surrender.** Where offered, you may abandon the hand before drawing any card and forfeit half your bet. This is late surrender, meaning it is only available after the dealer has confirmed no natural. Plenty of tables do not offer it at all.

Going over 21 is a bust. Your cards are taken and your bet is collected immediately, before the dealer plays. That is the whole basis of the house edge: you lose a bust hand even if the dealer goes on to bust as well.

When every player has finished, the dealer turns the hole card up and plays by fixed rule, with no choices at all. The one exception is that if every player has already busted there is nothing left to beat, so the dealer collects the bets and the round ends without another card being drawn. The dealer draws to any total of 16 or less and stands on any total of 17 or more, counting a soft 17 such as ace-6 as a 17 and standing on it. None of those options belong to the dealer: no doubling, no splitting, no surrender. If the dealer busts, every player still standing wins.

Rounds run back to back for as long as you want to keep playing. Casinos bury a cut card partway down the shoe and reshuffle at the end of whichever round reaches it, so the shoe is never dealt to the bottom. At home, play out the round you are in, then collect the discards and reshuffle everything before the next deal. If the cards do run out part-way through a round, shuffle the discard pile at once, leaving the cards already on the table where they are, and carry on dealing from it.

## **Goal & scoring**

The aim is to finish with a hand closer to 21 than the dealer's without going over. You are not racing the other players; every hand is settled independently against the dealer alone.

Settlement once the dealer's hand is complete:

A winning hand pays 1 to 1, so a 10-chip bet returns your 10 plus 10 more. A blackjack pays 3 to 2, so a 10-chip bet returns your 10 plus 15. A tie is a push and your stake comes back untouched. A losing hand or a bust loses the stake. Insurance is settled separately from the hand it was placed

alongside, so you can lose the hand and still collect on insurance, or the other way round.

A blackjack beats any 21 built from three or more cards, and it is paid at the better rate; a three-card 21 against a dealer blackjack simply loses. Two blackjacks push.

There is no running score. You play as many rounds as you like and count your chips at the end. Sensible play matters: played with correct basic strategy, a six-deck game with the rules above costs you somewhere around four tenths of one percent of what you stake, which is about as good as a casino game gets. Insurance is a losing bet at almost any count, and a table paying 6 to 5 on blackjacks instead of 3 to 2 adds roughly another 1.4 percent, wiping out that edge several times over.

| Scores              | Value                   | Notes                          |
|---------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Winning hand        | 1 to 1                  | —                              |
| Blackjack (natural) | 3 to 2                  | 6 to 5 at some tables          |
| Insurance           | 2 to 1                  | if the hole card is ten-value  |
| Even money          | 1 to 1                  | blackjack against a dealer ace |
| Push (tie)          | stake returned          | —                              |
| Losing hand or bust | stake lost              | —                              |
| Surrender           | half the stake returned | —                              |

## Variants

**Dealer hits soft 17** — The dealer must draw on a soft 17 such as ace-6 rather than standing on it, and stands only on hard 17 or any 18 and up. This is now the more common rule on casino floors and it costs the player about a fifth of a percent, because it lets the dealer improve a weak 17 into a winner. Tables normally state which rule applies in print on the felt: "dealer must stand on all 17s" or "dealer hits soft 17".

**6 to 5 blackjack** — The natural pays 6 to 5 instead of the traditional 3 to 2, so a 10-chip bet wins 12 rather than 15. It looks like a small change and is not: it adds roughly 1.4 percent to the house edge, which is more than every other rule on the table combined. Often paired with a single deck to make the game look generous. Check the payout before you sit down.

**Late surrender** — You may fold a bad hand before drawing to it and lose only half your bet, once the dealer has confirmed they do not have a natural. It is mainly used on hard 16 against a dealer 9, 10 or ace, and on hard 15 against a 10. Offered on many six and eight-deck games, rarely on single or double deck, and often not signposted, so ask the dealer.

**Rotating banker at home** — Rather than appointing one permanent dealer, pass the deal around the table so everyone takes the house side in turn, either

after each hand or after each shuffle. Whoever holds the deal is the banker and covers all bets from their own stack, so agree a table maximum they can actually pay. Rotating matters because the dealer side carries a real edge over a session; leaving it with one person all night is not a fair game.

**Pontoon** — The British relative of the game, and a genuinely different animal. Both dealer cards go face down, hitting is called twisting, standing is sticking, and you may instead buy a card by increasing your stake. You cannot stick below 15. Five cards totalling 21 or less is a five-card trick and beats everything except a pontoon, the ace plus ten-value hand; both pay 2 to 1. The dealer wins all ties, so there is no push.

Rules checked against: Wizard of Odds, Vegas Aces, Casino.org, PokerNews, BetMGM Casino Blog, Denexa Games, Wikipedia.

# Caribbean Stud

|                      |                                                    |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Caribbean Stud Poker, Casino Stud Poker            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-7 players (best with 5)                          |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), plus chips or counters |
| <b>Time</b>          | 20-60 minutes                                      |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Easy                                               |
| <b>Category</b>      | Casino                                             |

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## Setup

Poker hands, ranked the usual way, played against the dealer rather than against each other. That last part removes the thing most poker is about: there is nobody to bluff, because the dealer never makes a decision. What is left is a bet on your own five cards against a hand that follows a fixed rule.

One player deals and banks. In a casino that seat belongs to the house; at a kitchen table give it to whoever can cover the payouts, and pass it on before the evening turns into a very slow transfer of somebody's money.

Each player who wants a hand puts up an ante before the deal. Where a jackpot stake is being offered, that goes down at the same time and is settled entirely separately — see the variants.

The dealer gives five cards face down to each player and five to themselves, then turns one of their own face up. That single exposed card is all you learn about the hand you are up against, and it is the whole of what you have to work with.

Players look at their own cards, and everyone at the table is up against the same single dealer hand. That is worth noticing before the first deal: cards compared around the table would tell everybody something about what the dealer cannot be holding, which is information the game is not built to survive. Casinos have their own rules about it; a home table should agree its own, and the simplest is that you play your own five cards and say nothing about them.

## Play

One decision each, made after looking at your five cards and the dealer's single upcard.

- **Raise.** Put up a second stake of exactly twice your ante. There is no other amount, and this is the only bet you will make.
- **Fold.** Give the hand up and lose the ante.

Everyone decides in turn, and the decision is final. There is no drawing, no

second round of betting and nothing to do afterwards; the rest of the hand is settlement.

Once every player has raised or folded, the dealer turns their remaining four cards face up. Now the qualifier decides everything that follows: THE DEALER'S HAND ONLY PLAYS IF IT CONTAINS AN ACE AND A KING, OR IS A PAIR OR BETTER.

#### IF THE DEALER DOES NOT QUALIFY

Cards are not compared. Every player still in is paid even money on the ante, and the raise — twice the size — is handed straight back. It does not matter whether your hand was a royal flush or the worst five cards at the table: the raise wins nothing, which is the sting in the game and the reason a huge hand can feel wasted.

#### IF THE DEALER QUALIFIES

Each remaining player's five cards are compared with the dealer's, on the standard poker rankings.

- Your hand is better. The ante is paid even money, and the raise is paid at the ladder below — which is where the game's money is, since it climbs to a hundred to one.
- The dealer's hand is better. Both stakes are lost.
- The two are exactly equal. Both stakes are returned and nothing changes hands.

A casino usually caps what one hand can pay however the ladder works out, so a big hand at high stakes can be worth less than the multiplier suggests. At home there is no cap unless the banker sets one, and a banker who does not think about that before dealing has agreed to a liability they have not counted.

### **Goal & scoring**

Take more from the banker than you put in. Hands are settled one at a time and there is no running total; what is in front of you is the score.

Every hand resolves through the same two questions, in this order: did the dealer qualify, and if so, whose five cards are better. The first question is the one that shapes how the game feels, because whenever the dealer cannot qualify the raise — the bigger of your two stakes — is dead money that comes straight back untouched. Holding four of a kind against a dealer who cannot show ace-king pays you your ante and nothing else.

That is also why the fold decision is not the one it looks like. Folding costs the ante; raising costs twice the ante on top. The usual guidance is to raise

on any pair or better and fold below ace-king, which is roughly where the raise stops being worth its price. A table-ready version of the fuller strategy is to call with ace-king-jack-eight-three or better, which gives away a further tenth of a per cent against playing it perfectly.

When the dealer does qualify, the ante pays even money and the raise pays on the ladder above. A pair is worth the same as a high card there — the ladder only starts climbing at two pair — and it climbs steeply at the top, which is what people remember about the game and not what pays for most of their evening.

The rankings are standard five-card poker throughout, so a straight beats three of a kind, a flush beats a straight, and suits break nothing. Two identical hands are a tie and both stakes come back.

The house edge is real and it lives in the qualifier: play as well as the game can be played and it still costs about 2.6 per cent of everything staked. Two figures get quoted for this game and they are both true — that one measures against the ante and the raise together, while the larger number you will see elsewhere measures against the ante alone, which is the smaller of the two stakes. Neither moves much whatever you do with the cards. A jackpot stake is worse again unless the meter has grown very large. Whoever banks the game at home is being handed that edge, which is a reason to rotate the seat rather than to argue about who gets it.

| Scores                            | Value    | Notes                                            |
|-----------------------------------|----------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Ante, dealer does not qualify     | 1 to 1   | the raise is returned, whatever you were holding |
| Ante, beating a qualifying dealer | 1 to 1   | —                                                |
| Raise: pair or less               | 1 to 1   | —                                                |
| Raise: two pair                   | 2 to 1   | —                                                |
| Raise: three of a kind            | 3 to 1   | —                                                |
| Raise: straight                   | 4 to 1   | —                                                |
| Raise: flush                      | 5 to 1   | —                                                |
| Raise: full house                 | 7 to 1   | —                                                |
| Raise: four of a kind             | 20 to 1  | —                                                |
| Raise: straight flush             | 50 to 1  | —                                                |
| Raise: royal flush                | 100 to 1 | —                                                |

## Variants

**The progressive jackpot** — A separate fixed stake, put down with the ante, that pays on the strength of your own five cards alone — it takes no notice of the dealer, the qualifier, or whether you folded. A flush or better pays, with the smaller hands paying set amounts and a straight flush usually taking a share of a running meter and a royal flush the lot. It is the worst bet on the table by some distance until the meter has grown enormous, and it is the reason the



game is offered.

**Playing it at home without a house** — The banker holds a real edge here, so rotate the seat every few hands or the evening has a foregone conclusion. Set a cap on what a single hand can pay before dealing — a hundred to one on a raise is a serious liability at any stake worth playing for — and agree it out loud. Dropping the qualifier makes the game close to even and rather duller; halving the raise to one ante instead of two is the gentler adjustment.

**The stud game it borrows from** — Traditional stud poker is a different animal: cards are dealt one at a time, most of them face up, with a betting round after each, and every player is playing against the others rather than against a bank. Bluffing exists there because the opponents make decisions and can be made to regret them. Seven Card Stud is in this collection and is the closest relative here.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia.

# Red Dog

|                      |                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Yablon, Acey-Deucey, In-Between                                                                                            |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-8 players (best with 4)                                                                                                  |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 to 8 standard decks shuffled together; six is the casino norm, and more packs is better for the player rather than worse |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-30 minutes                                                                                                              |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Category</b>      | Casino                                                                                                                     |

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## Setup

Red Dog is banked. One person deals and covers every bet, and the players are not competing with one another at all — in a casino the bank is the house, and at a kitchen table it should be somebody with enough chips to pay out and a willingness to hand the job on, because the bank holds the edge and nobody should keep it all evening.

The name is shared, and the older claim is the stronger one. For most of the twentieth century Red Dog meant a five-card banking game in which you bet that you held something higher in whatever suit the dealer turned; card books still print that game under this name, and under High Card Pool, Slippery Sam and Shoot. What follows is what a modern casino means by Red Dog, which also answers to Yablon, Acey-Deucey and In-Between.

Shuffle between one and eight packs together. Six dealt from a shoe is the usual casino arrangement, and the deck count runs the opposite way to most games: extra packs help the player, trimming the bank's share from around 3.2 percent on a single deck to around 2.8 percent on six or more. Playing with one pack at home is fine as long as everything goes back in and gets shuffled after each hand.

Ranks are poker ranks and the ace is always high, so the order stops dead at both ends and nothing wraps — king up to two is a shorter distance than ace down to two. Suits are ignored from start to finish.

Agree a minimum and a maximum stake before the first deal, give everyone chips, and mark out a betting spot in front of each seat.

## Play

A single hand is dealt for the whole table. Everyone is betting on the same three cards, and the only private decision anyone makes is whether to raise.

Stakes go down first. The banker then turns two cards face up with a space left between them. Nearly always those two cards have room between them, and that is the hand the game is built around: the banker calls the

spread, meaning the number of ranks lying strictly in the gap. A 3 alongside a 9 leaves the 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8, so that is a spread of 5. Eleven is as wide as the gap ever gets, which takes an ace at one end and a two at the other.

A spread is the only thing that gives anyone a decision. Each player may raise, adding up to as much again as their original stake and no more, or may leave the first bet standing and add nothing. The choice is individual — nobody has to match the seat beside them.

The third card then goes into the gap. A rank strictly inside the two ends wins, and the raise is paid at the same odds as the stake it was added to. A card matching either end, or falling outside the pair of them altogether, loses everything put out, raise included. Landing on an end card is a plain loss rather than a returned stake, which is the first difference to look for if you have played the pot version described below.

Two openings never reach any of that:

- The two cards are neighbours, a 6 beside a 7. Nothing can come between them, so the hand is dead where it stands and every stake goes back.
- The two cards are a pair. The third card is turned at once with no raise offered, and only a third card of the same rank does anything: it pays 11 to 1, and any other card returns the stakes untouched.

The three cards are then cleared away and the next hand dealt. A casino buries a cut card in the shoe and reshuffles at the end of whichever round turns it up; at home, shuffle the discards back in whenever the pack runs low.



The two end cards fix the spread, and only a rank strictly inside them wins. Neighbouring ends leave no gap at all, so the hand is returned rather than played.

## Goal & scoring

You are betting that a third card will fall between two you can already see. Nothing else is scored, and one player's result has no bearing on anyone else's.

What a hit pays is decided by the spread alone, and the two pull against each other: a narrow gap is hard to fill and pays heavily, while a wide one comes in more often than not and pays even money for it.

The raise is the whole of the strategy, and it has one correct answer. A spread of 7 or more fills more often than it fails, so money added there is money on the right side of the bet; at 6 or less the odds are against you and the extra stake should stay in front of you. That dividing line holds whatever the number of decks — raise on 7 and above, never below, and there is nothing else in the game to learn.

Across a session the bank keeps somewhere between 3.2 percent of everything wagered at a single deck and 2.8 percent at eight, so the deepest shoe on offer is the one to sit at. There is no target and no finish: play as many hands as suit you and count the chips at the end.

| Scores                              | Value          | Notes                         |
|-------------------------------------|----------------|-------------------------------|
| Spread of 1                         | 5 to 1         | —                             |
| Spread of 2                         | 4 to 1         | —                             |
| Spread of 3                         | 2 to 1         | —                             |
| Spread of 4 up to 11                | 1 to 1         | —                             |
| Pair, then a third of the same rank | 11 to 1        | no raise is offered on a pair |
| Pair, then anything else            | stake returned | —                             |
| Neighbouring end cards              | stake returned | —                             |
| Third card on an end or outside     | stake lost     | the raise is lost with it     |

## Variants

**In-Between, played for a pot** — The home version, and the one that predates the casino table. Nobody banks: everyone antes into a pot, and each player in turn is given two cards face up and bets anything from nothing up to whatever the pot holds. Fill the gap and you take that much out of it; miss and you pay that much in. Landing exactly on an end card is a post and costs double the bet, which is what the fixed casino payouts are built to replace. Where the first card is an ace its owner calls it high or low; an ace turned second is always high. There are no spread odds at all — every win pays what was staked, so the judgement is how much of the pot to chase rather than whether to raise.

**High Card Pool** — The older game that the name belonged to first, still worth knowing because half the card books mean this one. Everyone antes, the dealer gives each player five cards, and in turn you bet anything from the ante up to the whole pot before the dealer turns a card face up in front of you. Show a card of that suit and higher in rank and you take your stake back plus the same again from the pot; fail and the pot takes your bet. Deal passes after everyone has bet, and the pot carries over. Slippery Sam and Shoot are the same wager with three cards each and the dealer putting up a bank instead of everyone anteing.

**Splitting a pair** — Played in some pot games in place of the flat 11 to 1. When the two end cards match, the bettor antes for a second hand and the dealer draws one further card beside each of them, making two ordinary spreads out of what would otherwise have been a one-card shot. Everything then proceeds as normal on both. It turns the rarest and swingiest hand in the game into two average ones, which suits a table that would rather keep the pot moving than watch it be won or emptied on a single card.

Rules checked against: Wikipedia, Pagat, Wizard of Odds.

# Three Card Poker

|                      |                                                    |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Also known as</b> | Tri Card Poker, Three-Card Poker                   |
| <b>Players</b>       | 2-7 players (best with 4)                          |
| <b>Deck</b>          | 1 standard deck (52 cards), plus chips or counters |
| <b>Time</b>          | 15-45 minutes                                      |
| <b>Difficulty</b>    | Simple                                             |
| <b>Category</b>      | Casino                                             |

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## Setup

One player is the dealer and everyone else plays against them rather than against each other. In a casino the house takes that seat permanently; at home, give it to somebody with a large enough bank to cover the table and pass it round when they have had enough.

The dealer needs a full pack, well shuffled, and a way to keep each player's stakes apart, because two independent bets sit in front of every player and they are settled by different rules.

Before any card is dealt, each player who wants a hand puts up an ante. That is the price of being dealt in. Anyone may also, at the same moment, put up a second and quite separate stake — this project calls it the hand bet, the casinos call it Pair Plus, and it is a wager on your own three cards being worth something regardless of what the dealer turns out to hold. You may back either, or both. The ante is what buys you cards, and a few tables will let you put up the hand bet on its own without one — an option that is to the player's disadvantage, so it is offered rather than recommended.

The dealer then gives three cards face down to each player and three to themselves, and nobody sees the dealer's until every player has decided what to do.

Hands here are three cards, which quietly reorders poker. A straight beats a flush, the reverse of the five-card game, and it is not an arbitrary house rule: three cards to a straight is the rarer shape, coming up in about 3.3% of hands against roughly 5.0% for three to a suit. Three of a kind climbs past both. Rarity sets the order, as it does everywhere in poker; it is only which shapes are rare that has changed.

## Play

Every player looks at their three cards and makes exactly one decision.

- **Play.** Add a second stake equal to your ante. This is not a raise and there is no amount to choose; you are simply staying in.

- Fold. Give the hand up. The ante is lost, and so is the hand bet if you made one, whatever your cards were worth.

The usual advice is to play any hand as good as queen-six-four and to fold everything below it, which is the point where staying in stops costing more than folding does. That one line is the whole of optimal play here.

Once every player has chosen, the dealer turns their three cards face up. Now the qualifier matters: the dealer's hand only plays if it is queen high or better.

#### IF THE DEALER DOES NOT QUALIFY

Nobody's cards are compared at all. Each remaining player's ante is paid at even money and the play stake is simply handed back — win or lose, strong hand or weak. The hand ends there for the ante side of the table.

#### IF THE DEALER QUALIFIES

Each remaining player's hand is compared against the dealer's, and the better hand wins.

- Beat the dealer, and the ante and the play stake are both paid at even money.
- Lose to the dealer, and both are lost.
- Tie exactly, and both stakes are returned.

The hand bet is settled separately and takes no notice of any of this. It pays if you hold a pair or better, and it pays whether the dealer qualified, beat you, or never got involved — the only way to lose it is to hold less than a pair, or to fold before the showdown.

### **Goal & scoring**

Win more from the dealer than you hand over. There is no running total and no end state: each hand is settled on its own and the stack in front of you is the only score there is.

Three things can pay, and they pay independently, which is what makes the game read as more complicated than it is.

The ante and the play stake are the wager against the dealer, and the qualifier decides how they behave. A dealer who cannot show queen high pays the ante at even money and returns the play stake, so a hand you would have lost costs nothing and a hand you would have won pays half what it might have. That is the trade the qualifier makes, and it is the reason a strong hand against a weak dealer can feel like a wasted one.

The ante bonus is paid on the ante for holding a straight or better, and it is the unusual one: it is paid on the strength of your own three cards alone, so it arrives even in hands where the dealer beats you and takes both stakes. A straight pays even money, three of a kind four to one, a straight flush five to one.

The hand bet ignores the dealer completely. A pair pays even money, and the ladder climbs steeply from there to forty to one for a straight flush, because three cards make those shapes rarely.

The pay tables above are the common ones and they are not universal — the hand bet in particular is where a house trims, and a table paying three to one on a flush rather than four is the same game with a materially worse deal. Read the layout before you sit down.

Played as well as it can be played, the ante side costs about 2 per cent, and adding the hand bet costs a little more rather than less. You will also see the figure quoted as around 3.4 per cent: that one measures against the ante alone, where the first measures against everything you stake in a hand, and neither is wrong. The strategy that gets you there is short — play queen-six-four or better, fold below it, and leave the hand bet alone.

Hands rank the same way whichever bet is being settled, and the order is the three-card one: straight flush, three of a kind, straight, flush, pair, high card. Between two hands of the same shape the higher ranks decide it, ace high down to two, and a hand identical all the way down is a tie.

| Scores                                     | Value       | Notes                               |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------|-------------------------------------|
| Ante and play, beating a qualifying dealer | 1 to 1 each | —                                   |
| Ante, dealer does not qualify              | 1 to 1      | the play stake comes back untouched |
| Ante bonus: straight                       | 1 to 1      | paid even if the dealer beats you   |
| Ante bonus: three of a kind                | 4 to 1      | paid even if the dealer beats you   |
| Ante bonus: straight flush                 | 5 to 1      | paid even if the dealer beats you   |
| Hand bet: pair                             | 1 to 1      | —                                   |
| Hand bet: flush                            | 4 to 1      | —                                   |
| Hand bet: straight                         | 6 to 1      | —                                   |
| Hand bet: three of a kind                  | 30 to 1     | —                                   |
| Hand bet: straight flush                   | 40 to 1     | —                                   |

## Variants

**Six Card Bonus** — A third stake, offered alongside the other two, on the best five-card hand that can be made from your three cards and the dealer's three together. It pays from three of a kind upward and takes no notice of who won



the hand, or even of whether you folded before the dealer's cards were turned over. Payouts vary widely between tables, and the top of the ladder is a royal flush.

**Prime** — A side stake on all your cards being the same colour, red or black, usually paying three to one, with a larger payout if the dealer's three match your colour as well. It is offered mostly in the United Kingdom.

**Playing it at home** — The house edge is what pays a casino's dealer, so at a kitchen table it just makes the dealer's seat the good one. Rotate it every few hands, or drop the ante bonus and the hand bet and play only ante against play, which is close to an even game. Agree the pay table out loud before the first deal, because everyone at the table has met a different one.

Rules checked against: Pagat, Wikipedia.